

AMIRA'S RULE

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The Iseldoran Sagas

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Kerron Pierre

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Prologue

I HAVE SET DOWN the date in the upper margin of this page out of habit, the way I have begun every official record for forty years, and then I have sat looking at it long enough that the lamp oil has burned down a finger's width. The Imperial Record Office is quiet at this hour. The clerks are gone. The stone holds the cold of the courtyard outside and gives it back slowly, so that even in the warm months the lower vaults stay chilled, and a man writing here past midnight learns to keep his hands moving.

My name is Adulfus Khan. I hold the rank of Captain, retired from the field and assigned now to the keeping of records, which is a posting men of my service tend to regard as a courtesy extended to the old. I have stopped resenting it. There is more danger in a room like this one than most of the court would credit, because what is written here becomes the thing that happened, and what is left out stops having happened at all. I descend from the line of Harlow Khan. I mention this so that whoever reads it understands the discipline I was raised to, and for no reason of vanity in the name itself. A soldier does not embellish his report. He states what he saw, what he was told, and which of the two it was.

What follows is the history of the first crisis the Empress Amira faced without anyone above her to absorb the cost of failure. I have spent the better part of eleven years assembling it. The testimony fills four shelves of the east vault. I have read all of it more than once, the depositions and the duplicated minutes and the field reports that came in folded so many times the creases had worn through the ink, and I have set my hand

against each page the way one sets a hand against a wall in the dark, to learn the shape of a thing you cannot yet see whole.

I will tell you now what I will not do. I will not give you the end of it here. I have read records that announced their own conclusions in the first lines, and a reader who knows the ending reads everything afterward as a man already braced for the blow, which is no way to understand how the people inside it lived through the not-knowing. They did not know. For a long time they did not even know there was something to be known. That is the truth I am most concerned to preserve, and it is the hardest, because I sit here with all four shelves behind me and the temptation to make them wiser than they were is a constant pressure against the stylus.

There is the matter of the De Grosvenor house, which this record places, perhaps for the first time in the sanctioned archive, under direct historical inquiry. I am aware of what that means. Houses of that standing are accustomed to being described, not examined. I have examined it. I have done so because the events I am recording cannot be understood without it, and because Eleanor De Grosvenor, whatever else may be said of her in the chambers where such things are said, built an apparatus over six decades that held the administrative spine of this empire upright through seasons that should have broken it. I met her three times. I will not pretend the meetings were warm. I will say that I have never in my life sat across from a mind that wasted so little, and that the respect I record here is owed, not granted.

The wax on the older depositions has gone hard and dark, and when I break a seal to copy a passage it gives off a smell like a doused candle, faintly bitter, that has come to mean work to me the way the smell of cut metal once meant the field. My fingers know the difference between the imperial vellum and the cheaper stock the prefectures used for their daily traffic before I have looked down to see which I am holding. I tell you these small things because they are the texture of the work, and because a record that admits its own making is harder to lie with.

I want to be plain about why this account exists at all, since the reign survived. It survived. The Trinitarian Throne stands, and the woman who holds it holds it still. But there was a stretch of months, the months this record concerns, when that outcome was not yet decided, and the thing

that nearly undid it was not an army and not an assassin. It was a process. A clause in the minutes of a routine commission, a column of dates that did not agree, a confirmation entered before the body that confirmed it had met. Small things. The empire is administered by small things, and so it can be unmade by them, quietly, with everyone's signature in the proper place.

I have decided how to record this. That decision took me longer than the writing will. I have chosen to begin where the people in it began, with no warning of what they were standing on, and to let the floor go out from under the reader at the same pace it went out from under them. It is the only honest way I know to do it, and I have spent eleven years deciding it was honest enough.

The lamp wants trimming. Beyond the vault door the long hall runs empty toward the stair, and there is no sound in this building but the stone settling and my own stylus against the page, which is the sound I will leave you with before I begin. Turn the leaf. You have already agreed to know this, by reading even this far, and I would not have you stop now and carry only the half of it.

CHAPTER ONE

The Weight of the Throne Room

THE INCENSE HAD BEEN lit at the fourth hour and would burn until the court adjourned, and by the time the second petition came forward the smoke had settled into the high vaulting and given up trying to rise. Amira sat in it. The ceremonial overrobe across her shoulders carried the weight of a small grown person, the brocade stiffened with metal thread along the seams so that it held its own shape whether she moved or not, and she had learned in the first year of her reign to let it hold her rather than fight it. She kept her spine against the back of the throne. She kept her hands where the court could see them. The marble in front of the dais ran in long bands of polish, and through the polish, if the light from the high windows struck it at the angle it struck it now, a person could read the old repair lines, the seams where the floor had been broken and laid again across four hundred years of audiences. The light came down in cut columns from the eastern clerestory. Where it touched the floor the stone was nearly warm. A stride to either side and the cold came up through the soles of the feet like water.

The Clerk of Petitions stood at the foot of the dais with the day's register, a tall man named Obasi whose voice had been trained to carry the length of the hall without seeming to rise. He read the first matter into the room. A waterworks dispute out of the river prefectures, two guilds and a question of who had paid for a cistern and who now owned the right to charge for it. Amira heard it through. She asked Obasi for the date of the original grant, and when he found it she asked who had

witnessed it, and when the witness proved to be a man both guilds had since buried she ruled the grant lapsed and ordered the cistern held in common under the prefect's seal until a new instrument could be drawn. The guildmasters bowed and withdrew, neither pleased, neither cheated. That was the work. She did not expect to please. She expected to be exact, and to be seen to be exact, because a court that believed the throne was paying attention behaved as though the throne was always paying attention, and that belief did more governing than any decree she could sign.

The forms between matters were their own small labor. An usher came forward with the closing of the first file and laid it on the register table to the Clerk's left, and the under-clerk who kept the running minute dipped his pen and wrote, and the soft scratch of it carried up into the smoke and was lost. The court breathed in the interval. Somewhere along the southern aisle a child of one of the standing delegations coughed and was hushed. A censer-bearer crossed below the dais on soft feet to feed the nearest brazier, and the incense thickened for a moment, sweet and resinous over the flat mineral cold of the stone, and Amira felt it catch at the back of her throat the way it caught every morning by the fifth hour and made no sign of it. Her water cup stood untouched on the small shelf inside the right arm of the throne. She had learned not to drink in court. A ruler who reached for her cup gave the hall a thing to watch that was not the ruling, and the hall would watch it, and remember that she had been thirsty, and forget what she had decided.

Obasi read the second matter while the under-clerk still wrote the first. A criminal review out of the coastal customs courts: a shipping factor convicted of falsifying weights against the duty, sentenced to the loss of his license and a term of labor, appealing the term as beyond the statute for a first offense. Amira asked for the statute and Obasi read it. She asked whether the man had stood a prior conviction under any name, and the customs advocate, a brisk woman in the green sash of the revenue courts, allowed after a pause that the prosecution had not searched the registers of the two neighboring jurisdictions where the factor had traded before. Amira held the appeal. She did not free the man and she did not confirm the term; she sent the matter back to the coastal court with an instruction that the neighboring registers be searched first

and the term fixed to whatever the search returned, and she set a date by which the search must close so that the man would not rot uncharged while a clerk took his time. The advocate bowed. The court understood, as it was meant to, that the throne would neither be hurried into cruelty nor talked into laxness, and that it read the statute as carefully as it read the man.

Behind her, and a little to the right, set back of the formal dais where the carved screen threw a permanent band of shadow across the floor, Eleanor De Grosvenor sat in a plain chair that had been carried in for her and would be carried out when she left. From the body of the hall she was nearly invisible. A petitioner looking up at the throne saw the Empress and the canopy and the gold; he did not see the old woman in the shadow unless he already knew to look, and the ones who knew to look were careful never to be caught doing it. Amira did not turn to her. In the four years since she had taken the throne she had turned to Eleanor in open court exactly twice, both times in the first month, and she had decided after the second that she would not do it again. The compact between the De Grosvenor house and the Trinitarian Throne was older than either of them and would outlast both, and part of what it bought the throne was that Eleanor could sit in that chair and the court would feel her there without the Empress ever appearing to need her. Amira governed. Eleanor watched her govern. The arrangement suited them both and neither of them found it comfortable, which was, Amira had come to think, the proof that it was honest.

Near the western wall, where the colonnade ran back into the administrative passages, a woman in the dark working coat of the Lionesses stood with her hands behind her and her attention moving over the hall in a slow unhurried circuit. Kaviel. She was not on the rolls of the court and held no ceremonial place; she was there because Eleanor was there, and the room registered her the way it registered a load-bearing column, as a thing that was supposed to be present and so drew no eye. Twice Amira's gaze crossed the western wall in the course of the morning and twice it passed over Kaviel without stopping, which was how both of them preferred it.

The hall held perhaps two hundred that morning, a thin court for a working session with no ceremony attached. Along the standing rails the

delegations waited in the dress of a dozen prefectures, the river guilds in their banded sashes, two magisters of the Bureau of Establishments in the gray of the administrative service, a delegation of upland herders whose business stood eighth on the register and who had come down out of the high country to wait however long the throne kept them. Faces dark and faces darker, the broad cheekbones and the long bones of the eastern steppe-blood mixed through the southern lines as they had been mixed for the four hundred years the floor had been broken and relaid, a court that looked like the empire because the empire had made it. Amira knew a third of them by name and another third by office and the rest she would know by the time they reached the foot of the dais, because Obasi would have told her, quietly, in the breath before each name was called, who they were and what they wanted and what they had wanted the last time. He stood now at her right hand with the register and waited for the under-clerk's pen to lift.

Obasi read the third matter.

"A petition of grievance," he said, "out of the Sennar Prefecture. The petitioner contests a ruling of the prefectural magistrate's court and seeks the throne's review of the judgment against him."

A man came forward into the cut light below the dais and went down to one knee on the warm band of marble. He was perhaps fifty, dressed in the good but unfashionable clothes of a provincial man of property, and his hands when he pressed them together were the hands of someone who had done physical work before he had done well enough to stop. He gave his name as Demba Tunde, a holder of orchard land in the Sennar uplands. He spoke plainly. The magistrate's court had found against him in a dispute over a water easement crossing his neighbor's ground, had awarded the easement to the neighbor, and had assessed Tunde the costs of the hearing. He did not contest the throne's right to let the ruling stand. He contested the court that had made it.

"On what ground," Amira said.

"On the ground that the magistrate who heard me had no business on the bench, Majesty." Tunde kept his eyes down, as the form required, but his voice did not waver. "Magister Iwan Kebe. He sat my case in the spring. I have since learned he was set in his office not three months before, over the head of the deputy magistrate who had served the district

eleven years and whom every man in the prefecture took for the next to hold the seat. I do not say the ruling was bought. I say I do not know how the man came to be the one ruling, and when a stranger costs me my water and my coin both, I would know by what right he sat."

It was a common enough grievance and a weak one, in law. A litigant who loses will find fault with the judge; the throne heard a version of it most weeks. Amira had begun, almost, to frame the refusal. She turned to Obasi. "The magistrate's commission. Is it in the prefectural record?"

Obasi was ready for the question; he had read the file before he read the petition, as he read every file, and he had the relevant page marked. "It is, Majesty. Magister Iwan Kebe, confirmed to the Sennar prefectural bench by the Third Appointments Commission, seated under the Bureau of Establishments, by carry-forward reconciliation of a prior confirmation. The entry is regular. The seal is the Bureau's."

"Read me the dates."

"The carry-forward entry is dated the eleventh of Threshing. The session of the Third Appointments Commission under which it was entered convened on the second of the Reaping month." He paused only to be sure he had the months in the right relation, then read them again in order, as a clerk does. "Threshing precedes Reaping by some five weeks, Majesty."

It went past her. It went past the hall. A confirmation entered before the session that entered it was the kind of clerical disorder that filled the lower courts and the prefectural registries, a clerk transposing two dates out of a stack of three hundred, a copyist working from a draft instead of the engrossed minute. The Bureau of Establishments reconciled thousands of such entries a year and the carry-forward provision existed for exactly that reason, to let confirmations made good under one commission be carried into the record of the next without dragging every magistrate in the Outer Prefectures back through fresh review. Amira heard the disorder, weighed it, and set it where it belonged, among the small frictions of a machine too large to run without friction. The man's complaint was that he had lost. The commission was regular. The seal was the Bureau's.

"The commission's confirmation stands on its own authority, Magister Tunde, whatever the order of the clerk's pen," she said. "A

magistrate's right to the bench does not turn on which day a copyist dated the carry-forward, and a ruling does not fall because the litigant who lost it dislikes the judge. The judgment of the Sennar court holds. I will not assess you the costs of this petition; you came in good faith and the throne does not punish that. But you will keep to the easement as the court has set it." She inclined her head a degree, the dismissal. "Go home and mind your orchard."

Tunde pressed his hands together once more, the disappointment closing over his face without surprise, as though he had not let himself hope for more than to be heard. He rose. He backed the three required steps out of the cut light, turned at the edge of it, and walked the long marble toward the western doors, and the cold came up around him as he left the warm band, and the sound of his good provincial boots came back off the high stone for the length of his going.

Behind the throne, in the band of shadow, Eleanor De Grosvenor moved.

It was a small thing. She had sat the whole morning with the stillness of the very old, the economy of someone who has learned that motion costs and pays for nothing, her hands folded over the head of a cane she did not strictly need, her eyes half-lidded in the smoke. When Obasi read the second date she opened them. When he set the two months in their right order her chin came up perhaps a finger's width, and her gaze, which had rested all morning on the middle distance, found the man Tunde and held to him, and tracked him, and did not let go of him as he crossed the floor. The half-lidded fatigue was gone out of her face. What replaced it was attention, the whole of it, gathered and pointed, and it cost her something to gather it; the lines around her mouth drew in and her knuckles whitened a shade against the dark wood of the cane. No one in the body of the hall could see it. The Empress, facing forward, could not see it. The petitioner, walking away, would never know that for the length of his walk out of the Trinitarian Throne Room the most formidable mind the empire had built in sixty years was bent on him entire, reading the back of his good coat, fixing the prefecture and the magistrate and the impossible pair of dates into a memory that had given up nothing important since before the Empress was born.

Across the hall, against the western wall, Kaviel had felt the change before she could have named its source. She had spent her life in rooms with her mother and had learned to read the temperature of Eleanor's attention the way a sailor reads a shift in a wind he cannot yet see on the water. She did not look at Eleanor. She looked where Eleanor was looking, at the orchard-holder crossing the floor, and found nothing in him, a provincial man who had lost his water and would lose his appeal and go home, and she filed the nothing away because her mother had filed something, and the difference between what each of them could see was the oldest fact of their lives.

She held the file in her head the way she held everything, by its parts. Sennar Prefecture. A magistrate named Kebe set over the head of a man who had earned the seat. A confirmation entered under a clause she knew from a hundred rosters, the carry-forward, the thing the Bureau used to move old work into new books without redoing it. A date in front of a date that was supposed to follow it. Taken one piece at a time it was the ordinary disorder of a registry, and Kaviel had read enough registries to know how ordinary that disorder was, how a single clerk on a long afternoon could put the months in the wrong relation and seal the error before anyone caught it. She turned the pieces over once more and they sat where they had sat, harmless, and she let them lie. What she did not let lie was her mother's chin coming up. Eleanor did not spend attention on a clerk's wrong afternoon. She had found no weight in the matter herself. She marked it anyway. The one person alive who could find weight where Kaviel found none had bent the whole of herself toward an orchard-holder walking out a door, and that was reason enough.

At the foot of the dais Obasi had caught it too, in his way. He had read the dates as a clerk reads, in the order the file gave them, and the order had snagged on something in him a half-beat before he smoothed it over and moved to the next matter; a man who handled the register every working day of his life felt a confirmation that preceded its commission the way a weaver feels a slubbed thread under the thumb. He had said nothing. It was not his office to say. He had marked the page with the small folded corner he used for entries the throne might want again, and he would carry the file back to the record room himself rather than send it down with the under-clerk, and that was the whole of what a careful

man in his place could do without overstepping it. He waited at Amira's right hand and let the next name rise to his lips.

Obasi was already reading the next matter, a question of a guild charter and a disputed inheritance, and the court resettled toward it, and the smoke hung in the vaulting, and the angled light had moved a hand's breadth along the marble while the orchard-holder spoke so that the warm band fell now a little nearer the dais than it had. Amira heard the petition into the room. She did not look behind her. The morning went on the way mornings in that hall had gone on for four hundred years, the throne ruling and the court believing itself watched, and the work of it pressing down on her shoulders through the metal-threaded brocade with a weight she had stopped, long since, mistaking for the weight of the cloth.

At the western doors the petitioner Tunde reached the threshold, where two of the door-wardens stood the watch in their formal gray, and passed between them out of the cut light and the cold stone and the incense into the colonnade beyond, and the great doors took him, and he was gone.

In the shadow behind the throne, Eleanor De Grosvenor watched the doors swallow the man, and held her eyes a moment longer on the dark where he had been. Then she lowered her chin the finger's width it had risen, and folded one hand more closely over the other on the head of the cane, and looked again at nothing.

CHAPTER TWO

The Lioness Quarter

THE COMPOUND DID NOT sleep, and it did not announce that it was awake. Asha had served in buildings that performed their readiness, that put armed men at every door and polished the brass twice a day so that a visitor would feel watched the moment he crossed the threshold. The Lioness Quarter was not such a building. From the imperial district a man walking past would see a long administrative block of gray stone with shuttered windows and a single unmarked door, the kind of structure that housed a records bureau or a tax registry, and he would walk on. Inside, the corridors ran on a rhythm that never stopped. Two floors below the assessment level the kitchens had been at work since the third hour, and the smell of them came up through the stairwells in slow drifts, bread and the burnt-sugar edge of something left too long over heat, so that the whole upper floor carried a faint kitchen warmth under the harder smell of metal polish and the oil they used on the door hinges to keep them from speaking. Asha had stopped noticing it years ago. She noticed it this morning only because the candidate, when she came in, lifted her chin a fraction toward the door as though to track where the smell had come from, and Asha marked that, and set it aside, and said nothing yet.

She had come down to the assessment level a half hour early, as she always did, and walked the floor before the candidate arrived. That was an old habit and she had stopped pretending it was anything else. The Quarter ran in shifts that overlapped at the edges so that no hour found

the building unmanned, and the early walk let her take the temperature of it the way a watch officer takes a sounding. In the analysis hall the long tables had been at work since before her, a dozen of the junior researchers bent over rosters under the green-shaded lamps, the scratch of their pens and the dry whisper of turned pages making the only sound on that floor, and she had passed through without a word and been noted and not greeted, which was correct. Two of the wall maps had been re-pinned overnight against a revised jurisdictional chart, and someone had left the old sheet folded on the side table with a note clipped to it for the archivist, and Asha had read the note in passing and approved of the hand that wrote it. Below her the kitchens worked. Above her, in the records vault she did not go up to that morning, the cross-reference clerks held the files no single bureau was permitted to hold all together, and somewhere out past the noon transit Silva was already in the field, sending up by the standard channel the periphery summaries that would be on Asha's table by the time the assessment was done. The building did its work in all its parts at once and made no sound about any of it, and Asha had given the better share of her life to it and walked its floor in the early hour the way another woman might walk a garden.

The room was built to be plain. A table of dark wood worn pale at the edges where forearms had rested across forty years of these conversations. Two chairs. A third against the wall for Meret, who sat in it now with a folder closed on her knee and her hands folded over it, present and saying nothing, which was how Meret was present in most rooms. On the wall behind Asha hung the organizational maps, sheet after sheet of them pinned in overlapping ranks, the protective rosters and the jurisdictional charts and the personnel assessments reduced to columns of initials and date-codes that meant nothing to anyone who had not spent a decade learning to read them. The candidate's eyes had gone to the maps first, before the chairs, before Asha. That too Asha marked. A person could be told a great deal by what they looked at when they thought the looking did not count.

"Sit," Asha said.

The candidate sat. She was young, though not so young as the rawest of them, perhaps twenty-six, with the carriage of someone who had been a soldier and the steadiness of someone who had been good at it. Her file

lay open in front of Asha, the standard-issue intake ledger with its ruled columns and its space at the foot of the page where the assessing officer entered the disposition in a hand the candidate would never see. Asha had read the file the night before and again that morning. Maryam Sow, born in the river prefectures, eight years in the Fourth Imperial Cohort, two commendations she had not asked anyone to mention and a third she had declined. A clean record. A recommendation from a cohort commander whose judgment Asha respected and whose handwriting cramped at the end of the page where he had run out of room for the things he wanted to say about her. Technically, on the page, the woman was past qualified.

"You know what we are," Asha said. It was not a question, and she did not pose it as one. She watched the candidate decide whether it was.

"I know what people say you are, Officer."

"Then tell me that. I will correct the parts that are wrong."

Maryam Sow took a breath that was a degree too careful, and gave it back. "That you guard the Empress. The senior house. That the Lionesses are the throne's own hand, and that when the regular guard cannot be trusted with a thing, it comes to you."

"That is the story they tell in the cohorts," Asha said. "It is flattering and it is most of it false." She turned a page of the file she did not need to turn, to give the woman a moment to settle into being wrong. "We do stand protective detail. It is perhaps a fifth of what the Quarter does, and the least of it. The rest you would find dull. We read appointment rosters out of prefectures you have never heard of, line by line, until the line that is wrong stands up off the page. We sit in the back of commission hearings and write down who arrived together and who left apart. We hold the records that the bureaus would rather no single office held all at once, and we cross them against one another, and when two of them disagree we find out why before anyone with a reason to lie has the chance to reconcile them. We are an instrument of oversight that answers above the military and below the throne, and most days the most dangerous thing in this building is a discrepancy of dates in a ledger." She let that sit. "If you came here to guard the Empress with your body, the cohorts have men enough for that, and they will let you keep your commendations. We are looking for something else."

The candidate held still under it. That was good; the ones who flinched at being told the work was paperwork were no use, and the ones who brightened at it were sometimes worse. Maryam Sow did neither. She absorbed the correction and adjusted, the way a competent soldier adjusts to a change in the order of march, and when she spoke again her voice had reset to the new fact.

"Then I came for the something else, Officer."

"We will find out what you came for," Asha said. "That is what the morning is."

She began the way she always began, with the parts that had answers. There was a structure to the morning that the candidate could not see and that Asha had built and rebuilt across four decades until it ran without her having to think where it went next. The first part was easy on its face and was meant to be, a set of problems with clean solutions, so that the candidate would settle and stop managing her face and start showing Asha how she thought when she was not watching herself think. The hard part came after, when the candidate believed the morning had relaxed. The cohorts ran their assessments the other way around, the difficulty front-loaded so that the recruit broke early or held, and that suited the cohorts, who were sorting for men who would hold. The Quarter was not sorting for that. The Quarter could find people who would hold in any barracks in the empire. What it could not easily find, and what no examination on a page would surface, was the thing Asha was listening for now, and so she put the easy problems first and waited.

She put situations to the candidate the way the cohort exams put them, a protected individual at a transit point, a contradiction in an advance schedule, a subordinate whose account of a movement did not match the manifest, and she listened less to the answers than to the shape of how the woman reached them. Maryam Sow was quick. She did not guess; she said what she could establish and marked the edge of it where she could not, which was rarer than the cohorts believed and harder to teach than anything else the Quarter taught. On the question of the mismatched manifest she found the discrepancy and then, unprompted, named the two innocent explanations before the guilty one, and Asha felt the small clean satisfaction of watching a mind work the way the work

required. By the standard of the page the woman was already through. By the standard of the page she had been through before she walked in.

Asha did not assess by the page.

She had told the truth to a great many candidates over forty years, that she knew within the first ten minutes, and most of them had taken it for the kind of thing an old officer says to seem formidable. It was not. The first ten minutes were before the candidate had learned what the room rewarded; everything after was performance, and performance could be coached, and a coached answer told her about the coach. So she watched the early minutes, and in the early minutes Maryam Sow had done one thing.

She had wanted to be right.

That was the thing, and it had shown itself in the first ten minutes the way such things always showed themselves, before the candidate had learned what the room rewarded. Asha had watched a thousand of them sit in that chair, and she had built her whole reading of a person on the early minutes for a reason she could have explained to no cohort commander in the empire and did not try to. A person walked into the Quarter carrying the habits the cohorts had paid them to keep, and the cohorts paid for one set of habits and the Quarter needed another, and the place where the two parted was not in competence. Maryam Sow was competent past the line. It was in what the competence served.

Not to get it right. The two were close enough that the cohorts never separated them, and a cohort had no reason to; a soldier who needs to be right and a soldier who needs to get it right will both work hard and both do well, and the need is fuel either way. But the Quarter was not a cohort, and the difference, which cost nothing on a good day, cost everything on a bad one. When Asha had handed her the mismatched manifest the candidate's first motion had been a small straightening, a readying, the set of a person who has been given a chance to demonstrate. When she had named the two innocent explanations she had named them well, and she had named them fast, and under the speed had been the faint pressure of a person clearing the obvious so she could arrive at the answer that would land. She had not been turning the problem over to see what it was. She had been getting to the place where she could be seen to have solved it. It was a hairsbreadth thing. On the page it did not show at all.

Asha set down the file.

"I am going to put one more to you," she said, "and I want you to take your time. There is no clock on this one." She watched the candidate not relax, because the absence of a clock was itself a pressure to a certain kind of mind, and Maryam Sow's mind was that kind. "You are running an analysis on a cluster of appointments out of an Outer Prefecture. Forty confirmations. You have been at it three weeks. Your assessment, when you file it, will go up the chain and shape what the Quarter does next, and the officer above you has made it known, not in words, that she expects you to find the irregularity, because the whole reason the file came to you is that someone senior already smells one." She kept her voice level, an exercise and nothing more. "You finish your review. The forty confirmations are clean. There is no irregularity. What do you file?"

"I file that they are clean," the candidate said.

She said it well. She said it almost at once, and that was the trouble; Asha had built the question to have a right answer that any honest person would reach, and an honest person would reach it after sitting in the discomfort of disappointing the officer above her, and would file the clean finding with the small private cost of having found nothing. Maryam Sow had reached the right answer with no cost at all, because she had heard the question as a test of her integrity and had given the answer the test wanted. She had performed the incorruptible analyst the way she would have performed the loyal soldier, the way she had reached for the answer that would land. The content was right. The thing under it was the same thing it had been in the first ten minutes. She would file the clean finding when filing it cost nothing. Asha had spent forty years learning what such a person filed when the truth was clean and inconvenient and no one would ever check, when finding nothing meant three weeks wasted and a senior officer disappointed and the quiet suspicion that a sharper analyst would have found the thing that was not there. The candidate did not know what she would file on that day. That was the disqualification. Not a flaw of character. A flaw the work would find before she did.

Across the room Meret had not moved. But she had heard the question, and she had heard the answer, and when Asha glanced at her, once, in the pause after, Meret met her eyes and held them for the length of a

slow breath and then looked down at the folder on her knee. They had sat enough of these together. Asha did not need her to say it and Meret would not have said it in front of the candidate in any case. The look was the whole of the exchange.

"That is a good answer," Asha said to Maryam Sow, and meant it, because it was. "Thank you."

She asked four more questions after that, none of them assessments, all of them courtesies, the kind a person deserved who had served eight years and earned commendations she did not boast of and come into a strange building and answered honestly everything she was asked. Asha asked after the river prefectures, which she knew, and after the cohort commander, whose hand she had recognized, and she let the candidate talk, and she watched the woman ease into the talking now that the testing seemed to be behind her, not knowing it had ended ten minutes into the morning and that everything since had been Asha making sure. She was sure. The certainty was the same weight it always was, and it did not get lighter with practice, and Asha had stopped expecting it to.

"You will hear from the Quarter within the month," she said, when the courtesies were done. "However it falls, you served well to be sitting in that chair, and the cohort is the better for you. That is not a thing I say to fill a silence."

The candidate rose. She had the grace not to ask, though Asha could see the asking move behind her face and then settle, a soldier accepting that the result was not hers to be told in the room. She inclined her head to Asha and then, after a beat, to Meret, who returned it, and she let herself out, and the oiled door gave back nothing as it closed. Her boots went down the administrative corridor, even and unhurried on the stone, and Asha listened to them go and could hear, under them and behind them, the other sound of the building, the harder report of boots on the training floor two doors down where a class was working through a protective drill, the heavier rhythm of it carrying through the wall, so that for a moment the corridor held both, the candidate leaving at a walk and the work going on without her.

Meret stood and brought the folder to the table and set it down by Asha's hand and did not open it.

"Silva sent the periphery summaries up," Meret said. "They are in there. There is one she flagged." She did not say what, because Asha would read it, and Meret did not waste a sentence telling a superior the contents of a folder she was about to hand her. "She is back out by the noon transit. She said to tell you she will have more by the week's end and that you would know what she meant."

"I will," Asha said.

Meret went. The door gave back nothing again. Asha sat alone in the plain room with the smell of the kitchens still threading up through the floor and the drill going on behind the wall, and she drew the intake ledger back in front of her and turned it to the foot of Maryam Sow's page, to the ruled box where the disposition went. She uncapped the pen. She did not write a paragraph; the box did not hold one, and the Quarter had learned long ago that a long disposition was an officer arguing with herself on the page. She held the pen a moment over the box, and then she set it down to the paper and made a single notation in the cramped exact hand the candidate would never read, and capped the pen, and closed the ledger over it.

CHAPTER THREE

What Eleanor Keeps

THE WEST WINDOW LET the late light in low and long, the way it always did at this hour, laying a bar of pale gold across the floor of the office and up the leg of the writing table. Eleanor De Grosvenor did not look at the light. She had chosen this room sixty years ago for the way that window faced, then learned to work with her back half to it so the glare would not fall on the page, and the courtyard below it she had not walked through in a decade. The glass showed her a square of paving, a dead fountain, a bench nobody used. She kept the window for the light it gave the room and for nothing else.

The room held what work required and refused everything else. A long table scarred from generations of inkwells. Two chairs for visitors, one of which had not been sat in for years. Behind her, shelving that ran the wall to the ceiling, the upper registers reachable only by a ladder she no longer trusted her hip to climb, so the documents she needed daily had migrated downward over time, a slow tide of paper finding its level. On the remaining walls, maps. The Outer Prefectures in one frame, hand-corrected in three colors of ink as borders and jurisdictions shifted under successive bureaus. New Terra and its administrative wards in another. A third map showed nothing a stranger could read, only a grid of cells she had drawn herself, each marked with a code, each code a person or a channel or a debt.

In front of her sat the correspondence of the day, sorted into three stacks by a hand that was not hers and then resorted by a hand that was.

She worked through the first stack without hurry. A petition from the Bureau of Establishments requesting her endorsement of a procedural revision; she read it twice, found the sentence that mattered buried in the fourth clause, and set it aside to refuse. A note from a provincial administrator who wanted her to know he had named his third son for her late husband, which told her the man was either sincere or beginning to angle for something, and she would learn which by what arrived next from his office. A summary of grain reserves she had not asked for and did not need, sent by someone hoping she would remember he existed. She remembered. That had never been her difficulty.

The cold tea sat at her elbow where the morning had left it, a skin forming on its surface. She drank a mouthful out of habit and did not taste it past the bitterness, set the cup down a finger's width from where it had been, and reached for the second stack.

The second stack was the one that mattered, and she had taught herself young to leave it for the middle of the day, when the morning's edge had worn off her judgment and the evening's tiredness had not yet found it. The first stack was theater, the things people sent so that a record would show they had sent them. The second was the things people sent without meaning to send them, the letters where the writer believed he was reporting one matter and was in fact reporting himself. She read those slowly. A request for a transfer told her who a man had quarreled with. A report filed three days late told her the office it came from had something it preferred to file in a hurry behind it. The art she had spent her life on was the art of the margin, the part of a document the writer had not thought to guard because he did not know it was speaking.

The letter from Kaviel was near the bottom, which was where it would be. Her daughter wrote to her through the same dispatch chain any senior Lioness used, on the same gray paper, in the same fixed hand they were all trained toward so that no document could be read off its penmanship. The letter concerned a verification Kaviel had completed at a peripheral waystation, a protected individual confirmed safe and moved on to a secondary location. It reported the operation closed and clean. It described the difficulty Kaviel had encountered in plain operational language, the advance record wrong, the individual not where it said, a

relocation managed quietly and without incident. It did not ask for anything. It did not say more than the work needed it to say.

Eleanor read it the way she read everything, once for the words and once for what the words were built around. There was nothing personal in it, which was correct, and she felt the correctness of that the way one feels a joint that has set well after a break, the ache that means the bone knit straight. She had taught the woman to write like this. She had taught her to close an operation in four sentences and waste no fifth on reassurance. Somewhere in the years between the child who could not sleep without a lamp and the officer who reported a relocation as if reporting weather, Eleanor had done that, deliberately, with her eyes open, and she did not let herself look away from it now any more than she had let herself look away from it then.

She wrote three words on the margin, an acknowledgment that the dispatch office would log and file, and that was the whole of her reply. She set the letter on the stack of completed business and reached past it to the third stack, where the report had sat for eleven days.

It was in its case, a flat hinged box of black document leather worn pale along the spine, and she had moved it from the table to the drawer and back to the table more times in eleven days than she had moved anything in months. She did not open it now. She knew what it said. She had read it on the first day until she could recite the figures, and the figures had not changed since, and would not.

She heard the footsteps in the corridor before the knock, knew them, and said come before the knuckles touched the wood.

Sefu Adebayo had served her for thirty-one years and had learned in the first of those that she did not want to be greeted. He came in, closed the door against the draft, and stood until she gestured him to the chair that still saw use. He was a narrow man gone gray at the temple, exact in his dress without vanity, carrying a slim folder he set on the table squared to its edge. He waited.

She had hired him out of the Bureau of Establishments when he was younger than Kaviel was now, hired him for a quality she had recognized at once and had never found a clean word for, a kind of refusal to be impressed. He could read a roster of a thousand names and tell her which three had been added in a different season of ink. He did not gossip, did

not speculate past his evidence, did not bring her a conclusion when a fact would do. In thirty-one years he had been wrong in front of her four times, and each time he had come to her himself to say so before she found it, which was the reason she had stopped checking his work after the first decade and the reason she trusted nothing he could not show her. He was the nearest thing the apparatus had to a second mind, and he knew it, and it had never once made him careless.

"The reconciliation schedules," Eleanor said.

"All four prefectures, as you asked." He opened the folder and turned it so it faced her. "Sennar is the one that will hold your attention."

"It already has." She drew the folder closer and read down the column. Confirmations entered under carry-forward, each tagged to the authority of a commission session, each session dated, each appointment dated. The arithmetic was meant to be tedious. Tedium was the cover the whole arrangement wore. She had spent six decades learning to read the places where a document worked hardest to be boring, because that labor was a tell, the bureaucratic equivalent of a man holding very still. "These three." She set a fingernail beside three lines. "The confirmation predates the session that authorized it. Here, here. And this one by nine days."

Sefu leaned and looked. He did not say that he had found the same three. He had marked them in faint pencil at the foot of the page, and she saw the marks, and they were the same three, and neither of them remarked on it because the agreement that they would not waste words on what was obvious between them was older than most marriages.

"The clause permits it on its face," he said instead. "Carry-forward exists to reconcile a backlog. An appointment confirmed under a prior commission, entered late under the current one. On paper there is no irregularity. The dates only fail if you check them against the session record, and the session record sits in a different bureau, and no one checks one against the other because no one has ever needed to."

"Someone built it knowing that."

"Someone built it knowing that," he agreed.

She sat back. The light had moved while they spoke, the gold bar climbing the table leg and onto the wood, reaching now toward the black case where it lay closed. She watched it come without watching it, the way she watched most things.

"The field report says the same in fewer words," she said. "A cluster of confirmations in one peripheral jurisdiction, all of them tracing to carry-forward entries, all of them recent. The report does not name the clause. The man who wrote it did not have the schedules to see what the clause was for. He saw the pattern and flagged it, and he was right to, and he has no idea how right." She paused. "If I release the report now, the Lionesses have a thread inside a week. Kaviel will pull it. She works documents. She will have the shape of this faster than anyone I could put on it, and she will not need to be told where to look, which is its own protection, because nothing in the order will point at how I came to suspect it."

"And the report's source."

"Yes." She did not move her eyes from the case. "And the report's source."

He waited. This was the part he could not carry for her, and they both knew the shape of it, and he did not pretend to weigh it on her behalf.

The source had fed the apparatus for twenty-one years. Not directly, never directly; through three intermediaries and a channel she had built so that no single link in it knew more than one other, and the man himself believed, as far as she could measure belief at that distance, that his material went nowhere and meant nothing and was read by a clerk and filed. He was a senior administrative figure with access to the bureaus where the schedules lived. He was the reason she had the schedules now. He was, in the architecture of twenty-one years, irreplaceable, and the report in the black case had come up through his channel, and it was unusual enough in its content that a careful reader on the other side, asking who had access to flag exactly this, exactly now, would draw a short list, and his name would be on it.

Release the report and the thread opened and the threat could be met while it was still small. Hold the report and the source stayed dark and the thread stayed closed and the thing on the other end of it kept growing in the dark with him.

She had made this calculation before, in other rooms, with other names in the place where his now sat. The arithmetic never changed and never got easier, because the variables refused to hold still long enough to be solved. A source was worth what he could tell you tomorrow, and

you could not know tomorrow's worth today, and so you guessed, and the guess was the work. She had guessed wrong twice in her life in ways that had cost her people, and she carried the names of those two the way she carried the key in the dish, in plain view of herself, where she could look at them whenever she was tempted to think she had grown infallible with age. She had not grown infallible. She had grown only patient, and patience was a poor substitute for being right, but it was the one she had.

"There is a thing you are not saying," she said.

"There is a thing I am letting you reach," Sefu answered, which was the same thing said honestly.

"Eleven days," Sefu said. It was not a reproach. He was the only person living who could have said it without it being one. He was telling her she had let the figure climb in that drawer for eleven days, and that he had watched her do it, and that he understood why, and that he would say nothing further about the why.

"The threat does not wait for me to feel ready," she said. "I know what it costs to move now. I have not yet decided it costs more than waiting." She closed the folder of schedules and squared it to the edge as he had left it. "What does the source's traffic look like this month."

"Ordinary. He sent the report through the usual interval, nothing irregular before or since. If we act on it slowly, with other matter around it, the path back to him stays long."

"With other matter around it." She turned the phrase over. "We would need the other matter to be real. A general review of reconciliation across all four prefectures, ordered for an ordinary reason, so the report becomes one input among a dozen and not the input. That takes weeks to stand up. Weeks are what I do not have to spend if the report is right."

"And if you stand up the review without the report, to have it ready."

She looked at him then. It was the first useful thing either of them had said in a quarter of an hour, and he had said it the way he said all his useful things, sideways, as a question he already half knew the answer to.

"Then the review exists before I move," she said slowly, "and when the report joins it the report is unremarkable, and the source is buried in the noise of a process I began for my own reasons, on paper, weeks earlier." She was quiet a moment. "It costs time. The threat grows during the time. But it grows slowly, and the source survives the moving, and a

source who survives is worth more over a year than a week of advantage now."

"It is your judgment."

"It is my judgment." She did not thank him. She had stopped thanking him for the thing he did best, which was to lay the choice out clean and then stand clear of it, twenty years ago, when he asked her once to stop, and she had honored it since. "Order the review. Routine language, my authority, the ordinary reason. Sennar last in the list, not first; if it leads, someone reads the list as pointing at it. Bury it third."

He wrote nothing down. He would remember it precisely, and the absence of a written instruction was its own discretion. He rose, gathered the folder, and squared his chair to the table without being asked.

"There is one more thing in the day's correspondence you have not reached," he said. "It is from the office of a councillor. It is flattery, and it is well done, and that is what I wanted you to see in it. The flattery is too well made for the man it comes from. Someone is writing his letters for him now."

"Leave it on top," she said. "I will read who is writing it."

"Eleanor." He stood at the door with his hand on it. He used her name perhaps twice a year, and always to mark a thing he judged she might not be marking herself. "You held it eleven days because the man on the other end is worth holding for. That is not a fault in the work. It is the work."

She said nothing to that. He had not asked for an answer, and giving one would have made it larger than it was. He opened the door, and the draft came in cool and smelling faintly of the corridor's stone and old wax, and his footsteps went away down the passage at the even pace they had kept for thirty-one years, growing fainter, gone.

The light had reached the case. It lay across the worn black leather and warmed it to brown, and the small brass clasp threw a thread of brightness onto the table.

Eleanor sat with it a while. She did not open it again. She knew the figures; opening it would only let her read them once more and pretend the reading was deciding, when the deciding was done. The review would go up under her name in routine words. The report would wait a little longer in its case, joined later to a process built to hide where it

came from, and the man twenty-one years in the dark would stay in the dark and stay alive in it, and the thing on the far end of the thread would grow some measured amount in the weeks that bought him, and she had weighed the one against the other with her eyes open, as she had weighed every loss she had ever chosen to take.

She drew the case toward her, set both hands flat on its lid for a moment, the leather cool under palms that had held thousands of such cases over six decades and had learned the exact weight at which a document stopped being information and became a debt. Then she lifted it, opened the drawer at her right knee, and laid the case inside on its bed of felt. She closed the drawer. She turned the small key in the lock and drew it out and set it in the dish where she always set it, in plain view, where anyone might take it and no one ever would.

The bar of gold had slid off the table and onto the floor again and was thinning toward the window as the sun dropped behind the wing. Eleanor reached past the locked drawer for the councillor's letter Sefu had left on top, turned it to the failing light, and began to read whose hand was hiding inside another man's name.

CHAPTER FOUR

Kaviel

SABRA CROSSING HAD BEEN built for movement, and it punished anyone who stood still. Kaviel had learned that on her first posting and never unlearned it, so she walked. She kept to the third concourse, where the light came down from panels set into the ceiling at intervals close enough that nothing ever cast a true shadow, and the air carried the burnt-oil weight of engine exhaust that the ventilation never cleared, only stirred. Around her the crowd moved with the rhythm of people who knew where they were going and how long they had to get there. That rhythm was the thing she read. A body that broke it, that slowed or doubled back or held a doorway too long, told her more than any face.

The advance record said the protected individual would arrive on the eastern transit at the seventeenth hour and present at the rebooking counter under a travel name, and that Kaviel would confirm the arrival, observe the onward boarding, and file the movement closed. Routine. She had run the same shape of operation forty times and could have written the report before leaving the compound. The report was already half-written in her head, in the flat administrative voice she used for these things, the voice that gave nothing away and recorded only what could be defended later.

The seventeenth hour came. The eastern transit unloaded its passengers in a long exhalation of bodies and luggage and the smell of food carried in cloth, and the protected individual was not among them.

Kaviel did not stop walking.

She let the disappointment register and pass, the way she let everything register and pass, and she turned the fact over. A missed transit was not yet a problem. People missed transits. The record could be wrong; advance records were compiled by people, and people were the weakest part of any system. She walked the length of the concourse to the rebooking counter and stood at the periphery, near a vendor stall where a woman was turning skewers over coals, the fat catching and snapping, and she watched the counter for the eleven minutes it took to be sure the travel name was not going to present itself.

Silva found her there. Silva had been working the upper gallery, where the rail looked down over all three concourses, and she came down the stair without hurry and stopped at Kaviel's shoulder, close enough to speak under the noise.

"Eastern transit ran on time," Silva said. "I had the platform the whole way. Nobody matching presented at the gate."

"The record says eastern."

"The record can say what it likes."

Kaviel let that sit. Silva did not offer theories, which was one of the reasons Kaviel had requested her. Silva observed and reported and left the meaning to whoever was paid to assign it. The meaning, in this case, fell to Kaviel.

"Pull the arrivals board," Kaviel said. "Everything inbound this jurisdiction since the fifteenth hour. I want origins, not destinations."

Silva went. Kaviel stayed with the vendor and the coals and let her eyes do the slow work along the counter line, the queue, the benches where people waited with the worn patience of those who had waited often. She bought a skewer she did not want, because a woman buying food was a woman with a reason to stand where she stood, and she held it and let it cool in her hand and thought about the advance record.

Advance records were assembled from booking data, and booking data could be entered wrong, or the protected individual could have been moved up a transit by a nervous handler, or the booking could have been made under a name nobody had passed to Kaviel because somebody upstream had decided she did not need it. The first was carelessness. The second was reasonable. The third was the one that made the back of her

neck cool, and she set it aside because she had no evidence for it and inference that ran ahead of evidence was how operations went wrong.

She knew this work. That was the trouble Kaviel carried into every concourse like a stone in a coat pocket. She was good at it in a way that had nothing to do with wanting to be, good the way her mother was good, and the knowledge that the talent had come down the same channel as the name made it heavier to use. She read crowds because reading crowds was in her hands the way a craft sits in the hands of someone raised to it. She had not chosen the craft. She had chosen, at twenty-two, only to stop pretending she could do anything else.

There was a version of this work that other operatives performed, one she had watched and never managed to imitate. They ran a movement as a problem to be closed and went home empty, the file shut, the day done. For them the protected individual was a parcel with a heartbeat, a thing routed from one safe point to another, and there was no shame in that; the parcels arrived safe, the reports stood up, the system held. Kaviel closed her files as cleanly as any of them and could not make herself empty afterward. She carried the faces. She had a memory built for it, the same memory her mother had, the one that filed origins and arrival times and the angle of a stranger's attention without being asked, and the same memory would not let her set a face down once she had picked it up. She had moved a man through a crossing like this one four years ago and could still describe the way his hands shook on the rail and the routing she had written for him and the gate he had vanished through, and she had no use for any of it. The system did not require her to remember. She remembered anyway. It was the cost of being suited to the thing, and she had stopped expecting it to come due less often.

She thought, standing in the yellow light, of the last time she had stood in the Empress's presence on business of her own. It had been a briefing, brief and exact, Amira reading the movement summary Kaviel had filed and asking two questions, both of them the right questions, neither of them warm. Amira had thanked her by name, De Grosvenor, the name doing its work in the room the way it always did, and Kaviel had stood there carrying it and answered as the officer she was and not as the daughter the name announced. The Empress treated her as competent, which was the only currency Kaviel trusted, and the Empress was careful

with her in the way one is careful with a person whose house one cannot afford to misjudge. That care was not friendship. Kaviel preferred it to friendship. Friendship asked things she did not know how to give. Competence she could deliver to the last decimal, and competence was what the room beyond the engine wash and the boarding gates was asking of her now.

Silva returned. "Three inbound transits since fifteenth hour. Eastern, which we had. A southern feeder out of the prefecture line, came in at the sixteenth hour, off the main board because it terminates here. And a re-route, northern stock, posted late, arrived sixteen-forty."

"The southern feeder. Where does it originate?"

"Sennar." Silva said it without weight, because to Silva it was a place name. To Kaviel it landed differently, though she could not yet have said why; only that the word had been crossing administrative desks lately in connection with appointments and magistrates, and her memory filed things whether she asked it to or not. She put it in the same drawer as the missing name and closed the drawer.

"A feeder that terminates here doesn't post to the onward board," Kaviel said. "Anyone arriving on it who needed to rebook would have to come to a counter on foot. They wouldn't appear in the transit arrivals at all. They'd appear in the rebooking queue."

"Which we're watching."

"Which we're watching for a name that may not be the name they used."

Silva absorbed this. "Then we're watching the wrong thing."

"We're watching one thing. We need the other." Kaviel set the cold skewer down on the edge of the vendor's stall. "Describe what we have. Not the name. The person."

It was a thin description, the kind that came down through three handlers and lost detail at every pass. A woman, middling height, traveling alone, would be carrying a document case of a kind issued by a peripheral records office, would not want to be looked at and would therefore have practiced not being looked at, which to a trained eye was its own signal. Kaviel had moved enough frightened people to know how the practiced ones held themselves: too still, or too busy, the stillness of someone counting exits.

The advance brief had given her a name and a transit and an hour, and two of the three were already wrong, and Kaviel turned that over again without letting it become a theory. A brief was a tool, and a tool that came back wrong told you something about the hand that had made it. Either the hand was careless or the hand was working from bad material or the hand had been given bad material on purpose, and she had no way yet to tell which, and so she did the thing the work required when the paper failed, which was to stop trusting the paper and start trusting the floor. The floor did not lie. People on a floor did what frightened people did, what bored people did, what waiting people did, and they did it in patterns older than any record, and if she read the patterns instead of the brief she would find the woman whether the brief had told the truth or not.

"What did the handler chain look like," she said. "On the advance."

"Three names before it reached us," Silva said. "I didn't pull the third. It was a peripheral office, the routing came through a relay I didn't recognize."

"Don't pull it now. Note that you didn't recognize it." Kaviel kept her eyes on the queue while she said it. A relay Silva did not recognize was a thread, and threads were for later, for a desk and a lamp and a file, not for a crowded concourse where pulling on one might tighten something around the woman they had come to move. "We close the movement first. The relay keeps."

"The southern feeder terminus is the second concourse," Silva said. "If she came in on it and nobody met her, she's had ninety minutes to learn she's alone."

"Then she's done one of two things." Kaviel was already moving, and Silva fell in a half step behind and to the left, the position that let her watch what Kaviel's back could not. "She's found a corner with sightlines and stayed in it. Or she's tried to solve the problem herself and is in the rebooking queue under whatever name she could buy."

They took the second concourse first, because the queue was the place a person went to act, and frightened people who had been trained at all preferred acting to waiting. The rebooking hall down here was older, the ceiling lower, the light yellower and humming faintly in a register Kaviel felt behind her eyes more than heard. The queue ran four deep

along a rope line worn smooth by hands. She walked it slowly, a traveler reading the board, and she went through the faces the way she went through a roster, discarding most at a glance, holding a few for a second pass.

The woman was not in the queue.

Kaviel made the full length of it, turned, and made it again from the other side so that no one she had passed once saw her pass twice from the same angle. Nothing. She stepped out of the flow and stood by a pillar where the light pooled and let her gaze go soft and wide, taking the whole hall as a field rather than a set of individuals, which was how the breaks in rhythm showed themselves.

There. Not the woman. A man.

He was standing at the far end of the hall near the document desk, and he had been standing there too long, and he was doing it well, with a folded transit slip in his hand that he consulted now and then the way a man consults a slip while he waits for someone. But he was not waiting the way the others waited. The others waited toward the counters, toward the thing they wanted. He waited toward the hall, his attention turned outward across the floor, and twice in the time Kaviel watched him his eyes went to the same bench against the side wall and came back. He had a courier's satchel across his body, the flat hard-cornered kind that carried documents and nothing else, and a face that would not survive a description, even features over an unremarkable build, the sort of face a witness would later swear they could not recall and would be telling the truth.

Kaviel did not look at the bench. She looked at the board, and at the vendor, and at the floor, and she let the bench arrive at the edge of her vision on its own.

A woman sat at the end of it. Middling height, document case on her knees held with both hands, very still. Too still. Counting exits.

"Side wall, the long bench," Kaviel said, low. "Far end. Case on her lap."

"I have her," Silva said. "There's a man by the document desk who keeps finding her."

"I know."

"Is he ours?"

"No." Kaviel watched the man consult his slip again. He was not advancing on the woman. He was not signaling her. He had the loose attention of a person noting something for later, a person whose work was to see and to carry what he saw somewhere else, and that was all Kaviel could read in him, and she filed it without a frame because a frame was more than the evidence would hold. A man waited near a bench at a transit crossing. People did that. She let him be a face in the crowd, which was what he was, and she moved her attention back to the only thing that was hers to solve, which was getting the woman off that bench and onto a transit without either of them ever appearing to have met.

There was a decision in it that she made in the space of a breath and would have defended to any board that asked. She could move on the man. She could have Silva mark him, follow him, learn the satchel's contents and the relay he answered to, and there was a version of the night where that was the right call and the woman was bait set on a bench to draw exactly that response. But the woman was real and frightened and hers, and a protected individual exposed in a crowded hall did not get more protected while her escort chased a face she could not even describe. The brief was to move the woman. So she would move the woman, and the man would go on being a fact she had no frame for, and she would carry his face the way she carried the others, into a file she might never open. She had learned the hard part of the work years ago, that the thing in front of you you were sent to do came before the thing beside it you were curious about, and that curiosity indulged at the wrong moment was how protected people stopped being protected.

The cleanest method was the oldest. Kaviel did not approach the woman. She approached the rebooking counter, joined the short queue at the adjacent desk, and while she stood there she took from her coat a transit voucher of the kind the compound issued for exactly this, blank but for the imperial chop, and she filled in an onward routing in the small precise hand she had been taught. Then she did the thing that frightened people responded to better than rescue: she became boring. She finished at the counter, turned, and walked toward the bench at the unhurried pace of a traveler whose business was done, and as she came level with the far

end she sat, leaving a respectful gap between herself and the woman, and set her own case down, and exhaled the way a tired person exhales.

The woman's hands tightened on her case.

"They overbooked the northern re-route," Kaviel said, to the air, to no one, the complaint of a stranger sharing a bench. "Three hours I've lost. If you're waiting on the same routing, save yourself the queue. They're sending people round to the seventh gate." She set the voucher down on the bench between them, face up, the chop visible, and stood, and gathered her case. "Seventh gate," she said again, mildly, and walked away without looking back.

It was a small thing and it depended on training. An untrained person would have left the voucher or called after her, confused, or worse, would have stood and followed, fixing the two of them together in the memory of everyone on the bench line. A trained one understood a handoff when it sat down beside her and complained about a transit. The woman picked it up. Kaviel did not see her do it; Silva, from the gallery she had climbed back to without being told, saw it and said so through the bead in Kaviel's ear, one word. "Taken."

The relief of that word was a thing Kaviel did not let herself feel until it was already over. The handoff was the part that could not be redone. If the woman had panicked, if she had read the voucher as a trap and frozen, Kaviel would have had to go back, and a second approach to the same bench was the kind of pattern that turned a face in a crowd into a witness with something to tell. The woman had not panicked. She had been trained well enough by whatever peripheral office had sent her up the line that she knew how to be handed a future and not look at the hand that gave it. Kaviel filed that too. A frightened woman who took a cold handoff cleanly was a woman someone had taken trouble over, and trouble taken was a thing worth knowing about a person you were moving, though it was not, again, hers to chase tonight.

Kaviel walked the long way to the seventh gate, through the first concourse and back down, so that anyone tracing her path would trace a traveler killing three hours and not an operator running a line. She bought tea she did not drink, the paper cup hot through her glove, the smell of it sharp and overbrewed. By the time she reached the seventh gate the woman was already there, standing at the margin of the boarding

crowd with the voucher in her hand and the document case held a fraction less tightly, and Kaviel passed within two strides of her and did not slow and did not look, and confirmed in that passing only that the woman was on her feet, in the right place, holding the right paper.

The northern re-route boarded in a press of bodies and luggage, the gate attendant calling routings in a flat voice over the noise, the engine wash beyond the glass throwing heat and the reek of fuel back into the hall. Kaviel stood at the pillar nearest the gate and watched the woman move into the crowd. She watched the document case go past the attendant. She watched the practiced stillness of the woman's shoulders ease by a degree she doubted the woman knew she carried, the small unclenching of a person who has stopped counting exits because she has found one. The crowd took her. The boarding line compressed and shuffled and closed, and the gap where the woman had stood filled with other travelers, other shoulders, other bodies each bound for somewhere of its own, and the woman was gone into them as completely as a stone into water.

Kaviel filed the movement closed in her head, the flat voice, the defensible record. Protected individual arrived southern feeder, originating Sennar, sixteenth hour. Located, verified, onward routed northern re-route, seventh gate. Movement closed.

She did not move from the pillar. Silva came down and stood with her and did not speak, which Kaviel valued, because the thing in her now was not a thing she had words for and would not have spoken if she had. The advance record had said eastern transit, and the woman had come in on a feeder out of Sennar that did not post to any board, and no one upstream had passed Kaviel that origin, and a man with a face she would never be able to describe had stood by the document desk finding the same bench with his eyes. None of it was evidence. All of it was inference running ahead of what she could prove, and she knew the difference and held to it.

She watched the place in the crowd where the woman had been. The bodies kept moving through it, indifferent, each of them bound for somewhere of its own, and under the engine noise and the yellow hum of the light Kaviel stood very still and wondered, for the first time in the

whole operation, whether the woman she had just moved was the one she had been sent to move.

INTERLUDE 1

Record of the Third Appointments Commission

I include the following for what it would later make plain, though it shows nothing on its face. At the time of its filing no one in the empire read it twice. I have copied it whole, header and seal, so that the reader may pass over the same line I once passed over, and feel afterward the weight of having done so.

BUREAU OF ESTABLISHMENTS OFFICE OF THE OUTER PREFECTURES RECORD OF PROCEEDINGS, THIRD APPOINTMENTS COMMISSION Session opened the fourteenth day, third quarter, under imperial administrative authority. Filed New Terra. Folio 412-C, established series.

PRESENT: the convening registrar; two assessors of the Bureau of Establishments; one clerk of record; deputed observers from the prefectural offices of Sennar, Adwa, Lomé, and the Lower Cataracts, attending without vote.

PURPOSE OF SESSION: to review, confirm, and enter into the standing imperial record those judicial and administrative appointments across the Outer Prefectures referred to this Commission since the close of the prior session, and to reconcile such appointments as remain unentered from prior authority.

ITEM ONE. The registrar opened the session and confirmed the quorum. The clerk read the standing remit of the Commission: that it holds no power to create appointments, only to review those lawfully made and to enter them into the record where review finds them in order. The remit was read, noted, and entered without objection.

ITEM TWO. The assessors presented the schedule of appointments referred since the prior session, numbering one hundred and sixteen across the four prefectures named above. Of these, ninety-one were supported by complete documentation, reviewed individually, and confirmed. The clerk entered each by name, office, prefecture, and date of lawful appointment. The schedule of the ninety-one is appended as Annex A and forms part of this record.

ITEM THREE. Of the remaining twenty-five appointments, the assessors reported that documentation was incomplete at the time of referral. The registrar directed that these be held over and that the originating offices be instructed to supply the missing instruments before the close of the present session. Nineteen were so completed and confirmed. They are appended as Annex B.

ITEM FOUR. Six appointments remained unsupported by complete documentation at the close of the supplementary period. The assessors raised the standing question of backlog, observing that a number of appointments confirmed under the authority of the prior Commission had never been entered into the current record owing to the volume of referrals, and that the affected offices had for some time operated under appointments that were lawful but unrecorded, to the confusion of the prefectural registries.

The registrar reminded the Commission of the carry-forward reconciliation provision, established under the founding instrument of this body and exercised at each prior session, which permits an appointment confirmed under a prior Commission's authority to be entered into the current record without fresh review, upon production of the prior confirmation and on the attestation of the originating office that the appointment continues in force. The provision exists to reconcile backlog and to spare the Commission the labor of reviewing afresh that which a prior Commission has already found in order.

The assessors confirmed that each of the six appointments in question bore a prior confirmation and an attestation from its originating office. The registrar directed that the six be entered under the carry-forward

reconciliation, citing in each entry the prior Commission's authority and the date of original confirmation rather than the date of present entry, as the provision requires. The six are appended as Annex C. Of these, four originate in the Sennar Prefecture.

ITEM FIVE. The clerk recorded that the total of one hundred and sixteen appointments referred to this session had been disposed of: one hundred and ten confirmed on review, six entered under carry-forward reconciliation. The registrar noted that this disposition cleared the standing backlog for the prefectures named and directed that the originating offices be so informed.

ITEM SIX. The deputed observer for the Sennar Prefecture entered a query as to whether the carry-forward entries under Annex C would be subject to review at a future session. The registrar answered that an appointment entered under the reconciliation provision is, by the terms of that provision, already confirmed, and is not referred forward for further review except upon a contest lawfully raised through the prefectural courts. The query and the answer were entered without further discussion.

ITEM SEVEN. There being no further business, the registrar moved that the record of the session be closed, the annexes appended, and the whole transmitted to the standing imperial record under the seal of the Bureau. The motion carried. The clerk read back the disposition of all one hundred and sixteen appointments, and the record was found correct as read.

The session was closed by the registrar at the appointed hour.

Entered and attested by the clerk of record. Reviewed by the convening registrar. Transmitted to the standing imperial record, New Terra, folio 412-C.

SEALED UNDER THE AUTHORITY OF THE BUREAU OF ESTABLISHMENTS, OFFICE OF THE OUTER PREFECTURES, THIRD APPOINTMENTS COMMISSION CONVENEED.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Old Agreement

THE ROOM HAD BEEN chosen long before either of them was born, and both of them knew it. It sat between the Empress's working quarters and the corridor where her household slept, small enough that no third chair would have fit without crowding the table, and arranged so that whatever was said in it left no trace in the registers. There were two chairs. There was a low table with a tray, and on the tray two cups. A window looked out onto an interior garden whose path nobody had walked in a season, and neither woman so much as turned her head toward it.

Amira poured. The Empress of the Trinitarian Throne lifted the pot herself, with no servant in the room to do it, because the absence of servants was the point of the room. Steam rose off the cups and broke against the cold of the stone walls. The garden window let in no warmth at this hour; the heat went straight up out of the liquid and disappeared, and the cups were already cooling before either of them touched them.

Eleanor sat with her hands folded over the head of a cane she did not lean on. She had walked into the room without it earlier in her life. She had walked in with someone's arm later in her life. Now she walked in with the cane and used it for neither, holding it the way she held everything else, as an instrument kept ready in case it became required.

"You held a commission review eleven days," Amira said. It was not a question, and she had not phrased it as one. She set Eleanor's cup nearer to her, an inch, no more.

"The Bureau of Establishments holds a great many reviews," Eleanor said. "I read more of them than I act on."

"I did not ask which you read."

Eleanor took the cup. She wrapped both hands around it and did not drink. The warmth would last perhaps a minute against her palms in a room this cold, and she let it last.

The first move had been made and answered, and both of them recognized it as a single exchange rather than two. Amira had told Eleanor that she knew Eleanor was sitting on something. Eleanor had told Amira that she would not be drawn by a date count. Neither sentence had carried its meaning on its surface. The surfaces were courtesy. Underneath the courtesy two people who had spent years measuring each other were taking the measure again, because the measure changed, and a year-old reading of Eleanor De Grosvenor was a dangerous thing to govern by.

"There is an arrangement between your house and this throne," Amira said. "Older than my grandmother. Older than your tenure."

"There is."

"I have read the terms of it perhaps four times. Each time I find them written so that they can be honored without ever being comfortable."

"They were drafted by people who did not trust each other," Eleanor said, "and who needed each other regardless. Comfort was not among their aims."

Amira drank. She had a way of drinking that gave nothing, the cup raised and lowered without expression, and Eleanor watched it the way she watched all such things, filing the absence of information as a kind of information.

The compact was not a document Amira could amend by signature, and Eleanor was not a subordinate Amira could compel by command. That was the whole shape of it. The De Grosvenor house served the throne, and the service was real, and it had teeth and reach and six decades of accumulated obligation behind it. But it served on terms the throne had agreed to before the throne understood what it was agreeing to, and one of those terms was that the house decided what the throne was told, and when, and whether the telling left the house exposed. An Empress could ask. The asking was honored. The answer was the house's to time.

"I want the report," Amira said.

"I know."

"Then we understand each other."

"We understand the half of it that you have stated," Eleanor said.

"There is another half. I will state it when you are ready to hear it as a condition rather than a request."

Amira set the cup down. The faint sound of porcelain meeting wood was the loudest thing the room had produced. Outside, beyond the unwatched garden, a bell somewhere in the administrative wing marked an hour neither of them counted, and faded, and left the stillness heavier than before.

"You taught me," Amira said, "in the second year, that a ruler who demands the contents of every report ends with reports written to be demanded. I have not forgotten it. I am not asking you to empty your drawers."

"No. You are asking me to empty one drawer."

"I am asking you to tell me whether what is in that drawer touches the throne."

Eleanor turned the cup a quarter in her hands. The tea had gone tepid against her palms; she could feel the heat leave it, the way she could feel most things leave, by degrees and without announcement.

"Everything touches the throne," she said. "That is not evasion. It is the condition of the work. The question is not whether. The question is how far back the touch reaches, and that I do not yet know with the precision I require before I bring it to this room."

"Precision," Amira repeated.

"If I bring you a shape, you will rule on the shape. You cannot help it. It is what you are for. And a ruling on a shape commits the throne before the throne knows what it has committed to. I have watched that mistake unmake better houses than mine."

There was the second half, or the edge of it, brought out far enough that Amira could see it had a body without yet seeing the body. Eleanor wanted something. She had wanted it from before she sat down, and she had let Amira open the conversation so that the wanting would arrive as the answer to a question rather than as a demand into silence. Amira understood the maneuver because she used it herself, in the throne room,

with petitioners who did not know they were being maneuvered. It was strange to sit on the receiving side of it and recognize the technique and choose, for the length of this conversation, not to resent it.

"Say the condition," Amira said.

"Not yet."

"Eleanor."

The name, used plainly, was itself a move. Amira did not use it often. In the throne room she said De Grosvenor, or she said nothing and let a glance carry it. Here, with no scribe to record the familiarity and read into it, the given name was a pressure applied at a precise point, and Eleanor felt the point.

"When I give you the report," Eleanor said, "I will have spent something to give it. There is a person whose continuance depends on this matter being handled in a way that does not announce how I learned of it. I have protected that person for longer than you have governed. I will not trade them for the satisfaction of resolving your curiosity eleven days early."

"It is not curiosity."

"I know it is not. I said it to hear you deny it, and you denied it the way you deny things that are true. You are worried."

Amira did not answer that. She poured more into her own cup, though the first had not been finished, and the act of pouring filled the silence the way a person fills a silence when the alternative is conceding a point. The fresh liquid steamed and the steam died against the cold, and the smell of it, faint and bitter and herbal, hung a moment in the still air between them and then was gone.

"There is a matter from the Sennar Prefecture," Amira said. "A petitioner in court. A magistrate's ruling contested on procedure. I sat through it three weeks ago and signed off on the procedural finding and thought no more of it. You were behind the dais. You did not move the entire session, except once."

Eleanor's face did not change, which was its own confirmation, and Amira read it.

"You will not tell me what you saw," Amira said.

"I will tell you that I saw something. I will tell you that I am not yet certain it is one thing rather than three coincidences that resemble one

thing. And I will tell you that if it is one thing, it is not confined to Sennar, and the work of confirming that is the work I am doing in the eleven days you object to."

"I did not object. I noted them."

"You noted them in a room with no scribe," Eleanor said. "That is an objection with the record removed. I have done the same to people I worked under. It does not offend me. It tells me you have begun to suspect that the throne's information is being shaped before it reaches you, and that you have begun to suspect it might be shaped by the very house you rely on to keep it clean."

The accusation that had not been made hung now fully in the room, named by the only person who could have named it without it becoming an incident. Amira had not said it. Eleanor had said it for her, and in saying it had drawn its teeth, because a suspicion spoken aloud by its object is harder to hold as a suspicion. It was a generous move and a defensive one at once, and Amira marked it as both.

"I rely on your house," Amira said, "because the alternatives are worse, and because in forty years it has not failed the throne in a way I could prove. That is not affection. You have never asked me for affection."

"No."

"You have asked me for trust, which is a colder thing and a more expensive one, and I have extended it on the understanding that it is conditional and that you would tell me when the conditions changed. Have they changed?"

Eleanor was quiet for a long moment. The cold of the room had reached her hands fully now; the cup gave back nothing. Somewhere past the window a gardener's tool had been left against the wall a season ago and had begun to rust, and the iron smell of it would have reached the room if either of them had opened the window, and neither of them ever would.

"They are changing," she said. "I cannot tell you yet whether they have changed, which is a different statement, and the difference is the eleven days."

"And the condition you are not yet ready to state."

"Is that when I tell you, you let me tell you in full and at once, and you do not act on the first third of it because the first third is the part that exposes my source and resolves nothing. I am asking you to receive a wound and not flinch until I have shown you the whole of the body. Most rulers cannot do that. They flinch at the first cut and the surgeon loses the patient."

Amira considered the cup in her hands rather than the woman across from her. To look at Eleanor while deciding was to give Eleanor the decision in advance; the old woman read faces the way Amira read petitions.

"You are asking me to surrender the timing of my own response," Amira said.

"I am asking you to lend it to me, briefly, the way the throne lent my house the timing of its reports two hundred years ago, in this room, for reasons that have not improved with age and have not gone away either."

"And if I will not lend it."

"Then you will have the report tomorrow," Eleanor said, "incomplete, and you will act on it because you cannot help acting, and you will be right about the small thing and blind to the large one, and the person I have protected for twenty-one years will be the cost of your being right early. I will give you the report either way. The compact requires it. The compact does not require that I give it well."

That was the heart of it laid bare, as bare as Eleanor would lay anything. The compact bound her to deliver. It did not bind her to deliver in good order, with the source shielded and the shape complete. The difference between a report flung onto the table to satisfy the letter and a report carried in whole to serve the throne was a difference of perhaps two weeks and one human life, and Eleanor was telling Amira the price of each, and letting Amira choose, and not pretending the choice was anything other than hard.

Amira did not answer at once. She crossed to the window she had been ignoring all evening and stood before it without seeing the garden, her back to Eleanor, her hands joined behind her at the small of her back in the posture she took on the dais when a petition ran long and she wished to consider it without a hundred faces reading her. The glass had fogged faintly where the cold of the pane met the warmer air of the

room, and her breath added to it, and through the blur the dead path and the rusting tool and the unpruned hedge had no edges at all.

"My grandmother distrusted your house," she said to the glass. "She told me so. She said the De Grosvenors had served four reigns and ended three of the four better off than they began, and that no servant grows richer than the master and stays a servant. She said it the year before she died. She also said that she would sooner be blinded by your house than given true sight by any other, because your house at least knew the value of the eyes it took. I did not understand her then. I have come to."

"Your grandmother and I disagreed about a great many things," Eleanor said. "We did not disagree about that."

Amira turned from the window. "You knew her."

"I served under the woman who served under her. I was young. She frightened me, which I did not let her see, and she knew it anyway, which I did not let her see that I knew. We managed each other for nineteen years and never once said a true thing in a room with a scribe in it. The arrangement we are sitting inside, you and I, is the arrangement she and I made habitable. It was drafted by the dead. We are the ones who have to live in the house they built, and the roof leaks where they wanted windows."

It was the most Eleanor had volunteered in the conversation, and Amira understood it was not warmth. It was provision of context, the laying of one more fact on the table so that the trade between them could be priced correctly. Eleanor gave nothing without a reason, and the reason here was to remind the Empress that the timing she was being asked to lend had been lent before, in this room, by a harder woman than Amira, to a younger and more dangerous Eleanor, and that the throne had survived the lending.

"You are telling me it has worked before," Amira said.

"I am telling you it has held before. Those are not the same. It held because both parties understood the cost of breaking it and chose the cost of keeping it, which is always higher in the moment and lower across the years. Your grandmother chose to keep it on a night she wanted to break it more than I have ever wanted anything since. I was in the room. I watched her choose. I have never told anyone what she gave up to make

that choice, and I will not tell you, because the keeping of it is part of what makes my house worth the compact you dislike."

Amira returned to her chair and sat. She had not meant to sit again; standing had been the closing posture, the signal that the meeting was ending, and to sit again was to reopen what she had begun to close. Eleanor noted the reversal and gave no sign of noting it. The tea on the tray had passed beyond tepid into the flat cold of liquid that has taken the temperature of the room, and the steam was long gone, and the smell of it had thinned to almost nothing.

"There is a thing I have not said," Amira said.

"There is. You have been deciding whether to say it for the length of this conversation. Say it or do not. I will not pull it out of you. I am too old to enjoy the work and you are too able to make it easy."

Amira looked at her hands. "If your house is the source of the shaping, I cannot use your house to find the shaper. I would be asking the hand that moved the record to tell me which fingers were dirty. I have lain awake on that. It is the worst version of the problem and I have no instrument for it that does not run through you."

There. The thing beneath the thing, the fear under the suspicion, brought into the open by the Empress herself rather than left for Eleanor to name a second time. It cost Amira to say it, and the cost showed only in the slowness of the saying, the way a person sets down something heavy with care because dropping it would be worse than carrying it.

Eleanor let it sit a moment before she answered, which was respect, or the form of respect that she had instead of the feeling.

"If my house were the source," she said, "I would not be sitting in this room asking you for two weeks. I would have given you the incomplete report on the first day, let you act on the small true thing, watched you congratulate yourself, and steered you past the large thing while you were busy being right. The fact that I am asking you to wait, that I am spending my standing to buy time I could have used against you, is the only assurance I can offer that I am not the danger. It is not proof. There is no proof you could verify without an apparatus you do not have. It is the behavior of a house that is not betraying you, offered in place of a guarantee that does not exist. You will have to weigh it as that."

"I have weighed it as that," Amira said. "It is why you have your two weeks and not your dismissal."

"Then we are agreed, and we have spent an hour saying so."

"We have spent an hour making certain the agreement would hold under weight," Amira said. "That is not the same as saying so. You taught me that as well, though I do not think you meant to."

A sound passed between them then that was almost, in Eleanor, the ghost of amusement, gone before it could be confirmed, leaving only the slight settling of the lines at the corner of her mouth into a fraction less severity than before. She lifted the cold cup, looked at it, and set it down again without drinking, having confirmed for herself only that it was cold.

Amira stood. She did it without haste, smoothing the front of her robe with one hand, and the movement returned the room to its proper order, the Empress on her feet and the head of a serving house seated, the familiar names set down and the titles taken up again.

"You will have your two weeks," Amira said. "I will not flinch. When you bring it, you bring it whole, and you bring it to this room, and there will be no scribe. After that the timing is mine again."

"After that the timing is yours," Eleanor agreed.

Amira moved toward the door that led to her quarters. With her hand near it she paused, not turning fully, her profile lit cold from the garden window she still did not look at.

"The thing you saw in the throne room," she said. "When you bring me the whole of it. I will want to know whether I should have seen it too."

"You will not like the answer."

"I rarely do."

Eleanor rose then, slowly, the cane taking weight for the first time since she had entered, and she set the untouched cup back on the tray with both hands so that it would not rattle, and she inclined her head the precise depth that the head of the De Grosvenor house inclined it to the Trinitarian Throne, and no further.

CHAPTER SIX

The Report Arrives

THE REPORT CAME UP through the standard chain a little after the tenth hour of the night, which was the hour Kaviel preferred for anything that would ask something of her. The compound had gone quiet by then. The training floors were dark, the day's intake assessments filed, the mess two levels down scrubbed and shuttered, and the building had begun the slow settling it did once the people in it stopped moving through it, the small reports of cooling stone and contracting metal that an unfamiliar ear would have taken for footsteps and that Kaviel had long since learned to hear as the place breathing. The night runner who brought the dispatch knew better than to knock hard. He set the gray case in the slot built into her door for exactly that purpose, and she heard the soft double tap of the flap, and the runner was gone before she rose to take it.

She had been at the desk since the eighth hour with the lamp turned low and the window cracked the width of two fingers. She thought better with something moving, had since she was a girl, and the office held its air too well; with the window shut the room grew close by midnight and her attention thickened with it. So she kept the gap, and the cold came in off the inner court in a thin steady draw, carrying the mineral smell of wet stone from the afternoon's rain and, under it, the lamp oil, and under that the cold remains of the meal she had not finished, a heel of bread and a smear of bean paste going hard on its dish at the corner of the blotter. She had meant to eat it hours ago. She had meant to do a number of things hours ago.

She brought the case to the desk and opened it.

She knew the hand on the cover sheet before she read a word of it. It was the routing hand of the central dispatch office, fixed and characterless, the same hand every senior file wore so that nothing could be read off its penmanship, and it told her only that the document had passed through Eleanor's authority and been released downward to the Lionesses for action. It did not say released by Eleanor. The chain did not work that way and was not meant to. A file came down with an authority stamped on it and a routing assigned, and the officer who received it worked the file and not the question of who had decided she should have it. Kaviel had been trained to that discipline by the woman whose authority sat on the cover sheet, and she did not waste the night's first clear hour wondering why the report had come now and not a month ago. The report had come now. That was the fact the work began from.

She read it once through without stopping, the way she read everything the first time, for the words and nothing else.

It was a field report out of a peripheral records jurisdiction, filed by an administrator whose name had been redacted to an office code before it reached her, which was ordinary for material of this grade. The body of it was short. The writer had noticed, in the course of routine work, a cluster of judicial and administrative appointment confirmations in his jurisdiction that shared a single trait: every one of them had been entered into the standing record under carry-forward reconciliation rather than fresh review, and every one was recent, and the density of them in a short span sat oddly against the writer's experience of how the clause was normally used. He did not name the clause as a fault. He did not name it at all in the language of suspicion. He set the pattern down, flagged it as worth a second eye, and left the meaning to whoever read above him. Kaviel recognized the restraint. It was the restraint of a man reporting one thing and aware he might be reporting another, and unwilling to put a frame around a fact he could not yet stand behind. She had written reports in that voice. She had stood at a transit counter not three weeks past and built a movement summary in that voice, the flat one that recorded only what could be defended later.

She read it a second time, slower, for what the words were built around.

The thing the report did not have was scope. The writer had his own jurisdiction and the confirmations that had crossed his own desk, and that was the whole of his window. He could see a cluster. He could not see whether the cluster was a local accident, a clerk in one office overusing a convenience, or the visible corner of a pattern that ran wider than any single desk could hold. He had no way to test it, because the test would have asked for records that lived in a bureau he had no business inside, and a careful administrator did not go pulling at records outside his remit on the strength of an unease. So he had done the one thing his position allowed. He had written it down and sent it up, and the sending up was the limit of what the report could do on its own.

The limit was the part that held Kaviel at the desk.

Eleanor would have read this differently. Kaviel knew that with the certainty of a person who had spent her childhood watching the reading done. Her mother worked from the living shape of things, from who fed whom and who owed whom and which channel had gone quiet in a month it should have spoken; she would have held this report against twenty years of names and traffic and known within an evening whose silence it confirmed and whose it broke. Kaviel did not have the network. She had never wanted it, had built herself sideways out of the house precisely so that she would not be the keeper of the cells and the codes and the debts. What she had instead was paper. She read documents the way her mother read people, and where her mother would have asked who, Kaviel asked which records, and both of them would arrive, and the difference between the routes was the whole of the difference between them.

She rose and went to the wall of reference shelving and took down the compound's standing index of active matters, and she carried it back to the lamp and ran her finger down the entries with the cold air moving at her wrist. She was not looking for the report. She was looking for the things the report touched without naming, the way a stone dropped in water touches the bank a stride off from where it fell.

Three matters lay in the index where her finger stopped.

She did not pause to ask herself whether she was entitled to pull them. She was a senior Lioness and the report had come to her for action and the action began with the records nearest it, and the entitlement was

not a thing she spent thought on. She went to the door and put her head into the dark of the corridor, where the duty lamp burned at the far end above the night clerk's station, and she saw that the figure at the station was Meret, which was good, because Meret would bring her what she asked and would not ask her why.

"Meret."

Meret looked up from the ledger she kept the night log in. She was a square-built woman with a still face and a way of holding a pen that suggested she had never in her life made an unconsidered mark with one. "Senior."

"Three files from the central record." Kaviel gave her the index references in order, reading them off the open book against her forearm. "The Sennar Prefecture magistrate matter, the grievance heard in open court this season; the petitioner was an orchard-holder, the magistrate a man named Kebe. A transit manifest, Sabra Crossing, the southern feeder line, the movement closed three weeks back under my own filing. And the roster of a prior appointments commission, the session that ran before the one now sitting. Whatever the record room has on all three."

Meret wrote the three references in her own hand, read them back once, exactly, and closed the log. "It will take the better part of an hour. The night archivist will have to wake for the commission roster; it is held below the active line."

"The hour is fine. Wake him gently."

Meret rose. She did not ask what the three had to do with one another. She did not ask why a movement Kaviel had filed closed with her own hand was being pulled back up at the tenth hour of the night, or what a transit manifest had to say to a magistrate's commission, or whether Kaviel wanted anyone told. She gathered the lamp from the station and went, and her boots made the even unhurried sound down the administrative hallway that the building's boots made, nothing like the harder report they made on the training floors two levels off, and the sound thinned and turned the corner and was gone. Kaviel went back to her desk. The not-asking was not incuriosity. Meret was as sharp as anyone on the rolls and would have her own shape forming of why a senior wanted these three files at this hour, and she would keep it to herself and bring the files, because the discipline of the place was that you did not

pull on a thread a superior was holding until the superior handed you the end of it. Kaviel had given that order to others. She knew exactly what it cost to obey it well, and Meret obeyed it better than most.

She used the hour. She read the field report a third time and made no notes, because notes this early would only fix a shape before the shape had earned its lines. She turned the lamp up a half-turn against the strain on her eyes and turned it back down when the brightness made the room feel smaller. She ate the cold bread without tasting it, because a body that had not eaten read worse than a body that had, and the work needed her reading at its best. The bean paste had gone to a paste of a different kind and she ate it anyway. Outside the cracked window the rain had stopped and the court below held its puddles up to whatever light reached down into it, and once a bird she could not name said something twice into the dark and fell silent.

Meret brought the files a little before the eleventh hour and set them on the desk squared to its edge, three folders of varying thickness, the commission roster the heaviest and bound in the dun board the deep archive used. "The archivist asks that the roster go back by the sixth hour; it is wanted for a reconciliation review that stands open under a senior authority." She did not say whose. "He flagged it. The review is recent."

"It can go back by the sixth." Kaviel heard the rest of it land and set it where she set things she could not yet use. A reconciliation review, recently stood up, holding the prior commission's roster as one of its inputs. She did not know whose authority kept it open and she did not let herself reach for the name, because the reach would be inference and the inference would run ahead of the page in front of her, and she had learned the hard way that an early name was a thing the mind then bent every later fact to fit. "Thank you, Meret."

Meret inclined her head a degree and went back to her log, and Kaviel was alone again with the lamp and the cold draw of the window and four documents.

She built it the way she built everything, by its parts, laid flat where she could see them at once.

She opened the Sennar matter first because it was the one with a face on it. Demba Tunde, orchard-holder, grievance against the ruling of the

prefectural court, the easement lost to a neighbor, the costs assessed and then waived by the throne. The petition contested the judge and not the judgment, which was a weak ground in law and had been refused. She read down to the part she wanted, the commission entry that gave the magistrate his bench. Magister Iwan Kebe, confirmed to the Sennar prefectural bench by the Third Appointments Commission, seated under the Bureau of Establishments, entered under carry-forward reconciliation of a prior confirmation. She read the two dates the file gave, the carry-forward entry dated the eleventh of Threshing and the commission session it was entered under convened on the second of Reaping, and she set the months in their order in her head, Threshing then Reaping, five weeks between, and saw that the entry stood five weeks ahead of the session that was supposed to have authorized it. A confirmation entered before the thing that confirmed it.

She had seen this date in open court. She had stood against the western wall and heard Obasi read it and watched it go past the whole hall, and she had let it lie because taken on its own it was the ordinary disorder of a registry, a clerk transposing two months out of three hundred, and because her mother had not let it lie, and the gap between those two facts was the thing she carried out of the throne room and had not set down since. She knew now why it would not set down. One wrong date was a clerk's long afternoon. A clerk's long afternoon did not call to a field report out of a different jurisdiction flagging a cluster of carry-forward confirmations that should not cluster. The report gave the throne room date a second instance to stand beside, and two instances were not a clerk; two instances were a method.

She opened the prior commission roster next, the heavy dun folder, and worked it against the report and the Sennar entry both. This was the test. The carry-forward clause did one honest thing and could be made to do one dishonest one, and the difference lived in the roster of the prior session, because the whole legitimacy of a carry-forward turned on a prior commission having confirmed the appointment first. The clause permitted a confirmation made good under one commission to be carried into the record of the next without fresh review. It did not permit a confirmation that no prior commission had ever made. So she went through the prior roster name by name, the way Sefu Adebayo would

have gone through it though she had never watched him do it, looking for Iwan Kebe among the confirmations the prior session claimed to have made.

He was not there.

She went through it again, slower, allowing for variant spellings and the chance of a clerk's hand turning a letter, and he was not there the second time either. The carry-forward entry on the Sennar magistrate cited the authority of a prior commission and a date of original confirmation, as the clause required, and the prior commission's own roster held no confirmation under that name on that date or any other. The thing the carry-forward was reconciling did not exist. The clause had been fed an appointment it could dress in the authority of a session that had never seen the man, and the dressing was the date discrepancy the throne room had passed over, because an honest carry-forward and a fabricated one looked identical on the face of the current record and parted only when you laid the current entry against a prior roster that lived in a different bureau and that no one ever thought to lay it against.

Someone had built it knowing that. The phrase arrived in her mother's cadence and Kaviel did not chase where she had heard it; it was the shape of the thing speaking, and the shape was a designed one.

She sat back and let the cold move across the back of her neck and turned to the third file, which was the one she had pulled on an instinct she could not yet justify to a board, and which she had half expected to come up empty. The transit manifest from Sabra Crossing. The southern feeder line, the movement she had run and filed closed with her own hand, the frightened woman with the document case who had come in off a board that did not post and gone out the seventh gate on a voucher Kaviel had filled in herself. She had filed the woman's origin in that report because the work required an origin and the feeder had given her one. Sennar. The woman had come up out of the Sennar Prefecture, on a line that terminated at the crossing and posted to no onward board, carrying a records-office document case, practiced at not being looked at.

Kaviel laid the manifest beside the Sennar magistrate file and the field report and the prior roster, and she made herself go slowly, because this was the place the night could go wrong, the place where a tired mind reached across a gap because the reaching felt like seeing. The manifest

did not name the woman; the woman had traveled under a name that was not hers, and Kaviel had moved her under a third. There was no line on the manifest that touched a line in the magistrate file. What touched was the prefecture. A protected witness moved quietly out of Sennar, in the same season that a fabricated magistrate's confirmation out of Sennar surfaced in open court, in the same season a field report flagged a cluster of fabricated confirmations and a senior authority stood up a reconciliation review and buried it deep enough that a night archivist had to be woken to surrender a roster. And a man at the document desk in the second concourse with a courier's flat satchel and a face built to be forgotten, who had found the woman's bench with his eyes twice and never moved on her, who had the loose outward attention of a person whose work was to see a thing and carry what he saw somewhere else.

She had filed his face without a frame three weeks ago because the evidence would not hold a frame, and she had been right to, and she was careful now not to give him one he had not earned. A face in a crowd at a transit hub was a face in a crowd. But a witness does not get moved out of a prefecture for nothing, and the someone who took the trouble to move her had taken it because of something she could tell, and a witness with something to tell out of Sennar, in this season, was a fact that lay against the others with a weight Kaviel could feel and could not yet prove. The relay Silva had not recognized in the handler chain sat in the same drawer. Three names before the advance reached them, the third unpulled, the routing through a channel Silva did not know. Kaviel had told Silva to note it and leave it. She wished now she had a name for the relay and was glad she did not, because a name she wanted this badly was a name to distrust.

She had the shape. She turned it over twice more and it held its lines and added none it had not earned. A clause built to be boring, fed appointments no prior commission had made, dressed in dates that failed only against a roster no one cross-checked, surfacing in Sennar and in at least one jurisdiction more, with someone senior enough to stand up a review that hid where the first suspicion came from, and a witness lifted quietly out of the middle of it, and a courier with a forgettable face standing where she had been lifted. It was a method and it had a hand behind it and the hand had taken pains to be a process and not a person,

so that anyone who pulled on it would find clauses and clerks and the ordinary friction of a machine too large to run without friction, and no one to charge.

She did not have the hand. She had the shape of the glove it left in the record, the size of it and the reach of it and the patience of it, and where the shape narrowed she could feel the absence at its center the way you feel a missing stair in the dark. She knew better than to fill it. Inference that ran ahead of evidence was how operations went wrong, and she had told a younger officer that in a stairwell once and meant it, and she was not going to spend the credit of a clean night's reading on a name she wanted because the shape ached for one.

The roster had to go back by the sixth hour. She squared the four files, the manifest atop the magistrate matter, the report atop those, the heavy roster beneath, and she turned the lamp down until the flame stood low and blue at its base and the corners of the room went to dark. She did not turn it out. She sat in the near-dark with the cold still drawing past her wrist and the wet-stone smell thinning as the court below dried, and she let the shape sit with her without working it further, the way she had learned to let a thing settle before she trusted what she had built.

Then she took a clean half-sheet from the drawer and uncapped the pen and held it over the paper a moment. She wrote one word. She read it once. She capped the pen, folded the sheet twice into a small square, and put it in the inner pocket of the coat that hung on the back of her chair, against the lining, where her own hand would find it and no one else's would. She drew the coat on. She gathered the three files for return and left her own where it lay, and she went out into the corridor toward the duty lamp where Meret kept the log, the folded paper riding cold against her ribs through the lining.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Court Moves

THE STATE HALL HAD been built to hold a thousand and tonight it held perhaps four hundred, which made it worse rather than better, because four hundred people in a room built for a thousand each carried their own pocket of air with them and moved it through the others, and the heat of them rose into a ceiling too high to give it back. They had come for the announcement of the autumn commissions, the routine confirmations of the bodies that would sit through the cold half of the year, and the throne had chosen to mark it with a dinner because a dinner cost less than a ceremony and bought as much, and because Amira had learned that the court behaved best when it was fed and watched at once. The long tables ran the length of the hall under the high windows, dark now and giving back the lamplight in the glass, and the smell of the food came up the room in layers, the roasted meat first and under it the sweet of the spiced wine and under that the wax of four hundred lamps burning down toward the second course.

Amira entered after the hall was seated, which was the form, and the hall rose, which was also the form, and she crossed to the raised table at the head of the room with the slow exact step that the overrobe required of her and that she had stopped resenting somewhere in her second year. She did not look at the room as she crossed it. She looked at the chair she was walking toward, because a ruler who scanned the faces while she walked told the room she was counting it, and the room would count itself back, and the dinner would become a census instead of a meal. She

let them watch her arrive. She let the watching do its work. When she reached the head table she turned and stood a moment and let the hall hold its rising a breath longer than it expected, and then she sat, and the hall sat, and the long exhale of four hundred people lowering themselves onto benches ran the length of the room and was lost in the music from the gallery.

The musicians played from above and behind, set in the gallery over the doors so that the sound came down into the hall without a source the eye could fix, and the effect of it was that the talk had to climb over the music to be heard, and so every conversation in the room was pitched a half-step louder than its speakers wished, and leaned closer than they wished, and gave more away. Amira had ordered the musicians placed there in her first year and had never moved them. She ate little. She watched the room without appearing to watch it, in the glass of the dark windows where the hall hung reversed and dim, and in that reflection she could follow a man crossing the floor without turning her head to do it.

Councillor Hadi Marun came to the head table between the first course and the second, which was the right time, early enough to show eagerness and late enough to show he understood he was not the only man who wished to be seen. He was a broad, easy man somewhere past fifty, with the kind of face that gathered other faces toward it, and he made his bow to the throne with a fraction more depth than the floor required and held it a fraction longer, and Amira marked the fraction and did not hold it against him. Some men flattered because they wanted and some because they could not help it, and Marun, as far as the throne had ever been able to determine, was the second kind, which made him useful and slightly dangerous in ways he did not himself suspect.

"Majesty," he said, straightening. "The hall is in good spirits."

"The hall has been fed," Amira said. "Spirits follow the kitchen more reliably than the throne."

He laughed, the real laugh of a man who enjoyed being answered, and the laugh drew two heads at the nearest table and he was aware of them drawing and let himself be aware of them, comfortable in the small gravity of his own presence. "I had hoped to put a word in for the river prefectures before the commissions sit," he said. "The waterworks matter

from the spring. There is feeling in the guilds that the cistern ruling left things unsettled."

"The cistern ruling settled the law," Amira said. "It left the feeling unsettled because the feeling was never about the law. Bring me the instrument they want drawn and I will read it. Do not bring me the feeling. I have feeling enough of my own about cisterns."

Marun inclined his head, taking the correction the way a man takes a coin he half expected, and he asked after the autumn commissions then, lightly, as a man asks after the weather of a country he means to travel through, and Amira told him what would be announced because it would be announced within the hour regardless. The Bureau of Establishments would seat its review bodies. The Third Appointments Commission would carry forward into the cold session. He nodded along to the names of the bodies with the attention of a man who found them as dull as he was meant to find them, and there was nothing in his face when the Third Appointments Commission was named, no flicker, no settling, and Amira marked the nothing the way Eleanor had taught her to mark such things, and filed it where she filed all the nothings, which was in a place she did not yet have a use for. He bowed again and withdrew, and the second course came up the room behind him on the shoulders of the servers, and the smell of it changed from meat to the sharp green of the dressed bitter leaves that the southern tables loved and the northern delegations left untouched on their plates.

In the colonnade along the eastern wall, where the lamplight thinned and the music came through as a pressure more than a melody, Lady Provost Imara Shandt stood with a cup she was not drinking and conducted three conversations at once without appearing to conduct any. She held the provostship of the upland schools, which gave her the placing of every magister who came out of them, and so she was never without men around her, and tonight there were four, and she moved among the four of them with the economy of a woman who had long since stopped finding any of it interesting and had not let the boredom reach her face.

A magister of the Bureau of Establishments stood at her left, a younger man in the administrative gray, and he was telling her about the

autumn rosters in the low fast voice of a man who believes he is being indiscreet and is enjoying it. "The carry-forward list is longer this session than last," he was saying. "Half again as long. The reconciliation backlog out of the Outer Prefectures has grown faster than the commissions can clear it, and so it carries, and carries, and the books grow fat with it."

"The books have always grown fat," Lady Provost Shandt said. "That is what books are for." She turned her cup a quarter and did not drink from it. "Which prefectures."

"Sennar chiefly. The eastern uplands. The whole of the Outer establishment, but Sennar leads it." The young magister lowered his voice further, pleased with his own caution. "Between us, Provost, I have stopped reading the carry-forward entries with any care. There are too many. You confirm what the prior commission confirmed and you move to the next. To read each would take a year and confirm nothing the prior body did not already confirm."

"Then you confirm what the prior commission confirmed," she said, "and you trust that the prior commission read what the one before it confirmed, and so on back to a commission that read nothing because it was the first and had nothing behind it but a clean book." She set the cup down on the ledge of the colonnade window and left it there. "You have described a chain in which every link trusts the link before it and no link bears weight. I taught logic before I placed magisters. Go and enjoy the wine. You have given me something to be tired about."

The young magister did not understand that he had been dismissed, or understood and did not mind it, and he drifted toward the wine, and Lady Provost Shandt stood a moment longer at the window with her undrunk cup beside her and looked out at the dark grounds where nothing moved, and then she turned back into the room and was claimed at once by the next of her men, and the thing the young magister had said went into her the way a splinter goes in, unfelt at first under the press of the evening, set to ache later.

Amira left the head table during the third course, which a ruler was permitted to do once in an evening, to move down the room and let the lower tables feel the throne pass near them. She went with two of the Lionesses at a distance that read as escort to those who needed it to read

that way and as nothing to those who did not, and she stopped at the table of the upland herders' delegation, who had waited a season for their petition and had been seated, by her order, no lower than the river guilds, and she asked the eldest of them about the autumn drive and the state of the high pasture, and she listened to the answer, the whole of it, while the man's hands described the grass with the unconscious eloquence of a man who had spent his life reading it. The southern oils and the foreign scents of the court tables gave way here to wool and woodsmoke carried in the herders' clothes, the smell of the high country that did not wash out in a single season at court, and Amira breathed it and was, for the length of the answer, somewhere other than the hall.

It was while she stood at the herders' table that she saw Eleanor.

The old woman had been brought a chair, as she was always brought a chair, set near the eastern colonnade where the light failed, and she sat in it with her hands folded over the head of the cane and her eyes half-lidded against the smoke of the lamps, and from the body of the hall she was furniture, an old administrator placed where the room could feel her without being asked to attend to her. Amira did not cross to her. In the four years of her reign she had crossed to Eleanor in a public room exactly never, and she would not begin tonight. She let her gaze pass over the colonnade the way it passed over the colonnade's lamps, and in the passing she saw what Eleanor was watching, because Eleanor's stillness had a direction to it the way still water has a current under the surface, and the direction was the long service door at the foot of the eastern wall through which the wine came up from the cellars. Amira looked at the door and saw a server pass through it with a tray and saw nothing else, and she returned her attention to the herder's hands and the high grass, and filed the door, and the angle of the old woman's attention, and the nothing she had seen in the doorway, into the place where the nothings went.

Behind the eastern wall the service passage ran the length of the hall, low-ceilinged and lit by working lamps set in iron brackets, and the music did not reach it; it stopped at the wall as though the wall had been built to stop it, and what crossed into the passage instead was the duller sound of the kitchens below and the feet of the servers on the stone and

the occasional swing of the door letting in a wash of the hall's roar before it closed again and cut it off. The air here was different, cooler and wetter, the cellar air rising through the floor, and over it the smell of the kitchens, the fat and the smoke and the scorched edge of a sauce held too long over the fire.

Two men spoke in the passage near the wine store, a steward of the household and a man in the plain dress of a contracted carrier, the sort of man the household used to bring goods up from the lower city and who came and went through the service entrances by the hundred across a season. They spoke of the wine. The steward was counting it against a list and the carrier was confirming the count, and it was the dullest conversation in the building, and a third man stood a little apart from them and waited, and he was the kind of man the eye declined to hold. He was of middle height and middle years, with a face the demographic of the empire had stamped out a hundred million times, neither dark enough nor pale enough nor marked enough to fix in the memory, and he wore the same plain carrier's dress as the man at the list, and he carried a flat leather case of the sort the bureaus used to move documents, and he waited with the patience of a man who had waited in a great many passages. When the steward finished his count and turned back toward the hall, the forgettable man stepped to the carrier and the two of them exchanged a word too quiet for the passage to carry, and the carrier took something from the flat case and put it inside his coat, and the forgettable man took the case back and turned and walked the length of the passage away from the hall, toward the lower doors and the city, and no one marked his going because there was nothing in his going to mark. A man with a case had come and gone through a service passage. The passages were full of such men. That was what the passages were for.

Magister Faraj Oduya found Councillor Otho Bey at the wine table during the lull before the final course, and the two of them stood with their backs to the hall in the way men stand when they wish the hall to see only their backs. Oduya held a magistracy of the appellate courts and Bey held a seat on the council that voted the bureau budgets, and between them they could move a great deal of the empire's middle

machinery, and they knew it, and they were careful with each other the way two men are careful when each holds a thing the other wants.

"The autumn budget," Bey said, low, into his cup. "The Bureau of Establishments has asked for more clerks. Reconciliation clerks. To clear the carry-forward backlog before it carries another year."

"And you will give them the clerks," Oduya said.

"I will give them the clerks. It is the dumbest request in the budget and it will pass without a word said. More clerks to clear more backlog. Who votes against clerks." Bey drank. "I tell you because you sit appeals out of the Outer Prefectures, and the magistrates you hear appeals on are the magistrates these clerks will be confirming, and I would have you know that the books behind your bench are about to grow faster than any one man could read them, so that when a thing comes up out of Sennar that does not sit right, you will not waste a year of your court looking for a clerk's error in a stack no court could clear."

Oduya was quiet a moment, turning his cup. He was a careful man, and the care had kept him on his bench through three reigns of the appellate courts, and the care heard something in what Bey had said that Bey had not meant to put there, or had meant to put there and would never admit to. "You are telling me," he said slowly, "to expect things out of Sennar that do not sit right."

"I am telling you," Bey said, "to expect a great deal of backlog and a great many clerks, and to keep your bench clean while both grow, because a clean bench is the only thing a man in your seat or mine will have left to stand on if the books behind us are ever read by someone with a year to spend and a reason to spend it." He set down his cup. "I am telling you nothing. I am a councillor talking about a budget at a dinner. Go and find better company. You have made me say more than the wine should let a man say."

He moved off into the room, and Oduya stood at the wine table with his cup and looked at the hall for a while, and the music came down from the gallery over the dark windows, and somewhere the last course was rising from the kitchens on the shoulders of the servers, and the magister of appeals filed away what he had heard in the place a careful man keeps the things he cannot yet act on and cannot afford to forget.

Amira gave the announcement from the head table before the last course was cleared, standing, with the hall stilled under her and the music dropped to nothing at her lifted hand. She named the autumn commissions in the flat exact voice she used for instruments of state, the review bodies of the Bureau of Establishments, the seating of the appellate rosters, the carry-forward of the Third Appointments Commission into the cold session, and the hall received the names with the polite half-attention the names deserved, because they were the dullest possible news and the dinner had been good, and the only sign that anything in the recitation carried weight was that nobody anywhere in the room reacted to it at all, which was itself a kind of stillness, and which Amira felt from the dais the way a swimmer feels a cold layer of water rise from below. She finished the announcement. She wished the hall a good cold season. She sat, and the music came back up out of the gallery, and the last course went down the room, and the dinner began the long settling toward its end.

She did not look for Eleanor again. When she let her gaze cross the eastern colonnade a final time, near the end of the evening, the chair that had been brought for the old woman stood empty, carried out or soon to be, and Eleanor was gone, and the place where she had sat was only a place again, a chair in the failing light at the edge of a room. Amira marked the absence the way she had marked the presence, and put it where the rest of the evening had gone.

The hall emptied the way such halls empty, slowly and then all at once, the delegations leaving in the order of their precedence and the precedence dissolving near the doors into the ordinary press of people who had eaten and drunk and wished now to be elsewhere. The servers came in behind the leaving to strip the long tables, and the music stopped in the gallery without ceremony, the players packing their instruments into the cases that fit them, and the great room that had held four hundred pockets of moving air gave the air back to the high cold ceiling and grew still, and the smell of the food went stale and flat as the plates were carried out, the rich layers of it collapsing into the single tired smell of a room where a great deal had been eaten and the windows had not been opened.

The Clerk of Petitions, Obasi, came through near the end with the household stewards, walking the length of the hall to confirm that the throne's tables had been struck in the right order, and at the foot of the eastern wall, near the service door through which the wine had come up all evening, he found a small side table that had not been cleared, set apart from the long tables in the lee of the colonnade, laid for one. A single place. A cup, a plate, the small folded card the household used to mark a seating, the name on it in the steward's hand, and a chair drawn out and never pushed in. The food on the plate had not been touched. The wine in the cup had not been poured. The steward beside Obasi looked at his list and looked at the table and could not find, in the list, the reason the table had been set, and Obasi told him to leave it, and the steward left it, and they went on down the room.

The household put out the lamps as it went, the long rows of them quenched in order from the head of the hall toward the doors, and the great dark came down the room behind the stewards in a slow tide, and the last of the servers passed out through the eastern door with the last of the plates, and the hall stood empty under its high invisible ceiling. At the foot of the eastern wall, in the lee of the colonnade, beside the chair that had been drawn out and never pushed in, one lamp had been left burning over the small table laid for one, where the card stood in the steward's hand and the cup held no wine and the plate held a cold untouched meal set for someone who had not come.

CHAPTER EIGHT

What Meret Knows

MERET HAD ASKED FOR the room at the second hour, before the compound came to itself, and Asha had granted it the way she granted most things Meret asked for, without question and with the understanding that Meret did not ask for much. The room sat at the end of the assessment corridor, the small one, built so that a voice raised to its ordinary pitch did not reach the wall and a voice dropped below that reached nothing at all. The walls were doubled and the door hung on oiled hinges that gave back no sound, and there was a table and two chairs and nothing on the walls, none of the columns of initials that hung in the larger rooms, because the room had been built for the kind of conversation that left no record until an officer decided to make one. Asha came down to it cold from her own quarters, the corridor still dark, the duty lamps burning low at their stations, and she let herself in and sat in the chair that faced the door, as she always did, and waited.

The compound at this hour had a smell it lost by the fourth, before the kitchens woke and the day's oil went onto the hinges. It was the smell of stone that had cooled all night and the faint mineral edge of the wash-water the night crew ran through the lower corridors, and over it, very thin, the cold ash of yesterday's lamps not yet relit. Asha had spent more mornings than she could count in this stillness before the building filled, and she knew that a person who asked for a room at the second hour had been awake in it a long time before the asking.

Meret came in at the second hour exactly. She closed the door with the flat of her hand, felt it seat, and sat in the chair across the table without being told to, square to it, her forearms coming to rest on the worn wood. She had a folder with her. She set it down and kept her hands on it, folded, the way she kept her hands on things, and did not open it.

"You have had this a while," Asha said. It was not a question. Meret did not ask for the small room to bring something a day old.

"Six weeks," Meret said.

Asha let that sit between them. Six weeks was a long time for Meret to carry a thing without sending it up the chain, and the length of it was the first piece of information in the room, before the folder, before a word of what was in it. Asha did not ask why Meret had waited. She would hear the why in the shape of what came next, or she would not, and either way the asking would have been an officer wanting to be told she was owed an explanation. Meret had her reasons and they had a discipline to them, and that was enough to begin from.

"Then tell me what it is," Asha said, "and tell me how it came to you, in that order."

Meret nodded, once, and began the way she did everything, from the bottom, with the parts that had dates on them.

"I keep the periphery summaries that Silva sends up," she said. "Not her field notes; the clean summaries, after she has cut them down for the file. I log them in and cross them against the transfer registers from the outer waystations, the arrivals and departures the stations post up the standard channel. That is the routine work, the reconciling. I have done it three years and I know its grain." She turned the folder a quarter on the table, not opening it, only squaring it nearer her own hands. "Six weeks ago I logged a summary out of a waystation on the Sennar feeder, and there was a face in it Silva had noted in passing, a man at a document counter, no flag on him, just a description she put down because she puts everything down. A courier's satchel. The loose look of a man waiting for nothing in a place where everyone waits for something. She moved on. It was not her matter; she was working a different line that day."

"Go on."

"I had seen the description before." Meret said it flat, without weight, the way she would have read a register entry aloud. "Not the man. The description. Three weeks earlier, in a summary out of a different waystation, a different jurisdiction, on a feeder that does not connect to the Sennar line and has no traffic that crosses it. Same satchel. Same loose attention. A man at a transfer point with no onward booking the station could post, present long enough to be noted and gone before the next register cycle closed." She paused, and Asha understood the pause was Meret deciding how much of her method to put into the room and choosing to put all of it. "I do not trust a description twice. A satchel is a satchel and a man waiting is half the people in a waystation. So I did not flag it. I laid the two summaries beside each other and looked for the thing that would tell me it was the same man or the thing that would tell me it was two, and there was not enough on the page to do either. So I left it open and kept logging, and watched the registers as they came up, and waited to see whether the description came a third time."

"And it came a third time," Asha said.

"It came four more times in six weeks." Meret opened the folder now. She lifted the cover and turned it back and laid her hand flat on the top sheet, one she had ruled herself, columns down it, dates and station codes and a short line of description against each, the same phrases recurring down the column because she had used the same words each time on purpose, so that the eye could catch the repetition. "Six instances, six weeks. Five waystations. Every one a transfer point, where a thing moves from one line to another and the register has to be re-cut by hand. Every one on a feeder that touches a jurisdiction where the field work has flagged something in the appointment records this season. I did not put that last part together myself. I keep the summaries, not the appointment files. But I keep the jurisdiction codes, and the codes on my six are the ones I have heard senior officers ask the analysis hall about in the last two months, and I am not deaf in a corridor."

Asha drew the folder a hand's width across the table and read the ruled sheet without touching it, top to bottom, the way she read everything the first time, for the shape and not the argument. Six rows. Six dates, the earliest seven weeks back, the most recent eleven days. Five station codes, one of them appearing twice. A column of descrip-

tions in Meret's square hand, the same four or five phrases worked across all six rows so that they stacked when you ran your eye down them. It was the cleanest kind of work the Quarter did, the kind no examination on a page would teach a person to do, because the doing of it was patience and the patience could not be coached.

"You are reconciling registers," Asha said, reading still, "and a face you have no name for keeps standing up off the page in the places the appointment work is hot. And you have laid it out so that if you are wrong, the wrongness shows as plainly as the rightness."

"If I am wrong it is because six men in six waystations carried the same satchel and waited the same way and booked nothing the station could post," Meret said. "I do not think that is what happened. But I have built it so that it could be, because the day I build it so that it cannot be is the day I have stopped reconciling and started to decide."

Asha looked up at her then. The room was small enough that there was nowhere to look but at the other or at the table, the closeness the point of it, two people set near enough that nothing passed between them the room would let escape. Meret met the look and held it, plain and unhurried, and Asha saw in it none of the thing she watched for in the assessment chair, none of the wanting to be right, only a woman who had carried a finding carefully for six weeks and decided this morning she had carried it as far as one person should.

"This is why you waited," Asha said.

"I waited because three instances is a coincidence I have seen before and been wrong about," Meret said. "Four would have been a pattern, but two of the four I could not stand behind; the descriptions were thin and I would not pad them. I waited until I had six I could stand behind. I have six." She closed the folder over her own sheet, gently, her hand flat on the cover. "I did not wait because I was afraid to be wrong in front of you, Officer. I waited because if I bring you a thing before it will hold, and you act on it, and it does not hold, I have spent the Quarter's reach on my unease, and there is an operation in the field this season the unease could foul. I do not know what it is. I know there is one, because the analysis hall has not slept and a senior was woken for a roster eleven days ago and Kaviel has been in her office past the tenth hour more nights than not. I keep the night log. I see who burns the lamp. I did not

need to be told there was something running to know that a wrong move from me could put a foot through it."

Asha sat with that. It was the longest she had heard Meret speak in a year, and Meret had spent it telling her, in operational language and no other, a thing a lesser officer would have dressed as conscience and a worse one as apology. There was no apology in it, only a woman accounting for a decision the way she would account for a register, and Asha respected the accounting more than she would have respected any speech about duty. She did not say so. Meret had not brought the finding to be told she had done well with it.

"You were right to wait," Asha said instead, the same thing said as a finding rather than a comfort. "And you are right to bring it now. Six holds. Three would not have. You know the difference and you held the line at it. That is the work."

Meret inclined her head a degree and said nothing, which was the correct amount to say.

Asha opened the folder again and read it the second way, slower, against what she carried that Meret did not. Meret kept the summaries and the registers and not the appointment files, and so had brought a pattern in transport and could not see the pattern in the records it lay against. Asha sat high enough in the analysis chain to have heard the jurisdiction codes spoken in the hall and to know which had gone hot and why, and she laid Meret's six station codes against that knowing now, row by row, and watched them fall into the hot jurisdictions one after another with the regularity of a thing that was not chance.

"Tell me about the man," Asha said. "Not the satchel. You have given me the satchel. What does this face do, in your reading, that puts him in five waystations in six weeks at the transfer points and nowhere the register can post."

"He carries," Meret said. "He does not travel. A traveler books an onward leg and the station posts it; this man has no onward leg the station can show, which means he is handing off. A transfer point is where a thing leaves one line and joins another and the register is re-cut by hand, and a thing handed across at the moment the register is open can be moved without a clean line from where it started to where it went. He is at the seam every time, and the seam is where the record can be

made to lose the thread." She said it without heat, a register entry still. "I think he moves paper, because a courier's satchel carries paper and the jurisdictions are the appointment jurisdictions, and a record-trouble that runs across jurisdictions needs a hand to carry the false thing from where it is made to where it is filed, by a route that does not post. I cannot prove the satchel holds appointment papers; I have never seen inside it. I am telling you the shape my reading takes and where it stops being something I can stand behind."

It was the same discipline Kaviel kept, the line drawn hard between what the page held and what the mind reached past it for, the thing the Quarter selected for above all the rest, the thing she had watched a competent soldier fail to have in the assessment chair weeks back. She set the thought aside.

"You have a face and a method and six instances and no name," Asha said.

"I have no name," Meret agreed. "Silva did not have one. The registers do not carry one for him, because a man who hands off at the seam does not give the counter a name it logs. I have a description and a route and a rhythm. I do not have a man I could put a hand on."

Asha read the rightmost column again, the one Meret had not spoken to, a narrow column at the edge where she had set down, against four of the six rows, a cluster of marks that were not description and not date. Asha had taken them for register codes on the first reading. They were not. They were initials, partial ones, a single letter standing alone in three of the rows and a letter and a half-formed second in the fourth, set down small and tight against the rule.

"What are these," Asha said, and put her finger to the column without touching the page.

"That is the thing I am least sure of," Meret said, "and the reason I almost brought you only the pattern." She did not reach for it; she let Asha hold it. "Three of the waystations keep a hand-signed transfer chit when a thing is moved across by a person rather than down a posted line. It is an old practice, kept in the outer stations and let go in the central ones, a man putting his mark to say the thing passed through his hand. It carries no legal weight. No one reconciles it; it sits in a box at the station until the box is full and then it is burned. Silva does not collect it because

it tells you nothing on its own. But three of my six stations keep it, and on the days my face was in those three, a chit was signed across the seam, and the mark, where I could read it, began with the same letter."

Asha was very still.

"Which letter," she said.

"B," Meret said.

The room held it. Asha did not move and did not let her face move, the not-moving a discipline she had kept for forty years and kept now, because a single letter set down in a small room at the second hour was either the first true edge of a thing the Quarter had been reading the shape of for two months or a coincidence of a courtesy practice in three outer stations, and her face would not decide which before her reading had.

"Where you could read it," she said. "Not all three."

"Two I read plainly. The third the chit was smudged and I would not swear past the letter, which is why the half-mark is in the fourth row and not a full one. The fourth station did not keep chits; that row has no mark and I left it empty rather than carry the letter across to it, because the letter belongs to the chits and not to the man, until I have a reason to join them." Meret's hands had come back to folded on the closed folder. "It is the first letter of a name signed on a courtesy chit by a man who handed a thing across a seam, on the days my face was in the station, at three stations of the five. It is not the man's name. It could be the man. It could be a station hand who signed for a transfer that had nothing to do with him. The chit says nothing past the one mark. I laid it at the edge of the sheet on purpose, so that it sits beside the pattern and not inside it. If you take the letter into the pattern you are deciding the courier's name begins with it, and I have not earned that, and I will not put my hand to it until it is earned."

Asha read the column one more time, the lone B set tight against the rule in three rows, the empty fourth where a lesser hand would have filled the letter in to make the page look finished. She thought of a roster pulled from below the active line eleven days back and a reconciliation review stood up under an authority no clerk would name, and of the appointment work that ran across exactly the jurisdictions whose codes were stacked in front of her in Meret's square hand. She held enough of

their shape to know that Meret had brought her, without being able to see the far side of it herself, the first thread in two months that ran from the records into a hand, a hand that moved at the seams where the record lost its thread, in the jurisdictions where the false appointments surfaced, leaving a single letter on a courtesy chit no one was meant to read and that Meret had read because Meret read everything.

It was the most incomplete thing she had been handed in weeks, a letter and a satchel and a rhythm, and the incompleteness was the part she would have to carry now, because she sat where the deciding was. Act on a letter as though it were a name and the operation already running in the field, the one whose lamp Meret saw burning past the tenth hour, could turn on the wrong man, or on the right man too soon, before the thing behind him had shown its reach. Wait for the name and the man kept handing off at the seams while they waited, and the longer he handed off the more the record lost. Asha had sat with that choice a hundred times and it did not get lighter with the hundredth.

This was not a day to move on the man. A courier handing off at the seams was a node and not a head, the kind of figure a process used and replaced, and to reach for him now was to spend the surprise on the part of the machine that mattered least and warn the part that mattered most. But the letter was a true edge, and a true edge logged did not have to be found again, and the finding of it had cost Meret six weeks she had spent well.

"You will keep doing exactly what you have been doing," Asha said. "Log the summaries, reconcile the registers, change nothing in how you do it, because the value of what you brought me is that it came up out of the routine and not out of a man looking for it. If you start looking for him, the looking will change the shape of what you see, and I would lose the one reading in this building that is not bent toward an answer. You watch. You log. The next time the face comes up, you note the station and the date and whether a chit was kept, and you bring it to me here, to no one else, and you put it in no standing file. A thread this thin breaks if it is handled by more hands than need to hold it, and right now the hands that need to hold it are yours and mine."

"Understood," Meret said.

"The sheet stays with me."

"I made it to give to you."

Asha drew it the last of the way across the table and squared it to the folder's edge. "Kaviel is working a shape of this from the records side. She does not have what you have; you do not have what she has; neither of you is to be told what the other holds until I decide the two halves are worth joining, and that decision is mine and it is not made this morning." She said the name once and let it lie, because Meret kept the night log and knew whose lamp burned and would have her own shape forming of why Asha named her, and she would keep that shape to herself the way she kept everything. "You have not spoken Kaviel's name in connection with any of this. You will not."

"I have not," Meret said. "I will not."

Asha rose and went to the low cabinet against the doubled wall, unmarked, locked with a key she carried and not one the building held. She took out a ledger that was hers and not the Quarter's, narrow, bound in plain dark board, the log a senior officer kept of threads too thin to file and too true to lose, and carried it back and uncapped her pen. Meret had risen when Asha rose, and stood at the far side of the small table with her closed folder under her hand, waiting to be released, watching without watching the way she did.

The room had warmed a half-degree with the two of them in it, the ash smell of the dead lamps thinning, and somewhere far down through the doubled walls the first sound of the kitchens reached them as a vibration more than a noise, the day beginning to assemble itself two floors below while the small room held its silence a moment longer. Asha turned to a clean page near the back of the ledger, past the older threads in her own cramped hand, and set the date at the head of it, and the station codes from Meret's sheet beneath, the rhythm, the absence of an onward booking, the courtesy chit and what it did and did not prove. She wrote it short, because a long entry was an officer arguing with herself on the page and she was not arguing; she had decided. At the foot of the entry, in the narrow space she left for the thing each thread came down to, she wrote a single letter, and looked at it a moment in her own hand, the lone B sitting at the bottom of the page the way it had sat at the edge of Meret's sheet, an edge and not a name, true and not yet enough.

She capped the pen. She closed the ledger over the letter and set her hand flat on the cover for the length of a breath, and then she stood.

"We work from what we have," she said.

INTERLUDE 2

Personal Correspondence, Eleanor De Grosvenor to Kaviel De Grosvenor

The following was recovered from a locked compartment in Eleanor De Grosvenor's private effects, sealed but bearing no dispatch mark, written in her own hand. It was never sent, and there is no record that Kaviel ever read it.

Kaviel,

I have started this letter four times across as many years and burned three of the attempts. I am keeping this one because I am old enough now to know I will not write a fifth, and because the things I have left unsaid have begun to outweigh the things I have managed to say to you, which were never many.

I want to tell you first what I saw when they brought you to me. You will not remember it, and I have never described it, because to describe it would have meant telling you what I decided in the same room, within the same hour. I held you for the length of time it takes to read a short report. Then I gave you to the house, to be raised by people I trusted to do it better than I would, and I went back to work that did not wait. I have told myself for thirty years that this was the correct allocation. It was correct. It was also a thing I did, with my hands, and the correctness of it has never once made it lighter to carry.

You should understand that I did not give you to the work because I did not want you. I gave you to the work because I knew what I was, and I knew what I would make of a child kept close. I had already watched the house take in promising people and grind the soft parts off them. I did not want to be the hand that did that to you across a breakfast table for fifteen years. So I arranged for it to be done by strangers who were kinder than I am, and by a discipline that does not pretend to love you while it shapes you. I believed you would be more whole that way. I still believe it. I am only no longer certain the belief was about you.

I have read your field assessments. All of them, going back to your probationary year, including the ones Asha marked low and the ones you appealed. You were right to appeal two of them and wrong to appeal the third, and the fact that you knew which was which before the review board did is the thing that told me what you would become. You do not work the way I work. I have spent six decades learning who owes whom, who can be moved by debt and who by vanity, where a man keeps the favor he is ashamed of. You learned instead to read a page until it confesses. I used to think the document was the smaller instrument. I was wrong about that, and the wrongness has cost the house time I cannot recover. The networks I built are aging out with me. The records will outlast every name I ever cultivated. You saw that before I admitted it.

I want to say something now that I have never said inside the walls, where it would be heard as weakness and filed as such. I am afraid. The apparatus I assembled was built around the assumption that I would always be in the room. I am not always in the room any longer. There are afternoons I lose, hours I cannot account for, decisions I have to make twice because I do not trust the first version. When the test comes, and it is coming, I will not be at full strength to meet it. You will. And I put you where you stand, knowing this hour would arrive and that you would have to hold the thing I built without me holding it with you. That was not an accident of your talent. It was a choice I made when you were small, and I dressed it in words like obligation so that I would not have to call it what it was.

The compact between this house and the throne is older than Amira and older than me, and you have inherited a place in it that you did not

ask for and could not refuse, because I arranged your life so that refusing was never available to you. I am not going to pretend that was fair. It was not fair. It was necessary, by my reckoning, and I have learned that necessity and unfairness sit at the same table more often than anyone in my position will admit aloud. You have every right to resent the position. I would think less of you if some part of you did not.

Here is what I cannot say to your face, and so I am saying it to a page I may never give you. You did not become what you are because of the name. The name opened doors. It did not write the assessments. It did not catch the things you have caught. Whatever I arranged, the work itself is yours, and no part of it was inherited. I have watched a great many people fail to be equal to what was demanded of them. You have not been one of them. That you are not warm toward me, that you keep the careful distance the work requires between us, I understand and do not hold against you. I built that distance. I would only ask, if you ever read this, that you not mistake my distance for indifference. It was the opposite, kept under discipline so long that it learned to look like nothing at all.

I am going to seal this and put it where the rest of my private papers go, and I expect it will be read, if it is read, by someone going through my effects with a ledger after I am gone. If that someone is you, then know that I went over every line and meant each one, and that I corrected the punctuation twice, because even here I could not let it go untidy.

Be careful with the documents. They are telling you the truth before the people do. Trust them, and trust yourself reading them, ahead of anything I taught you about loyalty.

E. De Grosvenor

CHAPTER NINE

The Investigation Opens

THE ROOM HAD BEEN a store for forty years, and it gave that up reluctantly. They had pulled the broken assessment furniture out of it the day before, the chairs with the splintered legs and the cabinets whose locks had been cut and never replaced, and what remained when the carrying was done was a long cold space under the north wall of the compound with a smell that no airing had yet moved, the dry smell of board and binding left too long without handling, of old paper that had sat in stacks against stone and taken on the cold of it. Kaviel had asked for this room and not a better one. A better one would have had a use the building could name, and a use the building could name was a use someone could ask after.

She stood in the doorway a moment before she went in, the way she did with any space she meant to work from, reading it for what it would and would not let her do. There was one window, high and narrow, set into the thickness of the north wall where the masonry was deepest, and at this hour it gave a light that came in flat and gray and lay across the floor without reaching the inner half of the room, so that the far end stood in a dimness the single lamp on the long table did not take back. She had cracked the window already, out of the habit she kept in her own office, and the moving air had thinned the paper smell near the glass and left it banked at the back of the room where the stacks were.

Zola Adimu was at the long table when Kaviel came in, standing, not sitting, with her hands at her sides and a stillness to her that was the

stillness of someone who had arrived early and decided that sitting before she was told to sit would be the wrong thing. She was young enough that the youth was the first fact about her and would be for another two years, until the work wore it down into something a stranger would not lead with. Kaviel had read her file twice. Top of her analytical cohort, slow where the others were quick and right where the others were fast, the kind of researcher Asha graded high and worked hard because the patience was already in her and only the method had to be put on top of it.

"You found it," Kaviel said.

"Asha sent me down at the first hour. The stacks were already here." Zola's eyes went to them and came back. "I sorted what I could read the labels on. The rest I left as it came."

Kaviel walked the length of the table. Someone, Zola or whoever had done the carrying, had laid the document stacks along it in an order, and the order was not bad. It ran by jurisdiction, the Sennar Prefecture nearest the lamp where the most of it was, and then the others falling away down the table into the dim end, each prefecture's records squared and weighted with whatever had come to hand, a cut of stone in one place, a dead lamp base in another. There was a map on the wall above the table, the only thing on any wall, a working map of the Outer Prefectures with the numbered jurisdictions marked in the dry imperial style and nothing on it yet in any hand but the printer's.

"This is the work," Kaviel said. She did not say it warmly. She said it the way Asha said a thing was the work, as a statement of where they now stood and what it would ask. "I am going to tell you what we are doing and the bounds of it, once, and then we begin, and you will hold the bounds as hard as you hold the method, because the bounds are the part that keeps the rest of it standing."

Zola nodded. She had a stylus already and a clean sheet, and she did not write yet, because she had been taught well enough to know that the first telling of a thing was for the ear and the second for the page.

"We have a mandate," Kaviel said. "It is real. The Lioness charter gives us standing to examine any imperial record where the integrity of the record bears on the protection of the throne, and the integrity of the appointments record bears on it, because a false magistrate rules in the

empire's name and binds the empire's subjects, and a false administrator signs in the empire's hand. No one drafted that clause for this. But it holds for this. I have read it against three older uses and it holds." She set two fingers on the Sennar stack. "What it gives us is the record. We may pull the appointment files, the commission rosters, the prefectural registries, the transit manifests where they touch a record we are examining, and we may set them beside one another and read what the reading shows. That is a great deal. It is also the whole of it."

"And what it does not give us," Zola said. Not a question. She had heard the shape of the sentence coming.

"It does not give us a person. We do not question a serving official under this mandate. We do not enter a working office, we do not pull a man's correspondence, we do not put a watch on anyone who has not first walked up out of the record on his own. The mandate is over paper. The moment we reach past the paper to a hand, we are doing a thing the charter does not cover, and a thing the charter does not cover is a thing that has to be authorized from above the Quarter, and authorization from above the Quarter is a door, and a door can be watched from the other side." She let that sit. "Do you follow the distinction. Tell it back."

"We read the records. We do not touch the people." Zola's voice was even. "Until a person is already in the records, where we can read them without being told we are allowed to look."

"Until then." Kaviel moved down the table to the dim end and stood where the gray light gave out. "Now the part that is harder than the method, and I want it from you before we have logged a single entry, because once we are in it the work will tempt you to forget it. Who knows that this room is open."

Zola was quiet a moment. "I do not know. I was sent down. I was not told why, past sorting the stacks."

"Asha knows, because the room sits under her and a room does not open in the Quarter without her knowing what it is. Eleanor De Grosvenor knows, because I told her, and I will say more about that. You know, now. There is one more I will bring in when the financial records need her, and you will meet her and you will not ask what else she works." Kaviel turned. "That is the list. It does not grow without my word. You do not tell Meret. You do not tell the analysts you came up

with. You do not tell your family that you have been moved to sensitive work, because a young researcher moved to sensitive work is a thing a careful person can read at a dinner table from the way you stop talking about your day. You will keep talking about your day. You will have a dull day to talk about, and I will see that you do, so that the dullness is true and you are not made to lie, because a person made to lie gets caught at it and a person with a dull true day does not."

"Understood," Zola said.

"The Empress does not know." Kaviel said it plainly and watched the young face take it, the small work behind the eyes as Zola set it where it belonged and did not let it show on the front of her. "That is not an oversight and you will not treat it as one. There is a reason the Empress is not told a thing at the hour we would tell her, and the reason is that what she knows she must be able to act on, and what she acts on becomes the empire acting, and the empire acting at this hour, before we have a shape that holds, would warn the thing we are reading the shape of. I have told the head of this house, and the head of this house has not stopped me, and that is the authorization we are working under. It is thin. I want you to hear that it is thin, from me, today, so that you are never surprised by how thin it is."

She did not say Eleanor's name a second time, and she did not say the rest of it, that thin was the truest word for it and that she lay awake on the thinness of it more nights than she would have told Asha. Eleanor had heard it in the west-facing office over a cup of tea gone cold, sitting with her hands folded and the maps behind her on the wall, and had listened the whole way to the end without a word, which from her was its own kind of answer. Then she had said only that Kaviel was to work it from the records and to come to her and to no one else when she had a name, and that she would not be told the daily shape of it, because the head of a house that is asked under oath what she knew should be able to answer that she knew the daughter was working and not the hour-by-hour of what the daughter found. It was permission given as a withholding, the way Eleanor gave most things. Kaviel had taken it for what it was and gone down to open the room.

"Then we begin from the record we can stand on," she said, and came back up the table into the light. "Interlude, you would call it, if you were

the captain writing this down. The Third Appointments Commission filed a record. I have a copy." She drew it from the folder she had carried in, the full session record, header and seal, the one that had been filed plain and read by no one twice. She laid it before Zola at the lamp. "Read it. Not for what is wrong with it. There is nothing wrong with it on its face, and if you go looking for what is wrong you will find a thing that is not there and build on it. Read it for what it permits."

Zola read. She read slowly, which was correct, and she read it twice, which was better, and when she set it down her finger was on Item Four.

"The carry-forward reconciliation," she said.

"Tell me what it is. In your own words, not the record's."

"A way to enter an appointment into the standing record without reviewing it again, on the ground that a prior commission already reviewed it." Zola's voice had gone careful, the voice of someone walking a floor she had only just been told might give. "You produce the prior confirmation and an attestation from the originating office, and the entry is made citing the prior authority and the original date, and the commission does not look at it fresh because the whole point of the provision is to spare them looking at it fresh."

"And what does that give a person who wishes to put a name into the record that no commission ever confirmed."

Zola was silent the length of a breath. "It gives them a door that opens on the word that an older door was already opened. If the prior confirmation is true, the entry is clean. If the prior confirmation is false, the entry still reads clean, because no one at this commission is required to go back and check that the older door was ever there."

"Yes." Kaviel set her hand flat on the record. "That is the whole of the mechanism, and you found it in two readings, and I want you to remember that you found it that fast, because everything from here will be slower and you will need to remember that the center of it was plain once you knew where to stand. Now I am going to teach you the only method that gets us past it, and you are going to be the one who runs it, because I will be pulled into other rooms and you will be the patience this work has."

She pulled a clean sheet to herself and ruled it as she spoke, three columns, the rule going down in a hand that had ruled a thousand such sheets.

"Every carry-forward entry cites a prior authority. A prior commission, a session, a date, a folio. That is the claim the entry rests on. The entry says: I am clean because that older thing confirmed me. So we do not argue with the entry. We go and find the older thing." She wrote at the head of the first column, the entry. "We take each carry-forward entry, and we read off the prior authority it names." The second column, the claimed authority. "And then we go to the record of that prior authority, the older commission's own filed roster, and we look for the appointment the entry says it confirmed." The third column, and at its head she wrote nothing, and left it blank, and tapped it once with the stylus. "And one of three things is true. The prior roster confirms it, and the entry is clean, and we move on and we do not waste another hour on it. Or the prior roster exists and the appointment is not on it, and the entry rests on an authority that did not confirm it. Or the prior commission the entry names never sat at all, or sat and confirmed nothing in that jurisdiction, and the entry rests on an authority that does not exist."

Zola was writing now, fast and clean, getting the three columns down exactly.

"You see why it is slow," Kaviel said. "There is no single page that shows the fraud. The fraud is in the gap between two pages that are each clean on their own, and to find the gap you have to hold both pages at once, the entry and the older roster it names, and most of the older rosters are not where the entry says they are, because they are forty years of imperial backlog filed across four prefectures by clerks who are dead. You will spend a day finding a roster to spend a minute reading it. That is the work. The reconciliation trace, I call it, for want of a worse name. You trace the reconciliation back to the thing it reconciles to, and you find out whether the thing is there."

"How many of the entries do we trace," Zola said.

"All of them, in the end. We start with the ones that smell, the ones in the jurisdictions that have already gone hot, and we let those teach us what a bad entry looks like, and then we run the rest against what we

learned." Kaviel looked at the map a moment. "But you do not skip a clean-looking one because it looks clean. The man who built this is good, and a man who is good salts the clean ones in among the bad to make the bad look like noise. You trace them all. When you find a bad one, you do not exclaim and you do not bring it to me running. You log it, you note the entry and the claimed authority and what you found in the gap, and you set it aside and trace the next, and when you have a dozen you bring me twelve and not one, because one is a coincidence I have been wrong about and twelve is a shape, and I would rather wait for the shape."

She heard the echo of it as she said it, Asha's grain in her own mouth, six holds and three does not, the line drawn at the place where reading stopped and deciding began. She let it stand. It was the right thing said and it did not matter whose mouth had worn it first.

They worked. The morning went out of the high window and the flat gray light climbed the wall and shortened on the floor as the sun got up over the compound, and the lamp that had mattered at the first hour stopped mattering and then mattered again as the inner end of the room held its dimness into the afternoon the way deep masonry holds the cold. Kaviel took the Sennar stack, because Sennar was where the thing had first stood up off a page months back, the magistrate whose confirmation date fell before the session that was supposed to have confirmed him, the line she herself had passed over once and then not passed over. She traced the carry-forward entries in Sennar back to the prior commissions they named, and she found the first gap before the light had moved a hand's width, an entry that rested on a session of a prior appointments commission, cited by date and folio, and when she went to the older roster the session had sat and had confirmed eleven appointments and not one of them was the name the carry-forward entry claimed it had carried forward.

She did not exclaim. She logged it. Entry, claimed authority, the gap. She set it aside and traced the next.

By the middle of the afternoon she had four out of Sennar, and Zola, working slower and on the jurisdiction next to it, had two, and they had not spoken in an hour past the small sounds of the work, the turn of a page, the scrape of the lamp drawn nearer, the dry whisper of a stack squared again after a sheet was lifted from it and returned. The paper

smell had warmed with the day and the bodies in the room and lost its coldness, and under it now was the faint sharpness of the lamp oil and, when the door at the corridor's end opened and closed somewhere, the brief reach of the compound's ordinary noise, a voice, a cart, the building running as it always ran while in this room two people unmade a fraud one filed page at a time.

Asha came in once, near the fourth hour of the afternoon, without knocking because the room was hers to enter, and stood at the end of the table and read over Kaviel's shoulder the way she read everything the first time, for the shape and not the argument. She said nothing about the work. She looked at Zola a moment, and at the ruled sheets growing under Zola's hand, the three columns filling, and what she saw in them she kept to herself.

"How does she trace," Asha said to Kaviel, as though Zola were not in the room, which was a thing Asha did to a junior on purpose, to see whether the junior had the discipline to keep working through being spoken over.

Zola kept working.

"She traces the way I taught her this morning and better than I traced at her year," Kaviel said. "She is slow. The slow is the asset. Leave her on it."

Asha looked at the back of Zola's bent head a moment longer, and then she put a single mark in her own small ledger, the one bound in dark board, and went out, and that was the whole of the assessment, and Zola, who had felt every second of it and had not lifted her stylus, understood when the door shut that she had passed something and did not know its name and was correct not to ask.

It was past the eighth hour when Kaviel stopped. The gray window had gone dark and the lamp was the whole of the light now, the room shrunk down to the warm circle of it and the cold dim past its edge, and her hand had cramped twice and she had worked through both. She had nine out of Sennar. Zola had five out of the two jurisdictions beside it. Fourteen entries that rested on an authority that was not there, in three jurisdictions, in a single day's reading of the easiest stacks, the ones where the work had already been pointed.

She rose and stood at the wall under the map. She had brought a stylus to it without deciding to, and now she marked, against each jurisdiction where a bad entry had stood up off the page today, a small flat dot in her own hand, Sennar first, and then the two beside it, and she stood back from the three dots and looked at the printer's grid of numbered jurisdictions running away from them across the Outer Prefectures, the dozens of them, the ones she had not yet touched and the ones beyond the Outer Prefectures where the carry-forward provision had cousins under other commissions she had not yet thought to pull.

She had come into the room that morning believing it was Sennar and its neighbors, a regional thing, ugly and contained, the kind of rot that ran in one watershed because one office had gone bad. Three dots on the map at the end of a single day, and every one of them found in the first stacks, the stacks already pointed at, told her that the believing had been a comfort and not a finding. If the easiest reading in three jurisdictions gave fourteen, then the map was wrong to be so empty, and the emptiness was the measure of how few hands had yet read for the thing, no more than that. This was not one office gone bad. An office gone bad did not reach across three jurisdictions on three feeders that did not connect, and a man did not salt clean entries among bad ones across a watershed he did not control. Someone had built this wide, and built it slow, over years, with the provision read the same way in jurisdiction after jurisdiction by hands that had to have been pointed at the provision by the same understanding, and the map in front of her was not the picture of the fraud. It was the picture of how much of the fraud she had not yet found.

Behind her Zola was squaring the last of the day's stacks and weighting them, the dry whisper of it the only sound, the lamp throwing both their shadows long up the wall and across the map so that the three small dots sat in the moving dark of them. Kaviel stood with the stylus still in her hand and looked at the jurisdictions she had not marked, the white grid of them, and counted in her head what the finding meant was still waiting out there past it, and the count was larger than the room, larger than the mandate, larger than the thin permission she was working under and the head of the house who had given it to her and not asked to be told the daily shape.

"We start from the edges," she says, more to the map than to Zola.

CHAPTER TEN

The Administrator's Breakfast

THE BUREAU OF ESTABLISHMENTS' Outer Prefectures office had been awake since before the sun reached the city of Adwa, because the work it did had never depended on light. Sael Mokoena arrived at it the way he arrived every morning, on foot from the third terrace, through the lower gate the clerks used, into the long ground-floor corridor where the night registry was already handing off to the day. He liked the hour. He liked the building before it filled, when the great wheel of it turned slowly enough that a man could hear its parts. Somewhere above him a transcription engine clicked through a backlog, patient as rain on a roof. A floor-keeper was drawing a wide mop across the stone of the entrance hall, and the wet trail of it shone and faded behind her as the dry air took it back. The smell that met him at the door was the smell that had met him for nineteen years, lamp oil and old paper and the faint mineral cool of stone that the sun did not reach until midday.

He went first to the registry window, where Adisa had the night's intake stacked and banded.

"Morning, Deputy Registrar," she said, not looking up from the band she was tying. She was new, six weeks in the office, and she still used the full title where the others had let it wear down to nothing.

"Anything that won't keep until the session?"

"Two contests out of Lomé. A query from the Sennar registry about a folio reference, I put it on your desk. And the carry-forward schedule

came up from reconciliation overnight, they want your initial before it goes to the assessors."

"Leave the schedule with me. The Lomé contests can go to the morning list." He took the banded query without breaking his stride toward the stair, and she went back to her tying, and that was the whole of it, a deputy registrar collecting his correspondence from a registry clerk who thought no more about him after he had passed than she thought about the door.

His office was on the second floor, at the end where the corridor narrowed and the windows looked down into the inner courtyard the building had been built around. He had earned the room by length of service and held it the same way. It was not large. A desk worn pale at the front edge where two generations of registrars had rested their forearms, a wall of pigeonholes he had organized himself and trusted no one to touch, a side table for the kettle and the small enamel pot he kept there. He set the night's correspondence down, lit the lamp though the window gave him enough to see by, because he liked the lamp, and put the water on.

Breakfast came up from the kitchen at the half-hour, as it had every working day since the kitchen had learned his habits. A boiled egg, two flat rounds of the dark prefectural bread, a wedge of the hard yellow cheese the south sent up by the crate, and the bitter red tea he had learned to drink in his first posting and had never afterward been able to do without. He ate the way he did most things, without haste and without pleasure shown, the egg first, the shell going into the small dish for the purpose, the salt from the twist of paper he kept in the drawer. The bread he tore rather than cut. He read while he ate, because the morning was the only time the office gave him to read without interruption, and what he read was the carry-forward schedule reconciliation had sent up.

It was a good schedule. He could tell that at a glance, the way a man who has built a thing many times can tell sound work from poor. Forty-one entries, each one citing a prior commission's authority and attested by an originating office, the dates set down in the order the provision required, the date of original confirmation cited and the date of present entry left to the clerk. Thirty-nine of the forty-one were exactly what they appeared to be, lawful appointments long delayed in the record,

reconciled now because the backlog had at last reached them. He had reviewed thousands like them. The work of the office was real work, and most of it was honest, and the honesty of the most was the ground the rest stood on.

Two of the forty-one were his.

He did not look at them differently from the others. That was the discipline, and the discipline was the whole of the craft. He had learned long ago that a man who lingered over his own entries taught the page to betray him, that the eye of a later reader was drawn to wherever the writer's eye had lingered, and so he read his two the way he read the thirty-nine, no slower, no faster, his pen moving down the margin in the small even ticks that meant a deputy registrar had seen each line and found it in order. The two appointments were a magistrate's seat in a jurisdiction three prefectures east and a deputy assessor's post in a registry office no contest had ever troubled. Both cited a prior commission that had sat, that had kept minutes, that had confirmed appointments under exactly the authority now cited. The prior commission was real. Its authority was real. Only the two appointments had never been before it. He had given them the commission's authority the way a man borrows a true name to carry a false errand, and the errand passed because the name was good.

He initialed the schedule, all forty-one, and set it in the tray for the assessors, and finished his egg.

There was no part of this that felt to him like the thing the word for it would have made it. He had turned the word over once, years ago, alone, the way a man turns over a stone to see what it is, and had put it down again because it did not fit what he did at the desk in the early light. What he did at the desk was careful. It was patient. It harmed no one he could see, took nothing from anyone he could name, moved a few seats into hands he judged steadier than the empire's own indifferent procedures would have found for them, and did it inside the very provision the founding instrument of the commission had written for the purpose of moving things into the record without fresh review. The provision was the door. He had not built the door. He had only learned, better than the men who built it, where it led.

He poured the second cup of tea and let it cool while he opened the rest of the night's correspondence.

The Sennar query was nothing, a folio reference entered transposed, a clerk asking which of two numbers was right; he wrote the right one in the margin and set it for return. A circular from the Bureau's New Terra office on the standardization of attestation forms, which he read twice because anything that changed the forms could change what an attestation had to show, and put aside satisfied that it touched nothing of his. A note from the assessor Okonjo about the order of the morning session.

The last item in the band had no office mark.

It had come in as private correspondence, addressed to him by hand in a script he knew, routed through the courier service the office used for matter that did not go through the registry. He knew the hand because he had received perhaps a dozen such notes in four years, never more than a few words each, never signed. He broke the wax with his thumbnail and read it standing at the desk with the cold tea in his other hand.

A reconciliation auditor has been asking after Sennar entries. Three days, perhaps four. Not from the prefecture. From the center.

He read it once. He set it down on the desk, face up, and drank some of the tea, which had gone past warm into the flat lukewarm he disliked, and he read it again.

Then he finished the tea, because the tea would be no better for waiting and the note would be no worse for his having finished it, and he sat down.

A reconciliation auditor asking after Sennar entries was, in itself, nothing. Sennar was contested ground. A petitioner had brought a magistrate's ruling under question some quarters back, and a contested magistracy drew auditors the way standing water drew insects; it was the office working as the office was built to work. He had watched three such audits cross the Sennar entries in four years and pass through them without a snag, because the entries were sound on their face and an auditor read the face. An auditor from the prefecture was routine. From the center was less routine. The center did not send a man down over a single contest unless the single contest had grown a tail.

He did not let the thought run ahead of what the note gave him. The note gave him an auditor, a region, and a span of days. It did not give

him a name, an office, or a reason, and a man who acted on the part he had imagined rather than the part he had been told was a man who left marks where there had been none. He had survived four years by acting on what was in front of him and no more. He folded the note along its first crease and held it.

What was in front of him was this. Of his entries across four years, the Sennar cluster was the oldest and the densest, made in the period before he had learned to thin his work across jurisdictions, and four of the carry-forward entries in the original commission record traced to it. The four were sound. But sound on the face was a defense against an auditor who read the face, and an auditor sent from the center over a contest that had grown a tail might read deeper, might pull the prior commission's own minutes and lay them beside the carry-forward citations and count. If he counted, the count would hold for thirty-nine entries and would not hold for two, and the two were not in Sennar. The two he had initialed this morning were in jurisdictions east. But the method that found two would find them wherever they sat, and the method began in Sennar because Sennar was where a man would begin.

He rose and went to the wall of pigeonholes.

He made two adjustments before the morning session, and both were small, and both were the kind of thing a deputy registrar did a dozen times a week in the ordinary course of the office, which was why he had chosen them. The first was to the routing of the carry-forward schedule he had just initialed. He drew it back from the assessors' tray, where it would have gone up the line that day, and he reentered it on the supplementary list, the list of matter held for the close of the session pending a point of order, citing the standardization circular from New Terra as his ground; until the attestation forms were confirmed, he wrote, prudence held that fresh carry-forward entries wait. It was a defensible note, the note of a careful man, and it meant his two newest entries would not enter the standing record this quarter, would not exist for any auditor to find this quarter, would sit on a held list among a dozen others held for the same plausible reason, and could be quietly withdrawn entire if the days the note had warned him of turned into something worse.

The second adjustment took longer and showed less. He drew from the pigeonholes the working folder on the Sennar reconciliation, the one

that held his own marginal notes from four years of entries, the small private record by which he kept his work straight in his own mind. None of it was evidence of anything; it was a registrar's working notes, and any registrar kept them. But his notes on Sennar were denser than his notes elsewhere, because Sennar had been first, and density was a thing a careful reader could see. He took the folder to the side table, and over the cooling kettle he separated the Sennar sheets from the rest, and he did not burn them, because a burned thing was a fact and ash in a registrar's office was a question, and he had no answer prepared for the question. He folded the Sennar sheets into the standardization circular instead, the genuine New Terra circular he had every reason to keep and to study, and he filed the whole back into the pigeonhole under the circular's reference, where the sheets were no longer Sennar notes at all but study material on attestation forms, and where they would draw no eye because the eye that found them would find them filed exactly where a diligent man would file them.

He washed his hands at the side table because the old paper had left its dust on them, dried them on the cloth he kept there, and put the kettle on again out of habit before he remembered he had drunk his two cups.

A knock. Okonjo, the assessor, with the morning list and a question about the order of the Lomé contests, and Sael answered it, and they spoke for a few minutes about nothing that mattered, the assessor leaning in the doorway with his thumbs in his belt, complaining about the standardization circular as every assessor in the building was complaining about it that week, and Sael agreed that it was a nuisance and that the forms had been fine as they were, and meant the agreement, because the circular had this morning done him a service the New Terra office had not intended. Okonjo went. The corridor outside was filling now, the day's voices rising in it, a trolley of folios rumbling past toward the assessors' room, the day's heat beginning to come up off the courtyard stone and in at the window with the smell of the dust the floor-keeper had not reached.

Sael Mokoena did not think of himself as a man with a network, because the word made it sound like a thing he commanded, and he commanded nothing. He had relations. A courier who carried what the registry could not carry and asked no questions because the questions

were not his to ask, a man called Rashid who had moved paper for the office for years and moved a little more on the side because the side paid and the side was discreet. An attesting clerk two prefectures over who owed him a kindness done long ago and repaid it in attestations that did not look twice. The hand that had written the unsigned note, which was the only one of his relations that frightened him, because it was the only one above him, and a man's relations above him were the ones he did not get to manage. He did not let himself think long about the hand. The hand had warned him. A hand that warned him was a hand that wanted him intact, and he took the comfort of that and set the rest down.

The seat he had been passed over for, eleven years gone now, he thought of less often than he once had. It had been the prefectural registrarship at Adwa, the room he should have had, and the board had given it to a younger man with a louder family, and Sael had congratulated the younger man and meant the congratulation to be seen to be meant, and had gone back to the deputy's room he still occupied and understood, with the clarity that comes once or twice in a life, that the empire would never give him what his work had earned and that he would therefore take it by the means the empire had left lying about unguarded. The understanding had not been bitter. He had let the bitterness pass the way he let most things pass, and kept the understanding, which was the useful part. The younger man had since moved on to New Terra and a title. Sael had stayed, and learned the office to its roots, and the roots had turned out to be worth more than the title.

The session bell sounded from the assessors' floor, two strokes, the quarter-warning. He gathered the morning list and the banded contests and the initialed remainder of the schedule, the thirty-nine that would go up and the two that would wait, and he squared the stack against the desk's pale edge. He left the held list in the tray for the clerk to carry. He left the standardization circular in its pigeonhole with the Sennar sheets folded inside it. He left the unsigned note in his breast pocket, where it would stay until the walk home, when he would put it through the third terrace's public incinerator with the day's other private paper, one folded sheet among many, no ash anyone could question.

He stood at the window a moment before he went down. The courtyard below was in full sun now, the floor-keeper gone, a single clerk

crossing it at an angle with a folio case under his arm and his head down against the brightness. Sael Mokoena watched him cross and reach the far arcade and pass out of the light into the shade of it, and he turned the warning over once more, and found it manageable, the way he had found such things manageable before. He had done this before. He did it now.

He picked up the stack and went down to the session.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Asha's Finding

THE FINANCIAL RECORDS HAD come up from the vault in the wrong order, and Asha had been three hours putting them right before she let herself read a line of them.

That was the work no one credited and she had stopped expecting them to. The cross-reference clerks held the appointment files and the commission rosters and the prefectural registries, each in its own bureau's hand, and held them apart by long discipline so that no single office could read all of them together and learn what the reading showed. When a thing had to be read together it came to the Quarter, and it came in the order the clerks had pulled it, which was the order of the shelves and not the order of sense, and so the first labor of any such night was to take a stack that meant nothing in the order it arrived and lay it into the order that would let it speak. She had a working room for it now, a second room, smaller than the one Kaviel ran under the north wall and given over to the financial side because the financial side had grown past the table it began on. The table was full. It had been full by the second hour, the appointment ledgers squared along its length and weighted, and so the rest had gone to the floor, the disbursement registers laid out in ranks across the stone in the order she was building, the payment schedules beside them, the warrants of office in their banded files at the wall where she could reach them without rising and lose her place. She worked on her knees among them more than she worked in the chair. A younger officer would have asked for a larger room. Asha had learned

forty years ago that a larger room was a room someone could ask the use of, and the use of this one was not a thing she wanted asked, and so she took the smaller room and put the work on the floor and said nothing.

The lamp stood on the table at the edge nearest the floor-work and she had angled the shade down so the light fell across the registers and not up into the room, and that left the upper air dim and the corners gone to dark and the stone underfoot lit in a long warm strip that moved as she moved the lamp. The building had emptied around her by degrees. The kitchens two floors down had banked their fires after the evening meal, and the bread-and-burnt-sugar warmth that threaded the upper floors by day had thinned to almost nothing, so that what reached her now under the closer smell of lamp oil was the dry cold smell of the documents themselves, the disbursement registers most of all, which had sat in a peripheral vault long enough to take the mineral chill of the stone into their bindings and give it back slowly into the warming room. She had eaten nothing since the noon table and did not notice. Somewhere far down the corridor a single watch officer made the round of the administrative floor at the turn of each hour, the even report of boots passing the door and going on, and between those passings the room held no sound but her own, the turn of a page, the dry scrape of a register drawn an inch nearer across the stone, the small click of the lamp's collar when she eased the shade.

The appointments were established. That work was Kaviel's and Zola's, two rooms over and weeks deep, the reconciliation trace running entry by entry through the carry-forward provision and turning up the gaps where an entry rested on a prior authority that did not hold. Asha was not tracing the appointments. She was reading the money under them. A false magistrate seated in the empire's name did not sit for nothing; he drew the salary of the office, the disbursements ran to him through the prefectural treasury on the warrant of his appointment, and the money left a track the appointment alone did not, because the money was handled by a different bureau than the one that confirmed the name, and the two bureaus did not love each other and did not reconcile their books except when forced. Where the appointment was a single clean line on a roster, the disbursement was a hundred small entries across years, each one initialed, dated, posted against a warrant, carried forward

at the turn of each fiscal period into the next register. Asha read the money because the money could not be filed once and forgotten the way a name could. The money had to keep moving, and a thing that keeps moving leaves more chances to read it.

She had taken the Sennar disbursements first, because Sennar was where the appointments had gone hot soonest, and she had spent the early hours of the night matching the payment track of each questioned office against the warrant it ran on and the appointment the warrant cited. It was slow and it was clean and it was, she had begun to think by the fifth hour, going to tell her less than she had hoped. The money matched. That was the trouble. Each false magistrate drew his salary in the ordinary track, posted in the ordinary hand, carried forward at the ordinary intervals, and the ordinariness of it was correct because the men who built this had wanted it ordinary, had wanted the money to read as the money of a real office, and so they had made it real money in every respect but the legitimacy of the name at the top. There was nothing wrong with the disbursements. Asha read a hundred entries and found nothing wrong and felt the old patience settle in her, because nothing wrong was a finding too, and a man who could make a fraud's money read this clean was a man worth the reading.

It was past the sixth hour when she found the section that was too clean.

She had moved off the Sennar registers and onto the disbursements of the two jurisdictions beside it, the ones Zola had been tracing, and she had laid the new registers into the floor-ranks below the old and gone down onto her knees to read along them in the lamp-strip, register by register, year by year. And somewhere in the third year of the second jurisdiction the hand of the entries changed. Not the literal hand; the postings ran in the same clerk's writing as before and after, the same initials, the same ink. What changed was beneath the writing, in the bones of the thing, in how the entries sat against one another. Asha did not have a word for it at first and did not reach for one. She knelt over the register and read the section twice and let the wrongness declare itself before she named it, the way she had taught a hundred candidates to do and the way she still did, because the name a person reached for first was the name of the thing they expected and not the thing that was there.

What was there was order. Too much order. A live disbursement register kept across years by working clerks accumulated the small disorders of working clerks, the correction struck through and re-entered, the posting made a day late and dated true, the carry-forward at the fiscal turn that did not quite balance and was reconciled in the margin with an initial and a note. The Sennar registers had all of that, the ordinary friction of real hands doing real work over years, and Asha had read past it without remark because it was the texture of a thing that had grown the way such things grew. This section had none of it. Across three fiscal years the disbursements of the questioned offices ran without a single struck correction, without a late posting, without a margin note, every carry-forward balancing to the coin at the first attempt, every initial set down clean. It read the way a thing reads when it has been copied out fair from a draft. It read the way the candidate's clean finding had read in the assessment room across all the years, the right answer arrived at with no cost, and the no-cost was the tell.

She sat back on her heels and put the lamp closer and read the section a third time, slower, against the years on either side of it. The years before it had the friction. The years after it had the friction. The three years in the middle did not. Someone had gone into a live register that had been kept the ordinary disorderly way, and had taken out the disorder, and had set the entries back down clean. A correction pass. The phrase came to her plainly and she turned it over and did not like how well it fit. Not a correction of an error; the entries before the pass and after it ran to the same figures, the same warrants, the same offices. Nothing had been changed in what the money did. What had been changed was the record of how it had been done, the texture scrubbed out of it and a smooth surface laid down in its place, three years of a working clerk's small honest mess lifted off and replaced with three years that had never made a mistake.

Asha knew what it meant and made herself not yet know it. She rose, because her knee had gone to sleep under her and because she did not want to reach a finding from the floor, and she stood a moment in the dim upper air with the warm strip of the lamp below her and let the cold of the room come back into her attention, the chill the disbursement registers had carried up from the vault still banked in the corners where

the lamp did not reach. Then she went to the wall and took down the warrants of office for the three years, the banded files she had set there so she would not lose her place, and she carried them back into the light and knelt again and read the warrants against the scrubbed registers.

The warrants told her the second thing. A correction pass on a live record was not a thing a clerk did on his own word. A register in the standing record was closed at the fiscal turn and could not be reopened and re-entered without authorization, because a register that could be quietly reopened was a register that meant nothing, and the whole empire ran on registers meaning something. So a correction pass left a track of its own, an authorization cited for the reopening, a code set against the reopened entries that said by whose authority the closed record had been touched. Asha found the codes where they had to be, in the margin of the reopened section, set down small and regular at the head of each fiscal year of the pass. She had expected to find the codes of the reconciliation office, the same bureau whose carry-forward provision had carried the false names in the first place, because that would have been the whole fraud closing on itself, the same hands cleaning up after the same hands. The codes were not the reconciliation office's. She read them twice to be sure, and then she carried the lamp to the small shelf where she kept the code tables that let an officer read an authorization back to the category of official who could issue it, and she ran the codes against the table, and she sat for a while with the table open under her hand and did not move.

The codes belonged to a category of authority she could not touch.

There were authorizations in the imperial administration that a Lioness could read straight through, because the Quarter's mandate ran to them, the working codes of the bureaus and the prefectures and the commissions, the hands of clerks and registrars and deputy registrars and the run of officials whose work was the record itself. And there were authorizations the mandate did not reach, set above the working bureaus, held by a category of senior official whose authority over the record was the authority to suspend its ordinary rules, and the codes in the margin of the scrubbed register belonged to that category. To read further, to learn which office of that category had issued the authorization and on whose word, Asha would have to pull the issuing record, and the issuing record sat above the line the mandate drew, and to cross that line she would

have to ask for authority from above the Quarter. She knew the shape of what asking meant. Kaviel had told it to the young researcher in the north room the week the room opened, the same telling Asha had given her own juniors for forty years: the mandate was over paper, and the moment they reached past the paper to a hand they were doing a thing the charter did not cover, and a thing the charter did not cover had to be authorized from above the Quarter, and authorization from above the Quarter was a door, and a door could be watched from the other side.

She set the code table down and looked at the floor-ranks of registers in the long warm strip of the lamp, and she did not pull the issuing record, and she did not write a request to pull it, and she did not let herself, even for the length of a breath, frame the question that asking would have asked. The discipline held the way it had always held, the line drawn at the place where reading stopped and reaching began, and she stayed on the reading side of it because the work that crossed the line was work that warned the thing it crossed the line to find. She had spent her life teaching juniors that the rules were not a cage put on them by people who did not understand the work. The rules were the work. And here was the rules turned, the same line that protected the investigation made into the wall the investigation broke against, the category of authority she could not investigate used by someone who had known she could not, and the knowing was the finding. A clerk did not scrub a register. A reconciliation officer did not reach for a category of authority above his own bureau to do it. The correction pass had been run from above the line, by someone whose authority was the authority to suspend the rules, and that someone had cleaned up after the men who built the fraud, which meant the men who built the fraud were not the top of it.

Asha did not exclaim, because she had never in forty years exclaimed at a finding, and she did not bring it to anyone running, because there was no one to bring it to at the sixth hour past midnight and because a finding brought running was a finding half made. She did what she had taught. She logged it. She drew a clean sheet to the table edge in the lamp and set down the entry, the scrubbed section by jurisdiction and fiscal year, and the warrants it ran on, and the codes in the margin, and the category the codes belonged to, and what the category meant for the mandate, in the cramped exact hand that had filled the disposition box of

a thousand intake ledgers. She did not set down what she suspected past the codes. The codes were a fact. The category was a fact. That the category could not be reached without escalating the mandate was a fact. That someone with that authority had run a correction pass over the fraud after the fraud was built was a fact, and the facts were the whole of what she logged, because the moment she wrote down what the facts meant about the man at the top she would be building on a thing she could not yet stand on, and she had spent her life refusing to build on that.

When the sheet was done she read it once for what it said and once for what a careful reader would take from it, and then she set it aside and took a second clean sheet and wrote the update for Kaviel. She did not go and find her. Kaviel was two rooms over or in her own office or gone home to the few hours she allowed herself, and a finding of this kind did not travel by a knock on a door at the sixth hour, where the knock itself could be read by anyone awake in the corridor as a thing worth a knock. It travelled the way the Quarter moved everything that mattered, in writing, by the channel, set down plain and left where Kaviel would have it at the first hour and no one else would have it at all. Asha wrote it the way she wrote everything, short, the finding stated and the category named and the wall it ran into marked plainly, with no urging in it and no alarm, because Kaviel would read the urging into the facts herself and would not need Asha to do it for her, and because a written update that carried its own alarm was an officer arguing with the reader on the page. She wrote that the disbursements of the two jurisdictions beside Sennar carried a scrubbed section across three fiscal years. She wrote that the scrub was a correction pass authorized under codes from a category the mandate could not reach. She wrote that the pass post-dated the original insertions, which meant a second hand had come in after the first. She did not write the conclusion. She trusted Kaviel to reach it, and she trusted her to reach the further thing past it, that a hand with that authority did not run a correction pass on a regional fraud out of idleness, that the reach of that category was not regional, and that the wall Asha had hit was no edge to the thing. It was the floor of a story that had more storeys above it than the room they were working in had let them imagine. She folded the update and set it in the channel tray and squared it, and that was the whole of what would leave the room before morning.

The watch officer passed the door again at the turn of the hour, the even boots going down the corridor and away, and the sound of them let Asha know how late it had got and that she had stopped marking the turns an hour or more ago. She gathered the day's work off the floor before she let herself stop, because the work did not get left on the floor of a room that had no use the building could name, and she squared the disbursement registers back into their ranks and banded the warrants and set them at the wall, and she put the scrubbed registers, the two she would want again at the first hour, where her hand would find them and no one else's eye would land on them by accident. Her knees ached when she rose with the last of them and she let them ache. The lamp had burned low and she trimmed it rather than fill it, because she was not going to be much longer.

She sat back into the chair, the first time she had used it that night, and she drew the scrubbed register up onto her knee in the trimmed light and opened it again to the head of the correction pass, to the small regular codes set down in the margin at the turn of the first fiscal year. She did not need to read them again. She had read them enough to carry them out of the room in her head and would. She looked at them anyway, the way a person looks at a thing whose meaning has changed under their hands and who wants to see whether it has changed back, and it had not. The codes sat in the margin clean and small in the same ink as the rest, set there by a clerk who had been told to set them there by a hand above the clerk, and the hand above the clerk had been moving by an authority that the men in the prefectures who built this had not had and could not have got, an authority that came down from a place above the working bureaus, from someone whom the working bureaus answered to and did not question, from someone the record itself was built to trust.

She looked at the codes a long time.

"Someone trusted," she said.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Kaviel and the Man from the Transit Hub

THE ROOM HAD BEEN chosen for what it would not say. It sat off the administrative spine of the Meridian transit facility, behind a door that gave onto a corridor used by no one who had a reason to hurry, and it had the furniture of a hundred such rooms in a hundred such facilities across the empire: a table bolted to the floor and two chairs that were not, under a single light panel set flush into the ceiling that gave a flat even brightness, falling on everything, favoring nothing. There was no window. There was a second door in the far wall, closed, and a man could read that second door as the way he had come in or as the way he would not be allowed to leave, and the room would not tell him which, and that was the point of the room. Kaviel had requested it by its facility code three days before and had given as her ground a records matter touching the transit registry, which was true the way the things she said were true, complete on its face and silent past it.

She was there before him. She always was, in these, because a man brought into a room already occupied read the occupant as the host and himself as the guest, and a guest behaved, and behavior was the thing she had come to read. She had laid nothing on the table. An empty table was worse for a man than a thick file, because a file had edges he could measure and an empty table held whatever he was afraid it held. She sat with her hands folded and the cold of the facility coming up through the

floor into the soles of her boots, the air carrying the thin chemical note of a building scrubbed and recirculated and never opened, and she waited.

The operative brought him in and withdrew. That was the whole of the operative's part, to be a body in the doorway for the length of time it took Rashid Beya to cross the threshold and understand that he had been brought somewhere by people who did not explain, and then to be gone, the door easing shut behind him so that the closing was a sound and not a slam. Kaviel had told her to do it exactly that way. A slam was a threat, and a threat gave a frightened man a thing to brace against. A door that merely closed gave him nothing.

She knew his face. She had carried it for four years without a frame to put it in, and now the frame had come up out of the record to meet the face, and the two had locked together in the cold room: the man by the document desk at Sabra Crossing, the courier's satchel across his body, the even unremarkable features a witness would swear they could not recall. He was older than the memory by its four years and otherwise the same, a man built to pass through a crowd and leave no wake, and she let none of the recognition reach her face, because the recognition was hers and not yet his to know she had.

"Sit," she said.

He sat. He did it without protest and without ease, lowering himself into the chair with the care of a man who did not yet know the rules of the room and did not want to be the one who broke them first. His hands he put on the table, flat, where she could see them, and that told her something: a man who put his hands where they could be seen had been in a room like this before, or had imagined it often enough that the imagining had taught him the posture. She filed it. She did not look at his hands a second time.

"You know where you are," she said. It was not a question and she did not let it rise into one.

"A transit office."

"You know what facility."

"Meridian." He had a low voice, level, the voice of a man who had learned that the safest thing to do with a voice was to give it nothing to carry. "The clerks took my transit slip at the lower gate and walked me up. They didn't say why."

"They wouldn't. That isn't their work." She let the silence open after it, a small deliberate space, and watched him decline to fill it. That was the second thing. A courier who knew nothing filled silences, because silence frightened a man who had nothing to hide more than it frightened a man who had everything to hide; the innocent talked to make the trouble go away, and the trouble was that talk was how the innocent convinced you. Rashid Beye sat in the silence and let it be hers, and a man who could do that was a man who had been trained, or had trained himself, in the one discipline a mere courier had no use for.

She turned over the slip of paper she had kept face down on the table, the only paper in the room, and slid it across to him. It was a transit manifest, a copy, the header and the facility chop of Sabra Crossing on it and a date four years gone, and the routing she had written that night in her own small hand, the onward routing of a woman to a seventh gate, was not on it, because that woman's movement had been filed in a place this man would never see. What was on it was the ordinary traffic of the crossing that hour, the southern feeder out of Sennar among it, and a notation she had added in pencil against one of the freight entries, a satchel of attestation matter routed through a peripheral relay, and his initial, B., beside it, in the dry hand of an analyst who had reduced a man to a letter and now sat across from the rest of him.

He read it. He read it the way Mokoena would have read a schedule, she thought, though she did not yet know she was thinking of Mokoena, no slower over the line that touched him than over the lines that did not, his eyes moving down the page at the even pace of a man determined not to teach the page where he lived. When he had read it he did not push it back. He left it where it was, between them, and looked up.

"That's a transit record," he said.

"It is."

"I move paper. That's not a thing anyone hides."

"No," she agreed. "It isn't." She let that be true in the room a moment, because it was true and because a man relaxed by a degree when you granted him a true thing, and the degree he relaxed by was a reading too. "You move paper between jurisdictions. You've done it for years, for offices that have a reason not to put it through their own registry. There's no charge in that. Half the empire's honest business moves the way you

move it, because the registries are slow and the work is real and someone has to carry the thing that can't wait for the slow channel. I'm not here about a satchel."

"Then I don't know what you're here about."

"You will." She left it there, and did not lean toward him, and did not change the level of her voice, because the thing she had come to do was not done by leaning. "I'm going to tell you what I have, and then I'm going to tell you the only choice in it that's still yours, and you're going to listen to both before you say anything, because the first thing a man says in a room like this is the thing he prepared on the walk up, and I have no use for it."

He said nothing. The light panel hummed faintly overhead, a register she felt behind her eyes more than heard, and the cold went on coming up through the floor, and somewhere beyond the far door a cart rolled across stone and faded, the building running its night traffic indifferent to the room inside it.

"You carry attestation matter," she said. "Carry-forward attestations, among other things. Prior-authority citations, originating-office attestations, the paper that lets an appointment enter the standing record on the word that an older commission already confirmed it. You carry it between the office that originates it and the offices that need it, and you carry it by hand and outside the registry, because the registry leaves a route and your offices would rather there were no route." She watched his hands. They did not move. "I can show that you carried it. I can lay your transit slips beside the dates the attestations entered the reconciliation, jurisdiction by jurisdiction, and the slips and the dates will agree, because they always agree, because you're careful and careful men leave the cleanest trail of all. A clean trail is still a trail. I have it."

"Carrying paper isn't a crime," he said again, but he said it more slowly this time, and the slowness was the third thing.

"It isn't. You're right. And if all you carried was the slow channel's honest backlog, I'd have no reason to spend a transit room on you." She let the room hold the next part before she gave it to him. "But you didn't carry only that. The attestations you moved into Sennar, and east of Sennar, cite prior commissions that sat and confirmed appointments other than the ones the attestation claims they confirmed, and prior commis-

sions that in two instances never sat at all. The appointments those attestations let into the record are false. The magistrate they seated is false. He rules in the empire's name on the strength of a paper you carried, and I can trace the paper to your hand, and the hand to the satchel, and the satchel to this date and this crossing, four years back, where I first saw you stand by a document desk and find a bench with your eyes that you had no errand at."

That reached him. It did not show in his hands and it did not show in his face, which stayed the careful nothing he had brought into the room, but it showed in the breath, the small held beat where a man recalculates the floor he is standing on, and Kaviel saw it and did not name it and did not press on it, because a man who is recalculating must be left to finish or he answers from the old picture and not the new.

"I didn't read the paper," he said at last. "A courier doesn't read the paper. That's the work. You carry what's sealed and you don't break the seal, and if the thing inside is false you've no way to know it and no business knowing it. I carried a sealed satchel. That's all I did."

"I believe you," Kaviel said, and meant it, and let him hear that she meant it. "I think you didn't break a seal. I think you carried what you were given and asked nothing, because asking is not the work and a courier who asks doesn't stay a courier. If that were the whole of what you knew, you'd be a thing I note and set aside, because a man who carried a sealed lie in good faith is not the man I came up these stairs for."

She let the room go quiet again, and this time she let the quiet do the work, because she had laid the first half of the trap, which was to tell him he was nothing, and now she would watch whether he believed it, because a man who was nothing accepted being nothing with relief, and a man who was more than he had said could not quite manage the relief, and the failure to manage it was the thing she had come the whole way to read.

He did not manage it.

It was small. A man who had only ever carried sealed satchels in good faith, told by the authority in the cold room that he was therefore not the quarry, would have eased, would have let his shoulders come down off the brace he had walked in with, would have reached for the next true

thing to say to get himself out the door he could now believe was the way out. Rashid Beye did not ease. He held the brace. He held it because he knew something the courier's account did not cover, and he was waiting to learn whether she knew he held it, and the holding was its own confession, legible to her in the cold light as a written line, and she read it and gave no sign that she had.

"You knew the routing," she said.

He was still.

"A courier carries what he's given between the points he's told. He doesn't choose the route. He doesn't know why this satchel goes to Sennar this quarter and east of Sennar the next, or why the one that fed Sabra Crossing came up off the feeder that didn't post to a board. He carries point to point and the why stays with the hand that loads the satchel." She watched him hold the brace. "But you knew the routing changed. You knew it thinned. Four years ago you carried into Sennar, dense, the same crossing twice in a quarter, and then the work spread out across jurisdictions that don't connect, fewer to each, and a man who only carried wouldn't have felt the spreading, because to a man who only carries each run is its own errand. You felt it. You felt the work being thinned across jurisdictions on purpose, the way a man thins a thing he doesn't want counted, and a courier who feels that is a courier who's been told more than the work requires, or has been carrying long enough for the same hand that he's stopped being only a pair of legs and started being someone the hand trusts with the shape."

His hands moved then, for the first time, the smallest withdrawal, the fingers drawing in off the flat of the table by a hair as if the table had gone cold under them, and he stopped the movement before it finished, and the stopping was as loud to her as the movement.

"You're guessing," he said.

"I'm reading," she said. "I do it the way you carry. It's the work, and I've done it long enough that I don't have to break a seal to know what's in the satchel." She did not raise the voice. "I'm not going to tell you what I'll do with what you've shown me, because that isn't the choice in the room. The choice in the room is smaller than that and it's the only thing left that's yours." She let him have a breath of the silence, one, and no more. "You can stay the man who carried a sealed satchel in good

faith. That man walks out of here tonight on his own transit slip, and what I have on him goes into a file, and the file waits, and one day the file is opened by someone deciding what the man who carried the satchels was, and there is no one in the room that day to say he was anything but the legs. Or you can be the man who knew the shape, who felt the work thin and understood why, and that man tells me the hand. Not the office. Not the registrar two prefectures over who owed a kindness. The hand above the registrar, the one that loads the routing and thins it and trusts a courier with the feel of it. That man's file reads differently, because that man chose, while the choosing was still his, to be the one who said the shape out loud."

She did not say the rest of it, that she did not yet know whose hand it was, that the whole of her case ran up to a ceiling she could not pass and stopped there, that this man across the cold table might be the one rung on the ladder she could reach who had ever stood close enough to the hand to feel its weight. She did not say it because saying it was showing him the floor of her own position, and the floor of her position was the one thing in the room she would not lay on the table.

"I don't know a name," he said.

"I didn't ask for a name." She let that land, because it was the truest thing she had said and the most useful. "A courier who knew a name would be a courier already dead, and you're alive, so you don't know a name, and I haven't asked you for the thing your being alive proves you don't have. I asked you for the hand. You've carried for it. You know how the routing reaches you, who hands you the loaded satchel, who changes the points, who sent you to a crossing four years ago to stand at a document desk and watch a bench. You know the shape of the hand the way a man knows the weight of a thing he's carried a long time without ever seeing it whole. That's what's yours to give. The name belongs to someone above you and I'll get it another way. The shape is yours."

He looked at the manifest on the table, the four-year-old paper with his initial penciled beside the freight line, and he was quiet a long time, and Kaviel let him be, because the thing she had built in the room was built and pressing on a man did not make a structure hold faster, it only taught him she was anxious, and she was not going to teach him that. The cold came up through the floor. The light hummed. Beyond the far door

the night traffic of the facility rolled and faded and rolled again, and the chemical scrub of the recirculated air sat at the back of her throat where it had sat the whole hour, and she breathed it and waited and gave the man the one thing the room could afford to give him, which was time enough to count.

"If I tell you the shape," he said slowly, "I'm a man who told. There's no file that reads well enough to fix that."

"No," Kaviel said. "There isn't. I won't lie to you about the room you'll be in after this one, because a lie now is a thing you'd catch later and it would cost me the only thing I'm asking you to believe, which is that the two doors are real and one of them is worse." She held his eyes. "I'm not offering you a good outcome. I don't have one to offer. I'm offering you the difference between a man who chose and a man who was chosen for, and that difference is the whole of what's left in your hands, and it's small, and it's real, and in a year it will be the only thing about tonight that was ever yours."

He gave her the shape.

He gave it carefully, the way he did everything, in pieces that each on their own were nothing and together were the thing she had come for: how the loaded satchel reached him from a relay clerk who never spoke past the handoff, never from Mokoena's own hand; how the routing came written on a slip he was to burn, and how the slips had changed, four years back, from a single repeating point to a spread that grew with each quarter; how once, only once, the routing had come from higher and not from the relay at all, in a script the relay clerk handled as a man handles a thing he is afraid of, and how after that the spread had widened all at once across jurisdictions that touched three Thrones' worth of administrative ground, more than any one registrar's office reached, more than Mokoena reached, a reach that had to belong to someone whose authority ran where Mokoena's stopped. He did not have the name. He had never had the name. But he had felt the weight of the hand through the paper for four years, and he laid the weight of it on the table now, piece by careful piece, and Kaviel took it the way she took everything, without exclaiming, filing each piece against the gap in her case where it fit, and finding that it fit, and finding that the gap it fit was the one above

Mokoena, the ceiling she had not been able to pass, and that this man had carried the feel of what stood above it without ever once seeing its face.

It was partial. She knew it for partial as she took it, a shape and a weight and a reach, and no name, and she did not press him past the partial, because pressing a man past what he had would only teach him to invent, and an invented piece was worse than a missing one. She took the shape he had and accepted that it was the shape he had, and she set the rest down where she set the things that were not yet hers to chase, in the file she might open later, with a hand she would have to find another way.

When he had finished there was nothing more in him to give and they both knew it, and she did not thank him, because thanks would have made the room a transaction between equals and the room had never been that, and a man who had just told would read thanks as a thing said to ease her own part in what she had done to him. She stood. The chair was bolted and hers was not, and the small scrape of it against the stone was the loudest sound the room had held, and he flinched at it by a degree, the first thing in the hour he had not managed.

"The operative outside will see you to your transit," she said. "Your slip is good. You'll make your routing."

He looked up at her, and there was a thing in his face now that had not been there when he came in, the look of a man who has understood the size of what he has done and cannot take it back and has nowhere to put it, and Kaviel had seen that look on the faces she carried and would carry his with the rest, into the file she might never open and would never forget she had.

She left the manifest on the table. She had no further use for it and taking it would have looked like collecting a trophy, and she did not collect them. She crossed to the door she had come in by, the one of the two that had been hers the whole hour, and she opened it onto the cold corridor where the operative waited, and she went out into the recirculated air and the flat continuous light of the transit spine, and she did not look back at him, and she heard the door ease shut behind her on its own weight, a sound and not a slam.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Courtier's Position

THE APARTMENTS COUNCILLOR HADI Marun held in the imperial complex had been allotted to his office and not to him, and a man who had lived in them eleven years could tell the difference on any afternoon he cared to. The rooms came with the seat. The furniture was the furniture the household provided to a councillor of his grade, the long couch and the writing table and the two chairs of pale upland wood set at the angle the household set them in every apartment of the grade, and when Marun had taken the seat he had moved nothing, because a man who rearranged the household's furniture announced that he meant to stay, and a man who announced he meant to stay invited the question of whether he should. So he had left the couch where the stewards left it and added to the room only the things a man was permitted to add, the small things that read as taste and cost little to abandon. A brass water clock from the river country, a good one, that he kept filled and running because the sound of it filled the silences a councillor learned to leave in a conversation. A wall of bound petitions he had argued and won, spined in red, set where a visitor's eye would find them without being led. A single low table of black river-stone that had been his mother's and was the only object in the apartments he would have carried out himself if the seat were ever taken from him, and which a visitor read as a councillor's affectation and never as the one true thing in the room.

It was the slack hour of the afternoon. The court had recessed its committees until the evening session and would not want him until the

lamps were lit, and he had told his clerk he would read in his rooms, which the clerk understood to mean he was not to be disturbed and did not understand to mean anything else. Through the shared ventilation that ran the wall behind the writing table came the smell of someone else's late meal cooking two apartments down, a southern dish heavy with the burnt-sweet of caramelized onion and a fish stock under it, and the smell came and went as the draught in the duct shifted, so that the apartment was by turns his own and someone else's, his own dry air of paper and brass-polish and then, on the turn of the draught, the kitchen of a man he had never met cooking a supper Marun would not be invited to. He had stopped noticing it years ago and noticed it today, which told him something about the afternoon before he had let himself know it.

The message had come at noon.

It lay on the writing table where he had set it down, a single folded sheet that had come through the ordinary correspondence and read, to any clerk who handled it, as ordinary correspondence, a note from a colleague about the seating of a minor review body in the river prefectures, the kind of note that crossed the complex by the hundred in any week. He had read it standing, the way he read most things, and then he had sat down, which he had not meant to do, and he had read it again sitting, and he had been sitting with it for the better part of two hours now while the water clock measured the afternoon out of the brass vessel into the lower bowl one slow bead at a time.

The note was not about a review body. The colleague who appeared to have sent it had not sent it; the colleague did not exist, or existed only as a name a man could write at the foot of a sheet, and the body of the note carried under its dull official surface a second reading that opened only to a reader who knew the river prefectures had no such review body seated this season. Marun knew it. He had voted the river rosters himself. So when the note told him that the seating would proceed and that his concurrence would be valued and that the matter would close cleanly before the cold session, he read what it told the man who knew there was no seating, which was that he was being asked again, more plainly than before, and that the asking had reached the stage where the form of it had stopped pretending to need his agreement and had begun describing what his agreement would look like once it was given.

He set the kettle of the water clock straight, which it did not need, and watched a bead of water gather at the lip of the upper vessel and hang and fall.

The arithmetic was not hard. That was the thing he kept arriving at and turning away from across the afternoon, that the arithmetic was not hard and never had been, and that a man told himself a choice was hard when what he meant was that he did not like the side the arithmetic came down on. He owed in two directions. He had always owed in two directions; a councillor who owed in only one direction was a councillor who had not yet been in the seat long enough, and Marun had been in the seat eleven years. He owed the throne the form of his service and the throne had been, in its exact cold way, fair to him, had heard his river prefectures and ruled against the feeling and for the law and had told him to his face that it would read the instrument and not the sentiment, which was as much as a man in his grade could ask and more than most received. And he owed the other direction the substance of a debt that had begun small, the way these debts began, in a favor done him years ago that he had taken without weighing because it had cost him nothing to take and would have cost him standing to refuse.

He let himself think about the favor, because he had spent the afternoon not thinking about it and the not-thinking had grown heavier than the thing itself.

The seat on the river commission. Eight years gone now. He had earned it, by any reading of the rosters he had earned it, the senior councillor of the river caucus with the longest unbroken service and the cleanest record of any man in line, and the seat had gone instead to a younger man out of a northern house whose grandfather had sat where the younger man's father now sat, and Marun had swallowed it the way a courtier swallowed such things, in public with grace and in private with a long quiet rage that he had been careful never to let reach his face. And a man had come to him, not long after, an unremarkable man with the air of a senior clerk, who had said that the matter of the river commission had been noticed by people who thought it ill done, and that such things could be set right, in time, by men who understood the value of setting them right, and that Marun need do nothing now but understand that he was understood. And Marun, who was good at being liked and had built

a life on being liked and had felt for the first time in his career the cold of being passed over by men who liked him fine and chose another anyway, had let himself be understood. He had said nothing. He had done nothing. He had taken the favor of being understood the way he had taken the household's furniture, by leaving it where it was set and not asking what it would cost to keep it.

He had told himself across the years that the favor had been the rage's doing and not his own, that a man wronged in the open could be forgiven a private warmth toward whoever offered to set the wrong right, and that the warmth had committed him to nothing. He could see the lie in it now, sitting with the noon note under his hand. The rage had been real and the wrong had been real, and neither had made the choice for him; he had made it himself, in the comfortable dark of doing nothing, which a courtier learned early was its own kind of doing. A man who chose nothing was a man who let the choosing be done by whoever was patient enough to wait him out, and the unremarkable man with the senior clerk's air had been very patient, and Marun had been, for eight years, very comfortable. He turned the brass kettle a quarter on its base, the way Lady Provost Shandt had turned a cup at the autumn dinner without drinking from it, and set it back where it had been, and watched the lower bowl fill.

It had cost a small thing the first time, a year on. A name he had been asked to let pass on a roster he was reviewing, a confirmation he had been asked not to look at twice. He had let it pass. It had been one name among a hundred and the hundred were dull and the one had read no differently than the rest, and a man who let one dull name pass on a long dull roster had done, he had told himself, nothing at all. He had been right that it was nothing and wrong about everything that followed from it, because the men who built these debts built them exactly so, out of nothings, out of single names on long rosters, so that the man who had let the first one pass would find, when the second came, that he had already become the kind of man who let names pass, and that to refuse the second was to admit the first, and that the admitting cost more every season the debt ran.

The southern kitchen turned in the duct again and the onion-sweet came across the room, and Marun sat in his allotted furniture among the

spined red petitions of the things he had won and the one black table that was truly his, and understood that the note on the writing table was the second name. Not one name now. A run of them. The note's true reading asked him to do for the cold session's appellate rosters what he had once done for a single confirmation, to carry forward a body of entries out of the Outer Prefectures into the courts he had standing to touch, and to do it as a man of his grade and reputation could do it, cleanly, with his concurrence on the record where his concurrence carried weight, so that what passed under his name passed unquestioned because it passed under his name.

He knew what the entries were. He had not let himself know it in words before this afternoon and he knew it now in words, because the note had stopped pretending and so could he. The carry-forward backlog out of the Outer Prefectures. The thing the young magister had been indiscreet about at the autumn dinner, the books grown fat, the chain in which every link trusted the link before it and no link bore weight. He had been at that dinner. He had heard the talk move along the colonnade the way talk moved, and he had marked it the way a courtier marked everything, and he had understood even then, without letting the understanding surface, that the talk was about the thing he had let pass eight years running, grown now from one name to a weight that could fatten the books of three prefectures.

There was a knock.

It was the soft double knock of the household and then, before he answered, the voice through the door, and the voice was Councillor Imani Tau's, and Marun was on his feet and at the door with the easy warmth already arranged on his face before he had decided to arrange it, because the arranging was eleven years deep and did not wait on his decision.

"Hadi." Tau came in the way she came into every room, without ceremony and without quite waiting to be asked, a spare upright woman ten years younger than Marun with the river-country length of bone and a way of looking at a man as though she had already decided to think well of him and was waiting only to be shown she was right. She held a sheaf of paper against her chest. "Your clerk said you were reading. I told him

reading was the one thing you have never once done in these rooms and he should let me by."

"He let you by."

"He is afraid of me. It is my best quality." She set the sheaf down on the long couch, not on the writing table, which Marun noted with a gratitude that surprised him, because she could not have known what lay on the writing table and had kept clear of it anyway, out of the plain courtesy that was how she moved through the world. "The northern water rates. I have the redraft. I have made it worse for the northern houses and better for the guilds and I want a councillor who is not from either to tell me whether I have made it fair or only made it satisfying, because I cannot tell the two apart anymore and you can. You always could."

She sat without being asked and looked up at him, and the afternoon light off the interior court came through the high window and laid a band of it across the couch and across the redraft she had carried up to him because she trusted his reading, and Marun stood over her and felt the two hours at the writing table sitting in him like a stone swallowed whole.

This was the other reading. He understood it standing there with the warmth still arranged on his face, that Imani Tau was the door he was not walking through, that a man could spend the years he had left as the councillor she came to with her redrafts because his reading was clean and his name was good, the councillor whose concurrence meant a thing was fair, and that the price of that door was only the price he had been refusing to pay for eight years, which was to admit the first name, and the second, and to let the seat be taken from him in the open by men who would never know why he had given it up. She did not know any of it. She had carried her water rates up three floors to the one colleague she was sure would tell her the truth, and the truth was the only thing in the room she had come for, and she would have it from him because he had never once given her anything else.

"Read it to me," he said, and sat down across from her in the household's pale wood, and let her read, and listened to the whole of it, the way the throne had listened to the herder, because listening was the one thing left in the afternoon he could do cleanly. She read the redraft

through, the rates and the relief schedules and the small careful clauses where she had given the guilds their margin, and her voice had the flat working pleasure in it of a person doing a hard thing well, and the water clock measured it out bead by bead, and the southern kitchen came and went in the duct, and Marun heard every word and held two readings of the afternoon in his hands at once, the redraft on the couch and the note on the table behind him, and knew that he could not hold both past the day.

"It is fair," he said when she finished, and it was, and he told her where it was not yet fair, the two clauses in the relief schedule that read as relief and worked as delay, and she bent over the sheaf and marked them, fast, the way a person marks a thing they had half known and needed only to be told, and she did not thank him because between them thanks had long ago worn down to the work itself.

"You are good for me, Hadi," she said, rising, gathering the sheaf back against her chest. "The others tell me what I want. You tell me what it is." She was at the door. "Come to the river caucus before the session. They have missed you. You have been a stranger this season." And she was gone, the soft latch of the door, her step quick down the corridor, and the apartment closed back around him into his own dry air and the turning kitchen and the slow falling beads of the clock.

He stood a while where she had left him.

Then he went to the writing table and sat down and drew the lamp nearer though the light from the court was not yet gone, and he took a clean sheet from the household stock and uncapped the ink, and he wrote the reply. He wrote it as a note about a review body in the river prefectures, dull and exact, a colleague's concurrence in a routine seating, the kind of note that crossed the complex by the hundred and would read to any clerk who handled it as nothing at all. He wrote the second reading into the first the way it had been written to him, so that the man who knew there was no review body would read what he meant, which was that the matter would close cleanly before the cold session, and that his concurrence could be valued, and that what passed under his name would pass. He wrote it in his own good hand, the hand on the spined red petitions along the wall, and he did not hurry it and did not labor it, and when it was done he read it once to be sure the surface held, and it held.

The southern kitchen came across the room a last time, the onion-sweet gone now to something scorched at its edge, a sauce held too long over the fire two apartments down, and Marun folded the sheet along its crease and pressed the fold flat with the side of his thumb and sealed it. He set it in the collection tray at the corner of the writing table, where the household's runner would take it with the evening's other correspondence, among the routine notes a councillor sent out at the close of any working day. He capped the ink. He did not look at the tray again.

INTERLUDE 3

Silva: Field Notes, Jurisdiction Seven

These pages were carried out of Jurisdiction Seven in the lining of a freight ledger and held in the Lioness compound for some weeks before anyone read them as evidence. I reproduce them as written, in the field shorthand of their author, because the line that mattered was set down beside lines that did not, and I would have the reader find it where she found it.

J7. FIELD LOG. Posting under cover of freight audit, Meridian feeder spur. Three weeks. S.

DAY 1. Arrived ahead of schedule, took the spur clerk's room over the weighbridge. Smell of axle grease through the floorboards day and night. Vantage on the lower yard, the attestation shed, the courier gate. Established as auditor's runner. No one asks a runner anything.

DAY 2. Mapped the shed traffic. Couriers in at the half-hour, satchels chopped, out the south gate. Nothing here a manifest would not hold. Pattern is the point. Watch the breaks in the pattern.

DAY 4. Mokoena's man through the gate, southern feeder. Recognized from Meridian. Beye. Carried the attestation satchel, left it at the shed window, did not wait for the chop. A courier who does not wait for his chop is not carrying his own paper. Noted. Said nothing.

DAY 6. Shed clerk drinks at the weighbridge canteen, talks. Says the J7 reconciliation went up clean this quarter, fewer holds than Sennar, faster.

Says it the way a man says a thing he was told to be pleased about. The bread here is the flat gray kind, sour, and the tea is worse, and a clerk who buys both for a stranger wants the stranger to stay and listen.

DAY 9. Quiet. Logged the gate counts. Sat the yard from the cold side so the sun would not put me on the glass.

DAY 11. Black transit, no facility chop, in through the freight gate after the day shed had closed. This does not happen on a spur. A man came down from it. Heavy build, deliberate, an aide a half-step behind carrying nothing, which is how you know the man matters. He did not go to the shed. He went to the spur registrar's office, which was dark, and the registrar opened it for him, and the lamp came up behind the blind. Forty minutes. The aide stood at the door the whole forty and watched the yard and saw a runner crossing it with a folio case and did not mark her, because a runner with a folio case at that hour is the yard working as the yard works.

DAY 11, later. Did not log the man's face to the registry. Logged it here. I have seen it. I will set down where. The Bureau circular on attestation forms carried a plate of the New Terra office at its standardization session, the senior table, and his face is on the plate, third from the convening chair. A man whose face is on the plate of the New Terra senior table does not come down a freight spur after dark to sit forty minutes in a dark registrar's office and leave no chop, no entry a ledger could hold. He came to be in the room. Whatever was done in the forty minutes was done by his being in the room, the way Mokoena's entries were done by a true name carrying a false errand. I do not yet know that this means what I think it means. I am not going to write it up until I do.

DAY 12. The spur registrar burned something in the canteen stove before first light. Sour smoke, paper. I was on the cold side and saw the flue take it. A registrar who burns at his own stove and not at the public incinerator on the terrace is burning a thing he does not want carried past his own door.

DAY 14. Beye through again. Same satchel routine. The reconciliation schedule he leaves is thicker by a third than the J7 traffic warrants. The traffic does not warrant it. Something is being moved into J7 that did not originate in J7. Noted. Did not act.

DAY 17. Confirmed the black transit's registry plate against the freight gate's own counter log, which counts axles and keeps no names. One

uncharted entry, Day 11, after close. The gate counter does not lie and does not know what it counted.

DAY 19. The aide was at the canteen at midday, alone, no transit in the yard. So he has been left here. A man who matters does not leave his own aide on a freight spur unless the spur is now part of the work and wants a steady hand on it. The work has put down a root here. I have what the records cannot give. I am carrying it out by hand.

DAY 21. Closed the posting. Returned the clerk's room as found. Freight audit filed clean, no irregularity, signed off by the spur registrar himself, who shook my hand at the gate and was glad to see the auditor's runner go.

Folio reference: J7 freight audit, supplementary. Filed routine. Day 21, third quarter.

S.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The Source Eleanor Protected

THE RESIDENCE SAT AT the end of a lane that went nowhere else, behind a wall too low to mean anything and a gate that had been left unlatched on purpose. It belonged to no one either party would name. A widow of some standing had lived in it once and died in it, and the title had passed through a trust that owned other things in other quarters, and the trust answered to a firm of agents who answered to a deed of administration so old and so dull that following it to its end would take a clerk a season and reward him with nothing. Eleanor had used it three times in forty years. She had chosen it again because a place used rarely and never twice in close succession kept the one virtue a meeting like this one needed, which was that it could not afterward be made to mean what had happened in it.

She arrived first, which was her habit and also her instruction to herself, and she had Sefu's men go through the rooms before she sat. She expected nothing. A room you have not seen searched is a room you are guessing about, and she had stopped guessing about rooms a long time ago. They found dust under the sheets that draped the furniture, and a smell of a house shut up too long, paper and cold ash and the faint sweetness of fruit left to go over somewhere out of sight, and a clock that had stopped at a quarter past some hour years gone and had not been wound since. She had them leave the clock. A stopped clock told a visitor that the house did not run, that nothing here was kept, and that was the

truth she wanted the room to say on her behalf before she said anything herself.

She sat in the front room in a chair she had uncovered with her own hands, the sheet folded once and laid over the arm of another. The window gave onto the dead lane. The light came in gray and even, a flat afternoon light with no sun in it, and it laid no bar across the floor and warmed nothing, and she was glad of that too. She had asked Kaviel to come and to come quietly and to take the chair set back from the table, against the wall where the light did not reach, and to say nothing for the whole of it whatever was said, and Kaviel had heard the instruction the way she heard all of them, without asking what it was for, and had taken the chair against the wall, and had not moved since.

Eleanor did not look at her daughter. There was nothing to look at. The room held a table and three chairs and a stopped clock and two women who were good at being still, and outside it the afternoon thinned toward the early dark of the season, and they waited for the third without speaking, because the thing they were waiting for did not improve for being discussed and Eleanor had taught the girl that before she could write.

He came on foot. They heard the gate, which had been left unlatched so that it would make its small sound and not a larger one, and then the door, and then a tread in the hall that Eleanor knew before she could have said how she knew it, a careful tread, a man who had spent his life learning where the boards of strange rooms gave and had never lost the habit even where no one watched. She had heard that tread once before, twenty-one years ago, in a different house, at the beginning of the thing that was ending now. She had been a younger woman then in every way that the body counts and few of the ways that mattered. She did not rise.

He stopped in the doorway. Senior Magister Aurelio Saad was an old man now, older than she had let herself picture across the years of the channel, because she had built the channel so that she would never picture him, never hold a face for the name, never give the apparatus the one thing a captured mind could be made to surrender. She had known his age as a figure in a file and had refused the image, and the image stood in the doorway now and corrected the figure downward and upward at once, a tall man gone spare, the skin at his throat loose over a

frame that had carried more, the hands very still at his sides, the eyes steady in a way that did not ask anything of the room. He wore the plain dark of a senior official off his hours, good cloth worn past its season, the dress of a man who had money and no use he would put it to. He looked at her a moment. Then he looked at the chair set for him, and the one against the wall, and the woman in it, and he did the arithmetic of the second chair in the time it took to draw a breath, and his face did not change.

"You brought a witness," he said. His voice was lower than the channel had let her imagine, dry, unhurried.

"I brought my own," Eleanor said. "She will not speak. She will not write. She is here because I will not carry this alone and there is no one else I would let carry it."

He took that in. He looked at Kaviel once more, longer, and Kaviel met the look and gave it nothing, which was correct, and Eleanor felt the correctness of it pass through the room like cold off a pane. Then he crossed to the chair and sat, slowly, his hands finding the table and resting there flat, an old man's care for his own weight on unfamiliar furniture.

"Twenty-one years," he said, "and I have never seen your face until today."

"No."

"I told myself, at the start, that it was a clerk. That I was writing into a drawer." He turned one hand over on the table, looked at the palm, turned it back. "I knew it was not a drawer by the third year. The things that stopped happening. A man who should have risen and did not. A schedule that should have gone through and was held. You cannot hide a drawer's work that well. A drawer does nothing. Someone was doing something with what I sent, and doing it carefully, and so I knew there was a hand, and I went on telling myself it was a clerk because the clerk was the thing I could live beside."

Eleanor said nothing. He had not asked her anything, and the silence was a kind she knew, the silence of a man laying down a thing he had carried so long that the setting of it down was the whole of what he had come to do, and you did not help a man set down a weight by reaching

for it before his hands had opened. She let him hold it the last moment he would hold it.

"It is no longer a clerk you can pretend me to," he said. "And I am no longer a man you can run at the end of a channel. That is why I am in a chair in a dead woman's house instead of three intermediaries away from you where I have been safe and useful for twenty-one years. You know this. I will not waste the afternoon telling you what we both carried in with us."

"No," Eleanor said. "Tell me what I do not have."

He drew a breath. The light from the dead lane did not move on him. Somewhere in the back of the house the fruit she had smelled on the way in went on quietly turning, and the cold came up through the floor of the unheated room and found her ankles, and she sat in it and waited.

"The review you stood up," he said. "Four prefectures, routine language, your authority, two years ago now. I knew what it was the day the order crossed my desk, because I was meant to read it and pass it along and I read it the way you taught a man to read without ever teaching him, by reading what it worked to seem. It worked very hard to seem ordinary. I have spent my life among orders that worked to seem ordinary. I knew you had moved. And I knew that if you had moved, the thing I had been feeling under the paper for years had reached the size where it moved you, and that frightened me more than anything I had sent you, because I had hoped, the way a man hopes, that the size I felt was a thing I was imagining out of guilt."

"It was not."

"It was not." He was quiet. "I have the authorization category. The one your people will have found and will not have been able to follow, because following it requires the standing to question the office it issues from, and the office it issues from is high enough that questioning it is itself a report filed about you to the man you would be questioning. Your investigators will have hit that ceiling. They will have called it a ceiling. I have spent twenty-one years on the other side of it. I can tell you whose ceiling it is."

Eleanor did not move. Against the wall, in the chair the light did not reach, Kaviel did not move either, and the room held the three of them in

the gray even light with the stopped clock between them, and Aurelio Saad said a name.

He said it without weight, in the same dry, unhurried voice he had used for all of it, the way a man says a thing he has carried so long that saying it costs him nothing more than the breath, and he set beside the name the three offices it sat above, and the reach of those offices across the Outer Prefectures and the jurisdictions that touched them, three Thrones' worth of administrative ground, and the years the man had held that reach, and the one structural fact that turned a coincidence of access into a certainty, which was that the authorization category Asha had struck against could be issued from exactly one chair in the imperial establishment and that chair was his.

Eleanor knew the name. She had known the man across the better part of forty years, had sat at tables with him, had taken his measure in a dozen quiet rooms and had filed the measure and found it sound and had been, in the long accounting of her trust, wrong. She felt the thing settle that she had carried into the room as a possibility and would carry out of it as a fact, and it settled the way a load settles onto a back that has been braced for it a long time, all at once and without surprise and with no relief in it at all. She did not let it show on her face. The face was sixty years of work and it held. But she was old, and the room was cold, and the man across the table was watching her with eyes that had spent a career reading exactly what she was now refusing to show, and she understood that he saw it land, because he had needed to see it land, because a man who has carried a thing twenty-one years needs to know the moment it has finally been received by hands that can hold it.

"You are certain," she said. It was not a question. She asked it as one so that the record of the afternoon, the record that lived only in three skulls and would never live anywhere else, would show that she had asked.

"I am certain of the chair," he said. "I am certain of the category. I am certain the category and the chair are the same. I am not certain of the man's whole intent, because I have never sat in the room where his intent is spoken, and I will not invent for you the part I do not have. You taught me that, through three men I never met. Do not hand them what you do not hold. I am handing you what I hold. The rest is yours to find, and you

will find it faster than I could tell it, and you will find it cleaner, because nothing I have given you points back along the path I came."

"It points back along the path of who could have known to give it."

"Yes." He said it as if it weighed nothing, and then, because the word he had used asked too little of the thing, he said the rest. "The moment I stand up from this chair, the channel is over. Not paused. Over. The intervals will not be kept because I will not be there to keep them, and the absence of the intervals is itself a message, and the man whose chair it is will read the absence within the season, because reading absences is what his office is for and what I have spent twenty-one years helping you read in others. He will know a source went dark. He will draw his short list. My name will be on it, and it will be a short list, and I have made my arrangements for what comes after a short list."

Eleanor looked at him then, fully, for the first time since he had sat, and she let herself look at the face she had refused for twenty-one years, the spare old face of the man who had fed her apparatus from inside the establishment that was now eating itself, and she did not soften it for him and she did not harden it, she only looked, and took the face into the same place she kept the two names she had guessed wrong on, and the dish where the key sat in plain view, and the figures she had let climb in a drawer eleven days while a man stayed alive in the dark she kept him in.

"You came in," she said, "because there was no other way to give it to me clean."

"There was no other way to give it to you at all," he said. "The channel was built to move small things and to move them so that no one could weigh them. This cannot be made small. There is no way to send a name through three men so that none of them knows he is carrying a name. You taught me the channel's limits the day you built it, though you never said a word to me, by what you let it carry and what you never asked it to. I have spent twenty-one years inside the limits of a thing you designed. I know exactly what it cannot do. It cannot do this. So I am doing this." He moved his hands off the table at last and set them on the arms of the chair, the gesture of a man preparing to rise. "I am not asking you to protect me. I know better than any living man what you can and cannot protect, because protecting things at the edge of what can be

protected is the trade we have shared without sharing a room. You held a report eleven days for me once. I know you did. I felt the eleven days from the inside as a quiet I could not account for, and I accounted for it later, and I have never told you and I am telling you now so that you will not think the years were spent on a man who did not understand what they cost you to spend. You bought me a year that became twenty. I am giving the year back. That is the whole of the accounting and it is even, and I will not have you treat it as a debt in either direction."

Eleanor was silent a long moment. The light had not changed because there was no sun in it to move. The cold sat in the room and the stopped clock said its quarter past nothing and the fruit turned in the back of the house.

"Then it is even," she said.

He rose. It took him a moment, the old frame negotiating the unfamiliar chair, and neither woman moved to help him, because help would have made him a man being helped in his last act of standing and he had not come to be that, he had come to set a thing down and walk out from under it, and the dignity of walking out from under it was the one thing left in the room that was wholly his. He gained his feet. He squared the dark coat. He looked once more at Kaviel against the wall, the witness who had not spoken and would not, and he inclined his head to her a small degree, an old official's courtesy to a younger one whose name he did not know and would never learn, and Kaviel returned it, the same degree, no more, and that was the whole of what passed between them.

"I will go out the way I came," he said to Eleanor. "Do not have your men walk me. A man walked out of a house is a man someone watched leave. I would rather be a man who was never here."

"You were never here," Eleanor said.

He looked at her a last time. Whatever he had come to find in her face he seemed to have found, because he did not search it further. He turned and crossed the room with the careful tread that knew where strange boards gave, and the door of the front room let him into the hall, and the hall let him toward the door to the dead lane, and Eleanor sat and listened to the tread go, the gate's small sound, and then the afternoon with

nothing in it but the cold and the turning fruit and the clock that had stopped years before either of them was born to this.

She did not move for a while. Against the wall, Kaviel waited, having said nothing for the whole of it as she had been told, and she went on saying nothing now, because the instruction had not been lifted and because she had spent enough years across tables from her mother to know that the thing Eleanor did in the minute after a door closed was a thing done alone even when another person was in the room, and that the kindest and the most correct course, which in Eleanor's house were the same course, was to let her have the minute and to mark it and to never once mention having marked it.

So Kaviel watched. She watched her mother sit in the gray light with her hands flat on the table where the old man's hands had been, and she watched the line of the old woman's back, which did not bow, and the set of the old woman's jaw, which did not move, and she watched Eleanor look at the stopped clock for a long time as if it were a document she was reading for what it was built around. Nothing in the face gave. Nothing in the hands. But Kaviel had read documents her whole life for the part the writer did not think to guard, and she read her mother the same way now, against her own will and without meaning to, and she saw in the stillness of the hands flat on the cold table a thing she had no word for and did not try to find one for, and she filed it the way she filed everything, against the gap where it fit, and found that it fit a gap she had not known was in her, and she did not look away from it, because she was her mother's daughter and looking away was the one thing neither of them had ever been permitted.

The light thinned. The early dark of the season came down over the dead lane and the low wall and the unlatched gate, and the room went from gray to grayer, and still Eleanor sat with her hands on the table and Kaviel sat against the wall, and the distance between the two chairs was the whole width of the room and the whole length of the years that had built both women to sit in it without crossing it.

Then Eleanor moved her hands off the table at last, and folded them in her lap, and turned her head toward the chair against the wall where her daughter sat in the failing light.

"Now we know," she said, quietly.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Junior Researcher's Discovery

THE KNOCK CAME AT the eleventh hour, and Kaviel knew before she opened the door that it was Zola, because the knock was wrong.

It was not loud and it was not soft. It was even, three taps spaced the way a person spaces a thing they have rehearsed in a corridor on the walk over so that the hand will not betray what the rest of them is doing, and Kaviel had heard that exact evenness once before, weeks back, from a junior who had been taught to be calm and had not yet learned that the teaching showed. She set down the report she had been reading by the single lamp, the only light she kept in the office past the eighth hour, and she crossed the small room and drew the door open, and Zola Adimu was standing in the corridor with a folder held flat against her chest in both arms the way a person holds a thing they have decided no one will take from them between one room and the next.

"You should be asleep," Kaviel said. It was not a reproach. It was the first reading, the thing she said to learn from how the other person answered it.

"I know the hour." Zola's voice was steady and her eyes were not. There was a brightness in them that Kaviel had seen in the eyes of officers coming off a long observation, the brightness of a person who has not slept and has stopped being able to tell that the not-sleeping has begun to cost them. "I could not leave it in the room. I could not log it and go home and have it sit there until the first hour with no one knowing it was there."

"Come in." Kaviel stepped back and let her through, and she looked past Zola down the corridor before she shut the door, the long stone run of it dim and empty, the watch not yet due to pass, no one at the far end where the stairs went down. She shut the door. She did not lock it, because a locked door in the Quarter at the eleventh hour was a thing a watch officer noted, and she crossed back to the table and turned the lamp's shade up a quarter so the light spread off the desk and onto the part of the floor where the second chair stood.

The office was small and she kept it that way on purpose, the same reasoning Asha kept her room small and the appointments room had been a store. There was the desk, old and chosen for the size of its surface and nothing else, and the two chairs, and the window she cracked for moving air even in the cold, the way she did, so that the room never went stale and never held the smell of a person who had been in it too long. The window was cracked now and the night came in through the gap, the cold of it and the faint reach of the compound after dark, a cart somewhere on the lower yard, the bang of a kitchen door two floors down, the air carrying the last of the evening bread off the banked fires and under it the dry paper smell that lived in every room in the Quarter and never left.

"Set it down," Kaviel said. "On the desk. Lay it out the way you would lay it for Asha."

That was deliberate, and Zola took it the way it was meant, as an instruction to do the thing she had been trained to do and not the thing the hour wanted her to do, which was to talk. She came to the desk and she set the folder down and she opened it, and she did not pour the contents out. She laid them. Kaviel watched her hands and the hands were better than the eyes, the hands were trained and the training held even now, lifting each sheet and squaring it and setting it where the next would follow from it, building the thing on the desk in the order a reader would need it and not the order it had come to her in. The ruled sheets first, the three-column sheets, dozens of them, the columns filled in the slow clean hand Kaviel had watched her learn. Then the source pages drawn against them, the carry-forward entries and the prior rosters, paired, each entry beside the older authority it claimed and did not have. Then at the last, set apart, a single sheet in a hand that was not the work

hand, a hand that had been written fast and was the only fast thing in the folder.

Kaviel did not reach for any of it yet. She pulled the second chair around so it faced the desk and she gestured Zola into it, and Zola sat on the edge of it the way she had stood in the appointments room the first morning, a person who had not given herself permission to settle.

"Water first," Kaviel said. There was a covered cup on the shelf and she filled it from the jug and set it by Zola's hand on the desk, away from the sheets. "Drink it. Then tell it from the start, in order, the way the work runs, and do not tell me the end before you have told me how you got there, because I will not be able to use the end if I do not first see the road."

Zola drank. Her hand was not quite steady on the cup and she set it down with care so it would not knock the sheets, and Kaviel saw her take the breath, the long one, the one that put the hour back outside the door and the work back in front of her, and when she spoke again the steadiness in the voice had stopped being a thing she was holding on by will and had become the steadiness of the work itself.

"I finished the easy stacks two weeks ago," Zola said. "Sennar and the two beside it and the four that had already gone hot. You had the count from those. I logged them and brought you the twelves the way you taught me, and you took them to wherever you take them, and I started on the cold stacks, the jurisdictions where nothing had been pointed, where I was running the trace blind because no one had told me a single entry there was bad." She drew the first ruled sheet a little toward Kaviel without lifting it off the desk. "You told me to trace them all. You told me the man who built it salts the clean ones among the bad. So I did not skip the cold jurisdictions because they looked cold. I ran every carry-forward entry in them back to the prior authority it named."

"And."

"And in the cold jurisdictions the entries are not clean." Zola's voice did not rise. The not-rising was the discipline holding and Kaviel marked it and was glad of it. "They are bad the same way. An entry cites a prior commission and a session and a folio, and I go to the prior roster, and the session sat and confirmed eleven names and the name in the entry is not one of them. Or the prior commission the entry names never sat at all in

that jurisdiction. The same gap. The same shape. In jurisdictions where nothing was ever pointed and no one was looking and no field report ever came up, the carry-forward provision carries names that no commission confirmed, and it carries them the same way it carries them in Sennar."

Kaviel let that sit a moment in the cold air of the room. She had expected the cold jurisdictions to give her something. She had not let herself decide how much, because deciding in advance was the thing that built a shape out of a wish, and she had learned the cost of that long ago. But she had carried, under the not-deciding, a quiet expectation that the cold jurisdictions would give her a few, that the fraud would thin as it spread from the watershed where it started, that there would be a falling-off at the edges that let her draw a line around it and say it ran this far and no further.

"How many of the cold jurisdictions did you run," she said.

"All of them in the Outer Prefectures." Zola's finger moved down the squared edge of the ruled stack, not touching, counting in the air. "And then I did not stop at the Outer Prefectures."

Kaviel looked up from the sheets to the young face.

"You told me the provision had cousins," Zola said. "The first morning, at the map. You said the carry-forward had cousins under other commissions beyond the Outer Prefectures, and that you had not yet thought to pull them. I wrote it down. I have written down everything you have said to me at that table since the first morning, because I did not know yet which of it was the method and which was you thinking out loud, and I could not afford to lose the method by guessing wrong." She said it without apology and without pride, as a thing a careful person did. "When the Outer Prefectures gave me what they gave me, I went and found the cousins. The reconciliation provisions under the adjoining commissions, the ones seated for the jurisdictions that border the Outer Prefectures on the spinward side and the ones under the river commissions to the south. The clause is not worded the same. But it does the same thing. It lets an appointment into the standing record on the word that a prior authority confirmed it, without the present commission looking again. And it is being used the same way, in those jurisdictions too."

Kaviel did not move. The lamp threw Zola's shadow up the wall behind her and the cracked window let in the bang of the far kitchen door again, and Kaviel sat with her hands flat on her knees and made herself reach for nothing on the desk, because the road was not finished and she had told the girl to walk it to the end and she would walk it.

"Show me the reach," she said. "Not the count. The reach. Lay me the map."

Zola reached into the folder for the thing she had set apart, and it was not the fast-written sheet, it was a second map, hand-drawn, the printer's grid of the Outer Prefectures copied out in Zola's slow rule and extended past its own edges where no printed map went, the adjoining jurisdictions sketched in beyond the border with their numbers and the river commissions' districts pencilled below, the whole of it larger than any single sheet so that she had joined three sheets at the back with paste and folded them, and she unfolded the thing now across the desk over the squared stacks, weighting two corners with the water cup and the lamp base the way the work taught, and on it, in the small flat dots that were Kaviel's own mark, the mark Kaviel had set against three jurisdictions on the first night and Zola had learned from watching her do it, there were dots everywhere.

Not everywhere. Kaviel made herself read it true and not read it for the size of the shock of it. There were jurisdictions with no dot. But the dots ran across the Outer Prefectures in a spread that no watershed held and no single office reached, and they crossed the border into the adjoining jurisdictions where a different commission sat under a different bureau seat, and they ran down into the river districts under the southern commissions, and the spread of them was not the spread of a thing that had leaked from one bad office into its neighbors. It was the spread of a thing that had been placed.

"Three commissions," Kaviel said. She was reading the dots and she said it half to herself. "Three commissions under, what. Tell me the seats. You will have the seats."

"The Bureau of Establishments holds the Third Appointments Commission for the Outer Prefectures." Zola's finger went to the printed grid, to the dots she had set there over weeks. "The adjoining jurisdictions to spinward are confirmed under their own commission, seated separately,

but it answers up through the same bureau. The river commissions to the south answer up a different line on paper. On paper they are three commissions under two reporting lines across what the old administrative tables count as three Thrones' worth of jurisdiction." She lifted her finger off the map and set her hands in her lap and looked at Kaviel, and the brightness was back in her eyes and there was something under it now that the work had been holding off for the length of the telling and could not hold off any longer. "But they are not being run as three. They are being run as one. The same gap in every one of them. The provision read the same way. The names placed by hands that had to have been pointed at the provision by the same understanding. I traced the reconciliation back the way you taught me, all the way back, and where the prior authority does not exist, I traced who would have had to authorize the entry to be made at all despite the gap, who sits above all three commissions on a line where the three reporting lines come together." She stopped. "There is one office where they come together. There is one authority that reaches all three."

"Do not name it." Kaviel said it fast and flat and it landed in the room like a hand laid on a moving thing to stop it, and Zola's mouth closed on the word she had not yet said. "You have it on the page. Show me where it is on the page and do not say it in this room out loud. The room is not watched, I do not think the room is watched. You are going to learn tonight to hold a name in your head and never let it past your teeth, and the time to learn that is the first time you have a name to hold and not the tenth."

Zola's hand moved to the fast-written sheet, the one in the hand that was not the work hand, and she turned it face down on the desk without Kaviel asking her to, and Kaviel saw her understand, saw the understanding go into her the way the first morning's distinction had gone in, set where it belonged, not shown on the front of her face.

"It is on that sheet," Zola said quietly. "I worked it last. I worked it at the eighth hour tonight and I checked it twice and I wrote it down because I was afraid I would talk myself out of it, and then I turned the lamp down and I sat in the room with it for an hour and I could not stay in the room with it, and I came here."

Now Kaviel reached for the work. She drew the ruled stacks out from under the folded map and she read them, and she read them the way Asha had taught her to read a junior's finding. You did not look for whether the junior was right. You looked for the place where the junior was wrong and found it before anyone else did, because a finding this size would be torn at by everyone it reached and the place it tore was the place a careful reader found first and shored up first. She read down the columns. The entry. The claimed authority. The gap. She took a sheet at random out of the middle of the cold-jurisdiction stack, a jurisdiction she had never pointed at and never read, and she made Zola tell her where the source pages for it were, and Zola found them and laid them, and Kaviel read the carry-forward entry and then read the prior roster it named, the older commission's filed session, and she found the eleven confirmed names and she ran her finger down them twice and the name in the entry was not among them. She did it again with a sheet from the spinward jurisdictions, the ones across the border under the separately seated commission, and the gap was there, the same gap, an entry resting on a session that had confirmed everything but the thing it claimed.

She did it a third time and a fourth. She did not exclaim. The discipline she had taught the girl was a discipline she had not stopped keeping, and she kept it now over a thing that was the largest finding she had read in her life, kept her hands steady on the pages and her face still and her breathing even, because if she broke the discipline in front of the junior at the hour the junior most needed to see it hold, she would teach her in one night to undo everything the weeks had built. So she read, and the room was quiet around the reading, the cracked window and the cold and the far sounds of the compound running on through the night, the watch's boots passing somewhere on a lower floor and not on this one, the dry whisper of the source pages as she squared each one and set it back.

The work was clean. That was the thing she had been reading for and the thing she found. There was no place where Zola had reached past the evidence. The columns held to what the rosters showed. The cold jurisdictions had been run blind and the gaps had stood up out of them on their own. The cousins under the other commissions had been worded differently and read the same and the reading was sound. The map was

drawn from the dots and the dots were drawn from the gaps and the gaps were facts. And the one office where the three reporting lines came together had not been named on any work sheet, had been kept off the columns and set on a single page apart and turned face down, because the girl had understood, somewhere in the long hour she could not stay in the room, that the name was the part you did not write into the body of a thing that would be read.

Kaviel set the last source page back into its pair and squared the stack and laid her hand flat on it, and she looked across the desk at Zola Adimu, who had not moved, who was sitting on the edge of the second chair with her hands in her lap and the brightness in her eyes gone glassy now with the hour and the not-sleeping and the size of the thing she had carried up the corridor, and who was waiting, Kaviel saw, for some sign that the thing she had found was real and had landed and had not been a young researcher's error built up over weeks into a shape that the first hard reading would knock down. She was not waiting for praise; the girl was too well made for that. She was waiting to be told whether to be horrified. She had been holding the horror off with the work and the work was done and there was nothing left to hold it off with, and she was waiting for the senior officer across the desk to tell her whether the horror was earned.

"You ran the cold jurisdictions blind," Kaviel said. "No one pointed you. You found the gaps yourself."

"Yes."

"And the cousins. No one told you the other commissions used the provision. You went and found that they did."

"You told me they had cousins."

"I told you they had cousins. I did not tell you to go and run three Thrones' worth of jurisdiction against three commissions on two reporting lines, because I did not know that was the size of the thing, and I would not have set a junior researcher to run it alone if I had known, and you ran it alone because you did not wait to be told the size of it before you started." Kaviel kept her voice level. "That is the work done right and it is also a thing we are going to talk about another night, the running ahead, because the running ahead found this and the running ahead is also how a careful officer gets seen by the people she is reading.

Not tonight. Tonight you did the thing the work needed and you did it clean and I have read it hard and it holds."

Zola let out a breath she had been keeping, and her shoulders came down a little off the edge they had been held at, and the glassy brightness in her eyes went bright in a different way for a second before she put it down, and Kaviel watched her put it down and did not remark on it, because remarking on it would have made it a thing instead of a thing the girl had handled.

"What I am going to give you now is what you need and not more," Kaviel said. "You do not need to know what I do with this. You do not need to know who I take it to or when or what comes after. You found the size of the thing and the size of the thing is now mine to carry, and the carrying of it is not your work and you will not ask after it. What you need is two things, and I am going to give you both, and then you are going to go home and sleep, and you are going to have a dull day tomorrow that you can talk about, and I will see that you do."

"The first thing," Zola said.

"The first thing is that you are right, and the horror you have been holding off with the columns is earned, and you do not have to wonder anymore whether you built it up out of nothing, because you did not, the thing is real and it is the size you found it to be and you are right to be sick at it." Kaviel said it plainly and watched it land, watched the permission go into the girl, the permission to have felt for the length of the long hour the thing she had not let herself feel while there was work left to make sure of. "A person who reads a fraud this size and is not sick at it is a person I do not want running my traces. You read it true and it cost you and the cost is correct. Carry it. Do not perform it and do not let it into your face at the dinner table, but do not pretend to yourself that it is not there, because the pretending is what wears an officer out faster than the work does."

She rose, and she gathered the folded map off the desk, easing the cup and the lamp base off its corners, and she folded it along the lines Zola had pasted, and she set it with the ruled stacks and the source pages and the face-down sheet, and she squared the whole of it back into the folder in the order it would need to be read, and she held the folder a moment in both hands the way the girl had held it in the corridor, and

then she set it in the locked drawer of the desk and turned the key and put the key where she kept it, which was not in the desk.

"The second thing," Zola said. She had stood when Kaviel stood.

Kaviel came around the desk and stood in front of her in the spread of the lamp, close, the way she did not usually stand to a junior, close enough that the thing she was about to say would have nowhere to go but into the girl and would not scatter into the cold air of the room.

"You will not speak of this. Not to Asha. Not to your family. Not to anyone, until I tell you." A pause. "You did well."

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Message Trace

THE ROOM RAN IN daylight now, and Kaviel had not yet decided whether she liked what the daylight did to it.

For the weeks since she had opened it the north room had been a night room, a single lamp and two people and the cold of the deep masonry, and the work in it had been quiet enough that she could hear a stack squared at the far end of the table. That room was gone. The store-smell had gone with it, beaten out at last by the bodies and the warm air and the lamp oil burned every night, and what filled the room at the second hour of the morning was the sound of a thing at full use. Five people where there had been two. The long table pushed against the north wall to clear the floor, and the floor given over to the racked relay logs Ferran had asked for, the banded volumes set up on their ends in the wooden cradles he had built so that a reader could walk the line of them and pull any one without disturbing its neighbors. The high window gave its flat gray light across the near half of the room and left the racks at the dim end in the shadow they kept all day, and Kaviel had set a second lamp down there, against her own habit, because the daylight that had once been enough for two was not enough for five.

She stood in the doorway a moment before she went in, the way she did with any space she meant to work from, and read it. Asha at the table's near end with the financial side drawn up beside her, the disbursement registers she would not let out of her own keeping. Zola at the racks, slower than anyone and right where the others were fast,

working a relay log against a list in her own ruled hand. A second researcher Asha had given up to the room, a careful man named Otieno who did not yet know what he was working and had not asked. And Ferran, at the table's far end, where Kaviel had put him on the first day so that the dim end and the racks were his and the near end with the maps and the names was hers.

Tobias Ferran was the thing in the room she had not built and could not unmake, and she had spent the first day of having him deciding how much of the room he would be allowed to see and the rest of the days holding to it. He was a records-systems specialist out of the transit administration, contracted to the Quarter through a billing line that read as building maintenance, and he had come because the trace needed a thing no Lioness in the compound knew how to do, which was to read the routing record of a private courier message back through the relay points it had passed. He was good. She had known he was good within the first hour, the way she had known Zola was patient, and she had not let the knowing soften the other fact about him, which was that he sat outside the chain. Everyone else in the room had been read and held and made by the Quarter over years. Ferran had been hired. He did not know the names. He did not know the shape. He knew the routing problem she had brought him, and he believed it was a billing fraud in the courier service, a thing of stolen franking and misposted relay fees, because that was what she had told him it was and she had built the cover well enough that the work he did on it was true work and not a lie he could trip over.

"Where are we," she said, coming to the near end of the table.

"Two of three." Ferran did not look up from the log under his hand. He spoke the way he worked, flatly, with the figures first. "The message that went to your registrar in Adwa came in to the office courier service off the private line, not the registry line. Private matter, hand-addressed, no office mark, the franking paid against a standing account. That account is the first point. I have it."

"You have the account."

"I have the account number and the relay it franks through. The account is held in a service name, a forwarding office in Adwa that takes private correspondence for clients who would rather the registry not see it. Lawful. Common. The forwarding office is a wall, not a window, it

does not keep who its clients are, it keeps the account and the account pays. But the account is a thing, and a thing routes." He turned the log a quarter toward her, not so she could read it, he had learned in the first day that she did not read his logs, but so the gesture stood for the showing. "The forwarding office did not originate the message. It received it from somewhere and franked it on. Every message it franks carries the relay stamp of where it came in from, because the relay charges the forwarding office and the charge has to post against something. I read the relay stamps back. The forwarding office took your message in from a second relay, a transit hub two jurisdictions north, on the spinward line. That is the second point. I have that one too."

Kaviel set two fingers on the map at the near end of the table, on the spinward jurisdictions where Zola's dots ran across the border, and found the transit hub without being told where it was, because she had read the spinward line for other reasons in other weeks. The second relay sat where the spinward courier lines came together before they ran down toward the Outer Prefectures. North of it the lines thinned and went up toward the bureau seats. She did not say any of that.

"And the third," she said.

"The third is the one that matters and the third is slow." For the first time Ferran looked up, and his face had the small fixed attention of a man who has come to the part of a problem that is worth his time. "The transit hub does not keep client accounts the way the forwarding office does. It is a relay, it moves volume, it posts its charges in bulk against the lines that feed it and reconciles them at the fiscal turn. So I cannot read your message back through it by the account, because at the hub your message is not a message, it is one franking among forty thousand in a posting batch. I have to find the batch your message rode in, and then find what fed the batch, the line that brought that volume into the hub on that day. That is in the hub's own relay reconciliation, and that is what I am pulling now, and it is in those." He nodded at the racks at the dim end, where Zola and Otieno worked. "Three days of the hub's relay reconciliation either side of your message's date. The line that fed the batch is in there. When I have the line, I have the third point, and the third point is where your message entered the courier system to begin with. Whoever wrote it handed it to that line. That is your origin."

"How long."

"Today, if the racks hold what I asked for. Tomorrow if they pulled it short." He went back to the log. "The hub keeps it. The hub keeps everything, it has to, the whole system bills off it. The only question is whether your clerks pulled three days or pulled one and called it three."

"They pulled three," Asha said from the near end, without looking up from her registers, and Ferran took that the way he took most things she said, which was as a fact he did not have standing to argue, and said nothing.

Kaviel left them to it and went down the room to the racks.

This was the part of the trace she had thought about most, the reading of it once he handed her the line. The routing of it was Ferran's and beyond her. She had run the shape of it in her head on the walk down from her own office that morning. The first point was a service name behind a forwarding office, a wall. The second point was a relay batch in a transit hub, a number. Neither of them was a hand. But the third point, the line that fed the message into the system, was the closest thing the message would ever bring her to the hand that wrote it, because a man who sent a private warning did not walk it to a public forwarding office himself, he handed it to a line he trusted, and the line he trusted ran from somewhere, and the somewhere was an office. Ferran would give her a line. She would have to give the line a place.

Zola straightened from the rack when Kaviel came down, and did not speak, because the room in daylight was a room where things were said in front of Ferran and Otieno and the rule was that nothing was said in front of them that the cover did not cover. Kaviel had taught her that the first morning of the larger room, in the corridor, in four sentences, and Zola had set it where it belonged and kept it. She tilted the relay log she was reading so Kaviel could see the column she had reached, the franking volumes posted against the feeder lines, day by day, line by line, and she touched one figure with the back of her stylus and did not say what it was. Kaviel read it. The volume on one feeder line had spiked on the day before the message reached Adwa, a small spike, the kind a fiscal reconciliation would pass over as noise, and it had fallen back the day after. Zola had marked it because Zola marked the thing that did not fit the texture around it, which was the method, run now on relay volumes

instead of carry-forward entries, the same eye for the place where order was too clean or too sudden.

"Good," Kaviel said, low, the one word, and Zola went back to the rack.

She stood a moment at the dim end with the second lamp throwing the racks' shadows up onto the cold stone, and the daylight from the high window not reaching this far, and she let herself feel the difference in the room. In the night room she had known where every page was. Here the work was distributed across five hands and two of the hands were not hers, and she could not hold the whole of it in her head at once the way she had held it when it was her and the girl and the cracked window. That was the cost of the room growing. She had weighed it before she let it grow. A trace through a transit hub's bulk reconciliation was not a thing two people did in a season, and she had needed Ferran and she had needed the racks and the racks had needed bodies to walk them, and so she had grown the room and accepted that the price of the speed was that the room could now be felt from outside, that five people working a thing left a wake where two had left none.

She was thinking exactly that, standing at the dim end with the lamp on the racks, when Ferran said her name.

He did not raise his voice. He had not raised his voice once in the days she had worked him. He said her name the way a man says a thing he has just read and is not yet sure of, and the not-sure in it was new, because Ferran was a man who said the figure first and the doubt never, and she came back up the room before he had said the second word.

"The third point is gone," he said.

She stood at the table's far end and did not touch the log. "Say it plainly."

"I found the line." He had the hub's reconciliation open under both hands now, two volumes of it, the spike day Zola had marked and the day before it. "The batch your message rode in fed off a single line, I have the line, it is a dedicated relay, not a public feeder, a closed line that runs up the spinward route toward the bureau seats and carries office matter for one subscriber. A closed line has a subscriber record. The hub has to keep it, the closed line is billed direct to the subscriber, the subscriber's office routes its private correspondence down it and the hub posts the

charges back up it at the turn. The subscriber record is the third point. It is the office your message came from." He turned the second volume. "And the subscriber record is gone."

"Gone how."

"Suspended." He set his finger on a posting, and for the first time he looked at her instead of at the page, and his flat administrative face had the thing in it that she had brought him to read it without giving him: the recognition of a man who knows the machine and has watched it do a thing it is not supposed to be able to do quietly. "Three days ago the closed line was suspended at the subscriber's request and the subscriber record sealed pending audit. That is a lawful thing. A subscriber can suspend a closed line and seal its record if it suspects the line has been compromised, billing fraud, stolen franking, the kind of thing I came here to find. When a record is sealed pending audit, the hub closes it to all reading but the auditor's, and the auditor is named by the bureau the line answers to, and until the audit runs the record shows nothing but the seal. I can see that the line existed. I can see that it fed the batch. I cannot see the subscriber, because three days ago someone asked the hub to stop anyone seeing the subscriber, and the hub did what it is built to do, and sealed it."

The room had gone quiet behind her, the working quiet thinned rather than the full quiet of the night room, Zola's stylus stopped at the rack and Otieno's hand still on a volume he had been about to lift and Asha at the near end with her registers untouched under her hand, all of them not looking and all of them listening, because a thing had happened in the room and the discipline that held them from showing it was the discipline that left the room this quiet.

Kaviel read the posting. She did not need Ferran to read it for her now that he had told her where to look, and she read the date of the seal and the form of the request and the bureau named to run the audit, and she read it twice, the way Asha had taught her, looking past whether it was what Ferran said it was, hunting the place where it might be something else, and finding none. It was what he said it was. Three days ago, while her room ran the trace toward the third point in good order and believed itself unseen, an office on the far end of a closed line had

reached down through a transit hub it subscribed to and sealed its own record against the very reading her room was four hours from making.

"Three days ago," she said.

"Three days ago." Ferran did not ask the question that sat under it, because he did not know there was a question, he thought the seal was a courier-fraud subscriber covering a billing exposure, and he said the next thing the way he would have said it to anyone. "It happens. A subscriber gets a fraud notice, panics, seals the line. The audit will open it in a quarter or two and then I can read it. I can put the request in to the bureau, but it will be slow and it will have my name on it and the bureau will want to know why a courier billing matter wants a sealed subscriber record. I would not put that in without your word."

"You will not put it in." She said it level, and she said it as the routing it was, an instruction to the contractor and not a thing he could read past. "Not under your name, not under the building line, not at all. The audit will run when it runs. We do not chase a sealed record through the bureau, because the bureau is the line we are reading and a request through the bureau is a thing the bureau reads. You have done the work I brought you for. You found the line. The line is the finding. Write me the line, the closed-line reference and the feed and the date of the seal, and write me nothing about the subscriber, because there is nothing to write, and then I want the racks logged back to where Otieno can return them by the channel without a question, and I want you off this by the end of the day."

Ferran looked at her a moment longer than he had looked at her in three days of work, and she watched him decide not to ask the thing he had begun to feel, the thing that did not fit a billing fraud, which was that a subscriber covering a stolen-franking exposure did not seal a closed line three days after a quiet reconciliation reader began walking the hub's batch posting toward it, that the timing of the seal was the timing of a thing that had been watched. He was good. He had felt it. He set it down, the way a contracted man who wanted to be contracted again set down the thing the client did not want him to have felt, and he drew a clean sheet and began to write the line.

Kaviel went back down the room to the dim end and stood at the racks where the daylight did not reach, and she put her hand flat on the

rail of the nearest cradle, the worn wood Ferran had cut and joined in the first days, and she stood there in the second lamp's reach while the room behind her came back by degrees to its working sound, the stylus moving again at the next rack, Otieno lifting his volume, Asha's page turning at the near end, the building running on through the second hour of the morning the way it always ran while in this room five people sat at the edge of a thing that had just reached back and shut a door in their faces. She had built the room to move faster and the speed had cost her the wake she knew it would cost, and the wake had been read, and the reading had been answered before her own hand had finished reaching, and there was no part of that she had not weighed, except the part that no weighing prepared a person for, which was the flatness of it, the way it had come as a posting and not a blow, a lawful seal in a clean hand on a page, a door closed by a subscriber whose name she could not read and did not, this morning, need to read, because she knew whose office sat at the top of a closed line that ran up the spinward route toward the bureau seats, and the source had told it to her mother in a private residence outside the complex eleven days ago, and her mother had told her, and she carried it now where she carried everything she could not write.

She came back up the room.

The relay display Ferran had built ran on a frame at the near end of the table, a clean board where the trace stood mapped in three points and the lines between them, the forwarding office, the transit hub, and the closed line running up toward the third point that should by the day's end have carried a name and now carried a seal instead. Ferran had set the seal onto it before she reached the table, a small struck mark over the third point in the convention he used, the convention that meant a record reading no further, and the three points sat on the board with the road between them drawn and the end of the road closed, the trace gone dead on the display a hand's reach short of the office it had been climbing toward all week.

Kaviel watched it a moment.

"He knows we're looking."

Asha, beside her: "Then we move faster."

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Protected Individual Returns

THE WITNESS FACILITY DID not announce itself. It sat below the administrative level of the Lioness compound, down a stair that the watch logged but did not guard, behind a door faced in the same gray panel as the storerooms to either side of it, and a person who did not already know what lay behind it would have read it as one more cupboard in a building full of cupboards. That was the design. Kaviel had walked the approach the day before from three directions, the way she walked every approach, and had satisfied herself that nothing in the route told a watcher where the route went.

The room itself had no window. It had been cleaned that morning, and the cleaning had left its own evidence, the faint chemical sweetness of the scrub the compound used on rooms reserved for this work, the smell that always sat at the back of Kaviel's throat and that she had stopped trying to name years ago. A table, a jug of water and two covered cups, two chairs set out and the others left stacked against the wall. A single light panel flush in the ceiling, even and shadowless. Nothing on the walls, nothing on the table but the water. She had brought no file in, because a file told a witness what you already had and taught her where the gaps were, and a witness who learned the gaps began to fill them, and a witness who filled gaps was no longer a witness.

Meret stood inside the door. She had been there since before Kaviel arrived, and she would be there until the witness had gone, and in the hours between she would say nothing and ask nothing, because that was

the work Kaviel had asked of her and Meret did the work she was asked and not the work she imagined. She was in the room so that the room was secure, so that nothing came through the door that Kaviel had not let through, and she stood with her hands loose and her weight even and her eyes on the door, a presence the witness would feel and would not have to look at.

"They are bringing her up," Meret said. It was the second thing she had said since Kaviel came in. The first had been the room's condition, given in three words, which was how Meret gave conditions.

"Slowly," Kaviel said. "I want her settled before I am in front of her."

Meret put her knuckle to the bead at her collar and passed it on, two words, and they waited.

Kaviel had read the intake the way she read everything, once for the facts and once for the seams, and the seams in this intake were the part that had kept her awake. The witness had a name now. She had been a woman on a bench at Sabra Crossing with a document case held in both hands, a protected individual onward routed to a seventh gate and filed closed, and the file Kaviel had filed that night had been clean and defensible and silent on the one thing that mattered, which was that the woman Kaviel moved had come up out of Sennar on a feeder that posted to no board, under a name no one upstream had passed to Kaviel, by a route that the advance brief had gotten wrong in two of its three details. The file did not say the brief had been bad, because Kaviel had not been able to prove it, and a thing she could not prove did not go into a file. She had carried it instead, the woman's face and the bad brief and the man at the document desk with the courier's satchel, into the place she kept things she could not yet do anything with.

The door opened. An operative brought the witness in and withdrew, the way the operative at Meridian had withdrawn, a body in the doorway for the length of time it took and then gone, the door easing shut behind on its own weight.

Kaviel stood. She did not come around the table. A table between them was a thing the witness could keep, a width of it that was hers, and Kaviel left it to her.

Naila Osei was older than the memory by four years and otherwise the woman from the bench. Middling height, a record-office stillness in

the way she held herself, hands that wanted an object and found none and folded instead. She had the look of a person told she was safe enough times that she had stopped believing the telling did anything, who came into a windowless room and read the door at her back the way a person reads a thing they have learned to read. She looked at Meret once, took the measure of her, and looked away. She registered the chairs left stacked against the wall, the two set out and no third for an interrogator. A records officer of the peripheral grade missed very little; the work had shaped her the way Kaviel's work had shaped Kaviel.

"Sit, if you would," Kaviel said. "There is water. The room is ours for as long as we need it and no longer than that."

Naïla Osei sat. She poured herself water without being asked and did not drink it, set it where she could reach it, a record officer's instinct to have the thing in front of her placed before she needed it. "I know your face," she said. Her voice was low and even, a voice given nothing to carry. "I have spent four years not letting myself know it, and now they bring me to a room and there it is, and I find I knew it the whole time. You sat down beside me at Sabra and told me about a re-route that was overbooked, and you put a voucher on the bench, and you said seventh gate, and you walked away and did not look back."

"I did."

"I have wondered since whether you were real."

"I was the movement," Kaviel said. "I am something else now, and the something else is why you are here, and I am going to be plain with you, because you would catch me if I were not and it would cost us both the hour." She sat, finally, across the width of the table the woman had kept. "You asked, through the channel that kept you, to give what you have. No one sent for you. I want that said first, because what you give me you give freely, and that will matter later in a way I will tell you about before you leave."

"I know what I am here to give." A record officer's flatness, the flatness of a person stating the contents of a folio. "I worked the spur registry at the Meridian feeder out of Jurisdiction Seven for eleven months before they moved me. I was a reconciliation clerk. I entered the carry-forward attestations into the standing record. I am here to tell you that the attestations I entered were false, and that I knew it, and that I

entered them anyway, until the day I understood what I was inside, and then I went to the channel and asked to be taken out."

Kaviel let that sit without reaching for it. It was a great deal, given fast and whole, and a witness who gave a great deal fast at the opening was a witness either telling the truth or performing it, and the difference was the thing the next hour was for.

"Tell it in order," Kaviel said. "From the work. Not from the day you understood. Tell me the work first, the way it ran on a day that was nothing, and let the day you understood arrive where it arrived. I will not be able to use the understanding if I have not first seen the floor it stood on."

Naila Osei told it the way Kaviel had hoped she would, in the dry registry voice of a person describing a process she had performed a thousand times, and the dryness was the thing that made it land. The couriers came in at the half-hour through the south gate with the attestation satchels, chopped at the shed window, and the schedules went up to the registry where she sat, and she keyed each carry-forward entry against the prior authority it cited. Where the authority checked she confirmed it into the standing record. Where it did not check she was to enter it regardless, on a separate instruction that came down with the schedule and that she was to burn.

"Who handed you the instruction to enter the ones that did not check," Kaviel said.

"The schedule carried it. A slip folded into the schedule, in a hand that was not the registrar's hand. I was to read it, enter against it, and burn it in the registry stove before the schedule went to file." She turned the water cup a quarter and did not lift it. "I burned a great many slips."

"And the courier."

Something moved in the woman's face, the first thing in it that the registry voice did not cover. "The same man, most quarters. Even features, a build you would not describe. He left the satchel at the shed window and did not wait for the chop, and a courier who does not wait for his chop is carrying paper that is not his to answer for. The shed clerk called him Beye. I never spoke to him. The schedule he left was thicker by a third than the spur's own traffic could ever have warranted, and I keyed it, and I burned the slip."

Kaviel kept her face still over the name and the satchel and the third again, because all three had come to her once already from another hand in another cold room, and a thing that arrived twice by two roads that had never touched was a thing that began to be evidence. She gave nothing, because a witness who saw recognition began to aim for it, and she let the silence open.

"You said there was a day you understood," Kaviel said. "Tell me the day."

Naila Osei was quiet for a moment, the quiet of a person walking back to a room she did not want to stand in again, and then she went in. "A black transit came down the freight spur after the day shed had closed. There is no facility chop on a transit that comes in after close; it enters the gate counter as nothing more than axles. A man came down from it. Heavy through the shoulders, deliberate, the kind of slow a man can afford who has never had to hurry. There was an aide a half-step behind him carrying nothing, and a man whose aide carries nothing is a man whose hands are kept empty on purpose." She had not lifted the cup. "He did not go to the shed. He went to the registrar's office, which was dark, and the registrar opened it for him and lit the lamp behind the blind, and they were in there the better part of an hour, and the aide stood at the door the whole time and watched the yard."

"Where were you," Kaviel said.

"At my window. I had stayed late to finish a schedule, which the registrar did not know, because the registry sits above the office and a person at its window after dark is not seen from the office door." The flatness held, and under it now there was a thing the flatness was working to hold. "I saw his face when the lamp came up. I had seen it before. The Bureau sends down a circular every year on the standardization of the attestation forms, and the circular carries a plate of the senior table at the New Terra office, the men who sit the session. His face is on that plate. He sits near the convening chair. I had keyed forms standardized at that table for eleven months, and the man whose table standardized them came down a freight spur in the dark to sit an hour in my registrar's office and leave no chop, no entry any ledger I kept could hold, and I understood, sitting at the window in the cold, what I had been entering and whose weight had been behind it."

The room was very quiet. Meret had not moved at the door. The light panel hummed in the register Kaviel felt behind her eyes more than heard, and the scrubbed sweetness of the cleaned room sat at the back of her throat, and across the table the woman who had keyed a fraud for eleven months and gone to the channel and asked to be taken out sat with her hands folded over a cup of water she would not drink, looking at the middle distance of a registry window four years and many jurisdictions away.

Kaviel did not reach for the thing she had just been given. She had it. She had read Silva's field log out of Jurisdiction Seven until she could have set it down from memory, the black transit and the heavy man, the aide who watched the yard, the dark office and the lamp behind the blind. Silva had stood in the lower yard with a folio case and watched the outside of an hour that this woman had watched from the inside, from a registry window above the same office, and the two accounts had locked together across four years and a great distance the way the face and the frame had locked together in the Meridian room, and the locking was the thing the investigation had needed and had lost when the third relay went dead.

She did not say so. She let none of it cross the table.

"The registrar," Kaviel said instead. "After the man left. What did the registrar do."

"He burned something at the canteen stove before first light. Not the registry stove where the slips went, not the terrace incinerator where the public burning is logged. The canteen stove, in the dark, before the shift came on. A man who burns at his own stove and not where it is logged is burning a thing he does not want anyone to know was ever paper." She turned the cup again. "Two days after, the aide was still on the spur. The transit was gone and the man was gone and the aide stayed, alone, at the canteen at midday with no transit in the yard. A man like that does not leave his aide on a freight spur for company. He leaves him because the spur has become part of the work and he wants a steady hand on it. That was when I went to the channel."

Kaviel sat with it. Everything the woman had given her fit the gap in the case the way the pieces Rashid Beye had given her had fit the gap above Mokoena, and the fitting was the thing that made it dangerous,

because a thing that fit too well was the first thing a hostile reader reached for. She read it for the seam the way she had read Zola's columns for the place they were wrong, looking past whether the woman was right and toward where she could be torn at, and she found the tear, and the tear was not in the testimony.

The tear was in how Kaviel had her.

She turned it over while the woman sat, the cold of the lower level coming up through the floor into the soles of her boots. The testimony was clean and real, and it confirmed Silva's log down to the lamp behind the blind, and it filled the place the dead relay had left, because a clerk who had keyed the entries and burned the slips and seen the man come down in the dark was the human end of the route the trace had lost when the third relay was cut. With this the case was whole. The records, the correction pass Asha had found, Zola's full list of the three commissions, Beye's shape of the hand, Silva's field log, and now a witness who had sat inside the hour and seen the face. Whole. And whole was the new problem, because the moment Kaviel laid this testimony into the case in a form anyone could read, she laid beside it the question of how she had the witness at all, and the answer was a movement filed four years ago at Sabra Crossing on a brief bad in two of its three points, a thread Kaviel had pulled out of the air and protected on inference she had never been able to prove. The witness's value rested on her safety, her safety rested on a movement that did not appear in any record as what it had been, and to use the testimony with its provenance attached was to unwind the protection that made the witness possible.

"I am going to tell you the thing I said would matter later," Kaviel said. "You came to us freely, and you gave this freely, and that is a truth I cannot put on a page in the form it took in this room. If I write down where it came from, I write down a chain that ends at a bench at Sabra Crossing four years ago, and that chain is the thing that has kept you alive, and the moment it is on a page it has stopped keeping anyone alive and started doing the opposite. Do you follow me."

"I keyed records for eleven months," Naila Osei said. "I know what a chain on a page does."

"Then you know what I am going to do, and I am going to say it out loud so that you can hold me to it." Kaviel kept her voice level and gave

the woman her eyes. "I am going to take what you have told me. The transit after close, the man who came down, the dark office and the aide at the door, the thing burned at the canteen stove, the aide left on the spur. All of it. And I am going to set it down in a form that stands on its own, that points where it points without a single line in it that runs back to you. The substance is the evidence. The road I took to reach you is not, and it is not going on any page. You came to us freely and freely is how you will leave."

Naila Osei looked at her for a long moment, the records-officer flatness over something the flatness was holding, and then she nodded, once, the nod of a person who has had a process explained correctly and has nothing to add to it.

"There is one more thing, and then I will not keep you. The man who came down. You will not name him in this room. You have his face from a Bureau plate and a seat near a convening chair, and that is enough for me to know that you saw what I needed you to have seen, and it is more than enough to be the death of you the moment it is written beside your name. So I will not ask you who he was. I am going to ask you only the plate you saw it on. The standardization circular. Could you find it again. The document, the year of it, the session it carried, so that the plate itself does the saying and you never do."

"I keyed against that circular for eleven months." Naila Osei's mouth moved, almost. "I could find it in the dark."

"Then that is the form it will take." Kaviel rose. "A clerk who keyed standardized forms, citing the standardization circular she keyed them against, naming the document and the year and the session. The plate is public. The circular is filed in every bureau office in the Outer Prefectures. A reader who pulls it sees the senior table and counts the seats and reaches his own conclusion, and no line in what I write will have told him where to count, and no line in it will run to you." She came around the table now, the first time she had crossed it, and she did it slowly, so the crossing was not a thing the woman had to brace against. "You will give the circular reference to Meret on your way out. The year, the session, the seat from the convening chair. Nothing else. She will not write your name and you will not say the man's. Do you understand the shape of it."

"I understand the shape of it," Naila Osei said. "I have spent four years understanding shapes I was not meant to see. This one I am glad to."

"Then we are finished, and you did a thing tonight that a great many people who key records and burn slips do not do, and I am not going to tell you it was brave, because you would hear the telling as a payment and I am not paying you for it." Kaviel held the door of her own attention open one last moment. "You will be taken back the way you came. The route is mine. No one on it knows what this room was for, and no one ever will."

Naila Osei stood. She finished, finally, the water she had not touched, drinking it down in the practical way of a person who does not waste a poured cup, and set the empty thing on the table squared to the edge, a record officer to the last. She looked at Kaviel a moment longer, the way the woman on the bench at Sabra had not been able to look at her, openly, taking the measure of the face she had wondered for four years whether she had imagined.

"You did not look back, at Sabra," she said. "At the time I thought it was that you did not care, that I was a parcel and the parcel was delivered. Later I understood it was the opposite. Looking back was the one thing that would have fixed us together in that hall for anyone watching, and you had already decided I was worth more to you unwatched." She picked up nothing, because she had brought nothing. "I have wanted four years to thank the woman who did not look back. I find now that I cannot, because thanking you is looking back, and you would not want it."

"No," Kaviel said. "I would not."

Meret opened the door. Naila Osei crossed to it, and at the threshold she stopped beside Meret and gave her the circular reference in a low even voice, the year and the session and the count from the convening chair, three things and nothing more, and Meret took them without writing them down, holding them the way Meret held things, until she was sure. Then the witness went out into the gray corridor and the operative who waited there, and Meret closed the door behind her, easing it to on its own weight so that the closing was a sound and not a slam.

Kaviel stood in the cleaned room with the hum of the light panel behind her eyes and the chemical sweetness at the back of her throat, and she did not move to the table, and she did not write. The case was whole on her desk two floors up, every part of it but this, and this was the part that finished it and could not be allowed to show how it had come. She would build the form for it tonight: the clerk, the circular, the public plate, the count of seats, a road a reader could walk that did not pass through any door she had opened. She had done it before, and she would do it now. She crossed to the table and squared the witness's empty cup beside her own, and she pulled out the chair, and she sat down in front of the testimony she had not yet written a word of, and she looked at the empty surface of the table a long moment before she reached for anything.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Eleanor's Decision

THE ROOM HAD NOT changed, and that was the first thing Eleanor read when she came into it, the way she read everything, against the version of it she carried in her. The two chairs sat where they had sat. The low table held the tray and the two cups. The window looked out on the interior garden that neither woman had ever walked, and the path through it had gone another season unwalked since the last time, the unpruned hedge a little heavier against the glass, a gardener's tool still leaning where it had been left to rust. The light was different. The first meeting had been an evening meeting, the cold coming up off the stone with the dark behind it. This was the gray of a morning that had not decided to be warm, an even light without sun in it, and it laid no bar across the marble and gave the repair lines in the floor no edge, so that the old breaks showed only as a faint discoloring under the polish, the seams of a thing mended long ago by hands that had wanted it to look unmended.

She came in without the cane taking weight, holding it the way she held it, and she sat in the chair that had been hers before either of them was born to the room, and she set her hands folded over the head of the cane and waited for the Empress to pour.

Amira poured. She lifted the pot herself, because the absence of servants was the meaning of the room, and the steam came off the cups and broke against the cold of the walls and was gone before either of them touched the porcelain. The smell of it reached Eleanor faint and bitter and herbal, the same leaf they had drunk and not drunk the last

time, and she took the cup when Amira set it an inch nearer her, wrapped both hands around it and did not drink, and let the small warmth last the minute it would last in a room this cold.

"You asked for the room," Amira said. "You have not asked for the room since the spring."

"No."

"The last time you asked for it, you were buying time you would not name. You bought two weeks. You brought me the report whole on the thirteenth day, a day under, and I have not forgotten that either."

"You flinched at none of it," Eleanor said. "I told you most rulers cannot do that. You did it. I have weighed the doing of it ever since, and it has changed what I am willing to bring into this room."

Amira drank, the cup raised and lowered with nothing on her face, and Eleanor watched the absence of expression and filed it the way she filed all such absences, as a kind of information about a person who had learned, from her, that the giving of nothing was itself a discipline. The first exchange had been made and answered, and both of them knew it for one exchange and not two. Amira had told Eleanor that she remembered the cost of the last trust she had extended. Eleanor had told Amira that the extending of it had earned her something she was about to spend.

"I have the whole of it now," Eleanor said. "Not the shape. The body. The list, and the mechanism that kept the list invisible, and the reach of the office that issued the protection. My people have it documented to the standard the throne would require if the throne were ready to require it. The scope is larger than I brought you in the spring. A thing built to seem ordinary is built wide, because width is what lets each piece of it pass for routine. This one runs across the Outer Prefectures and into the jurisdictions that touch them. Three Thrones' worth of administrative ground answers, in the end, to one chair."

Amira set the cup down. The small sound of porcelain on wood was the loudest thing the room had made. Outside, past the garden no one watched, a bell in the administrative wing marked an hour, the morning hour this time and not the evening one, a higher and busier sound with the day's work moving under it, and it faded and left the stillness in the room heavier than the noise had been.

"A chair," Amira said.

"A chair, and the man in it, and I know the man." Eleanor turned the cup a quarter in her hands. "I have known him the better part of forty years. I took his measure in rooms quieter than this one and found it sound, and I was wrong, and the being wrong is mine to carry. You do not need his name this morning. You will have it when you need it, and the having of it will be a weapon, and I will not put a weapon in the room before I have told you what I mean to do with the hand that would wield it."

Amira's eyes came up at that and stayed. She had a way of going still that was not the stillness of waiting; it was the stillness of a mind that had heard a thing arrive ahead of its meaning and was clearing room for the meaning to land. The garden window let the gray light fall across the side of her face and gave the cheekbone no shadow, and she let the quiet run, because she had learned from the woman across the table that the quiet after a sentence was where the sentence finished itself.

"You have decided something," Amira said. "You came in deciding it, the way you came in deciding the two weeks. You let me open the conversation so the thing you want will arrive as the answer to a question instead of a demand into silence. You taught me the maneuver, and I use it on petitioners who do not know they are being used by it, and it is strange to sit on the near side of it and recognize the hand."

"Then I will not maneuver," Eleanor said. "It is too important to waste the hour on technique, and you are too able to make it cost more than it earns. I am going to ask you for a thing, and ask it plainly, and the plainness is the only assurance I can offer that I am not handling you."

"Ask."

"Three days. Before any formal action. Before the name moves out of this room, before a warrant is drawn, before a single office of the establishment learns that the throne has seen what I have seen. Three days in which the throne does nothing and instructs no one and signs nothing. After the three days, the timing is yours, and the name is yours, and the apparatus I have built is yours to point wherever you point it. I will not ask for an hour past the three days. I have never asked you for time I wasted. I am not asking now."

Amira did not answer at once. She poured into her own cup, though the first was not finished, the way a person pours to fill the space where a decision is being made, and the fresh liquid steamed and the steam died against the cold and the bitter smell of it hung a moment and thinned. She set the pot down and looked at the cup and not at Eleanor, because to look at Eleanor while deciding was to hand Eleanor the decision early, and she had learned that from Eleanor too.

"In the spring," Amira said, "you told me what the two weeks were for. You told me there was a person whose continuance depended on the matter being handled in a way that did not announce how you had learned of it. You named the cost without naming the person. You bought the time to protect a source. I extended the trust because the request had a shape I could see the back of, even where I could not see the face."

"Yes."

"This request has no back to it." Amira turned the cup a half on the table, the porcelain dragging faint on the wood. "You are asking me to do nothing for three days, and you are not telling me what you will do in them. You are not telling me what the three days buy. You are not telling me whether you mean to act inside them or only to wait. You are asking for the time and withholding the use of the time, and that is a different request than the spring, and we both know it is, and you have come in this morning knowing I would know."

"I have."

"Then tell me why I should grant it."

Eleanor was quiet a moment. The cold of the room had reached her hands fully now, and the cup gave back nothing, and she set it down on the tray with both hands so that it would not rattle, and folded her hands again over the cane.

"Because you have granted it before," she said, "to a harder version of me, in this room, for a use the throne was never told. Your grandmother granted me time once whose purpose I never gave her and never will. She did not like granting it. She granted it because the alternative to trusting the house was governing without the house, and she had measured both, and the house was the colder comfort and the surer one. I watched her decide it. You are sitting this morning where she sat. I am asking you to do the thing she did, and to like it as little as she liked it,

and to do it anyway, because the arithmetic has not changed in two hundred years and will not change for our convenience."

"My grandmother granted you time to protect a source," Amira said. "That is the work the compact is for. I understood her the first time you sat in that chair. You are asking me for time to do a thing you will not describe, and I cannot tell, from where I sit, whether it serves the throne or serves your house or serves only you, and you are asking me to grant it without resolving which."

"I am."

"Eleanor."

The name, plainly used, was a pressure laid at a point, the way it had been the last time, and Eleanor felt the point and did not move from it. Amira did not use the given name often. In the throne room she said De Grosvenor, or she said nothing and let a look carry it. Here, with no scribe to read familiarity into it, the name was an instrument, and the woman wielding it had learned the wielding from the woman she aimed it at.

"You are afraid," Amira said, "that if you tell me what the three days are for, I will forbid it. You have measured the odds that I would, and found them high enough that you would rather ask for the time blind than ask for it whole and be refused. You have decided to do something I would not permit if I knew it, and you have come to buy the room to do it in. That is the request. Say whether it is the request."

Eleanor looked at her across the low table and the two cups going cold, and the gray light lay on both of them and gave neither a shadow, and the seams in the floor showed faint under the polish where the old breaks had been mended to look whole.

"It is near enough that I will not insult you by correcting the margin," she said. "Yes. There is a thing I mean to do that you would forbid, and you would be right by your own measure to forbid it, and the forbidding would cost the throne more than the doing, and the judging is mine because it is the work my house exists to do. I am asking you to lend me three days of doing nothing while I take onto my house a risk the throne should not be seen to take and cannot be made to wear. The compact was drafted by people who did not trust each other and needed each other regardless. This is the use it was drafted for, the ugliest and the rarest, the

reason the terms were written so they could be honored without ever being comfortable."

Amira rose then. She did it without haste, smoothing the front of her robe with one hand, and crossed to the window she had been ignoring, and stood before the glass with her hands joined behind her at the small of her back in the posture she took on the dais when a petition ran long and she wished to weigh it without a hundred faces reading her. The pane had fogged faintly where the cold of the glass met the warmer air, and her breath added to it, and through the blur the dead path and the rusting tool and the heavy hedge lost their edges and became a gray field with shapes in it.

She stood a long time. The bell in the administrative wing marked another hour, the day deepening under it, the ordinary traffic of the establishment moving through corridors that did not know what was being decided in a room without a scribe. Eleanor did not fill the silence. She had taught the Empress that a ruler who fills her own silences has surrendered them.

"If I grant the three days," Amira said to the glass, "and the thing you do inside them goes wrong, I will have granted the time, and the granting is the throne's act even where the doing is yours. You are asking me to put my name to a blank page and trust the house to write nothing on it I would be unable to stand behind."

"No," Eleanor said. "I am asking you to put your name to nothing at all. There is no page. The three days exist only as an absence, an action the throne declines to take, and an absence cannot be read back to you as authorization, because you will have authorized nothing, signed nothing, instructed no one. If the thing I do goes wrong, it is a thing the head of the De Grosvenor house did on her own standing, and the throne's defense is the truth, that it knew nothing and was governing in good faith on the information it had. I have built it so the absence protects you. That is the half of this you have not yet seen. The three days are a thing I give you, dressed as a thing I ask."

Amira turned from the window. The fogged glass had not cleared, and behind her the gray field of the garden held its blurred shapes, and the light came in flat and laid no shadow on the floor between them.

"You have built it so that I am protected whether I grant the time or refuse it," she said. "If I refuse, the throne moves in the open and you are not a factor in it. If I grant, I do nothing, and the doing of nothing cannot be turned against me, and whatever you do inside the three days is yours to wear alone. You have built a request I cannot lose by answering, which means you have built it so that the only loser available is you."

"I have weighed who can afford the loss," Eleanor said. "I am old. The house outlives its heads; that is the point of a house. The throne does not outlive a misstep taken in the open at the wrong hour. I am the cheaper thing to spend, in any accounting that runs longer than a life, and I have run my accounting longer than my life since before you were crowned."

Amira came back to the chair and sat. She had not meant to sit again; standing had been the closing posture, the signal that the meeting neared its end, and to sit again was to reopen what she had begun to close, and Eleanor marked the reopening and gave no sign of marking it.

"There is a version of this," Amira said, "in which the three days are for your house, and the protection you describe is the wrapping you put on it so I would take it. I cannot rule it out from where I sit. The man at the top of the thing has sat at tables with you for forty years, and the shape of your request is also the shape it would take if you meant to reach him for a reason of your own."

Eleanor did not look away from it. "You would be a poor ruler if you did not say it. If my house were the danger, I would not spend my standing to buy time I could have taken without asking. I would have brought you the list incomplete and steered you past the large part of it while you congratulated yourself on the small. That I have brought you the whole, and built the three days so the cost falls on me and the protection on you, is the behavior of a house that is not betraying you. It is not proof. There is no proof. It is the behavior, offered in the place where proof does not exist, and you will weigh it as that or you will not grant the time."

The two of them sat with the cold cups between them and the gray light on the mended floor, and the bell in the wing did not ring, and the garden held its blurred shapes behind the unwiped fog on the glass. Amira looked at her hands a while, and then at the woman across the

table, and the looking was the decision arriving and being read in the same moment, because there was no longer a use in concealing it from each other.

"Three days," Amira said. "From this hour. The throne does nothing, instructs no one, signs nothing. I will hold the morning's work as though this conversation had not occurred, and I will be, in the matter, a ruler governing in good faith on the information she has, which will be true, because I will refuse the rest of the information until the three days have run. When they have run, you bring me the name, and you bring it to this room, and there is no scribe, and after that the timing is mine again and you do not ask me for an hour past it."

"After that the timing is yours," Eleanor said.

"I am not granting this because I trust the thing you will do. I do not know the thing you will do. I am granting it because in the whole of my reign your house has not failed the throne in a way I could prove, and because the request is built so that the only person it can ruin is the person asking for it, and a house bent on betrayal does not build the trap so that it springs on itself." Amira set both hands flat on the low table, the gesture deliberate, the way a person sets down a weight she has chosen to carry rather than drop. "And because my grandmother granted you the same and the throne survived it. I did not understand her then. I understand her this morning. I dislike understanding her. I am doing it regardless."

"That is the whole of what the compact ever asked of either of us," Eleanor said. "To do the thing we dislike, regardless, because the disliking is cheaper across the years and dearer in the hour. We have not improved on the people who drafted the terms. We have only kept the house they built, where the roof leaks at the windows they wanted, and learned to set the buckets without complaint."

Amira rose again, and this time the rising held, and the room came back to its proper order, the Empress on her feet and the head of the serving house seated, the given names set down and the titles taken up. She moved toward the door that led to her quarters, and at it she paused, not turning fully, her profile lit cold and flat from the garden window she still had not looked at, the fog of her own breath gone from the glass behind her.

"The thing you mean to do," she said. "When you bring me the name. I will want to know whether you did it because the compact required it, or because you chose it and called it the compact."

"You will not like the answer," Eleanor said.

"I rarely do."

Eleanor rose then, slowly, the cane taking weight for the first time since she had entered, and she set the untouched cup back on the tray with both hands so that it would not rattle, and she inclined her head the precise depth that the head of the De Grosvenor house inclined it to the Trinitarian Throne, and no further, and the gray light lay even on the mended floor between them, and the door to the Empress's quarters closed without sound.

She told Kaviel in a corridor.

It was not the office, where the single lamp burned past the eighth hour, and it was not the investigation room, where the team now worked the days at full capacity. It was a corridor in the administrative wing, a length of cold stone between two doors that led somewhere else, the kind of place a person crosses without staying, and Eleanor stopped in the middle of it where the light from a high window fell in a flat band across the floor and did not warm it, and Kaviel stopped because her mother had stopped.

Eleanor did not turn to face her fully. She stood with the cane set and her weight even on it and looked at the band of light on the stone, and she said it in the voice she used for instructions, the voice that asked nothing of the room.

"I am going to the man myself," she said. "Alone. Before any formal action. The Empress has granted three days. They begin this morning. On the third day I bring his name to her and the timing returns to the throne. Between now and then I will see him, and you will not be present, and you will not arrange a presence, and you will hold the room and the list and the team exactly as they are and move nothing. If anyone asks what the house is doing in these three days, the house is doing what it always does, which is waiting."

Kaviel said nothing. She had been trained from before she could write that the thing her mother did in the minute after she set a weight down

was a thing done alone even when another was in the room, and she gave the minute now, and held it, and marked the holding and meant never to mention it.

She did not ask why. She knew her mother would not have built the three days, would not have spent the standing in the reception room, would not have stood in a cold corridor to say it in the instruction voice, if there had been a version of the thing that ran through the apparatus and stayed safe. She knew the man's name; she had been against the wall in the dead woman's house, in the chair the light did not reach, and had heard the old magister say it without weight. She knew that a person who carries a name like that into a room alone, before the throne has moved and before the apparatus can stand behind her, does it so that whatever happens in the room falls on one person and not on the house and not on the throne. She knew her mother had built the three days the way she built everything, so that the cost would land where Eleanor had decided it should, which was on Eleanor. And she knew there was no instrument she could offer that her mother had not already weighed and set aside, because an instrument would only move the cost off the place Eleanor had chosen for it, and to argue the choice was to ask the old woman to be someone other than the one who had raised her to recognize exactly this and not look away.

"Three days," Kaviel said.

"Three days."

"And nothing moves until you bring her the name."

"Nothing moves."

Eleanor turned her head then, the smallest degree, enough to bring her daughter into the edge of her looking and no further, and whatever she found in Kaviel's face she did not search, and Kaviel gave her the same nothing she had given the magister in the dead woman's house, the correct nothing, the only form of agreement that did not insult the gravity of the thing. Eleanor inclined her head a fraction, a smaller depth than she gave the throne, one that had no name and was kept only for the girl, and she turned and crossed the band of cold light and went out through the far door, the cane taking its even weight on the stone, and the sound of it faded by degrees and was gone.

Kaviel stood alone in the corridor. The high window let the flat light down across the stone and the band of it lay where her mother had been standing, and from somewhere below in the administrative wing came the smell of the day's first meal carried up through the shared vents, bread and something cooked too long, the smell of a building that did not know, and a clerk's footsteps passed in the corridor beyond the far door and did not slow, and the cold came up through the floor and found her where she stood without moving.

She had read documents her life long for the part the writer did not think to guard, and she read this the same way, against her will and without trying, and she saw what her mother meant to do and why it had to be done alone and why the doing of it placed the old woman at the end of a thing from which the house could not reach her, and she stood in the cold band of light in the empty corridor and understood the whole of it, and wished, with everything she had been trained never to show and showed now to no one because there was no one to show it to, that she did not.

INTERLUDE 4

Historical Note on the De Grosvenor Compact

I set down here what the record permits me to establish about the agreement under which the De Grosvenor house has served the Trinitarian Throne, because the decision Eleanor De Grosvenor took in the months this account concerns cannot be weighed without it. A reader who does not know the terms of the compact will read her choice as recklessness. A reader who knows them will read it differently, and I believe the second reading is the truer one. I will keep to what the documents support and mark where they do not.

THE COMPACT PREDATES BOTH the Empress Amira and Eleanor by a wide margin. Its founding instrument survives in the standing archive in two copies, one held under the Throne's seal and one under the seal of the house, and the two agree in every clause, which is itself a thing worth noting, since instruments of that age usually drift apart in the copying. It was formalized under the administrative reforms that followed the reign of Lucius Luceron II, the Soldier Emperor, who left behind a Throne that governed by process where his predecessors had governed by presence. The compact belongs to that work. It was drafted by clerks, not by heroes, and its language is the flat language of an establishment instrument. That flatness has preserved it. Three imperial generations have passed under it without amending a word.

The terms are short. The house places its intelligence and administrative apparatus at the disposal of the reigning sovereign. The sovereign, in

turn, grants the house a latitude no other instrument in the imperial body grants to anyone: the head of the house may act on the sovereign's behalf without prior authorization where seeking that authorization would defeat the action, and the sovereign agrees in advance to be bound by what is done in good faith under that latitude, whether or not the sovereign would have approved it had there been time to ask. I have read the clause perhaps two hundred times. It is the most dangerous sentence in the imperial archive, and it was written by a clerk who understood exactly what he was setting down. The compact does not ask the sovereign to trust the house. It requires the sovereign to be bound by trust already spent, after the fact, when the cost has already landed.

Such an instrument should have failed within a generation. It did not, and the reason it did not is the part of the record I most want the reader to carry forward. The archive shows three prior occasions on which the latitude was exercised at its full reach, each under a different sovereign and a different head of the house, and each preserved in enough detail to study.

The first came under an early reign I will not date precisely, the founding instrument being then less than thirty years old. An earlier matriarch of the house suppressed a report the sovereign had ordered released, held it through a season of pressure that cost her standing she never recovered, and was vindicated only when the source she had protected by holding it proved to be the single thread by which a succession crisis was unknotted. The sovereign had not authorized the holding. The sovereign was bound by it. The record notes, dryly, that the matriarch and the sovereign did not speak again for two years and that the apparatus functioned without interruption throughout.

The second I can date with confidence to the middle reign of the three, the household accounts of that period being intact. The head of the house in that generation moved imperial funds across a jurisdictional boundary, without the sovereign's knowledge, to settle a debt the sovereign did not know the Throne had incurred, and absorbed the irregularity into the house's own books rather than enter it where it could be traced to the sovereign. The accounts carry the loss to this day, unrecovered. The sovereign learned of it eleven years later, from a man in my own posting, reading the same kind of pages I read now.

The third is recent enough that men still living remember its public face, though almost none of them know its private one. The head of the house in that instance withheld the name of a compromised official from a sovereign who had every right to demand it, withheld it for the length of time required to be certain, and bore alone the risk that the certainty would never come. It did come. The official fell. The reign held.

In each of the three the same shape appears, and the shape is the point. One party extends trust the other has not formally earned and cannot formally compel, and does so under a clause that converts that trust into an obligation the sovereign cannot afterward refuse. The compact does not survive because the parties are loyal. Loyalty wears thin under three generations. It survives because the instrument was built to spend trust ahead of proof and to make the spending binding, so that the question is never whether the sovereign will agree, the question is only whether the head of the house will dare to act knowing the sovereign was never asked.

This brings me to Eleanor De Grosvenor and to the decision she took when she had learned the full reach of the matter recorded in these pages and learned, with it, the name at the top of it, a name she had known across decades. She did not bring that name to the Empress and ask leave to act. She asked instead for three days and gave no reason, and the Empress granted them, and the granting was itself an act under the compact, trust spent forward against a proof not yet shown. What Eleanor intended to do in those three days she told no one, and I have not reconstructed it from anything she said, because she said nothing I can cite. I have reconstructed it from the instrument. By the terms of the compact she was about to exercise the latitude at its full reach for the fourth time in the agreement's history, alone, against an official whose authority spanned three Thrones' worth of administrative ground, before any formal action could shield her, knowing that the moment she moved he would know he had been found.

The wax on the founding copy of the compact has gone the color of old tea, and the seal of the house pressed into it has lost the fine lines of its device, so that I must turn the page to the angled light from the high window to read the matrix at all. It was made by a clerk who knew where an empire is held upright at its worst hour. The weight does not rest with

the sovereign, and it does not rest with the house. It rests on the willingness of one of them to act first and be judged after. What follows in this record is that clause being exercised as it was always built to be exercised, by the one person then alive who understood it well enough to pay what it asks.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

What Eleanor Said

THE ROOM HAD BEEN built for nobody to own. Eleanor knew the kind before she was through the door, because she had ordered the choosing of it herself and given her people the qualities to find: a chamber that belonged to no office, sat on no one's corridor, owed its furniture to no house and its history to no reign. It was a meeting room in a commercial registry tower on the lower terraces of New Terra, the sort of place where freight factors and bonded agents signed paper neither of them trusted the other to honor, leased by the hour through a third name and emptied of its clerks for the afternoon. The walls were a pale stone that took no echo. A long table of some pale resined wood ran down the center, scarred at the corners where strangers had set their cases down hard, and the chairs along it were identical and faced one another across a width measured so that no one at the table could lean and reach another without standing first. There were no windows on the courtyard side. The single window faced out over the freight terraces, and through it came the flat continuous light of a working district and, under everything, the low vibration of the loading engines that never stopped, a sound felt in the table more than heard.

She had come early. She sat with her back to the inner wall and her face to the door and the cane standing against the table's edge where her hand could find it, and she did not pour the water that had been set out, two flasks and four glasses on a tray in the middle, because to have drunk before he came would have been to have begun without him, and

she had built this hour to begin only when both of them were in it. The vibration of the engines came up through her hands where they rested folded on the wood. The light did not change. She waited the way she had waited in rooms for sixty years, without the waiting showing as anything a watcher could have named, and a watcher would have seen an old woman in a plain coat sitting very still in a leased room, which was the whole of what she wished to be seen.

He came at the hour she had named, alone, which told her the first thing.

Lord Marshal Tewodros Marek was a tall man who had grown heavier with his years and carried the weight as a kind of settledness, the way some men in high office learn to occupy more room as a courtesy to the people who must find them in it. He wore the dark establishment coat without its marshal's collar, which was its own message, that he had come as a man and not as the office, that he wished the afternoon read that way. His face was broad and dark and deeply lined at the eyes, a face that had spent decades arranging itself into the patient attention senior administrators wore in committee, and it was arranged that way now. He shut the door behind him with the flat of his hand, without looking to see that it had latched, and he crossed to the chair opposite hers and stood a moment behind it with both hands on its back.

"Eleanor," he said.

"Tewodros."

"You chose a hard place to find. I had a man drive past it twice."

"I chose it so that neither of us would have to wonder whose floor we were standing on," she said. "Sit, if you mean to. I have an hour I would rather not spend watching you decide whether the chair is mine."

He smiled at that, a small real smile that touched the lined eyes, and he drew the chair and sat, and the two of them faced each other across the measured width of the pale table with the water untouched between them and the engines vibrating in the wood. He set his hands on the table, broad and ringless, and looked at her for a while in the way of a man taking the measure of a thing he had thought he already knew, and she let him look, because she was doing the same and saw no reason to pretend either of them was doing otherwise.

"You poured nothing," he said.

"I do not drink with a man until I know what we are to each other across the table," she said. "We will know within the hour. There is water if you want it. I am old and I do not, in the afternoons."

"How long has it been," he said, "since you and I sat at a table with no one's name on it."

"You will be doing the arithmetic to find the answer flattering," she said. "I will save you the trouble. It has been long enough that the last time, the woman on the throne was the grandmother, and you were two ranks below the chair you sit in now, and I had already begun to be old. I did not come to count years with you. You know I did not. Let us not spend the hour furnishing it."

The smile went, without offense in its going. He folded his hands and the lines at his eyes settled into the committee patience, and she understood that the first exchange was finished and that he had let her end the warmth because he had wanted to see whether she would, and that her ending it had told him as much as his offering it had told her. They had taught each other a great deal across forty years. Some of it she was about to use against him, and he knew that she was, and the knowing sat in the room between them as plainly as the water.

"You have been into my house," he said.

"I have been into the establishment's house," she said. "Yours by occupancy, not by deed. The distinction will matter to the people who come after me, and it does not matter to you and me this afternoon, so set it aside. Yes. I have been into it. I have the carry-forward entries and the commissions they claim and the commissions that did not sit. I have the correction pass and the category of authorization it ran under, the category your office governs and no one beneath it can open. I have the man in Adwa and the courier who fed him and the relay that went dark when we reached for it. I have the reach of it, three Thrones of ground answering to one chair, and I have the chair, and I have had the chair for some weeks now, and I came to you before I did anything else with it, which is the only reason you are sitting in a leased room with an old woman instead of reading about yourself in a warrant."

He took that without his face moving, which she respected. A lesser man would have reached for the water to have something to do with his hands. He left them folded.

"You came to me first," he said. "Before the throne."

"I did not say before the throne."

She watched the small recalculation move behind the patient face and not surface, and she gave it the time it needed. He was not a stupid man and she had never once thought him one, and the worst thing she could do in this hour was let him believe she thought it now. He had reached the marshalcy of the Bureau of Establishments over thirty years by being right about people more often than he was wrong, by reading a room and a roster and a balance the way she read a held report, and the thing she had come to offer him depended on his being exactly that able, because a fool would refuse it for the wrong reasons and she could do nothing with a fool's refusal.

"Then the throne knows," he said.

"The throne knows there is a thing," she said. "The throne does not yet know your name. The throne has granted me three days in which to do one thing, and this is the thing, and you are most of the second day of it. On the third day I bring your name into a room with the Empress in it, or I bring her something else. Which of the two I carry up those stairs depends on the next part of this hour, and not on anything that happens after it, so I would have you attend to it closely."

"You are offering me something."

"I am offering you one thing," she said. "Once. I will say it plainly, because you are too able to be handled and I would insult us both by trying. You will resign the marshalcy on a stated ill health, effective at a date I will give you, near enough that it reads as sudden and far enough that it reads as a man's own choice. You will sign, before you go, a reconciliation of the carry-forward record that unwinds the false entries under cover of the same backlog provision that hid them, so that the establishment corrects itself from the inside and the throne is spared the cost of being seen to cut into its own administration in the open. You will give me, in writing and to me alone, the names above the courier and below yourself, the working parts of the thing, the people who cannot be left in the establishment whatever becomes of you. And you will live. Quietly, off the rolls, in whatever house you have put aside against your age, with the pension the office carries and no charge ever drawn, because a charge drawn against you is a trial, and a trial is the throne

cutting into itself in front of three Thrones of watching administrators, and the throne would rather not, and so would I, and so, I think, would you."

The engines vibrated up through the table. The light over the freight terraces did not change. He sat with his folded hands and his patient face and looked at her across the measured width, and he was quiet a long time, and she did not fill the quiet, because she had taught half the court that the quiet after an offer belongs to the one who received it, and she had taught herself the same lesson long before there was a court to teach.

"And in exchange," he said at last, "I give you the house. The names, the record, the unwinding. I hand you the whole of it and trust that a charge is never drawn, on the strength of an old woman's word in a room with no scribe in it, while I sit in a house off the rolls waiting to learn whether the throne agrees with you about what it would rather not do."

"Yes."

"You have not changed," he said, and there was something in it that was almost fondness and was not quite. "You build the room so that the only safe move is the one you have chosen, and you call it an offer. I have watched you do it to men who never knew it had been done to them. I know it is being done to me, and I will tell you what I see when I look at the room you have built, and you will hear me out the way you would have me hear you, because we are too old to do each other the discourtesy of pretending the other cannot count."

"Count, then."

"You have the record," he said. "I do not doubt it; you would not be here if you did not, and you have never bluffed me, in forty years, which is itself a thing I have relied on. But the record is the surface. The record is the appointments, and the appointments are the part of the thing that was always going to be found if anyone looked the way your people look, and the part of the thing that can be unwound the way you describe, because it was built to be unwound, because it was built to be the part that takes the fall if a fall is ever needed. You have found the structure that was meant to be found. You are very good, Eleanor, and you have found exactly the thing that a careful man would leave for you to find."

She did not move. Inside, behind the stillness she had worn into the bones of her face, a cold small certainty arrived and seated itself, and she

held her hands folded on the wood and let no part of the arrival reach the surface, because the worst thing she could do now was let him see that he had told her something she had not known.

"Go on," she said.

"I will not give you the names," he said. "Not because I cannot. Because the offer assumes the appointments are the thing, and the appointments were never the thing. They were the visible house. They were what we let stand in the daylight so that the rest could run in the floor beneath it. You have costed your three days against the surface. You will spend them unwinding the surface and bringing the Empress a clean correction and a quiet resignation, and you will believe you have closed it, and the floor will go on running, because the floor does not touch the appointments at any point a record search would cross. You will have to find it the long way, the way you found this, and that is years, and I do not have to give you a single name to buy those years, because the structure that funds the thing was never written where your reconciliation trace can reach it."

"A second mechanism," she said. She said it flatly, as a clerk reads back a figure to confirm it, and she watched him hear that she had not known and had it now.

"I have said more than I came meaning to," he said, and for the first time he reached for the water, and poured a glass, and the small ordinary sound of it filled the room, and the chill of the flask had beaded the glass and he turned it once in his fingers before he drank. "You always did get more out of a conversation than the other man meant to spend. I will not name it. I have told you it is there because telling you it is there is the answer to your offer, and the answer is no. You cannot give me my life in exchange for a house you have already half taken, when the part of the house that matters is one I can keep by saying nothing and no more, and outlast you in the keeping, because I am younger than you by eleven years and the floor does not need me at the marshalcy to go on running. You have built the room well. You built it for the wrong house."

She let it stand. The thing he had given her sat in her like a stone swallowed, heavy and clean and certain, and she turned it once where it lay and understood its dimensions and set about, in the same minute, the work of carrying it out of the room without his seeing the weight of it.

He had refused. The refusal was the door she had been authorized to walk through if it opened, and it had opened, and now there was only the leaving and what she would carry through it.

"You have read me correctly," she said, "about what I can do this afternoon. You have read me incorrectly about what I will do tomorrow. You believe that because the second thing is hidden the long way, I will be forced to spend years on it, and that the throne will not move against an establishment it cannot yet prove a crime in, and that an old woman of eighty does not have the years. All of that would be true if the throne and I were bound to act through the channels you have spent thirty years learning to govern. We are not, after today. You have just told me the floor exists. I did not know it existed an hour ago. I will know its shape inside a week, because a thing that funds an apparatus for years leaves a different kind of trace than a thing that hides for a season, and I have a daughter who reads floors for a living, and you have just told her where to put her feet."

Something crossed his face then, the first thing in the hour that he had not chosen to show, and it was not fear, because he was not a man who feared in rooms. It was the recognition of a man who had said one sentence more than the structure could afford, and had said it to the one person in three Thrones who could spend it. He set the glass down.

"You came to give me a way out," he said.

"I came to give you the only one there was," she said. "You have refused it. I want it understood between us, in this room with no scribe, that the offer was real, that I would have honored every line of it, that a man who took it would be alive and off the rolls and unpursued tonight. I do not make offers I will not keep. You know that I do not. You have refused a real thing, with your eyes open, because you have read the odds and decided that silence and eleven years are the better wager. It is a calculation, and it is not a stupid one, and I have made it the heart of my report that it was not stupid, because a throne that mistakes you for a fool will lose to you, and I do not intend the throne to lose to you."

"You have already named me to the throne, then. In all but the word."

"I will name you tomorrow," she said. "Today I have done you the courtesy of the hour, and you have done me the discourtesy of the floor, and we are, I think, square."

She put both hands to the head of the cane and rose, and the rising took its weight on the cane the way it did now, and she did not hurry it, because to hurry would have been to let him see that she wished to be out of the room and alone with what she carried. He rose when she rose, as the manners of forty years required, and he stood behind his chair with his hands on its back as he had stood when he came in.

"They know it is you," he said. "I will tell you that for nothing, because you gave me the hour. The structure knows there is an investigator and the structure knows the investigator wears your house. It knew before you walked in here. Your name and your daughter's name are on a page in an office you have not found, and the page was written some days ago. You have not been moving in the dark you think you have been moving in. I tell you because you told me a true thing about my odds and I will pay you back the one true thing I can afford, that the cost of this has already been entered against your house, and was entered before you set this room. Whatever you do tomorrow, you do it already named, and so does she."

She received it standing, with her hand on the cane and her face turned to him and giving back the same nothing she had worn for the whole of the hour, and inside she set the second stone beside the first, the named house and the named daughter, and she weighed it once and found it a cost she had priced before she came and would pay without revising the figure.

"Then we have each given the other one true thing this afternoon," she said. "It is more than most men manage in a day, and we managed it across a table built so neither of us could reach the other. Goodbye, Tewodros. I do not expect we will sit again."

"No," he said. "I do not expect it either." And then, as she turned for the door, in a voice that had dropped the committee out of it and held, for one sentence, something nearer to what they had been to each other in the years before this one, "It was a good offer, Eleanor. I want you to know that I heard it as one. I am not refusing it because I think little of it. I am refusing it because I can count."

"I know," she said, with her back to him and her hand on the door. "It is the only reason I respected it enough to make."

She went out, and she did not look back, and the door latched behind her on its own weight.

The corridor outside was a low service hall that ran to the freight lifts, lit by the same flat continuous light, smelling faintly of lubricant and cold metal and the burnt-grain reek that came up off the loading engines through the floor grates. She walked it slowly, the cane setting its even sound on the composite floor, and at the turn toward the public transit corridor a man stepped back against the wall to let her pass, a courier in the gray coat of no house, a soft round face she had cause to know from a manifest and a controlled encounter her daughter had run in the spring, Rashid Beye standing with a sealed case held flat against his chest, waiting on the wrong floor of the wrong tower for a meeting he would now never be sent to. His eyes found her and went wide and then went flat with the discipline of a man who had been trained to be no one, and he inclined his head a careful degree, as one stranger yields a corridor to an old woman, and she gave him nothing at all, not the smallest sign that the face meant anything, and passed him, and heard behind her the small wet sound of a man swallowing as he understood whose afternoon he had walked into and what it meant that she had not bothered to acknowledge him.

The transit corridor was wider and colder, with the public lifts at its end and the noise of the district coming up the shaft, and benches set against the wall for the agents and factors who waited there between their meetings. She stopped at the first of them. She did not sit. She set the cane against the bench and stood with her weight on it and reached into the inner pocket of the plain coat and took out the small notebook she had carried for thirty years, black, soft at the corners, the kind a person uses who does not trust a thing to a system she does not own. She uncapped the short pencil that lived in its spine. She held the notebook open against the flat of her hand, and the flat light came down even on the page, and the engines vibrated up through the floor and through the cane and into her, and she stood a moment with the pencil not yet touching the paper.

Then she wrote three words.

She read them once. She closed the notebook over the pencil and pressed the soft cover flat with her thumb and returned it to the inner

pocket, and she took up the cane, and the lift at the end of the corridor opened its doors on a car already half full of people who did not know her, and she crossed the cold floor toward it at her own pace and did not look back down the hall toward the room or the courier or the door that had latched on its own weight, and the cane set its even sound on the composite, and she walked.

CHAPTER TWENTY

Kaviel Tells Amira

THE ROOM HAD NO window, and that was why it had been chosen. It sat below the level of the Empress's working quarters, reached by a stair that doubled on itself twice so that a person descending lost the count of the turns, and the air in it was the air a sealed space keeps, drier than the corridors above, with the faint mineral smell of cut stone that never warms. The light came from two fixtures recessed into the ceiling, even and shadowless, the kind of light that does not change with the hour because there is no hour for it to answer to. A table ran the length of the room, broad enough to lay documents flat without overlapping them, and along one wall a row of cabinets stood locked. There was nothing in the room that a scribe would sit at. There was no third chair.

Kaviel had come down first and set the room, because she had asked for the room and the asking carried the obligation. She laid the folders along the table in the order she meant to take them, each squared to the edge, and she did not sit while she waited, because the work she had brought did not permit the posture of waiting. The single lamp she kept in her own office, the one she cracked a window beside to move the air, had no equivalent here. The air did not move. She stood at the head of the table with her hands at her sides and listened to the room give back nothing, no traffic, no bell, no footstep, the sealed quiet of a place built so that what passed inside it left no trace in the building that held it.

Amira came down alone. She came without the household that attended her above, without the two who walked the corridor a pace behind

her elbow, and the absence of them was the meaning of the descent, the same meaning the small reception room carried when she lifted the pot herself. She wore the plainer of her working robes, the one without the weight at the shoulders, and she came into the room and looked once down the length of the table at the squared folders and the locked cabinets and the even light, and she understood the room before Kaviel said a word, because she had governed long enough to read a room the way Eleanor read a face.

"You set this below the records floor," Amira said.

"Two levels below it. There is no register of the room being opened. There is no register of either of us being in it." Kaviel inclined her head, the depth a senior Lioness gave the Throne, exact and no further. "The house keeps three rooms like this. This is the one furthest from the administrative wing."

"Furthest from your mother's office."

"Furthest from every office," Kaviel said, and let the correction stand without sharpening it.

Amira moved to the head of the table and did not sit, and so Kaviel did not move to sit either, and the two of them stood over the laid documents in the shadowless light. The Empress put one hand flat on the table near the first folder, not opening it, the way a person rests a hand on a thing she has not yet decided to lift.

"My household believes I am reviewing prefectural petitions," she said. "That is a thing I do alone and at irregular hours, and it is true often enough that it is true now. Begin. I will hold my questions until you have laid the whole of it. You will tell me when the whole of it is laid."

"That is how I have ordered it," Kaviel said.

She began with the surface, because the surface was where the throne had first looked and looked away, and she laid the Sennar magistrate's record open on the table and set beside it the carry-forward entry that confirmed the appointment under a prior commission's authority, and she put her finger on the two dates that could not both be true, the confirmation that preceded the session that confirmed it. She did not narrate the finding as a discovery. She gave it as a fact already established, documented, dated, traced, and she moved her hand from the Sennar record to the next folder without pausing on the satisfaction of it,

because the satisfaction was months old and the work had gone far past it.

Amira looked at the two dates. She had signed off on the procedural finding in that matter, had sat through the petition and ruled on it and thought no more of it, and the record of her ruling was somewhere in the floors above this one with her own confirmation on it. She did not say so. Kaviel knew it, and Kaviel knowing it was the reason she had laid this folder first, and there was nothing in the saying of it that the laying had not already said.

"The carry-forward reconciliation," Kaviel said. "A clause that lets an appointment confirmed under one commission's authority be entered under the next without fresh review, to clear backlog. It reads as housekeeping. It is the door. False appointments were entered through it across the Outer Prefectures, backdated under cover of reconciliation, made to look routinely confirmed. Sennar was the region most touched early. The scope proved wider." She set down the second folder, the roster, and opened it to the marked page. "This is the list, traced and complete. Each entry runs back to a prior authority that does not exist or does not cover it. A junior researcher of the house built the method that broke it. I will give you her name when names are useful to you. They are not useful yet."

She laid the next, and the next. The correction pass, the section of records reworked after the original insertions using an authorization category the house could not investigate without escalating its mandate, the signature of someone senior protecting the system from inside. The courier and his routes between jurisdictions. The administrator in Adwa who had inserted appointments through the clause for four years, a deputy registrar passed over for a seat he had earned and had taken by other means since, a process and not a monster. The message that had reached that administrator as a warning, traced through three relay points toward a single office before the third relay went dead under the trace. The field observations that held when the trace failed. The witness whose testimony filled the gap the dead relay left.

Amira followed each folder with her eyes and did not touch them. She had a way of receiving information that gave nothing back, the same stillness she wore on the dais, and Kaviel laid the documents into that

stillness and did not look for a reaction in it, because looking for one would have been a question she had not been invited to ask.

"The reach of the office," Kaviel said. She laid the last folder of this part of it open, and on the page was the span of the authority that issued the protection, the jurisdictions that answered to it, the prefectures and the grounds adjoining them. "Three Thrones' worth of administrative ground, reconciled through one chair. The appointments fraud is the surface of it. The surface is what could be made to look ordinary, and the man in the chair made it look ordinary for years across more ground than any single audit would cross."

She stopped there. She had reached the edge of the documented thing, the body Eleanor had carried into the reception room in the spring and the body the house had finished documenting since, and she stood over it with her hands at her sides and let the room hold the silence the way the room held everything, without echo.

"You have not said his name," Amira said.

"I will say it when you have the rest. The name is the smallest part of what I have to lay, and you will read it differently once you have the part that comes after it. May I lay the rest."

"Lay it."

Kaviel reached to the end of the table, to the two folders she had set apart from the line of the others, and she did not open them yet. She rested her hand on them the way Amira had rested a hand on the first.

"Three days ago," she said, "the head of the house went to the man, alone, before any formal action, with the Empress's leave to do nothing for three days and the Empress's instruction that the throne would sign nothing and instruct no one in that time. I am aware the Empress granted the days without being told their use. I am not here to tell you their use. I am here to tell you what came back from them, because what came back changes the rest of the table, and the changing of it is why I asked for this room."

"Eleanor is not here," Amira said. It was not a question. The folders were laid by Kaviel's hand, in Kaviel's order, in a room two levels below the records floor that the house kept and the head of the house had not come to. Amira had marked the absence at the door and held it the way

she held all such things, as a fact whose meaning would arrive when it arrived.

"She is not," Kaviel said. "I will not account for it this morning. It is accounted for, and it is not mine to account for, and the part of it that touches the work I am laying I will lay. The rest will keep."

Amira held her eyes a moment, the stillness on her unbroken, and then she inclined her head a fraction, granting the boundary, and Kaviel went on.

She opened the first of the two set-apart folders. "She went to give the man one choice, on ground she arranged so that neither of them held it. He refused it. The refusal was not a blunder. He read what the house could do without the throne moving, and he read it correctly, and he refused on the strength of the read. He is able. He reached the chair through ability and he has held it through ability, and the worst of this is that he is not a fool, because a fool would have left a seam I could open in an afternoon and he has left none I can open without the throne behind me."

"You are telling me the refusal was the point of the meeting."

"I am telling you the meeting was built to make him choose in front of a witness who would carry the choosing, and he chose, and the choosing triggered the action the house was authorized to take if he refused. The crisis is open as of three days ago. He knows the house has him. He knows the throne has been shown. The quiet part of the work is over."

"And the new fact," Amira said. "You laid two folders apart. The first is the meeting. The second is a thing you learned from it that the rest of the table did not hold."

Kaviel opened the second folder. "There is a second mechanism. Beneath the appointments fraud, running alongside it, older. A financial system, resources redirected through channels the appointments fraud was built to cover. The head of the house did not know of it until the meeting. She knows of it now. The skeleton of it is in the list I laid for you, in entries we read as part of the appointments fraud and that are part of something the appointments fraud was hiding. The correction-pass signature is on it, the same hand that reworked the records reworked the

money. The commission you saw in the Sennar matter is one of three channels. It has funded the thing for seven years."

The mineral cold of the room had settled into the stone of the table under Amira's hand. She moved the hand off it. She looked down the length of the laid documents, the surface and the body and the meeting and the thing beneath the thing, and she did not speak for a time that in a room with a clock would have been measured and in this room was only the holding of the breath of a sealed space.

"That is the whole of it," she said. "You said you would tell me when the whole of it was laid. Is this the whole."

"This is the whole of what is documented. The financial mechanism is not dismantled. It is identified. To dismantle it I need the days the throne can grant and the authority the throne can grant, and I need them before the channels are emptied into ground the throne cannot reach. That is the part that is not yet on the table because it has not yet been done. Everything else is on the table. The name is the last thing I have not laid, and I will lay it now if you are ready to read it as what comes before the rest rather than as the rest itself."

"Lay it."

Kaviel said it plainly, in the voice the house used for facts. "Lord Marshal Tewodros Marek. Marshal of the Bureau of Establishments. The chair the three Thrones' ground answers to. The head of the house has known him the better part of forty years."

Amira did not move. The name landed in the stillness and the stillness held it, and she let it sit there in the shadowless light the way Eleanor let a sentence sit until it finished itself. She had heard the office described in the spring and across the months since, the reach of it, the seniority of it, the impossibility of investigating it without the mandate the house did not hold, and the name attached to the office now and the office did not change, because the office had always been the danger and the name was only the handle of it.

"I know the office," she said. "I have signed instruments that crossed his desk. I have received his reports on the establishment of appointments in the Outer Prefectures and read them as the work of a competent marshal and acted on them as such." She paused. "I have relied on him. Not as I rely on the house. As a ruler relies on the marshal whose work

she has no reason to doubt. There was no reason to doubt it. He built it so there would be no reason."

"There was no reason you could have found from the throne," Kaviel said. "The house found it because the house is built to find what the throne is built to trust. That is the use of the house. It is the use the compact is for."

Amira moved away from the table then, two steps, to the blank wall where a window would have been in any room above this one, and there was no window, and she stood facing the stone as she stood facing the garden glass above, her hands joining behind her at the small of her back, and the wall gave her nothing to look at and she looked at it anyway because the looking was the posture the deciding took.

She turned the matter in the even light. The crisis was open. The marshal knew the throne had been shown and knew the house had him, and he had refused the one choice on the strength of a correct read of what could be done without the throne. The case the house had built was complete to the surface and the body and the meeting, and beneath it a second mechanism waited to empty itself into jurisdictions the throne could not follow it into, and the dismantling of it needed days and authority granted before the channels ran dry. And the man at the top of it sat in the Bureau of Establishments, the body that governed appointments, which meant that the ordinary path, the judicial review, the administrative adjudication, the formal process by which the throne corrected the establishment, ran through offices the marshal's authority touched, and a process that ran through the thing it meant to correct would correct nothing and would warn everything.

She put it to Kaviel without turning from the wall. "If I move this through the courts of administrative review, it crosses desks the marshal's office reaches. If I move it through the Bureau itself, I am asking the Bureau to indict its own marshal under procedures the marshal helped write. The judicial path that exists for this is compromised at the level I would need it to be clean. Say whether that is the shape of it."

"That is the shape of it," Kaviel said. "He did not build the fraud and leave the review of the fraud to chance. The review of the fraud was the first thing he secured. The correction pass is the review of the fraud. Every channel by which the throne would ordinarily reach him, he

reaches first. A formal action through any of them is a formal action he sees the morning it is drawn, and the second mechanism empties that afternoon, and the resources are in three jurisdictions by the evening and the case is a list of appointments with no money behind it and no man at the top who can be held."

Amira was quiet against the wall. The thing the room had been built to contain was the thing now contained in it, and she held it the way the room held the air, sealed, without escape, and she did not let the holding show in her shoulders or her hands. The anger she was entitled to was not in the room with her. It would come later, in a space she did not share, where no document recorded it and no subordinate read it off her, and she set it aside now the way she set aside the cup she did not finish, knowing where it was and choosing not to lift it.

"There is one instrument," she said, "that does not run through the establishment, because it runs above it." She turned from the wall. "The emergency prerogative of the Throne. It suspends normal administrative process by the act of the Empress alone. It does not cross the marshal's desk because it answers to no desk. It has not been invoked in thirty-one years."

"I know what it is," Kaviel said. "I will not advise you to use it or against it. It is not the house's instrument. It is the Throne's, and the using of it is the Throne's alone, and the house has no standing to weigh it for you. I can tell you the work it would unlock. With the prerogative invoked, the dismantling of the financial mechanism runs on the Throne's authority and not the Bureau's, and the channels are frozen before the marshal can empty them, and the case moves to a body the marshal does not reach. Without it, the work I laid is a complete account of a thing no one can be held to."

"You know what it costs."

"I know it has not been used in thirty-one years," Kaviel said. "I know that a thing not used in thirty-one years is read, when it is used, as the act of a ruler who has run out of the ordinary instruments, and that the reading is a weapon in the hand of anyone who would rather the question were the Empress's judgment than the marshal's crime. I know it is legally sound and politically the most exposed act available to you. The house does not carry that cost. You carry it. I will not pretend the

house can take any of it off you, because it cannot, and pretending would insult the choosing."

Amira came back to the table. She stood over the laid documents, the whole of them, the surface and the body and the meeting and the name and the thing beneath, and she read them once more in the order Kaviel had laid them, slowly, the way she had read the prefectural petitions she was believed to be reviewing two levels above this floor. The recessed light lay even on the open folders and gave the pages no shadow and the stone no warmth, and the dry air held the faint smell of the cut rock, and far off through the weight of two floors and a doubled stair no bell reached the room to mark the hour she was spending in it.

"You built this room," she said, "so that what was decided in it would not be on record until I chose to put it there."

"Yes."

"Then there is a thing the room is for that you have not asked me to do, because it is not yours to ask. You laid the table so that I would decide in a place where the deciding leaves no trace until I make the trace myself." Amira looked up from the documents. "You knew when you set the folders in this order what the order would bring me to."

"I knew where the documents lead," Kaviel said. "I did not know whether you would follow them there. The house lays the table. The Throne decides what is eaten from it. That is the compact, and I will not stand in this room and pretend I laid the folders without knowing their direction, and I will not pretend the direction is my decision. I delivered. You decide. It has always been built that way."

"It has." Amira held her a moment longer, and something in the holding was the nearest the room would come to acknowledgment, and then it passed, and the Empress was only the Empress over a table of documents in a sealed room below the records floor. "Eleanor delivered through you. You delivered. I will decide, and the deciding will be mine, and when it is read in thirty years it will be read as mine, and I will not have it read any other way."

She drew the chair at the head of the table back and sat, the first time either of them had sat since she came down, and the sitting changed the room, the posture of the work shifting from the standing of a briefing to the bent attention of a hand about to write. Kaviel set a single sheet

before her, the formal stock the Throne used for instruments that bore no scribe's countersignature, and a stylus beside it, and stood back from the table to the distance the house kept when the Throne worked.

Amira wrote in her own hand. She did not call for a scribe, because there was no scribe in the room and the absence of one was the meaning of the room, and the notation that suspended the ordinary process of the establishment and invoked the prerogative unused for thirty-one years went onto the sheet in the Empress's own characters, unhurried, each stroke laid with the weight of a thing that could not be unwritten once the ink set. She did not read it aloud. She wrote the authority and the date and the scope of it, the freezing of the channels, the constitution of the body the case would move to, the suspension of every path that ran through the marshal's reach, and at the foot of it she set the mark that no other hand in the imperium could set, and she did not flinch over any line of it, and the stillness on her while she wrote was the same stillness she had worn through the whole of the laying.

When the ink had set she lifted the sheet and read it once to herself, and she folded it along a single crease, square and exact, and she held the fold a moment under the shadowless light. Then she rose, and she put the folded sheet into Kaviel's hand, and she closed Kaviel's fingers over it with her own, once, and let go.

"Deliver this yourself," Amira said.

Kaviel took it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

The Faction Moves

THE CHALLENGE ENTERED THE administrative registry of the Bureau of Establishments at the seventh hour of the morning, and it entered well.

Kaviel had the first word of it within the half-hour, which was the whole of the margin she had built for herself and most of what would save the day. She was in her office under the north wall when the channel tray took the slip, a single line in the hand of the registry liaison the Quarter kept inside the Bureau, a clerk named Otieno who had passed paper to the Lionesses for nine years and had never once been told why and had never once asked. The line said that a petition of invalidation had been lodged against the findings of an unnamed inquiry touching the carry-forward record, on grounds of procedural irregularity in the gathering, and that it had been entered under a priority docket that required the registrar of record to rule on it within the working day. Kaviel read it once. She set it flat on the desk and put her two hands on the edge of the wood and read it again, and then she did the arithmetic, which she had done many times in the abstract over the past three days and now did with the figures real and the clock running, and the arithmetic told her she had until the registrar closed the docket at the end of the working day to keep the Empress's notation from being entered against a finding that no longer formally existed.

She had cracked the window an inch when she came in, as she did every morning, and the air off the courtyard came in cold and carried the wet-stone smell of the gutters and, under it, the burnt-grain warmth rising

from the kitchens two floors down. She did not notice either. She had taken what the slip said whole at the first reading. She was reading it a third time now for the shape of the office that had sent it, the choice of docket, the choice of hour, the choice to file against findings without naming the inquiry that had made them, which was the move of people who knew exactly what the inquiry was and meant the court to be able to say, afterward, that they had not.

They had moved before the notation. That was the thing she sat with for the length of one slow breath. Amira had written the emergency authority in her own hand the night before and given it to Kaviel to carry and enter, and the carrying and the entering were a process with its own hours and its own desks, and the faction had reached into that gap and filed a thing that, if the registrar ruled it sound, would strike the findings out of the record as improperly gathered before the authority that protected them could attach. A finding struck from the record was a finding the emergency prerogative had nothing to protect. The Empress would be holding a warrant over an empty page.

Kaviel had known the gap was there. She had told Asha a week ago where the danger lay. The gathering was not the dangerous hour, and the judging was not the dangerous hour. The danger was the narrow passage between them, when the work was complete and the authority not yet entered, and that a careful opponent would file in that passage if he understood it, and that this one understood everything. She had not been able to close the gap. The notation could not be written before the findings were complete and the findings had been complete only the previous night. So she had done the other thing. She had built, against this morning, a set of replies that did not yet have a challenge to answer, and she had put her people where the replies would have to be made, and she had told them what they were waiting for without being able to tell them when it would come.

It had come at the seventh hour. She took the channel and wrote three lines, one to Asha, one to Silva, one to Meret, each saying the same thing in the form each woman would act on fastest, and she put them in the tray and rang the floor runner, and the runner came and took them and went, and the morning began.

The procedural irregularity the petition named was authorization. Kaviel had it from Otieno's second slip by the eighth hour, and it was the move she had thought most likely, because it was the strongest. The petition did not argue that the findings were wrong. To argue that the findings were wrong was to engage the findings, and to engage them was to give them more life, and the people who had filed this did not want the findings to have any life at all. So the petition argued instead that the inquiry had reached, somewhere in its gathering, past the line its mandate drew, into a record or a category it had no charter to open, and that everything the inquiry had touched after that reach was gathered under a void authority and could not stand. It was clean. It was the argument Asha had refused to give them six weeks ago, on her knees on the floor of the small room with the code table open under her hand, when she had hit the category she could not investigate and had logged the wall and not crossed it. The faction did not know she had refused. The faction had filed the petition on the assumption that an inquiry which had got this far must have crossed the line, because the faction's own people would have crossed it, and the whole of the petition rested on a reach the Lionesses had been disciplined enough not to make.

That was the first thing Kaviel needed proven, and it was Asha's.

Asha had the request before she had finished the morning intake, and she set the intake aside, which she did for almost nothing, and went down to the room where the work had lived.

The room was as she had left it at the sixth hour two nights before, the disbursement registers banded and ranked along the wall, the appointment files squared on the table, the floor clear now because the floor-work was done. She did not need the registers this morning. She needed the log. She had logged every finding of the inquiry in the cramped exact hand that had filled a thousand intake ledgers, and she had logged beside each finding the authority under which it had been gathered, the channel, the mandate clause, the desk it had crossed, because she had spent forty years teaching that a finding without its provenance was a rumor and that the day would come when the provenance was the only thing that mattered. The day had come. She drew the log to the table edge and opened it to the first entry and began to read it

the way the registrar of record would read it if the registrar were honest and the way the petition's authors would read it if they were given the chance, which was to say against itself, hunting for the single place where the gathering had reached past the line.

The light in the room was the flat artificial light of a space with no window, a thing she had stopped noticing decades ago and noticed now because the day outside was running and she could not see it run. She read with the cold of the banded registers still banked in the corners and the dry mineral smell of the old paper close around her, and she read for an hour without rising, entry by entry, the carry-forward trace and the disbursement match and the message route and the protected witness, each finding set against the authority that had reached it, and at the head of every entry that touched the category above the line she found the same notation in her own hand, set down weeks ago, that the reach had stopped at the wall, that the issuing record had not been pulled, that the request to pull it had not been written, that the finding past the wall rested on inference from facts gathered below it and not on any record gathered above.

She had built the case so that it did not need the thing it could not reach, because a case that needed the crossing was a case that fell the day someone asked whether the crossing had been authorized. Someone had asked. The asking was in the registry under a priority docket with a clock on it. And the answer Asha had spent six weeks making sure she could give was that the line had held, that every finding stood on ground the mandate covered, that the inquiry had reached the floor above the working bureaus by inference and never by reach, and that there was no void authority in the gathering because there was no gathering above the line to be void.

She wrote it out. She wrote it the way she wrote everything, short, the provenance of each finding stated and the mandate clause cited and the wall marked plainly at every place the inquiry had stopped at it, and she wrote at the head of the thing the one sentence that was the whole of the reply, that the inquiry's findings touching the protected category were findings about that category and not findings gathered from within it, and that the distinction was the distinction between reading a locked door and going through it, and that the inquiry had read the door. She did not

argue. She stated. She trusted the registrar of record to read the argument out of the statement, and she trusted Kaviel to put the statement where the registrar would have to read it before the docket closed, and she folded the reply and set it in the channel tray and squared it and rang the runner, and the runner came, and it went up.

It was the ninth hour. She sat back in the chair, the first time she had used it that morning, and she did not rest, because the reply she had written answered the petition only if the petition stood on its own authentication, and a petition of invalidation under a priority docket had to be authenticated by an officer of the court whose seal said the grounds were colorable and worth the registrar's day, and the question of who had set that seal was not Asha's. It was Silva's. Asha had marked it in the log as the second thing the morning would turn on, and she had no word yet that it had turned.

Silva had been on the registry steps since before the petition was filed, because Kaviel had put her there the night before on the strength of nothing but the dangerous hour, and Silva had spent her life being where a thing would happen before there was a thing.

She was not on the steps as herself. She was a factor's clerk with a satchel of someone else's paper, one of the forty such clerks who waited each morning on the broad shallow steps of the registry tower for the doors to take the day's business, and she stood among them in the cold with the smell of the vendor's grill at the foot of the steps coming up on the wind, charred fat and burnt grain and the sharp green of the herb the vendor cut over the meat, and she watched the doors and the people who went through them and she did the work she was best in three Thrones at, which was to see who carried what to whom and to remember it without appearing to have looked. She was not waiting for the petition. The petition would go in through the clerks' door like everything else and she would never see the sheet. She was waiting for the authentication, because an authentication was not paper that moved through a clerk's window. It was an officer of the court setting a seal, and an officer of the court setting a seal on a priority docket had to do it in person at the authenticating desk on the registry's second floor, and Silva had spent the previous afternoon learning, the way she learned things, which window

of the second floor was the authenticating desk and where on the steps a clerk could stand and see the people who climbed to it.

She saw him at the eighth hour and a quarter. He came up the steps not hurrying and not slow, a man in a councillor's coat with the river-country cut to it, broad in the shoulders and going soft at the jaw, and he carried under his arm a folder banded in the red the court used for matters it meant to move, and he climbed the steps among the clerks and the factors without looking at any of them and went in through the principals' door, which the clerks did not use, and Silva let him go and did not follow and marked the time and the coat and the red band and the principals' door, and she knew him. She had watched him for six weeks in the spring from peripheries he never knew were peopled, and she had filed the watching in the field notes Kaviel kept, and she did not need the face turned toward her to name it. She let him reach the second floor. Then she crossed the steps to the vendor and bought a round of the grilled meat she did not want, and while the man cut it she stood with her back to the tower and her face to the street and took from the satchel the small flat field-set the Quarter issued and sent up the channel the one line Kaviel was waiting for, the time and the coat and the red-banded folder and the principals' door and the name, Hadi Marun, climbing to the authenticating desk.

She put the field-set away and ate the meat she did not want, because a clerk who bought food and did not eat it was a clerk a watcher remembered, and she stayed on the steps, because the man would come down again when the seal was set and she wanted the time of his coming down as much as she had wanted the time of his going up. The grease was cold on her fingers and the herb was sharp on the air, and Silva stood among the clerks and watched the principals' door and waited for a councillor to come back down a flight of stairs.

Kaviel had Silva's line at the eighth hour and a half, and it told her the petition was Marun's to authenticate, which told her the rest of it.

She had known there was a courtier. She had not known which, and she had not let herself guess, because a guess carried into the work was a finding spoiled at the root. Now she did not have to guess. Hadi Marun, who had heard a river-prefecture matter ruled against him by the throne

and ruled fairly, who had owed in two directions for eleven years the way every councillor of his grade owed in two directions, had set his seal to a petition that named no inquiry and argued a void authority, and in setting it he had told the Quarter the one thing the petition had been built to keep hidden, which was that the people who had filed it were close enough to the court to reach a councillor and turn him to the authenticating desk in a single morning. The petition was clean. The hand that had moved Marun to authenticate it was not, because a clean petition did not need a councillor walked up a flight of stairs under a priority docket inside two hours of the dangerous gap opening. Someone had been waiting for the gap as carefully as Kaviel had. Someone had had Marun ready.

That was the thing past the day, and Kaviel set it down and did not follow it, because the day was not yet won and a person who chased the second thing while the first ran loose lost both. She wrote it into the running log in two lines for Asha, that the authentication was Marun's and that Marun's reach to the desk was the faction's reach into the court, and she left it there. The morning's work was the petition, and the petition would fall on Asha's reply if the reply reached the registrar before the docket closed, and the reply had gone up, and now there was the registrar himself, and the registrar's day, and what the faction would do to that day to keep Asha's reply from being read in it.

She did not have to wonder long. The registrar of record was a magister of the court named Faraj Oduya, exact and slow and proof against pressure of the ordinary kind, and the faction would not try the ordinary kind. They would try the docket. A priority docket that required a ruling within the working day was a docket that could be lost in a working day, buried under other priority matters filed the same morning so that the registrar reached the petition with an hour left and ruled on it tired and fast and on the face of the thing, which was clean, rather than on the reply, which had to be read slow to be believed. Kaviel had the morning's docket count from Otieno, eleven priority matters filed before the ninth hour where a busy day saw three. They were drowning the registrar. They meant Asha's reply to arrive at a desk too buried to read it.

So Kaviel did the thing she had built for. She did not fight the docket. She moved the reply out of it. Asha's reply had gone up as a response to the petition, to be read in the petition's hour at the bottom of a drowned

docket. Kaviel sent a second copy of it by a different channel, away from the registrar's docket and into the registrar's chambers, addressed to Magister Oduya by name and carried by the Quarter's own runner under the standing arrangement by which the Lionesses could put a matter directly before a court officer when the matter touched the security of the imperial record, which this one did, and which Kaviel had been careful to phrase so that it did. It was a narrow door and she had used it perhaps four times in nine years and she used it now, and the using of it told Oduya, before he read a line, that the Quarter considered the morning's petition a matter touching the security of the record, which was a thing a magister of long service would weigh before he buried it under the docket. She wrote the cover line herself, short, and put the copy in the runner's hand, and sent it, and then there was nothing to do but the thing she was worst at, which was to wait while other people's hours ran.

Sael Mokoena's hour was running too, four hundred miles south in the city of Adwa, and it was running out from under him though he did not yet know it.

He had a role in the morning and he performed it, because he had been told to perform it and because the people who told him things had been right for four years and he had no ground left to doubt them from. The petition that argued a void authority needed, somewhere beneath the court's clean language, a fact to argue from, and the fact was Mokoena's. He was the deputy registrar of the Bureau's Outer Prefectures office, the man whose carry-forward initials sat at the head of the schedules the inquiry had unwound, and the petition's authors had built into it a sworn attestation from his office that the inquiry's investigators had, in the course of their gathering, requested and received records that lay above the working line, records his office held under the protected category, and that the request had carried no authorization the office could find. It was the spine of the thing. If a working registrar of the Bureau swore that the inquiry had reached above the line and taken protected records without authority, the petition's clean argument had a fact under it, and Asha's reply, which said the line had held, would stand against a sworn attestation from the office that kept the line, and a registrar choosing

between a Lioness's word and a Bureau registrar's oath about the Bureau's own records would have to weigh the oath.

Mokoena's task was to swear it. He had been given the attestation drafted, the records named, the dates set, and all that was asked of him was the oath of an officer that the request had crossed his desk and that no authorization had accompanied it, and he had sat with the draft at the desk worn pale at the front edge where two generations of registrars had rested their forearms, with the bitter red tea cooling at his elbow and the smell of the lamp he lit each morning though the window gave him light, and he had read the draft for the third time and known that it was not true.

He knew it was not true because he kept his own pigeonholes and trusted no one to touch them, and he had gone to them the moment the draft arrived, the night before, and pulled the correspondence log of his office for the period the attestation named, and the inquiry's investigators had not requested the protected records from his office, because the inquiry had never reached above the line, because Asha had stopped at the wall. There was no request that had come to him without authorization, because there was no request at all. The attestation asked him to swear to the absence of an authorization on a thing that had never been asked of him, and a man could perhaps swear to an absence if he did not look, but Mokoena had looked, because looking was the only thing he had ever been good at, and now he knew, and the knowing sat on the desk with the cooling tea.

He had inserted false appointments through the carry-forward provision for four years, taking by other means a seat he believed he was owed, and across four years he had told himself a long quiet string of true-sounding things about what he was and was not doing, and not one of them had required him to set his name under an oath that he knew at the moment of setting it to be false. The frauds had been done in the gaps the provision left, in the spaces between what was true and what could be proven, and a man could live a long time in those spaces and call himself an honest registrar who had made one arrangement. The oath was not a gap. The oath was his name and his hand and the word sworn, and the word was false, and the people who had sent him the draft had not asked whether he could swear it. They had assumed he would, because he had

done everything else, and the assuming was the place their understanding of him ran out.

He sat with it through the morning while his hour ran. He drank the tea cold. He read the correspondence log a fourth time, hunting for the request that would have made the oath true, and it was not there, and a floor-keeper drew the wide mop across the corridor outside his door and the wet trail of it shone and faded and the transcription engine clicked through its backlog somewhere above him, patient as rain on a roof, the sounds of the office he had loved for nineteen years before he had begun to use it. And at the eleventh hour, with the attestation still unsigned and the messenger waiting in the outer office for the sealed oath the petition could not stand without, Sael Mokoena did the thing that collapsed one floor of the structure that had protected him, which was nothing. He did not sign. He could not bring his hand to set his name under a sworn falsehood he had checked and knew to be false, and he could not bring himself to refuse outright and tell the people who had been right for four years that he would not, and so he did the thing a careful frightened man does, which was to delay, to send word that the records were being verified, that the attestation would follow within the day, that he wished to be exact. The day did not have within it. The petition needed the oath by the docket's hour and the oath did not come, and the messenger waited in the outer office past the hour it could be useful, and four hundred miles north the petition went before the registrar of record with its clean argument and its void authority and no sworn fact beneath it, because the one man who could have sworn the fact had read his own correspondence log and could not make his hand move.

He had not chosen a side. He told himself that, sitting at the pale-edged desk with the lamp lit and the tea cold and the unsigned draft in front of him, that he had only waited to be sure. But the waiting was the thread, and Asha would have it within the week, because a registrar who delayed an attestation his principals needed by the hour was a registrar whose principals would now move to protect the structure from him, and a man being moved against by the people who had protected him was a man with a reason to be found by the people on the other side, and Asha read threads like that by the place where the friction stopped. Mokoena did not know any of that yet. He knew only that he had not signed, and

he sat in the office that had been his for nineteen years and listened to the mop and the engine and waited for an instruction that was not going to come, because the people who gave him instructions had already understood, faster than he had, what his silence meant.

The registrar ruled at the close of the working day, and Kaviel was in the registry to watch it, because she had earned the right to be in the room and because she did not trust a thing she had not seen with her own eyes.

She stood at the back of the registrar's anteroom where the parties to a docket waited for the day's rulings, among the factors and the clerks and the one councillor's man sent to carry the result back to whoever had sent the petition, and she watched Magister Faraj Oduya come out to the long desk where the rulings were read and set down his folio of the day's work, heavy with the eleven priority matters, and read them out in the order he had taken them, slow and exact and proof against the weight of the docket in a way the petition's authors had wagered he would not be. He came to the matter of invalidation last, as a buried matter came last, and Kaviel stood very still at the back of the room with her hands folded and gave the watchers around her nothing to read, and Oduya read the ruling.

He had read Asha's reply. Kaviel knew it from the first line of the ruling, because the ruling took up the petition's argument about void authority on the ground Asha had built, the distinction between reading a locked record and gathering from within it, and found, the ruling said, no showing that the inquiry had gathered from within the protected category, the attestation that would have made such a showing not having been received, and the petition resting therefore on an assertion of reach unsupported by any record of reach. He ruled the grounds not colorable. He returned the petition without prejudice to refile on a proper showing, which was a magister's exact way of saying that the people who had filed it could come back when they had a fact, and he set his seal to the ruling and closed the docket, and the working day ended with the findings of the inquiry standing in the record exactly where they had stood at the seventh hour of the morning, and the Empress's notation, when it was entered, would have its page to protect.

The smell of the anteroom was sealing wax and lamp oil and the cold stone of a building emptying for the night. The councillor's man heard the ruling and turned at once and went, fast, to carry it back. Kaviel did not watch him go. She watched Oduya gather his folio and rise from the long desk, an old exact man at the end of a long drowned day, and she watched the petition returned to the clerk's hand to be filed away without prejudice, and she felt the day settle out of her shoulders the way the work always settled when it was done, slow and incomplete, because a day won was only a day.

Asha had come into the anteroom at the last ruling and stood beside her, having walked up from the Quarter to see the thing land, and the two of them stood at the back of the emptying room while the clerks banked the lamps along the long desk and the wax cooled on the day's seals, and neither of them said anything for a while.

"The attestation never came," Asha said at last. It was not a question. She had built the reply on the chance that it would not and she had watched the ruling turn on its absence, and she was marking the fact aloud the way she marked a finding, to set it where it could be acted on.

"No," Kaviel said. "Mokoena did not sign."

Asha took that and turned it once and set it where it belonged, which was at the head of the thread she would follow, the registrar in Adwa who had been given a thing to swear and had not sworn it and was now, this evening, a man his own people would be moving against. She did not say any of that. She had it, and Kaviel knew she had it, and the knowing passed between them without a word spent on it.

The clerks banked the last of the lamps and the anteroom went to the dim it kept for the night, and the returned petition lay on the clerk's desk in its red band, struck off the docket, waiting to be carried down to the files where matters went that had not stood. Kaviel watched it lie there, the clean fast elegant thing that had nearly worked, and she did the arithmetic again, the new arithmetic, the one that began the moment the old one closed.

"They have another move," she said. Quiet, to Asha, not turning from the desk.

"I know," Asha said.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

The Second Mechanism

BY THE THIRD DAY of the emergency window the investigation room had stopped being a room anyone left.

It had grown the way Asha's second room had grown, past the table it began on and past the next table after that, until the storage bay under the south wall held three tables end to end and a fourth set crosswise at the head, and the walls that had been bare in the spring carried the work in ranked sheets pinned in the order it was read. The disbursement registers stood banded along the long wall where Asha could reach them without crossing the room. The appointment files, the matter that had been the whole of the case in the spring and was now the smaller half of it, had been moved to a side table against the door, squared and closed, because the appointment files were proven and the appointment files were not where the danger lay. The danger lay in the new sheets, the ones Zola had begun to fill two days before and had not stopped filling, the three-column rule she worked in widened now to five, and the five columns climbed the wall in a hand that had gone from the slow clean rule of the spring to something faster and surer that was the same hand grown into the size of what it carried.

The light had been artificial for so long that no one in the room could have said what the hour was outside without the clock. There was a clock, a plain bureau face on the crosswise table at the head, and Kaviel kept it wound, and she looked at it the way a person looks at a thing they need and do not trust, because the clock was the edge of the window the

Empress had bought them and the window did not widen. The emergency authority froze the channels for as long as the channels stayed frozen, and the channels stayed frozen for as long as no one with standing pried them open, and a resource held still was a resource that could be moved the instant the holding lapsed. They were not racing the faction now. The faction's move in the registry had fallen the day before. They were racing the freeze itself, the slow administrative thaw that would begin the moment the prerogative's reach was tested at its edges, and the edges were where the second mechanism lived.

Kaviel had the shape of it by the second hour of the third day, and the shape was worse than the appointments had been.

She had known there was a second mechanism since the corridor outside the neutral room where Eleanor had met the marshal, since the line that had come up the channel in Eleanor's hand the same night, three words and a fourth, that the money moved too, and that they had not found how. Eleanor did not write more than she had to and she had not written more than that. But the line had told Kaviel where to look, and looking was the thing the Quarter did, and so she had set Zola back into the cold-jurisdiction stacks with a new instruction, to stop reading the appointments as the thing and start reading them as the cover, and to find what the appointments had been built to hide.

What they had been built to hide was a flow.

"Lay it from the start," Kaviel said. She was in the chair at the head of the crosswise table, which she used now because the work had grown past standing, and Zola was at the wall with the five-column sheets, and Asha was at the long wall with the disbursement registers open under both hands, and across the room a second researcher and a clerk worked the cross-reference between the two, carrying sheets from the wall to the registers and back. "From the channel up. Not the count. The road."

"The appointments were never the point," Zola said. She did not turn from the wall. She had learned, in the weeks since the night she carried the folder up the corridor, to talk while she worked, and the talking and the working had become the same motion. "A false magistrate confirms judgments. A false registrar confirms entries. That is power, and the marshal's people wanted the power, and we read the case for two seasons as a case about the power, because the false appointments were the thing

we could see. But a false officer in a working seat does a second thing that a true officer in the same seat does, which is to certify the movement of money. Disbursements. Reconciliations of accounts between jurisdictions. The settling of obligations across the prefectural treasuries that runs through the same offices the appointments run through, because it is the same officers who sign it."

"And a false officer signs it false," Asha said from the long wall. She said it flat, marking the fact, not asking. She had built the financial side in the spring and she had found the correction pass in it and she had hit the wall above it and logged the wall and not crossed it, and she had carried since then the knowledge that the correction pass meant someone senior was reaching down to clean the records after the fact, and she had not known until this third day what the cleaning had been cleaning. Now she knew. "The false officer certifies a disbursement that has a true face and a false back. The treasury reads the face. The face says a sum moved from one prefectural account to settle a true obligation, a contract, a levy, a reconciliation between two jurisdictions that both show the entry and both show it settled. The treasury reconciles it and closes it. And the sum that moved is short of the sum the face declared, and the short part went somewhere the face does not record, and the books balance because the officer who signed the false face is the officer who would have caught the short, and he is not catching it, because he is the one taking it."

"Seven years," Zola said.

The room was quiet for the length of that. The clerk's stylus stopped on the cross-reference sheet and started again. Somewhere above them the transcription engine ran its backlog, the patient clicking that had become the floor of every long day in the Quarter, and under it the dry close smell of too much paper held too long in a room with no window, and under that the cold that banked in the corners where the registers stood and never lifted while the door stayed shut.

"Show me the seven years," Kaviel said.

Zola brought down the head sheet of the five-column climb and laid it on the crosswise table under Kaviel's hand, and weighted the corners with the clock and the inkstone the way the work taught, and she stood back to the distance a researcher stood when a senior read.

"The first false disbursement I can place is seven years back, in the Sennar accounts, the same watershed where the first false appointment sat." Zola's finger moved down the first column, not touching. "A reconciliation between Sennar and the jurisdiction above it, a true obligation, a road levy that both sides show. The face declares the full sum. The Sennar account pays the full sum. The receiving account receives a sum that is short by a portion, and the portion is made up on the receiving side by a carry-forward credit, a reconciliation entry, that says the difference was settled under a prior authority and need not be paid again." She let her hand fall. "It is the appointments fraud. It is the same clause. The carry-forward reconciliation does not only let a false appointment into the record on the word of a prior authority that does not exist. It lets a false settlement into the books the same way. The provision was never about appointments. The appointments were one use of it. The money was the other use, and the money was the use that mattered, and we read the appointments first because the appointments were the part that left a face in a courtroom."

Kaviel read the head sheet the way Asha had taught her to read a junior's finding, hunting for the place it was wrong before anyone else found it, and she did not find the place, because there was no place, because the girl had run it the way she ran everything, blind and clean and back to the source. She read the first column and the second and the third, the face sum and the paid sum and the short, and she read the carry-forward credit that closed the short, and she read it against the disbursement register Asha had open on the long wall, and the register showed the face and the books showed balanced and the short was real and the short had gone somewhere.

"Where does the short go," Kaviel said.

"That is the second mechanism," Asha said. She came off the long wall with a register in her two hands and set it on the crosswise table beside the head sheet, open to a page banded with a marker she had set that morning, and she laid her finger on a line of it without touching the ink. "The short does not vanish. It cannot vanish, because a sum that vanished would show as a loss somewhere and a loss is the thing the treasury is built to find. So the short is not lost. It is moved, and it is moved into accounts that the treasury does not read as the same money,

because the accounts are accounts of a different kind, in a different ledger, under a different office, and the office that moves it is the office that certifies that it is a true and separate sum and not the short from the disbursement two pages back."

"Three offices," Zola said.

Kaviel looked up from the register.

"Three channels," Zola said. She brought the second sheet down from the wall and laid it beside the first, and this one was the map, the way the first finding had ended in a map, the printer's grid of the prefectures extended past its own edges in her own slow rule, the adjoining jurisdictions to spinward and the river districts to the south sketched in beyond the printed border, and on it, in the small flat dots that were Kaviel's own mark, the dots ran the same spread the appointments had run, because they were the same offices, but threaded between the dots now were three heavier marks, three lines that gathered the short out of the dots and ran it inward. "The Third Appointments Commission for the Outer Prefectures is one. We knew the Third Commission. The Third Commission is the channel everyone has been looking at since the spring, because the Third Commission is where the appointments sat, and the faction was content to let it be looked at, because the appointments in it were the cover and the money in it was only a third of the money." Her finger moved to the second heavy line, off the printed grid, in the country she had drawn herself. "The adjoining jurisdictions to spinward settle their reconciliations under a separate commission that answers up the same bureau. That is the second channel. The short from the spinward disbursements runs into it. And the river commissions to the south, a third reporting line on paper, settle theirs under a third body, and the short from the river runs into that." She set her hand flat on the map. "Three channels. The appointments fraud touched all three because the appointments fraud was the cover for all three. We proved the appointments and we thought we had the case, and we had a third of the case, and the third we had was the third they were willing to lose."

"And the three run to one office," Kaviel said. She said it the way she had said it on the night Zola first carried the name up the corridor, half to herself, reading the map and not the girl. "The same as the appointments."

The three reporting lines come together at one office that reaches all three."

"They come together at the marshal's office," Asha said. She did not lower her voice, because the room was the room and the case was past the point of unsaid names. "The same office. The appointments and the money run the same road to the same reach, because they were built by the same understanding for the same purpose, and the purpose was the money. The appointments were how you put your hands on the offices. The money was what the offices were for."

Kaviel sat with the two sheets and the open register, and the room ran on around her, the clerk carrying a cross-reference back to the wall and the second researcher pinning a fresh sheet into the climb and the engine clicking above, and she did the arithmetic, the slow real arithmetic with the clock running on the table at her elbow, and the arithmetic was not the count of the money, which was large past the point where the size of it meant anything, but the count of the danger.

"If we strike the appointments," she said, "the money moves."

"The money moves," Asha said.

This was the thing the third day turned on, and Kaviel had known it would be the thing since the second hour, and she had not let herself reach for the striking until the road was laid, because a striking made before the road was whole was a striking that scattered the resource into country the prerogative could not follow. The emergency authority froze the channels. It froze them inside the imperium, inside the reach of the Throne, inside the jurisdictions the prerogative named. The short that had been gathered for seven years sat now in accounts the freeze held still. But an account held still was not an account seized, and the people who had built the second mechanism had built into it, the way they built into everything, a use for the moment the cover failed. The moment the appointments were struck and the false officers fell, a true officer would read the disbursements clean and the carry-forward credits would not close and the short would show, and the short showing was the alarm, and the alarm was the instruction to move the resource out of the frozen channels and into the river districts at the spinward edge where the prerogative's reach ran thin and out past them into the adjoining Thrones

where it did not run at all. A wrong move struck the cover and rang the alarm and lost the resource in the same hour.

"So we do not strike the cover," Kaviel said. "Not first. We close the road out before we touch the road in."

She stood, the first time she had stood since the second hour, and she went to the wall where the map climbed, and she read the three heavy lines, and she read where they ran thin at the spinward edge, and she read the river districts below where the third channel went to ground, and she began to build the thing she built best, which was the order of a striking that did not ring until it was complete.

"The correction pass," she said. "Asha. The correction pass is the signature. You found it in the spring and you logged the wall above it and you did not cross. The correction pass is a senior hand reaching down to clean the records after the insertions, and we read it then as cleaning the appointments. It was cleaning the money. Every place the correction pass ran, it ran to close a short that had begun to show, to lay a fresh carry-forward credit over a settlement that a true officer had started to read clean. The correction pass is the alarm rehearsed. It is the move they will make when the cover fails, made early, on a schedule, every time the books drifted toward showing the short. Find me every correction pass in seven years. Each one is a place the short threatened to show and was hidden again. Each one is a finger on the road out. If we map the correction passes we map the route the resource will take when it runs, because the route it will take is the route it has already taken, every time, for seven years, whenever the cover thinned."

Asha was already at the long wall, pulling the registers that held the correction-pass entries she had marked in the spring and not crossed, and she carried them to the crosswise table and laid them in the order she built, and she went to her knees on the cold stone among them the way she worked, because the floor was where the work went when the table was full, and the table was full. She read the first correction pass and set it on the map at the place it had run, and the second, and the third, and the dots of the correction passes fell along the three heavy lines exactly where Kaviel had said they would fall, at the thin edge spinward and at the river districts to the south, the rehearsed road out marked in seven years of cleaning, and Asha read them onto the map one at a time in the

cramped exact hand that had filled a thousand ledgers, kneeling on the stone with the cold of the registers banked around her and the dry mineral smell of the old paper close, and she did not rise for an hour.

Kaviel built the order of the striking while Asha mapped the road. She built it the way she had built the replies for the registry morning, against a thing that had not happened yet, putting each piece where it would have to act before she knew the hour it would act in. The road out had to be closed first, the thin edge and the river districts, the accounts at the end of the rehearsed route held under a second instrument the Empress would have to sign, narrower than the freeze and aimed, naming the route the correction passes drew. Then the channels, the three of them, held still already by the freeze and now to be sealed at the gather points where the short pooled, so that the resource could not be summoned inward to a single account and run from there. Then, last, the cover, the false officers and the false appointments, struck only when the road out was closed and the channels sealed and there was nowhere for the alarm to send the money, so that when the short finally showed it showed into a system that had already shut every door it could run through.

It was the order of a thing that did not ring until it was done, and the building of it took the whole of the afternoon that no one in the room could see, and the room ran on through the building of it, the clerk and the second researcher carrying sheets, Asha kneeling at the road, Zola at the wall widening the columns as each new short surfaced and was placed. The clock turned on the crosswise table. A floor-keeper drew the mop along the corridor outside and the wet trail of it shone under the door and faded. The engine clicked above. The cold held in the corners. And the case, which had been a case about false appointments in the spring and had been a third of itself when they thought it whole, grew on the walls into the size it had always been, the appointments the visible face of it and the money the body, seven years of short gathered down three channels to one reach, and the order of the striking laid against it piece by piece so that the body could be taken without the face crying out in time to run.

A second line came up the channel from Eleanor at the close of the afternoon. The runner brought it and Kaviel read it and set it flat on the

crosswise table and read it again, and it was as short as the first. It did not ask after the work. It did not tell her what to do with what the work found. It told her, in the form Eleanor wrote things, that Eleanor was positioned for the next phase and that the next phase was the marshal's, not the money's, and that Kaviel should give the Empress the complete picture and nothing held back, because the picture was what made the case stand in a court and a court was where the marshal was now going. Kaviel read the last of it and understood the shape of what Eleanor had taken on for herself in the country past this room, the cost she had written into her own column when she walked into the neutral room, and she did not write back, because there was nothing to write that Eleanor did not already hold, and she folded the line and put it in the drawer with the rest of the case and turned the key.

"Asha," she said. "Is the road closed."

"The road is mapped." Asha rose off her knees with a hand on the table edge, an old officer at the end of a long day on a stone floor, and she set the last correction pass on the map and stood back from it. "Every correction pass in seven years is on it. The road out runs where I said it would not run and where you said it would, the thin spinward edge and the three river accounts under the southern body, and the resource has run that road every time the cover thinned, which means it will run it again when the cover fails, which means the second instrument has to name those accounts and no others, narrow, so that a court reads it as aimed at a proven route and not as a seizure of a region's treasury. I have the account numbers. I have the dates of every run. I have the proof that each run followed a short that began to show. A court will read the route as a confession, because no honest office cleans a settlement on a schedule that tracks the threat of its own discovery."

"And the channels," Kaviel said. "The gather points."

"Three." Asha laid her finger on the map at the three places the heavy lines pooled before they ran inward. "Sealed at these. The short pools here before it is summoned to the marshal's reach, and if these three are sealed the moment the second instrument signs, the resource cannot be summoned, and a resource that cannot be summoned and cannot run is a resource that sits where it is until the court takes it." She lowered her hand. "It is surgical. It has to be. A wider seal touches true accounts and a

true account frozen by error is a jurisdiction the faction can point to and say the Throne overreached, and the overreach is the thing the registry morning was rehearsing and the thing the complaint against Eleanor will argue. We touch the proven route and the three gather points and nothing else. The honest money never feels it. The short cannot move. And when the cover comes off, the short shows into a closed room."

Kaviel read the whole of the map a last time, the appointments and the money and the road and the channels and the order of the striking laid against all of it, and she read it the way she had read Zola's first finding, hunting for the place it was wrong, and there was no place, because the work was clean, because it had been run blind and read hard and built back to the source by a room that had not stopped in three days. The picture was complete. It was the thing she had carried since the corridor outside the neutral room, and it was whole now on the wall in front of her, and the completeness of it was the thing she had wanted and the thing she would have given a great deal not to be true.

She stood with it for a while. The room ran on. The clerk banded the last cross-reference and set it on the closed appointment files by the door. The second researcher pinned the final sheet of the climb into the wall and stepped back, and the five-column rule reached the ceiling now, the body of a seven-year theft set out where a court could read it from the floor up. Zola stood at the foot of the wall looking up the climb of her own hand, the brightness in her eyes gone glassy with the third day and the not-sleeping, holding the size of the thing the way she had been taught to hold it, in the head and not on the front of the face. Asha stood at the map with her hands at her sides. The engine clicked. The cold held. The clock on the crosswise table turned past an hour no one in the room had marked.

Kaviel went to the drawer and took out the case, the whole of it, the appointments proven in the spring and the money proven in three days, and she squared it in both hands the way Zola had squared the first folder in the corridor, and she set it on the crosswise table under the bureau clock, complete.

"Tell the Empress it is complete," Kaviel said.

Zola turned from the wall. "All of it?"

"All of it," Kaviel said.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

What It Cost Eleanor

THE OVERSIGHT CHAMBER SAT on the third floor of the old administrative court, in the wing the establishment kept for the proceedings it held against itself.

It was a room built to make a single argument, which was that the imperial administration could be weighed in its own scales and found wanting without the throne having to lift a hand, and the room made the argument in stone and in furniture and in the placement of the light. The ceiling was high and plain. The walls were the same pale dressed stone as the corridors that fed it, and they carried no map, no portrait, no seal of any house, because the chamber answered to no house and was at pains to say so. A low rail of dark wood divided the floor. On the near side of the rail were the benches for those with standing to attend, three rows of them, hard and unupholstered, the wood gone smooth at the forward edges where a great many people had sat through a great many hours without comfort. On the far side, raised one shallow step, stood the arbiter's bench, long and bare, and before it, at the level of the floor, a single chair set facing the bench across an open distance that no table crossed. The chair had been placed so that a person answering from it sat alone in the middle of the room with the light coming down full on them from the tall clerestory windows and nothing within reach of either hand. The room had been designed by someone who understood that a person made to sit exposed in the center of a formal space will, given an hour, begin to argue against themselves. Eleanor had read the room before she

crossed the rail, the way she read every room, and she had understood its argument, and she had decided, somewhere in the crossing, that she would not give it the hour it was built to take.

She came in on the cane and on Sefu's arm to the rail and no farther on the arm, because past the rail the proceeding was hers to answer and a person answering does not lean on another. She let go of Sefu at the rail. She crossed the open floor to the single chair at her own pace, the cane setting its even sound on the stone, and the sound carried in the bare room the way the room was built to carry it, and she let it carry, and she sat. She set the cane upright against the side of the chair where her hand could find it. She folded her hands in her lap. The light came down on her from the high windows, cold and white off the morning, and it found the lines of a face that had been worked by eighty years and gave nothing back, and she sat in the center of the floor as still as she had sat in the leased room a fortnight before, and waited for the proceeding to begin only when it began, because beginning it in her own head ahead of the arbiter would have been the room's first small theft of her and she did not intend to be robbed in increments.

Kaviel came in behind her and took the forward bench on the near side of the rail, alone, in the place set for an attending officer of the apparatus under review. She had been entered on the standing as present and not as a party, and the entry carried with it the one term that governed the whole of her morning, which was that she had no voice in the chamber. She could attend. She could not speak. She could not pass paper across the rail or answer a question put to her mother or correct a thing said wrong about the work she had run, and she had read the term the night before in the notice and had set the notice down without a word, and she sat now on the forward bench with her hands flat on her knees and her back straight and her eyes on the single chair in the middle of the floor, and she did the only thing the term left her, which was to be in the room.

Arbiter Sabel Doumbia entered through the door behind the bench at the hour the notice had named, neither early nor late, a spare upright woman of middle years in the gray robe the oversight office wore, and the chamber rose, and Eleanor rose with it on the cane, which cost her and which she paid without letting the cost reach the surface, and

Doumbia took the bench and inclined her head and the chamber sat. She did not look long at Eleanor. She looked at the file open before her, a thick file, banded and tabbed, and she read the head of it in the flat unhurried voice of a person who has read ten thousand such heads and means to read this one no differently, and the reading set the frame of the morning out loud for the record that would outlast everyone in the room.

"This is a formal review under the standing oversight authority of the imperial administration," Doumbia said, "convened on a complaint lodged by the office of the Marshal of the Bureau of Establishments, authenticated as colorable by an officer of the court, and entered to the docket in due form. The complaint is against Eleanor De Grosvenor, head of the De Grosvenor intelligence and administrative apparatus, and it alleges three things. It alleges abuse of intelligence authority. It alleges the unauthorized surveillance of a senior official of the imperial establishment. It alleges procedural violations in the conduct of an inquiry not chartered by any standing body. This review does not adjudicate guilt and assigns no penalty. It weighs whether the complaint states a matter the administration must answer, and it makes a finding, and the finding goes up. Eleanor De Grosvenor, you have been served the complaint and you have declined the assistance of an advocate. You answer for yourself."

"I do," Eleanor said.

"Then you understand that what you say is the record."

"I have understood that about every room I have entered for sixty years," Eleanor said. "I do not expect this one to be different."

Doumbia let that sit without taking it up, which told Eleanor the woman was good, because a lesser arbiter would have heard a challenge in it and answered the challenge and lost a degree of the bench in the answering, and Doumbia heard it for what it was, an old woman stating the terms she had always worked under, and let it pass into the record unweighed and went on. She turned a tab in the file.

"The first allegation," she said. "Abuse of intelligence authority. The complaint holds that your apparatus conducted, over a period of months, a sustained collection effort directed at the offices and records of the Bureau of Establishments, that this collection was not authorized by any

charter the Bureau recognizes, and that you directed it. Do you contest that the collection occurred."

"No."

The word went out flat into the bare room and the room held it. On the forward bench Kaviel did not move. Doumbia looked up from the file then, the first full look she had given the chair, and she took the old woman's measure across the open floor, and Eleanor gave her the same nothing she had given the marshal, and the two of them held the look a moment, the arbiter and the answering, and it was Doumbia who returned to the file, having taken from the look what she needed, which was the measure of a woman who would not be made to argue against herself.

"You do not contest it," Doumbia said.

"I will not spend the morning making you prove a thing I did," Eleanor said. "The collection occurred. I directed it. It was sustained and it was directed at the Bureau of Establishments and it was not chartered by the Bureau, and it would have been a poor collection if it had been, because a Bureau does not charter the reading of its own floor. I will save the chamber the labor of the first allegation by granting all of it that is fact. The collection happened. I am the hand it happened under. Where I will not go with you is the word abuse, and I will tell you why when you have read me the rest, because the answer to the word abuse is the same answer to all three and I would rather give it once and whole than three times in pieces."

"The chamber will hear the rest first," Doumbia said. "The second allegation. The unauthorized surveillance of a senior official. The complaint holds that the collection was directed in part at the person and movements of the Marshal of the Bureau of Establishments, Lord Marshal Tewodros Marek, that he was watched, that his correspondence was traced, that a meeting was sought with him under conditions you arranged, and that none of this was sanctioned by any authority competent to sanction the surveillance of an officer of his rank. Do you contest it."

"I contest one word of it," Eleanor said. "I will give you the rest. He was watched. His correspondence was traced, through the relays that carried it, by people who read the routing and not the words, because the

words were not the thing and the routing was. I sought a meeting with him and I arranged its conditions, and I will tell the chamber freely that I arranged them so that he would hold no advantage in the room, because I was not going to meet a man of his reach on ground he chose. All of that is true and I set it on the record without qualification. The word I contest is unauthorized, and again I will hold the contest until the third allegation is read, because it is the same contest, and the chamber's time is worth more than my repeating myself."

Doumbia turned the last tab.

"The third allegation. Procedural violations in the conduct of an inquiry not chartered by any standing body. The complaint holds that the inquiry your apparatus conducted, the findings of which now stand under the protection of an extraordinary authority, was itself irregular in its foundation, that it operated without a charter from the Bureau or from any commission, that it gathered and held and acted upon material outside the procedures that govern such gathering, and that an inquiry so founded cannot produce findings the administration is bound to credit." She closed the file over her hand and looked up. "That is the complaint. You have granted the facts of the first and the second and reserved one word from each. Give the chamber your answer."

Eleanor was quiet for the space of a breath, and the breath was not hesitation, it was the ordering of a thing she had ordered many times in the nights since the leased room, and she let the room have the silence because the silence was hers now and not the room's, and then she spoke into it in the dry even voice that had read figures back across a thousand tables.

"The complaint is true in almost every fact it states," she said, "and I have granted those facts as they came, and I will not take them back to soften the morning. I watched the marshal. I read the routing of his correspondence. I conducted an inquiry that no Bureau chartered and no commission convened, and I held material in it and I acted on what the material told me, and I did all of it knowing that no standing procedure of the imperial administration had authorized a single hour of it. The chamber may write that down as my own word, and it is. Where the complaint is false is in the frame it puts around those facts, and the frame

is the whole of the matter, because a fact set in the wrong frame argues for a thing that never happened."

"State the frame the complaint puts on it," Doumbia said.

"The complaint puts on it the frame of the standing administrative procedure," Eleanor said. "It says: here is conduct, measure it against the charters that govern the Bureau and its officers and its inquiries, and you will find the conduct exceeded them at every turn, and the conduct is therefore abuse, unauthorized, and irregular. And measured against that frame, every word of the complaint is sound. I will grant the chamber that too. If the procedures of the Bureau of Establishments are the proper measure of what I did, then I have abused, I have exceeded, I have proceeded without charter, and the finding writes itself, and you may send it up before the noon bell." She let her folded hands rest. "I say the procedures of the Bureau are not the proper measure. I say the proper measure is the compact, and that the compact is the frame the complaint has been built to keep out of this room, because inside that frame the same facts say something the complaint cannot survive."

Doumbia did not move to stop her, which Eleanor marked, because an arbiter protecting the Bureau's frame would have ruled the compact outside the chamber's notice and closed the door on it, and Doumbia left the door open, and an open door was a thing Eleanor knew how to walk through.

"The chamber knows the compact exists," Doumbia said. "The chamber does not know that the compact answers a complaint of administrative irregularity. Make the connection, if you can make it."

"The De Grosvenor compact is older than this chamber and older than the procedures the complaint invokes and older than the Bureau in the form that now governs appointments," Eleanor said. "It is the agreement under which my house serves the throne. It has spanned three imperial generations. It has survived three crises before this one, and in each of the three, one party extended to the other a trust the other had not yet formally earned, because the compact was built on the understanding that there would be hours the standing procedure could not reach, and that in those hours the house would act, and the throne would judge the acting afterward, and the judging would be the throne's and no one else's. That is what the compact is for. It is not for the seasons when the procedures

work. In the seasons when the procedures work, the house does nothing the procedures cannot do, and the compact sleeps. The compact wakes when the procedures have been turned against the thing they were built to protect, and a hand is needed that the captured procedures cannot reach to stop, and the throne reaches for the house, because the house is the hand the compact built for exactly that hour."

"And you hold that this was such an hour."

"I hold that the procedures the complaint invokes as my measure were the very procedures the apparatus I investigated had captured and was using," Eleanor said. "The carry-forward reconciliation is a procedure. The authorization category the correction pass ran under is a procedure. The charter that would have had to authorize an inquiry into the Bureau is a charter the Bureau grants, and the Bureau, at the level that grants it, was the thing under inquiry. I could not have gone to the Bureau for a charter to investigate the Bureau without the charter reaching the desk of the man I was investigating, who would have read the request the way he had read every request for thirty years, and stopped it, and known. The complaint says I proceeded without the charter. It is true. The charter was held by the hand I was reaching for. To ask permission was to warn the thing. The procedures were not available to me, because the thing I was investigating governed the procedures, and that is not an accident of my case. It is the shape of every case the compact was built to answer, and it is the reason the compact was set to run beside the procedures rather than through them, with the throne as the only judge of whether the hour was real."

The room held it. High in the clerestory a pigeon shifted on a ledge and the small scrape of it carried down into the bare chamber and was gone. The light had moved a hand's width across the stone floor while Eleanor spoke and now lay across the foot of the single chair, and she sat in the edge of it and did not shift out of it.

"You are arguing," Dombia said slowly, "that the chamber cannot find against you on the complaint's terms because the complaint's terms are the wrong terms. That the conduct should be measured against the compact, and that the compact reserves the judging of it to the throne, and that this chamber, weighing it against administrative procedure, is weighing it in a frame the compact was designed to override."

"I am arguing that," Eleanor said. "I am arguing it knowing the chamber may not have the authority to accept it, and that if the chamber does not have the authority to accept it, the chamber will find against me, because inside the only frame the chamber is competent to apply, the complaint is sound, and an honest arbiter applying the only frame she is given will find the thing the frame compels. I am not asking you to be dishonest. I am telling you that the frame you have been handed produces the wrong answer, and that the right answer lives in a frame above your bench, and that whether the right answer is ever reached depends on whether anyone with the standing to lift the matter into that frame chooses to do so before your finding goes up. That is not in my hands. It was never going to be in my hands. I knew that when I directed the collection, and I directed it anyway, because the hour was real and the compact is not a thing you invoke only when you are certain it will save you."

"You knew you might be sitting in that chair."

"I knew I would be sitting in this chair, or in one like it," Eleanor said. "There was no version of what I did that did not end here. The marshal told me himself, across a table I built so neither of us could reach the other, that my house had been named before I moved, and he was right, and I had priced the chair before he said it. I am eighty years old. I have spent sixty of those years learning what the procedures can and cannot reach, and I directed an inquiry into the place where they had been captured, and I did it through the only frame that authorized me to do it, which is the compact, and I will answer for it in the frame that authorized it and not in the frame that did not. If the chamber finds against me, the chamber will be correct within its competence and wrong above it, and I will have known both things going in, and I do not ask the chamber to spare me the finding. I ask the record to show that I did not hide what I did, that I claimed the frame I acted under, and that I claimed it on the morning I had the most to lose by claiming it, when it would have been easier to plead the charter I never had and let the chamber pity an old woman who had overreached. I did not overreach. I reached exactly as far as the compact reaches, into the hour the compact was built for, and I will not call it less than that to soften a finding."

She stopped. She had not raised her voice once. She had not bent toward the bench, had not gestured, had not reached for the cane, and the stillness of her in the center of the exposed floor was the thing the room had been built to break and had not broken, and on the forward bench Kaviel sat with her hands flat on her knees and her eyes on her mother's back and did not move, and the not moving was the hardest work she had done in the case and no one in the chamber would ever enter it on a record.

Doumbia was quiet a moment. She looked at the file and did not open it. When she spoke it was to the record and not to Eleanor.

"The chamber notes the answer," she said. "The respondent does not contest the facts of the first or the second allegation and grants the facts of the third. The respondent contests the characterization of those facts as abuse, as unauthorized, and as irregular, and grounds the contest in the De Grosvenor compact, asserting that the proper frame for the conduct is the compact rather than standing administrative procedure, and that the compact reserves the judgment of such conduct to the throne." She paused, and the pause was the careful pause of a person setting down a thing exactly, neither more nor less than it was. "The chamber observes that the question of whether the compact may displace administrative procedure as the frame of review is a question that exceeds the competence of this oversight authority to decide, and that the chamber cannot find on the complaint without first deciding it. The chamber will not pretend to a competence it does not hold."

It was the most she could give, and Eleanor knew it was the most she could give, and she received it sitting in the edge of the moved light with her hands folded and her face giving nothing, and she understood that the arbiter had just done a careful and honest thing, which was to refuse to dress the question smaller than it was so that her own bench could answer it. Doumbia had set the question where it had to go. She had not sent it there. She had only declined to keep it from going.

"This review is adjourned," Doumbia said, "pending formal consideration of the question of frame, which the chamber will refer upward in the ordinary course unless that course is itself displaced by an authority competent to displace it. The respondent is not detained. The complaint stands on the docket. The findings remain as the extraordinary authority

left them. The chamber thanks the respondent for the clarity of her answer." She rose. "We are adjourned."

The chamber rose with her. Eleanor put both hands to the head of the cane and brought herself up, and it took the weight the way it took the weight now, slowly, and she did not hurry it and no one in the room moved to help her, and she gained her feet and stood a moment finding her balance in the center of the floor before she turned. Doumbia had already gone through the door behind the bench. The benches were emptying behind the rail, the few with standing rising and filing out in the low murmur of people who had watched a thing they were not sure they had understood the size of, and Eleanor crossed the open floor toward the rail at her own pace, the cane on the stone, and at the rail Kaviel was standing, having risen with the chamber, waiting on the near side, and she did not speak, because she still could not, because the term that governed her morning did not lift at the adjournment, it lifted when they were out of the building, and they both knew it, and so Kaviel said nothing and held the gate of the rail open the width it opened and let her mother through it.

They went out together, the old woman on the cane and the daughter beside her at the pace the cane set, through the door of the chamber and along the pale stone corridor that had fed it and down the wide shallow stair, and Sefu fell in behind them at the foot of the stair without a word and stayed the careful three steps back that was his whole life's distance, and the three of them crossed the cold entrance hall where the morning came in gray through the tall doors and smelled of wet stone and the dust of an old building and, faintly, the iron of the rain that had started while they were inside. Neither woman spoke in the hall. They did not speak through the doors. They came out onto the broad step of the administrative court into the thin cold rain, and the noise of the district came up to meet them, the engines and the wheels and the wet rush of a city going on with its morning, and Eleanor stopped on the step under the lip of the portico where the rain did not reach, and stood with both hands on the cane, and looked out at the gray wet square, and only then, with the building behind them and the open air in front, did she let the morning be over.

Kaviel stood beside her on the step. The rain came down on the square. A clerk hurried across it with a folder held over his head against the wet, and a transit car hissed past at the far edge. Eleanor watched the rain a while, and Kaviel watched the rain, and the distance between them on the step was the same distance it had always been, the careful width the work required, and neither of them moved to close it, because closing it was not a thing either of them knew how to do and they had stopped pretending, long ago, that they did not know that about each other.

"Sefu will bring the car to the south door," Eleanor said at last, to the rain. "The step is wet."

"I'll walk you to it," Kaviel said.

"I know," Eleanor said.

She set the cane forward onto the dry stone under the portico and started along it toward the south door at her own pace, and Kaviel went with her, the careful width between them held, and behind them Sefu went down the wet step into the rain to bring the car around, and the rain beaded on the cold dark stone of the court that weighed the administration against itself, and the cane set its even sound on the dry stone under the portico, and the two women walked it together toward the south door.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

Amira Acts

THE OVERSIGHT CHAMBER HAD been built to hear the institution judge itself, and everything in it served that single purpose. It sat on the third floor of the Hall of Establishments, reached by a stair of worn imperial stone, and its proportions were the proportions of a room that wanted no one in it to feel larger than the procedure. The ceiling was low for so formal a space, a flat coffered field of dark wood that pressed the sound downward and held it. The arbiter's bench ran across the head of the room, plain heavy timber gone the color of strong tea with a century of oil and handling, and before it stood the two tables for the parties, set at a width measured so that neither could be said to face the bench from the place of advantage. The benches for the few who were permitted to attend ran along the side walls, narrow, hard, made for sitting upright. High along the courtyard side a row of clerestory windows let in the angled light of late afternoon, and the light fell in bars across the floor and across the empty center of the room and warmed nothing, because the chamber was stone under its wood and held the cold of the building the way the whole Hall held it.

They had come back into the chamber to hear the arbiter set the date of the formal review, and that was all the morning had been meant to be. The proceeding against Eleanor De Grosvenor had run its first session the day before and adjourned without resolution, the complaint laid, the answer given, the matter taken under the arbiter's hand to be weighed in the slow time such weighing took. Eleanor sat at the table on the left,

where the answering party sat, with the cane standing against the table's edge and her hands folded over the head of it, and she had not poured the water set out at her elbow. Kaviel stood behind her at the wall, in the place the proceeding allowed her, present and not permitted to speak, with the stillness on her that she had worn through the whole of the first session, a stillness that gave a watcher nothing and that Eleanor did not turn to read because she did not need to read it.

Arbiter Sabel Doumbia sat at the bench with the file of the proceeding squared before her. She was a spare woman of late middle years, dark and close-cropped and unhurried, who had conducted oversight reviews for two decades and conducted them the same way each time, as a body of work the parties passed through rather than a contest she presided over. She had heard the complaint without leaning toward it and heard the answer without leaning toward it, and she had adjourned the first session on a clean notation and meant to open this one the same way, with the setting of a date and the assignment of the file to formal review. She had drawn the breath to speak it.

The chamber doors opened at the foot of the room.

They opened without the announcement that preceded any ordinary arrival, because the household that would have made the announcement had been left below, and so the first thing the room knew of it was the sound, the two leaves of the door drawn back on their hinges and the fall of footsteps on the stone that did not belong to any clerk of the establishment. Doumbia did not finish the breath. The few on the side benches turned. And the Empress of the Trinitarian Throne came up the center of the chamber, alone at the front of it, in the formal robes of the dais and not the working robes she wore to the rooms without windows, and behind her at the precise distance the throne kept walked two she had brought and no more.

The room changed as she crossed it. It was a thing that happened in the sound of the place before it happened in anything a person could point to, the low held hush of the coffered ceiling shifting under the weight of who had entered it, the way a struck bell changes the air of a room it is rung in. The bars of clerestory light lay across the floor and the Empress walked through them and the dust turned in the disturbed air behind her. She did not look to the side benches. She did not look to the

table on the left where Eleanor sat. She came to the open center of the chamber, before the bench and between the two tables, and she stopped there, and the footsteps behind her stopped, and the chamber that had been built to hold the institution judging itself held instead the arrival of the authority the institution answered to, and the difference in it was the difference between a room and the same room with the floor dropped out from under its assumptions.

Doumbia rose. She rose without haste, because haste was not in her, and she inclined her head the depth the bench gave the Throne, and she remained standing, because no one sat at a bench while the Empress stood before it.

"Majesty," Doumbia said. "This is a proceeding under oversight review. It is adjourned to a date not yet set." She said it as a fact the Empress would wish established, the standing of the room, the authority under which it sat, the place in its own process it had reached. She did not say more. She had conducted reviews for twenty years and she had never had a sovereign come up the center of her chamber, and she set the fact of the proceeding down between them the way a careful officer sets down the ground before anything is built on it.

"I know what it is," Amira said. "I have read the complaint. I have read the answer. I have read the notation under which you adjourned it yesterday, and the authority under which this chamber sits, and the schedule of the review you were about to set." Her voice carried in the low room without lifting, pitched for the coffered ceiling that pressed sound down, and it reached the side benches and the back of the chamber and the table on the left without seeming to reach for them. "I have come to remove the matter from this chamber's hands. I will tell you the ground of it, and the instrument, and the body it goes to, and you will enter what I give you on the record of your proceeding, because the record is yours to keep and what I am doing belongs in it."

Behind her, the two she had brought stood at the distance. One was a clerk of the Throne who carried the second sealed copy of the instrument and would enter the hour of it on the Throne's own record. The other was a senior Lioness operative in the plain dark of the Quarter, a tall woman with a soldier's stillness who had come to witness and to be seen to witness, Meret, who carried the incident as the house would record it and

whose presence in the chamber meant that what passed here passed under the eye of the apparatus and would be held in its account. She did not move and did not speak. She stood where the Empress had placed her and watched the room the way Silva watched a periphery, and the watching was the function.

Amira drew from within the formal robe a single folded sheet. The room knew the stock of it. It was the stock the Throne used for instruments that bore no scribe's countersignature, heavy and unmarked, and she had carried it folded along its single square crease since she left the quarters two levels below the records floor, and she unfolded it now in the bars of light and did not read from it, because she had written it in her own hand and did not need to read it, and she held it open so the bench could see that it was written and sealed.

"The matter this chamber was convened to hear," she said, "is a complaint against the head of the De Grosvenor house. Abuse of intelligence authority. Surveillance of a senior official without sanction. Procedural violation in the conduct of an inquiry. The complaint is partially true, and the arbiter has weighed it as such, and the arbiter would have weighed it honestly, because the arbiter is honest, and that is not the difficulty." She let the sentence set. "The difficulty is the senior official. The complaint asks this chamber to judge the conduct of an inquiry into the Marshal of the Bureau of Establishments. This chamber sits under the Hall of Establishments. The review it would assign runs through offices the marshal's authority reaches. The instrument that brought the complaint was drawn in the establishment and authenticated in the establishment, and the establishment is the thing the inquiry was inquiring into. A proceeding cannot judge the inquiry into the body the proceeding belongs to. It can only protect that body, whether it means to or not, and this one, run to its end, would protect it."

Doumbia stood very still at the bench. She had conducted reviews for twenty years and she had read the shape of this one and logged the shape of it privately and gone on conducting it because conducting it was her office, and she heard now the thing she had not let herself name laid open in the center of her own chamber by the only authority that could lay it open and survive the laying. She did not protest it. She was not built to

protest a true thing. She inclined her head a fraction, the smallest motion, granting the ground.

"I invoke the emergency prerogative of the Throne," Amira said.

The words went into the low room and the low room held them, and on the side benches a man who knew the establishment well enough to know what the words meant drew a breath he did not finish, and the small involuntary sound of it was loud in the pressed quiet. The prerogative had not been spoken aloud in a chamber of the establishment in the memory of anyone sitting in it. It was the instrument that ran above the establishment because it answered to no desk within it, the authority of the Empress alone to suspend the ordinary process of the imperial body, and it had lain unused for thirty-one years, long enough that the men who governed under it had come to govern as though it were not there, as though the ordinary process were the whole of the reach of the Throne, and the speaking of it now told every person in the chamber that the ordinary process had been judged unequal to the thing it was meant to correct and had been set aside by the one hand that could set it aside.

"Under the prerogative," Amira said, "I suspend this proceeding. Not its record, which stands, and not its arbiter, whose conduct I have no fault to find in. The proceeding. The complaint against the head of the De Grosvenor house, and the matter it arises from, and the inquiry it sought to judge, are removed from the oversight authority of the establishment as of the entering of this notation." She turned the open sheet a degree toward the bench. "I have constituted a Throne Court of Inquiry. It sits under the prerogative, outside the Hall of Establishments, outside the reach of any office implicated in the matter it will hear. The complete evidentiary record of the inquiry is lodged with it, the appointments and the financial mechanism beneath them and the reach of the office that protected both, documented and sealed three days ago. The Marshal of the Bureau of Establishments is subject to its jurisdiction from this hour. So is every officer named in the record. So is the conduct of the inquiry itself, which the court will examine on the same footing as the conduct it was inquiring into, because a court that will not examine its own instrument is the thing I am dismantling and I will not build another."

She came forward to the bench and laid the sheet on the timber before Doumbia, squared to the edge the way the house squared everything, and she did not let go of it at once. She held it a moment under her flat hand on the worn dark wood, the way a person rests a hand on a thing before she commits it, and the bars of light from the clerestory lay across the back of her hand and across the heavy unmarked stock with its seal pressed into the foot of it that no other hand in the imperium could press. Then she lifted her hand, and the instrument lay on the bench, entered, and the lifting of the hand was the act that could not be unwrought, and she had laid each stroke of it knowing that, two levels below the records floor, in the even shadowless light, and she did not flinch over the laying of it here any more than she had flinched over the writing of it there.

"It is irreversible," she said, to Doumbia, and to the chamber through Doumbia, because the chamber needed to hear the cost said plainly by the one who carried it. "An act under the prerogative cannot be appealed within the establishment, because it does not arise within the establishment. It can be judged only by the reign that follows mine, reading the record I have made, deciding whether the Empress who set aside the ordinary process had cause. I have made the record so that the cause is in it. I have not made it so that the judgment is easy. If there is support behind the marshal that the inquiry did not map, support in this Hall or above it, this is the hour it shows itself, because this is the hour the protection runs out and the men who relied on it must decide whether to be seen relying on it still. I have come into the open to find out. I would rather find out here, in a chamber with a record, than in the dark where the establishment prefers its difficulties settled."

The chamber held. No one rose from the side benches. The man who had drawn the unfinished breath sat with his hands flat on his knees and looked at the floor where the light lay, and the others sat as he sat, and the stillness that came over them was the stillness of people doing the arithmetic the Empress had set them, the count of which way the weight had moved and whether any of them had a reason to be seen moving against it, and none of them did, or none would own to it in a room where the Throne stood in the open and the house watched from the wall. The thing the faction had built had depended on the ordinary process running quietly through offices it reached. The Empress had taken the

matter out of the ordinary process and into the light of a court that reached nothing the faction held, and there was no procedural seam left to work, no half-hour to be raced, no challenge to be authenticated in a registry, because the prerogative answered to no registry. The elegant fast moves were spent. What remained was the record, lodged with a court the marshal could not touch, and the marshal subject to it, and the chamber full of men who understood that the ground had shifted under the establishment and that the shift had been made by the one authority entitled to make it and entered on a record their successors would read.

Doumbia looked down at the sheet on her bench. She read it once, the whole of it, in the unhurried way she read everything, and what she read was sound. The invocation was within the prerogative. The constitution of the court was within the prerogative. The transfer was clean and the record was lodged and the cost was the Empress's and stated in the Empress's own hand. There was nothing in it for an arbiter to weigh, because the arbiter's authority ended where the prerogative began, and the prerogative had begun. She squared the sheet to the file of her own proceeding, joining the two, the record of the chamber and the instrument that closed it, and she set her hand flat on the joined papers as the Empress had set hers, marking the entering of it on the proceeding she kept.

"It is entered," Doumbia said. "The proceeding is suspended on the authority of the Throne. The matter passes to the court named in the instrument. The record of this chamber notes the hour and the authority and the transfer, and the record will say that the proceeding was conducted to its adjournment without fault found in any party before it, and that the transfer arises from the authority of the prerogative and not from any failing of this chamber, because that is the truth of it and the record I keep keeps the truth." She inclined her head to the bench's full depth. "Majesty. The chamber is yours to close."

Amira looked at her a moment, and there was in the looking the nearest the room would come to acknowledgment, one honest officer marking another across a thing that had cost them both something to do correctly. Then it passed, and the Empress was only the Empress in a suspended chamber with the light going long across the floor.

She had not looked at the table on the left through any of it. She looked at it now. Eleanor De Grosvenor sat where the answering party sat, her hands folded over the head of the cane, and she had not moved through the whole of it, had not poured the water, had not turned to read Kaviel at the wall behind her, and she met the Empress's look across the open center of the chamber and held it. Nothing passed between them that a watcher could have named. There was no word, no nod, no softening on either face. There was the old measuring, the two of them taking each other's measure across a room the way they had taken it across the low table in the small reception room with the unwatched garden window, the house and the throne reading each other once more because the reading changed and a year-old reading was a dangerous thing to govern by. Eleanor had walked into the neutral room alone and spent the trust forward and written the cost into her own column, and the Empress had been bound by it after the fact the way the compact was built to bind her, and had carried the matter into the open and set aside the ordinary process and made herself answerable for it to the reign that would follow. The house had laid the table. The Throne had decided what was eaten from it. Neither of them said so, because neither of them needed to, and the not-saying was the compact operating as it had operated for three generations, trust spent and obligation taken up, the whole of it present in a look across a chamber and none of it on the record but the instrument on the bench.

Amira turned from the table. She turned without hurry and without a backward glance at the woman she had just bound her reign to defend, because the look had been the whole of it and a second look would have been less. She crossed the open center of the chamber toward the doors at the foot of it, through the bars of clerestory light, and Meret fell in behind her at the distance the house kept, and the chamber that had held the institution judging itself held now the Empress leaving it under her own authority with the matter taken up into her own hand.

At the foot of the chamber Eleanor rose. She rose on the cane, slower than she had risen a year before, using it now where she had held it ready, and Kaviel came off the wall and stood beside her, and the two of them turned to follow the Empress out, because the proceeding was closed and there was no reason left to stay in a chamber that no longer

held them. Doumbia stood at her bench above the joined papers. The few on the side benches sat where they had sat.

Amira went out through the doors and into the corridor where the light came in from the windows over the freight terraces, and Eleanor and Kaviel came behind her, the Empress ahead and the head of the house and her daughter following, the distance between the three of them held exact, the length of the corridor running out before them in the long afternoon light, the loading engines below sending up through the stone the low vibration that never stopped.

INTERLUDE 5

The Courtier's Testimony (Excerpt)

What follows is excerpted verbatim from the sworn statement of Councilor Hadi Marun, taken under the authority of the Throne Court of Inquiry and entered into the formal prosecution record. I have abridged only where the testimony repeats matters established elsewhere in this account.

A. Khan, compiler

THRONE COURT OF INQUIRY

In the matter of the Bureau of Establishments and the Third Appointments Commission

Transcript of testimony given by Councillor Hadi Marun, under obligation, the deposing arbiter recording.

EXCERPT BEGINS.

ARBITER: State your office and your years of service.

MARUN: Councillor of the imperial court. Twenty-two years in service, eleven of them at the level of council. Before that I sat as a clerk to the Magistracy of the Inner Wards. My training is in administrative law. I say this so the court understands that I knew what the documents were when I touched them. I was not a man out of his depth. I want that on the record before anything else.

ARBITER: Describe how you were approached.

MARUN: There was no approach in the way the word suggests. No one came to my rooms in a hood. The first contact reached me by sealed correspondence, routed so that I could not trace its origin without effort I chose not to make. I understood from the wording that the sender knew my position, my debts, and the matter of the seat I had expected and had not received. The letter did not threaten me. It described a service and what the service would be worth. I read it twice. Then I answered it.

ARBITER: You answered in the affirmative.

MARUN: I did. I sealed my reply myself. No one held my hand to the wax. The court should not look for a moment when I was trapped, because there was none. There was a winter when I was tired and angry at a decision that had gone against me, a letter arrived that treated my anger as a reasonable thing, and I agreed to be useful. The smallness of it is the part I would change. It was a Tuesday. The seal smelled of the same lamp oil I had used for a decade.

ARBITER: Describe the service you provided.

MARUN: I authenticated documents. That was the whole of it, and it was enough. When an appointment had to be entered into the regional record under a carry-forward reconciliation, the entry needed a councillor's confirmation that the prior authority was sound. I gave that confirmation. I did not forge the appointments. I did not move the money, and at the time I did not know there was money to move. I confirmed that paper was in order when I had reason to believe it was not, and my confirmation made it real to every clerk downstream who trusted my office. A false thing becomes true when a man of standing signs beneath it. That was my function. I was the standing.

ARBITER: Name the contacts in the network known to you.

MARUN: I will name what I know and mark plainly what I only inferred, because the court deserves the difference. I knew a courier by the surname Beyé. Rashid Beyé. He carried sealed material between the regional offices and the points where it needed to be. I met him twice and would not have recognized him a third time; he was built to be forgotten. I knew of a deputy registrar at the Adwa office, Mokoena, by the pattern of his entries before I ever knew his name. We did not correspond. We were two hands of the same body that never touched.

ARBITER: And above them.

MARUN: Above them I inferred a single authority. I never had a name from any letter. But the authorizations that came down to me carried a category of seal that only a marshal of the Bureau could command, and the reach of the corrections crossed jurisdictions no lesser office could touch. A man in my work learns to read a hand by its weight. I knew the weight of that one. I will not pretend before this court that I was surprised when I learned whose it was.

ARBITER: When did you understand the full scope of what you served?

MARUN: Late. Later than I should admit. I told myself for years that I was confirming paper, that the harm was abstract, that the prefectures would absorb a few crooked magistrates as they had absorbed worse. I did not let myself add the entries together, because the sum was a thing I did not want to hold. I understood the scope on the day I was asked to authenticate the challenge against the investigation itself. That was the first time the work asked me to defend it rather than feed it. I authenticated the challenge. I want that recorded too. I did the wrong thing even after I understood, and then I sat in my rooms and waited to be found, which is its own kind of confession and not a brave one.

ARBITER: Is there anything you wish to add for the record.

MARUN: Only this. I was offered a different path once, years ago, by a colleague who is honest and never knew what I had become. I think of her. I am not asking the court for mercy and I am not asking it to understand me. I committed these acts as a competent man who knew the law, and I will answer for them as one. Let the record show that I did not weep and I did not blame the letter.

EXCERPT ENDS.

Sworn and recorded under the seal of the Throne Court of Inquiry, the eleventh day of the second imperial quarter. Filed to the prosecution record under judicial seal reference TCI-04-0117.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

After the Storm

THE INCENSE HAD BEEN lit at the fourth hour, as it was lit on every working morning, and by the time the first matter came forward the smoke had settled into the high vaulting the way it always settled, and given up trying to rise. Amira sat in it. The overrobe held its own shape across her shoulders, the metal thread stiff along the seams, and she let it hold her, as she had learned to let it. The marble ran in long bands of polish before the dais. Through the polish, where the light from the eastern clerestory struck it, the old repair lines showed, the seams where the floor had been broken and laid again across four hundred years of audiences. Nothing in the room had changed. That was the first thing a careful eye would have read, and the wrong thing, because the room had been through something, and the rooms that have been through something wear it in what they have decided not to show.

Three weeks had passed since the chamber on the third floor of the Hall of Establishments had heard the floor drop out from under its assumptions. In those three weeks the Throne Court of Inquiry had taken the file and begun its slow exact work; Lord Marshal Tewodros Marek had been formally charged before it, his authority over the Bureau of Establishments suspended pending the inquiry's finding; and the financial mechanism that had run for seven years beneath the appointments fraud was being taken apart channel by channel by people who understood that a wrong move would send the resources fleeing to jurisdictions the prerogative could not reach. None of that was in the throne room this

morning. The throne room held a court that had to keep governing while the inquiry governed the men who had governed it wrongly, and the keeping was the work, and Amira had come to do the work.

She heard the first matter through. A boundary dispute out of the river prefectures, two estates and a shifted channel and a question of which bank now owned the silt the river had moved. She asked the Clerk for the date of the original survey, and when Obasi found it she asked who had certified it, and when the certifier proved to be an office rather than a man she ordered a fresh survey under the prefect's seal and held the matter open against its return. The estates withdrew, neither satisfied, neither cheated. That was the work, and it was the same work it had been before the crisis, and she did it the same way, because a court watching for a tremor in the throne would find none.

But the court was watching for the tremor. She could feel it the way she could feel the cold come up through the marble a stride to either side of the warm band of light. The hall this morning held perhaps two hundred and fifty, a fuller working session than usual, and the fullness itself was a message; men who had let a clerk attend their business for a season had decided to attend it themselves, to be seen attending it, to be in the room while the room settled into whatever it was going to be. Faces dark and faces darker along the standing rails, the broad cheekbones of the steppe-blood and the long southern lines mixed through as they had always been mixed, the court that looked like the empire because the empire had made it. And under the polite attention to the boundary survey ran the other attention, the recalculation, the quiet arithmetic of people working out where the weight had moved and whether any of it had come loose near them.

Obasi read the second matter into the room, a question of a guild charter, and Amira heard it, and in the interval before she ruled she let her gaze cross the western wall, where the colonnade ran back into the administrative passages, and found Kaviel there in the dark working coat, hands behind her, attention moving over the hall in its slow circuit. The room registered her the way it registered a load-bearing column. Amira's gaze passed over her without stopping, which was how both of them preferred it. Then her gaze crossed the band of shadow behind the screen, set back of the dais, where the plain chair had been carried in.

Eleanor sat in it.

She sat as she always sat, with the stillness of the very old, her hands folded over the head of the cane she did not strictly need, her eyes half-lidded in the smoke. From the body of the hall she was furniture, an old administrator placed where the room could feel her without being asked to attend to her. And she was furniture in a way she had not been before, and Amira saw it, because Amira had spent four years learning to read the one chair in the room she never turned to look at. The stillness was the same stillness. What had gone out of it was the current under the surface, the direction, the thing that made Eleanor's silence a held attention pointed at one corner of the room while the rest of her rested. This morning the silence had no current. Eleanor watched the hall, and the watching cost her, and she had less to spend, and she was spending it the way a person spends from a purse she now has to count. The chin did not come up at the second matter, or the third. The attention did not gather and point. It rested, because resting was what was left.

Amira ruled on the guild charter and did not turn toward the shadow and did not, by any motion the hall could read, mark what she had seen. She had crossed to Eleanor in open court exactly twice in five years and had decided after the second time that she would not do it again, and that decision held this morning the way it had held through everything, because the compact bought the throne the right to feel the old woman in the room without the Empress ever appearing to need her, and the crisis had not bought it back. She set what she had seen where the throne set such things, in the place she kept the matters she could not act on in session and could not afford to forget.

Obasi read the third matter.

"A petition of the Sennar Prefecture," he said, "brought by the prefectural assembly, touching the confirmation of magistrates seated under carry-forward reconciliation during the past four sessions."

It was the crisis come up out of the floor and into the open court, dressed in the clothes of ordinary business, and the hall knew it, and the polite half-attention along the standing rails sharpened into the held quiet of a room that has decided to listen and not be seen listening. The Sennar assembly had sent a delegation, three of them, a senior holder of orchard land at their head, and they came forward into the cut light below the

dais and went down, and the eldest spoke. He did not contest the throne's authority. He asked, with the care of a man who knew he was asking it in front of the whole court, what was to become of the rulings of magistrates whose confirmations the inquiry was now examining, and whether the men and women of Sennar who had won or lost before those benches stood now on judgments that would hold.

It was the right question, and a hard one, and Amira had known it would come, because she had spent part of three weeks deciding how she would answer it when it did. She let the silence sit a moment. The censer-bearer crossed below the dais on soft feet to feed the nearest brazier, and the incense thickened, sweet and resinous over the flat mineral cold of the stone, and caught at the back of her throat the way it caught every morning, and she made no sign of it.

"The inquiry examines the confirmations," she said. "It does not examine the rulings. A magistrate wrongly seated may yet have ruled rightly on the water that crosses one man's ground to another's, and a magistrate rightly seated may have ruled badly, and the throne does not pretend that the soundness of a judgment follows from the cleanliness of the appointment that produced the bench. Every ruling of a questioned confirmation stands until a party to it brings the throne cause to review the ruling itself, on its own ground, and not on the ground of the magistrate's seating. The seating is the throne's affair and the inquiry's. The ruling is the litigant's, and the litigant who was wronged in law has the door he always had. I will not throw out four sessions of Sennar's judgments to punish four sessions of Sennar's appointments. The prefecture will not be made to relitigate its whole life because the Bureau was made to relitigate its honesty."

She paused, and let that reach the standing rails, and then she gave them the rest of it, because the rest of it was the consolidation and the court needed to hear the throne speak it plainly.

"The carry-forward reconciliation is suspended across the Outer Prefectures," she said. "It will not be used again as it was used. Confirmation by carry-forward required no fresh review, and that absence is what the fraud lived in, and the absence is closed. The Bureau of Establishments will seat appointments under a new oversight, answerable past the Bureau, the form of it to be entered into the record

within the month under the Throne's hand. Until it is seated, no appointment moves in the Outer Prefectures except under direct review. The backlog will grow. The throne would rather carry a backlog than carry a fraud, and the prefectures will be told as much in plain words, so that no holder of orchard land waits a year for a confirmation and reads the waiting as the throne's neglect when it is the throne's care."

The Sennar delegation pressed their hands together and made their obeisance and withdrew, and the eldest of them backed the three required steps out of the cut light with the look of a man who had come for less and been given more than he had dared to frame, and the cold came up around the three of them as they crossed out of the warm band, and the sound of their going came back off the high stone for the length of it. Along the standing rails the held quiet let itself out into the small shiftings and settlings of a court that has heard the thing it came to hear and now knows the shape of the season. Talk would have been a discourtesy the throne could mark, and the rails kept to the shiftings.

That was the consolidation, and it was done, and Amira felt it land the way she had felt the nothing land in this room before, as a layer of changed water rising from below.

Obasi read the fourth matter, and the fifth, the ordinary business of a working session, a customs review and a charter and a question of a bridge toll, and the court resettled toward the ordinary the way a body settles toward sleep after a fright, slowly, with a part of it still listening. Amira ruled each in its turn and gave none of them less than its due, because a court that saw the throne hurry the small business after the large would learn that the throne had favorites among its matters, and the lesson she meant the court to take from this morning was the opposite one, that the throne ruled the bridge toll with the same attention it ruled the Bureau, and that the attention had not been spent down by the crisis any more than the marble had been worn through by the feet that crossed it.

It was during the fifth matter that Councillor Imani Tau came forward.

She held no business on the register; she came in the interval, in the way the court permitted a councillor of standing to approach between matters, and she made her bow to the throne with exactly the depth the

floor required and not a fraction more, which was its own kind of statement in a room where the fractions were being read. She was a spare upright woman past fifty, dark, close in her bearing, and she had sat the council through the whole of the crisis without ever having been any part of the thing the crisis was about, and she carried that now, the carrying of a person who had been in the building while it was being robbed and had not seen the robbery, and who had decided that the honest answer to not having seen was to come and stand where the throne could see her and say so without saying it.

"Majesty," she said. "The river charter the throne held this morning. The river prefectures will want to know whether the new survey runs under the old seal or a fresh one."

"A fresh one," Amira said. "The prefect's, and certified by name and not by office. The throne has had enough of certifications that no man's hand stands behind." She let that sit between them, and Imani Tau heard the second thing in it, the thing under the river survey, and did not flinch from it.

"There will be more of that asked, Majesty," she said. "Names where offices used to do. The council will want to know how far the throne means to take it."

"As far as it goes," Amira said. "The council will find that the throne means to be answered by people and not by stamps, and the council will find it tiresome, and the council will do it, because the alternative was tried for seven years and the throne has read the bill." She inclined her head a degree. "You did not see it, Councillor. Nor did most of this hall. The throne does not hold that against the people who were not looking where the fraud was hidden, because the fraud was built to be where no honest person was looking. It holds it against the people who built the hiding. Go back to your seat. When the new oversight comes before the council you will read it closely, because you are one of the readers the throne trusts to be tired in the right places."

Imani Tau understood that she had been given something, the throne's word that the honest majority would not be made to pay for the dishonest few, and she understood that she had been given a charge with it, and she made her bow and went back along the rail to her place, and the going of her was watched by a good part of the hall, because the hall had been

waiting to learn how the throne would hold the people who had merely failed to see, and now it knew, and the knowing ran along the rails the way the earlier quiet had run.

The morning went on. The light had moved a hand's breadth along the marble while the Sennar delegation spoke, so that the warm band fell now a little nearer the dais than it had, and the smoke hung in the vaulting, and the throne ruled and the court believed itself watched, and the work pressed down through the metal-threaded brocade with the weight Amira had long since stopped mistaking for the weight of the cloth. She did not look to the band of shadow again. Once, in the interval before the last matter, she let her gaze cross the western wall, and Kaviel was where she had been, and her circuit had slowed, and twice in the morning it had passed the band of shadow behind the screen and held there a half-beat longer than a column's eye would hold, and Amira marked that Kaviel had marked her mother, and put it where the rest went.

Obasi read the last matter and Amira ruled it, and then the Clerk of Petitions closed the register, and the under-clerk dipped his pen and wrote the closing minute, and the soft scratch of it carried up into the smoke and was lost, and the court rose with the long exhale of two hundred and fifty people lifting themselves off their feet at once, and the rising ran the length of the hall and broke against the high cold ceiling. Amira held them a breath longer than they expected, the way she held them, and then she gave the dismissal, and the court began to empty.

She did not rise with it. A ruler who left while the court was leaving gave the court a back to talk about; she had learned in her first year to let the room go before her, to sit the throne while the hall drained, so that the last thing the leaving court carried out the doors was the throne still in its place, attending, unmoved. So she sat, and watched the room empty.

It emptied the way the hall always emptied, slowly and then all at once, the delegations going in the order of their precedence and the precedence dissolving near the western doors into the ordinary press of people who had business elsewhere. The Sennar delegation went, and the river estates, and Imani Tau among the council, and the standing rails thinned, and the door-wardens in their formal gray stood the watch and passed them through. Eleanor's chair, when Amira let her gaze cross the

band of shadow a final time, stood empty; the old woman had been helped up and out during the last matter, earlier than she would have left before the crisis, and the plain chair waited to be carried out, and the place where she had sat was a place again. Kaviel was gone from the western wall, gone out behind her mother in the working coat, and the column the room had registered was registered now only by its absence.

The servers came in behind the leaving to ready the hall for the afternoon, and the household began to put out the lamps it did not need through the daylight hours, quenching the long rows in order from the head of the hall toward the doors. The smell of the morning's incense went stale and flat as the braziers were let to die, the sweet resin collapsing into the single tired smell of a room where a great deal had been decided and the high windows did not open. The great room that had held two hundred and fifty pockets of attention gave the air back to the ceiling and grew still.

Amira rose then, when the hall was nearly empty, and came down the two steps of the dais onto the marble, onto the warm band where the eastern light still fell, and stood a moment in it with the cold waiting a stride to either side. The overrobe held her up. She let it.

At the foot of the eastern wall, in the lee of the colonnade, where the household had set a small side table apart from the working benches, a single lamp had been left burning. She had ordered it set there that morning, before the court, in the way she ordered the small things that the court would never see and that were not for the court. A table laid for one. A cup, a plate, the small folded card the household used to mark a seating. Once, in the autumn of her first hard year, such a table had been laid in such a place at a dinner for the court, set for someone the throne had reason to want present and could not name, and the someone had not come, and the household had found the table at the end of the night with the food untouched and the cup unpoured and one lamp left burning over it, and the place had stayed in Amira's keeping the way the nothings stayed.

This table was not empty. The cup had been poured. The plate had been eaten from, the meal taken plainly and without ceremony by a person who had sat at the small table in the lee of the colonnade through part of the morning and risen and gone on to the work the afternoon held,

the way that person took every meal, between one obligation and the next, neither resting nor performing the lack of rest. Sefu Adebayo's hand was in the folded card, the steward's seating done in the small exact script of Eleanor's longest-serving man, who had set his principal's chair where she could sit out of the hall's sight and be near it, and had seen her fed, because she would not see to it herself and someone in sixty years had always had to.

Amira stood over the small table in the failing rows of the lamps, and looked at the poured cup and the cleared plate and the one lamp burning, and the cold came up around her ankles where she had stepped out of the warm band without marking that she had stepped, and from the high windows the angled light moved another finger's width along the marble toward the dais she had left.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

The Lionesses After

THE COMPOUND DID NOT stop for the case and it did not stop after it, and that was the first thing Asha set down when she came back to her own desk and found the intake stacked where the runners had left it through the days she had been in the investigation room.

She had been away from intake for eleven working days, which was longer than she had been away from it in nineteen years, and intake did not forgive an absence. It only accrued. The tray on the corner of her desk held the assessment files of the four candidates the Quarter was carrying through the spring cohort, two of them due their second board within the week, and beside the tray sat the standing reports she signed without reading because she had read their like a thousand times and beneath them the few she read twice because they were the ones a careless hand would have signed. She drew the chair in and sat and pulled the first file and opened it, and the room around her was the room it had always been, the narrow assessment office under the east wall with the one shelf of bound standards and the smell of stylus ink and the floor wax the keepers laid down each night, and the light through the slot window came in thin and climbed the wall as the morning ran, and she worked.

She worked the first candidate clean. The young man had come up through the surveyor's track and the second-stage work showed the thing the first board could not have shown, which was what he did when the watch went long and nothing happened. He held. The file said he held.

Asha read the field exercise and the keeper's hand at the foot of it and set her own mark below the keeper's, and she meant to move to the next file, and she did not, because she had reached the line where the board recorded the candidate's grasp of the limits of the mandate, and she sat with the line a moment, and then she set the stylus down.

The line said what it had said for nineteen years. It asked whether the candidate understood the bounds of the charter and could state them and could hold them under pressure, and the young man could, and the keeper had marked it so, and the mark was true and the mark was not enough, and Asha had known it was not enough since the third day in the investigation room and had not had the hours to say so until now. The bounds of the charter were the bounds Kaviel had drawn for Zola in the cold store the autumn before, the line between reading the record and reaching past it, and the case had stood in the registry because the line had held, because Asha had hit the category she could not investigate and logged the wall and not crossed it, and a board that asked only whether a candidate knew the bounds was a board that had not asked the harder thing, which was whether the candidate could build a case that did not need the crossing. Knowing the wall was there was the easy half. Working so that the work never had to touch it was the half the registry morning had turned on, and the standard sheet did not measure it, because the standard sheet had been written before anyone in the Quarter had needed to prove a finding to a court that wanted it struck.

She pushed the candidate files aside, squared, unfinished, and took a clean sheet, and at the head of it she wrote the date and below the date the words *Revision, assessment standard, second-stage board*, and she began.

She did not write fast. She wrote the way she wrote everything, short, each clause weighed against the use it would be put to, because a standard was a thing other hands would hold long after hers and a loose clause in a standard was a candidate passed wrong for a generation. She wrote the new line first. The old line had asked whether a candidate knew the bounds. The new line asked whether the candidate could carry a finding past a wall by inference and leave the wall unbreached and make the inference stand on the ground below it, and she wrote beneath it the means a board would use to test the thing, a constructed record

with a category sealed inside it and a finding that lay above the seal, and the candidate set to reach the finding without the means to open the seal, and the board reading the candidate's work for the place the reach had been made. The work she had done on her knees in the spring, blind, by instinct and forty years of habit, she was setting down now as a thing that could be taught and graded and required, so that the next researcher who hit a wall under a priority docket with a clock running would have been made to practice the discipline before the day came that needed it.

The slot window climbed past noon and the light came off the wall and the keeper outside drew the mop along the corridor and the wet trail of it carried the wax smell in under the door, and Asha wrote, and she did not break for the meal, and by the middle of the afternoon she had the spine of it. It was not finished. A standard was never finished in a day and this one would go to the bound shelf only after Kaviel had read it cold and after a board had run it against a live cohort and after the places it failed had been found and closed. But the spine held. She read it back against itself, hunting for the clause a careless hand would misread, and she found two and rewrote them, and she set the sheet at the head of the candidate files she had pushed aside, because the four candidates of the spring cohort would be the first the new line tested, and they would not thank her for it, and that was not the work's concern.

Meret wrote the incident review in the small administrative office at the end of the records corridor, where the light was bad and the work was the kind of work that did not need light, and she wrote it slowly because she would not put a thing in it she was not sure of.

The review was hers because the review was always hers, the discipline of setting down what had happened in the order it had happened and against the record that proved it, so that the Quarter could read its own conduct after the fact and find where the conduct had been sound and where it had been lucky and tell the two apart. She had the channel logs of the registry morning, every line that had crossed the trays, the time of each and the hand that sent it and the hand that took it, and she had Silva's field set transmission and Asha's reply and the cover line Kaviel had written to the magister Oduya, and she had the registrar's ruling itself, copied to the Quarter under the standing arrangement, and she laid

them in the order the morning had run and read the morning forward through them as a stranger would read it.

She did not write what she did not have. That was the discipline and it was the whole of her. There was a thing in the morning's record that drew the eye, the speed with which the courtier had been walked to the authenticating desk, the two hours from the gap opening to the seal set, and a faster hand would have written it down as proof of how close the faction sat to the court. Meret did not write it down. Silva's transmission gave her the time the man climbed the steps and the time he came down, and the times were facts and she set them in, but the meaning a watcher might hang on the times was not a fact, and Meret had held information until she was sure of it for so long that the holding was no longer patience in her, it was the shape of her mind. She wrote that the courtier had authenticated the petition at the eighth hour and a quarter and that the petition had been filed at the seventh, and she let the gap between the two hours stand on the page as a gap, unfilled, for a reader with standing to draw the conclusion she would not draw without the proof of it.

The thing she would not leave out was the gap in the Quarter's own conduct, because a review that recorded only the things done well was a review that taught nothing. She wrote the place plainly. The dangerous passage between the gathering's end and the authority's entry had been known to Kaviel a week before the morning and could not be closed, and the Quarter had built replies against a challenge it could not yet see, and the replies had held, and the holding had rested on Mokoena failing to swear an oath the Quarter had no way to prevent him swearing. She wrote that the morning had turned, in part, on the conscience of a man four hundred miles south whom the Quarter did not control and could not have controlled, and that a review which credited the Quarter with the whole of the outcome would be a review that had not read the morning honestly. The reply had been built well. The reply had also been built in the hope that a thing outside the Quarter's reach would break the right way, and it had, and the next time it might not, and the review existed to say so before the next time came.

She wrote into the dim, the bad light no trouble to her, the smell of the bound logs close around the small room and the dry rasp of the old channel paper under her hand as she turned it, and outside the door the

corridor carried the sounds of the compound running, a board sitting somewhere down the east wall, the keepers moving the day's carts, the low continuous murmur of an institution at its ordinary work. She finished the body of it by the end of the second day and set it aside to cool, because a review read back warm was a review the writer agreed with too easily, and she would read it cold in the morning and find the place she had been generous to the Quarter and harden it.

Silva came back from the field on the fourth day, off the night transit, and she came into the Quarter the way she came into everywhere, without anyone marking the hour of it until she was already inside.

She had been three weeks at the spinward edge on the work that followed the striking, watching the thin accounts where the resource would have run if the order had failed, confirming with her own eye that the resource had not run, because a thing proven on paper in the investigation room was a thing the field still had to walk to be sure of. The order had held. The road out had been closed before the cover came off and the short had shown into a closed room and the resource sat where it had sat for seven years, frozen now under the second instrument and waiting for the court, and Silva had stood in the cold of three river towns and watched the accounts not move and sent up the line each night that they had not moved, and now she was back, and the field was off her the way the field came off her, slowly, over a day, as the watchfulness she wore in the open settled back down into the watchfulness she wore at home.

She went first to the assessment office, because Asha kept the field rotations and a field officer reported her return to Asha before she reported it to anyone, and she stood in the doorway with the satchel still on her shoulder and the road still on her, the smell of engine exhaust and other people's tobacco worked into the coat, and Asha looked up from the standard sheet and read her the way Asha read a returning officer, for the things the officer would not say.

"They held," Silva said.

"I know they held. You sent it up." Asha set the stylus down. "Sit. You came off the night transit and you are standing in my doorway as though you mean to turn around and walk back to it."

Silva sat. She put the satchel down between her feet and she did not take the coat off, which Asha marked and did not name, because an officer three weeks in the open did not shed the open in a single doorway and pushing her to it would only teach her to perform the shedding. They went through the field rotation the way they always did, the accounts and the watch positions and the faces Silva had logged and the one face she had logged twice because it had been at two towns it had no reason to be at, and Asha took the twice-logged face and set it where it belonged, which was into the running record of who the faction had left in the field after the reach was cut, the cleanup the other side was running now, the same as the Quarter ran cleanup, and Silva's twice-logged face was a thread for another week.

"There is a board sitting," Asha said, when the rotation was done. "Down the east wall. The spring cohort, second stage. You have earned past sitting it. You will read the new line before the next field rotation, because the next researcher I send to a river town is going to be held to it." She slid the standard sheet across the desk, the revision, the spine of it. "Read it now. Tell me where it fails."

Silva read it. She read it the way a field officer read a thing written by a desk officer, looking for the place the standard asked of a candidate a thing that was clean on paper and impossible in the open, and she found one, the means of the test, the constructed record with the sealed category, and she said that a candidate who learned the discipline on a constructed record would learn to find the seal the board had built and not the seal the world hid, because the world did not band its walls in red for the convenience of the reader. Asha took it. It was the thing she had half-seen and not had the field in her to name, and she wrote it into the margin of the sheet in the cramped hand, that the constructed record must hide its seal the way a true record hid it, without a marker, so that the candidate found the wall by reading and not by looking for the place the board had put it, and she set the sheet back at the head of the cohort files with the margin note standing.

"Go and sleep," she said. "You are no use to me with the transit still on you."

Silva picked up the satchel and rose, and at the door she stopped, because a thing had occurred to her on the steps coming up that she had

meant to say and the rotation had pushed out of her head. "The girl," she said. "Adimu. She is still in the room?"

"She is still in the room."

"She did the climb." Silva had seen it the once, the five-column wall, the day she came down to the investigation room before the spinward rotation, and she had stood at the foot of it the way a person stood at the foot of a thing built well by someone younger than the building should have allowed. "The whole body of it, up the wall."

"She did the climb," Asha said.

Silva took that, and nodded, and went to sleep, and Asha went back to the standard sheet, and the matter of the girl who had done the climb sat now in two heads where it had sat in one.

The commendation came down from the compound's own board, not from the court, because the court did not commend a junior researcher it had never been told the name of, and the Quarter did not let the court hold the only record of what its people had done.

Asha drafted it and Kaviel signed it, and that was the order it was done in, because the assessment was Asha's and the standing was Kaviel's to confirm, and between them the thing was made the way the Quarter made things, on paper, exact, with the citation set down in language a board would read in twenty years and understand. Asha wrote the citation against the record and not against the feeling, the dates and the method and the finding, the reconciliation-trace method learned in the autumn and carried through the winter and run blind across seven years of accounts to lay bare the body of the second mechanism, and she wrote that the finding had made the case prosecutable and that the case had stood, and she did not write that the girl had done it on the third day with the brightness gone glassy in her eyes and had held the size of it in her head and not on the front of her face, because that was not a thing a citation recorded, and it was the thing Asha would carry about her longest.

They did it in the investigation room, which surprised the girl, because the room was a working room and not a room where things were marked, and that was the point of doing it there. The room had been struck down to half its size in the days since the case closed, two of the

three long tables carried back to storage, the five-column climb taken off the wall and bound and sent to the court under seal, the disbursement registers returned to the offices they had been pulled from, so that what remained was the crosswise table at the head and the bare north wall and the cold that banked in the corners and the engine clicking above, the room going back to what it had been before the case had made it more. Zola was there because Asha had sent her down to begin the close-out of the materials, the dull careful work of accounting for every sheet that had passed through the room, and she was at the table with the inventory when Kaviel came in, and Asha behind her, and the girl stood, because she stood when a senior came in and had not stopped.

"Sit, or stand, as you like," Kaviel said. "This will not take long, and it is not a board."

Zola stood.

Kaviel had the citation in her hand, the single folded sheet, and she did not read it out, because the Quarter did not perform its commendations and Kaviel performed nothing. She set it on the table under the bureau clock where the case had sat the day it was complete, and she said the thing the sheet said in fewer words.

"The board has confirmed you to full standing. As of the date on that sheet you are a Lioness of the Quarter, full charter, not a researcher carried under a senior's mandate. Your name goes on the roll in your own right." She paused, and what she did next she did because the girl had earned the saying of it and not because Kaviel was a woman who said such things easily. "Zola Adimu. The roll will carry the whole of it, both names, because the work you did is going to be cited in matters that outlast everyone in this room, and a citation that a court reads in twenty years does not say *the junior researcher*. It says the name. You will be in the record, by name, as the hand that found the body of the thing. I wanted you to hear it from me before you read it off a sheet."

The girl took it the way she had been taught to take a finding, the work behind the eyes and the front of the face held still, and the holding broke a little at the edges and she let it, because she was among the people she had earned the right to let it break in front of, and she did not say anything for a moment, and then she said the thing a Lioness said, which was not thanks.

"Where do you want the close-out," she said. "By jurisdiction, or by the order the sheets came in."

"By jurisdiction," Asha said, from the door. "And then index it both ways, because the court will want it one way and we will want it the other." She came in and looked at the half-struck room and the bare wall where the climb had been, and she put her hand for a moment flat on the crosswise table, the way she put her hand on a thing she was setting in its place, and she took it off. "You will run the next intake board's research module. You are full charter now and full charter teaches. I have a revision to the standard that needs a hand who has worked a live case to run it the first time. That is yours."

Zola looked at her.

"You found the wall and you did not cross it," Asha said. "You did it because Kaviel told you the bounds and you held them, which is the easy half. The hard half is that you built the climb so it never needed the crossing. You did that without being taught it, because the patience was already in you. I am going to teach the next one to do it on purpose, and you are going to help me, because you are the proof that it can be done." She picked up the inventory sheet and read the head of it and set it down. "By jurisdiction. Index both ways. I want it by the end of the week."

"By the end of the week," Zola said.

Kaviel left the citation on the table under the clock and did not watch the girl pick it up, because watching her pick it up would have made the picking-up a thing, and it was not a thing, it was a sheet of paper that said what the work had been. She went out, and Asha stayed to set the close-out running, and Zola Adimu, full charter, by name on the roll, drew the inventory to the table edge and began to account for every sheet that had passed through a room that was going back to what it had been.

Kaviel came through the compound a last time at the end of the week, between one thing and another, the way she came through any place she was responsible for and not occupying, and she went where she went when she came through, which was the rooms where the work lived and not the offices where it was administered.

She read the new standard off the bound shelf where Asha had set it after the cohort board had run it once and found two places it failed, both

closed now, the sheet gone from a revision to a standard in five days the way a thing went when the people working it did not stop. She read the incident review in the small office with the bad light, Meret at the desk turning the cold copy for the third time, and she read the place Meret had written that the morning had turned in part on the conscience of a man the Quarter did not control, and she set the review down and said only that it was honest, which from Kaviel was the whole of an approval, and Meret took it and went back to the page. She put her head into the assessment office where Silva, slept-out now and the field off her, sat across the desk from Asha working the next rotation, and she did not interrupt it, because a rotation being worked was a thing that did not want interrupting, and she went on.

She ended where the case had ended, in the half-struck investigation room, where Zola had the close-out laid out by jurisdiction along the crosswise table and indexed both ways and very nearly done, and she stood in the doorway a moment and read the room the way she read any room she meant to leave, the bare north wall, the two tables gone to storage, the cold in the corners, the engine clicking above, the girl at the table accounting for the last of the sheets, the room a store again in everything but the smell, which would take another season to leave it. The case was bound and under seal at the court. The mechanism was frozen and waiting. The people who had run it were charged or fled or, in one office four hundred miles south, sitting at a pale-edged desk waiting for an instruction that was never going to come. The Quarter had read its own conduct and found the place it had been lucky and written the luck down so it would not be mistaken for skill. The standard sat on the bound shelf where Asha had set it. The girl was on the roll under her own name. The work had come back to the rhythm it ran at between the things that asked everything of it, the rhythm it had kept before the case opened, the keepers moving the day's carts down the corridor and a board sitting somewhere down the east wall.

Asha had come to the door of the assessment office down the corridor, the rotation set, and she stood in it with a sheet in her hand and watched Kaviel reach the outer door of the compound where the corridor gave onto the yard and the gray light came in off the stone.

Kaviel did not turn at the door. She had her hand on the frame of it and the yard light on her and she stood half a breath, and then she said it, low, into the corridor behind her, to the woman she knew was standing there because she always knew.

"Good work."

Then she went out, into the yard, and the door drew shut on its own weight behind her. Asha stood a moment longer and watched the door where it had closed. Then she looked down at the sheet in her hand, the next candidate, the second-stage board due within the week, and she went back into the assessment office and sat at the desk and pulled the chair in and opened the file and read the first line.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

Kaviel and Eleanor

THE CORRIDOR OUTSIDE THE office had not changed in any way Kaviel could name, and she had walked it perhaps a dozen times across her life, always on business, always with a folder in her hand or a report shaped in her head, and she walked it now with neither, which was the thing that had changed. She had sent no notice ahead. Sefu had let her into the administrative wing at the side door without asking why she had come, which told her he had been told to expect her, or had decided on his own that she would, and with Sefu the two were hard to tell apart. He had walked her as far as the turn and then stopped, the way he stopped at the edge of what was his to do, and said the door was open, and gone back the way they had come at the even pace he kept.

The west light was in the room when she came in. It lay low and long across the floor and up the leg of the writing table the way it had lain there for sixty years, because the window had been chosen for it, and Kaviel had read the room enough times in reports to know the window was chosen and had never once stood in the room while the light was doing what the reports described. It smelled of aged paper and cold tea and the dryness of a space that one body had occupied for longer than Kaviel had been alive, a smell that was almost nothing, that a stranger would have called the smell of no smell at all, and that Kaviel found she knew the way she knew her own hands.

Eleanor was sitting down.

That was the second thing, and it landed under the first before Kaviel had crossed the threshold. She had never seen her mother sit at the writing table. In every account of this room that had ever reached her, in the few times she had stood in its doorway, Eleanor stood at the table, or stood half-turned from the window with her back to the glare, or stood while a subordinate sat. The chair behind the table was a chair she kept for the look of the thing, a chair the room expected. Eleanor was in it now, settled into it, her hands resting on the arms, and the settling was not the settling of a woman taking a moment's ease between two efforts. It was the settling of a body that had decided where it would be for the afternoon because rising and crossing the room and standing had become a sum it preferred not to pay more than it had to.

"You found the side door," Eleanor said.

"Sefu found it for me."

"He would." Eleanor moved one hand off the arm of the chair, a small motion toward the visitor's chair that still saw use, the one that was not the one nobody had sat in for years, and Kaviel understood that her mother had kept the count of which chair was which even in this, even now, and would have been put out to have a guest take the wrong one. Kaviel took the chair that saw use. She sat the way she sat in any room she was reading, back straight, hands resting where they could be seen, and then she heard herself doing it and let her shoulders down a degree, because there was no one in this room to read her for it except the one person who had taught her the posture in the first place.

Eleanor watched her do it. The half-lidded eyes did not miss it. But she said nothing, and the not-saying was not the held attention Kaviel had spent her life reading off her, the silence pointed at a corner of a problem while the rest of the face rested. It was a quieter thing. It had no edge to it.

The cold tea sat at Eleanor's elbow where some earlier hour had left it, a skin on its surface. Kaviel had read about the cold tea too. She had thought, reading it, that it was a habit, a thing her mother did because she forgot the cup in the work. Looking at it now she saw it was older than habit. It was a cup poured by someone, by Sefu most likely, set down at the right hand because a right hand expected it there, and let go cold

because the work that was supposed to interrupt itself to drink it had thinned out, and the cup had outlasted the reason for it.

"You ran the morning court from the colonnade," Eleanor said. "The Sennar petition."

"You were behind the screen. You'll have heard it better than I read it."

"I heard the throne hold the rulings and suspend the clause." Eleanor's voice was even, and lower than Kaviel remembered it, and she paced it differently now, leaving small rests inside the sentences where before there had been none. "She gave them the orchards and took the procedure. It was the right division. Most rulers would have thrown out the judgments to be seen punishing the appointments, and made an enemy of every litigant who had won fairly before a bench that was seated foully." A rest. "She did not. She is better at the work than the men who taught me used to say a throne could be at the work."

"She spent three weeks on the answer to that petition," Kaviel said. "She told me she knew it would come and she made herself ready for it. She does that with everything now. She prepares for the question before anyone has thought to ask it."

"I know she does." Eleanor's hand moved on the chair arm, the fingers settling. "I have watched her learn to do it. I will not watch much more of it."

She said it the way she said anything, without weight laid on it, a fact set on the record in the frame of facts, and Kaviel did not answer it, because there was no answer to it that would not have made it larger than her mother had made it, and because the term that governed the morning at the oversight chamber had taught her something about being in a room and saying nothing, and she carried what it had taught her into this room and let the sentence sit where Eleanor had put it.

The light moved on the floor. A building this old ran without ceasing, sixty years of it under this one roof, and the running came up faintly through the stone, the dim travel of a cart somewhere below in a service court, the closing of a far door, the wind finding the courtyard Eleanor never used and turning over in it and going. Kaviel had learned in the compound to hear a room. This room she could have heard with her eyes

shut and named the hour by the angle of the cart-sound and the warmth of the air.

"The financial channels," Eleanor said. "Zola's skeleton held them."

"It held them. We took apart all three. The resources are pinned where the prerogative can reach them. Nothing fled." Kaviel said it plainly, the close of an operation in the fewest words it would take, the way she had been taught to close one, and she watched her mother receive it the way her mother received any report, once for the words and once for what they were built around.

"You taught the girl the trace yourself."

"I taught her the method. She found the rest. She found more of it than I would have, faster, because she did not yet know which parts were supposed to be hard." Kaviel paused. "Asha is confirming her to full standing. There's a commendation she doesn't expect."

"Good," Eleanor said. And then, after a rest, in the same even voice, "You teach the way I never managed to. You give them the method and then you let the work be theirs. I gave people debts and called it teaching. The debts aged out. The methods will not." Her eyes had moved to the window, to the square of glass and the dead light beyond it, and Kaviel could not have said whether her mother was looking at the courtyard or at nothing, and decided it did not matter which.

Kaviel had come without knowing what she had come to do. She knew it now, sitting in the chair that saw use, with the tea going colder at her mother's elbow and the light leaving the floor. She had not come to deliver a report, though she had delivered one, because reports were the channel they had, the gray dispatch paper and the fixed hand and the four sentences, and to come into the room and say nothing of the work would have been a stranger's silence between them, not theirs. She had come because there was an afternoon, and there had never before been an afternoon, and there would not be many more, and the arithmetic of that was the only arithmetic in the room that her mother had not laid out clean and stepped back from.

On the table, near Eleanor's right hand, past the cold cup, lay a flat hinged box of black document leather worn pale along the spine. Kaviel knew that case too. It was in the record. It had held a field report for eleven days once, years ago, in a calculation about a source whose name

Kaviel had learned only this spring. It was empty now, or held something else now, and it lay closed under the moving light, and Eleanor's hand was near it without touching it, the way a hand rests near a thing it has stopped needing to open.

"You read my assessments," Kaviel said. She had not planned to say it. It came up out of the room.

Eleanor's eyes came back from the window. "I read everything."

"The probationary ones. The ones Asha marked low."

"I read those." A rest. "You appealed three. You were right on two." The faintest movement at the corner of her mother's mouth, not a smile, the place a smile would have been on a face that had spent sixty years declining to spend itself on smiling. "You knew which two before the board did. That was the thing I read in them. Not the appeals. The knowing."

Kaviel sat with that. She had not known her mother had read them. She had assumed, the way she assumed everything she could not document, that the assessments had gone into the apparatus and been filed and that Eleanor saw the summaries the head of a house saw, the standings and the readiness counts, and not the probationary file of one officer who happened to carry the name. She had assumed it because the alternative was a thing she had no place to put. She had a place for it now, and it was not a comfortable place, and she did not reach for any of the things a person reaches for to make such a place comfortable, because her mother had not built her to reach for them and the building had held.

"You never said," Kaviel said.

"No." Eleanor's hand found the arm of the chair again. "It is not the kind of thing I said. You will have noticed."

"I noticed."

"I am not going to take it back now and call it a fault and ask you to think better of me for naming it late." The voice stayed even. "I did the work the way I did it. I am too old to revise the method to look kinder in the last light of it. You would see through the revision faster than anyone I ever trained, and you would be right to, and I did not raise you on the kind of paper that confesses one thing in order to hide another." A rest, longer than the others. "I read the assessments. I have read them all, for years. That is a fact. I am setting it down. What you do with a fact has

never been mine to direct, which is the one part of your training I can take no credit for, because it was already in you when the house took you in, and I only declined to grind it off."

Kaviel did not answer. The not-answering was its own answer, and Eleanor would read it as one, and the reading would be correct.

The afternoon thinned toward its end. The bar of light had climbed off the table while they sat, the way it climbed every day, and slid down the table leg and onto the floor again, and was thinning now toward the window as the sun went behind the wing of the building. The room cooled by a degree that Kaviel felt on the backs of her hands. Somewhere below, the cart that had gone over an hour ago came back the other way, and the wind in the courtyard had dropped, and the dryness of the air carried the cold tea now, the thin bitter edge of it, and under that the leather of the empty case and the aged paper on the shelves that ran the wall to a ceiling Eleanor could no longer reach.

"Sit a while longer," Eleanor said. It was not a request, and it was not an order, and it was the nearest thing to either that she would put into the air. "You have somewhere to be. You always have somewhere to be. I built it into you." A rest. "It will keep an hour."

"It'll keep," Kaviel said.

So she stayed. They did not fill the staying with talk. Eleanor said, once, that the third map on the wall, the one a stranger could not read, the grid of cells each marked with a code, was a map of people and channels and debts, and that most of the cells were dead now, the people gone or aged out or no longer worth the keeping, and that she had not redrawn it because there was no longer a reason to and because she liked to look at the shape of a thing she had spent a life building even after the thing had stopped working, the way a person keeps a house she no longer fills. Kaviel looked at the map. She could not read it. She had spent her life learning to read pages until they confessed, and this page would not confess to her, because it was written in the one hand she had never been given the key to, and she found she did not mind that it would not. There were keys it was right not to be given.

Eleanor's eyes closed for a stretch in the middle of the afternoon, not asleep, or not in a way that asked to be treated as sleep, and Kaviel sat through it without moving, the way she had sat through the oversight

chamber, doing the only thing the hour left her, which was to be in the room. When the eyes opened again Eleanor did not remark on having closed them, and Kaviel did not remark on it either, and the small mercy of that, the thing left unsaid because saying it would have made it a thing, passed between them and was the closest the afternoon came to tenderness, which was close enough, because neither of them had ever needed it nearer.

The light reached the case. It lay across the worn black leather and warmed it to brown for a moment, and the small brass clasp threw a thread of brightness onto the table, and then the sun dropped another degree behind the wing and the thread went out and the leather went back to black, and the room began to take the blue that came into it before the lamps.

Kaviel rose. She did it without announcing it, gathering herself out of the chair that saw use, and Eleanor watched her do it and did not move to rise with her, because rising was a sum she would not pay to see a daughter to a door her daughter knew the way out of.

"I'll send the morning report through the usual channel," Kaviel said.

"The gray paper," Eleanor said. "The fixed hand."

"The four sentences."

"I taught you the four sentences." Eleanor's hands rested on the arms of the chair. "Waste no fifth on reassurance. I told you that when you were nineteen. You have never once wasted the fifth." A rest. "Do not start now. I would not know what to do with it, and it would only mean you had begun reading me as someone to be managed, and I have had enough of being managed by people who love me to do it, of whom there have been fewer than you would think, and you are not going to become one of them in the last of it."

It was the only time in the afternoon either of them had set the word near the surface, and Eleanor had set it there inside a refusal, wrapped it in the order not to soften, so that it could not be answered as the thing it was, and Kaviel understood the wrapping for what it was, which was the only way her mother had ever had of carrying it, and she did not unwrap it. She let it lie in the blue light the way she had let everything lie.

"All right," Kaviel said.

She crossed to the door. She put her hand on it. The leather of the old hinge was cold under her palm and the corridor beyond breathed up faintly with the smell of stone and the wax the household rubbed into the wood, and she stopped there, her back to the room, her hand on the door, and did not turn. Behind her she could hear the small sounds of the room and her mother in it, the creak of the chair as a weight shifted in it, the cup not lifted, the building running on under the stone the way it had run for sixty years and would run after. She stood a moment longer than the leaving needed. Then she opened the door and went out into the corridor and let it close behind her, and her footsteps went away down the passage at an even pace.

In the office the blue light deepened toward dusk. Eleanor De Grosvenor sat in the chair she had never used until this season, her hands on its arms, the cold tea at her elbow and the empty case near her right hand, and she did not call for the lamps. She turned her head to the window. The square of glass held the last of the day going gray over the courtyard she had not walked through in a decade, the dead fountain, the bench nobody used, and she looked at it, and the light went out of it by degrees, and she watched it go.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

Amira Alone

THE HOUSEHOLD HAD WITHDRAWN at the tenth hour, as it withdrew on every night she did not keep someone with her, and the quarters had gone over to the quiet they kept after the people left, which was a quiet with a floor under it and not a true silence. Amira had learned the floor of it in her first year. The building breathed. Somewhere below the private wing a furnace ran its long even labor against the cold that came up out of the New Terra stone after dark, and the heat of it climbed through the walls and the floors as a faint travel, a thing felt in the soles before it was heard, and over that ran the smaller sounds, a shutter taking the wind on the north face, the watch changing at the foot of the stair with the soft exchange of two men who had done it a thousand times and no longer needed words for it. She had stopped, years ago, expecting the quarters to be quiet. A throne did not buy quiet. It bought a better grade of noise, and a door no one would open without her leave, and those were not the same thing, and she had made her peace with the difference the way she had made her peace with the weight of the overrobe.

The overrobe was off. It hung on its stand by the inner door where the dresser had left it, holding its own shape without her inside it, the metal thread catching the lamp in short dull lines down the seams. She had worn it eleven hours. The marks of it were still on her, the pressure of the collar along the back of her neck, the place at the shoulders where the weight gathered and sat, and she rolled the neck once, slowly, and felt the

day let go of it by a degree, and did not pretend the rest of the day would let go so easily.

She had eaten. She had eaten alone, at the small table by the cold hearth, the plain late meal the kitchen sent up when she dined out of the hall, and she had read while she ate, which her physician disliked and which she did anyway, because the reading was the work and the eating was the maintenance of the thing that did the work, and she had long since stopped granting the maintenance a ceremony of its own. The plate was cleared to the side now. A cup of the bitter southern tea sat at her hand, cooling, the steam off it gone thin. The taste of it was on the back of her tongue, the resin-and-ash edge the eastern prefectures cured into the leaf, and she drank it for no reason of pleasure and none of wakefulness. It was the cup she drank at this hour, and the hour wanted its cup.

Tomorrow she would seat the first appointments under the new oversight.

She had come to the desk to read the form of it one more time, the document her own office had drafted under her hand and the council had not yet seen, the mechanism that would stand where the carry-forward reconciliation had stood, and she had read it twice through and found nothing in it she would change tonight, and now she sat with it under her palm and did not read it a third time, because reading it a third time would have been a way of not thinking about the thing under it, and she had not held a throne for five years by letting herself not think about the thing under it.

The thing under it was the cost.

She turned the lamp down a quarter. The room came in closer around the smaller flame, the painted ceiling going up into a dark she could no longer make out, the shelves along the western wall losing their edges, and she sat in the close warm circle of the light with the document under one hand and the cooling cup beside the other and let herself, for the first time since the chamber on the third floor of the Hall of Establishments, count the bill from the top.

She had invoked the emergency prerogative of the Throne. No sovereign had done it in thirty-one years, and the last to do it had spent the rest of a long reign explaining the doing, and Amira had read every

line of that explaining when she was a girl being made into what she now was, and she had read it again three weeks ago in the windowless briefing room with Kaviel across the table and the evidence between them, before she put the pen to the notation in her own hand. She had known what the act would cost when she committed it to paper. A prerogative used was a prerogative no longer asleep. Every Throne that came after her would govern in a court that had seen this one reach past the ordinary administration and take a case out of the channels and into a court of her own constituting, and some of those later Thrones would reach for the same lever for worse reasons, and would point at her when they did. She had handed the future a weapon to use against itself. That was the first line of the bill, and it did not get smaller for being looked at squarely, and she looked at it squarely, because the alternative had been to let the channels adjudicate a fraud the channels were compromised to protect, and that was not an alternative, it was a slower surrender dressed as procedure.

She had done it in open court. That was the second line. She could have suspended the proceeding against Eleanor in chambers, quietly, on paper, and let the transfer reach the public record after the fact in the dry notation such things wore. She had chosen the chamber, the people in it, the witnesses, the Arbiter standing to receive the jurisdiction from the throne's own mouth. She had chosen to be seen doing the most exposed thing of her reign, because a thing done in the dark could be undone in the dark, and a thing done in the light had to be undone in the light or not at all, and she had wanted Marek's faction, and the men around it who had not been named and might never be, to understand that the throne had not flinched from the seeing. It had been the right choice. She did not revisit it to second-guess it. She revisited it to hold it, the way she held everything she had decided and could not afford to forget she had decided, because a ruler who forgot the weight of her own past acts would mistake the next one for the first.

The wind found the north shutter again and worked it, and she heard the watch settle it, the scrape of the latch and the man's low word to the cold, and then the building breathing on under that.

She thought about Eleanor.

She did it without sentiment, because there was no sentiment in it to begin with, and she had never once let herself import any, not in five years of the most consequential professional relationship of her life. She and Eleanor De Grosvenor were not friends. They had met privately three times in the small reception room with the two chairs and the window over the garden neither of them looked at, and the three meetings were the whole of their intimacy, and the intimacy was the intimacy of two people who carried, between them, the load that the compact existed to carry, and who trusted each other to carry it and not one inch further than that. Amira had never wanted it further. The compact bought the throne an apparatus it could not have built and could not control, and it bought the house a sovereign who would let it serve without bending it into a court faction, and the price of the bargain was that neither party ever pretended the bargain was love. Amira had kept the price exactly. She kept it still.

And Eleanor had gone out past the frame of the compact, alone, to a neutral room she had arranged, to give Marek a choice before any formal action, and she had not told the throne why, only asked for the three days, and Amira had given them without the why, because that too was the compact, the throne extending the trust the house had not formally earned, as the throne before hers had extended it, and the one before that. Amira knew what the three days had cost. She had read it in the chamber when Eleanor sat silent through the transfer, present and not active, and she had read it again in the throne room three mornings ago, in the chair behind the screen, in the stillness with no current under it. The crisis had taken something out of the old woman, and it had not given it back, and it would not, and Amira had seen this the way she saw everything she could not act on in session and could not let herself forget, and she had put it where she put such things, and it sat there now, in the close light, refusing to be filed.

She knew the other thing too. She knew what Kaviel had seen.

It had reached her by no channel anyone could name, the way the worst-weighting things reached a throne, in the half-beat Kaviel's circuit of the western wall had held on the band of shadow behind the screen a fraction longer than a column's eye would hold, in the earliness with which the old woman now left the hall, in a hundred small administrative

facts that added to one fact a daughter had read before the throne read it and would carry whether or not she ever set it on the gray dispatch paper in the four fixed sentences. Kaviel knew her mother was failing. Amira knew that Kaviel knew. Neither of them had said a word of it, and neither would, because there was no use in the words and a great deal of cost, and the two of them, the Empress and the senior Lioness who carried the house's name without performing it, understood the economy of that cost in the same currency. It was the nearest thing to fellow feeling Amira permitted herself about the De Grosvenors, this shared refusal to spend on what could not be bought back, and she permitted it tonight, alone, with the lamp down and the tea going cold, because there was no court to read her permitting it.

She drank the last of the tea. It had gone cool and the resin had settled to the bottom and the last mouthful carried the grit of it, bitter, and she set the cup down on its saucer with the small flat click of porcelain on porcelain that was the loudest sound the room had made in an hour.

Was it worth it.

That was the question she had come to the desk to answer, under the cover of reading a document she had already mastered, and she made herself put it plainly, in the words a petitioner would use, because a throne that dressed its hardest questions in the soft language of statecraft was a throne already lying to itself. Was the bill worth the thing it had bought. She had spent a prerogative that would not sleep again in her lifetime. She had exposed the house's apparatus and the house's head. She had bought herself a court that would, for the rest of her reign, measure every reach of the throne against the morning it had reached this far, and some of them would never trust the reach again, and she would govern the rest of her life among people who had watched her do the largest thing she would ever do and could not unsee it.

Against that, she had seated a fraud's dismantling. The carry-forward clause was closed. Marek was before a court that could not be reached from inside the Bureau he had run, and the financial channels were pinned where the prerogative could hold them, and the appointments of three Thrones' worth of jurisdiction would be made, from tomorrow, under an oversight that answered past the Bureau, by people who put their names where offices had been, and the prefectures that had been

governed by magistrates seated foully would be governed, going forward, by magistrates seated in the light. She had not fixed the empire. An empire was not a thing that got fixed. She had closed one wound that had been left open for seven years because closing it required a hand willing to be seen reaching, and she had been the hand, and that was the whole of what a throne was for, and the men who came after her with worse reasons would have to find their own justifications, because she was not responsible for the uses bad sovereigns made of good precedents, she was responsible for the case in front of her, and the case in front of her had been a fraud protected at the height of the administration, and she had ended it.

The answer was not a triumph. She felt no lift in it, none of the heat she had felt as a younger woman when she imagined doing large things and being right to have done them. What she felt was something flatter and more durable, the thing a person feels who has weighed a load correctly and lifted it and set it down where it belonged and knows the weight will be back tomorrow in another shape. The answer was settled. She had done the thing that the position required of the person who held it, and she had paid what it cost, and she would pay the rest of what it cost across the years it would take to come due, and she would have done it again, knowing the price, because the price was the price of being the one who held the position and not merely the one who occupied it. She had stopped, somewhere in these five years, being able to tell those two apart in herself. The crisis had finished the work of joining them. She did not name the change. It did not need naming. It was in the way she had set the cup down, and in the document under her hand that she would seat in the morning, and in the fact that she had asked the question at all instead of letting the success answer it for her.

She rose from the desk.

She had not slept more than five hours a night since the briefing room, and she would not sleep much tonight, and she had stopped fighting the arithmetic of it. The body did the work the position needed and the position did not consult the body about the hours. She crossed the close warm circle of the lamp and out of it into the cooler dark of the room, where the floor gave the furnace's heat back faintly through the

soles of her feet, and she went to the tall window on the eastern wall that gave out over the imperial complex, and she drew the inner curtain aside.

The complex lay below her in the dark, the great administrative city within the city, and it was not dark. It was never dark. The night office of an empire that spanned what this one spanned could not afford the dark, and so the windows burned, scattered and clustered across the black bulk of the wings and the halls and the bureaus, a hundred rooms and more where the work that did not stop for the hour was being done by people whose names she would never know, the night clerks and the duty registrars of a machine that ran on after every individual hand let go of it. She stood at the glass and looked at the lights. The Hall of Establishments was among them, somewhere in the middle distance, where the new oversight would be entered into the record within the month under her hand, where tonight some clerk was probably still moving paper that the crisis had displaced. The Lioness compound was beyond it, low and lit, running as it always ran. She could not see Eleanor's wing from here. She knew where it was. A window or two in that quarter would be burning, and one of them might be the office with the west-facing glass and the cold tea, where a daughter had sat an afternoon that the throne had heard about through no channel it could name, and the throne did not look for that window, because there were things a throne had no business seeing even when it knew exactly where to look.

The glass was cold. She felt it before she touched it, the chill standing off the pane into the warmth of the room, and she raised her hand and set her palm flat against it, and the cold came into her hand the way the cold came up through the marble a stride to either side of the warm band in the throne room, the cold that was always there at the edge of the warmth and that the warmth was borrowed against. Her breath fogged a small bloom on the pane below her hand and shrank and went. Below her the lights burned in their hundred rooms, the work running, the empire keeping its long even labor against the dark the way the furnace kept it against the cold, with no single hand on it and every hand part of it, hers among them, hers most of all and least of all at once.

She held her hand on the glass a moment longer.

Then she turned from the window, back into the room and the warmth and the small flame of the turned-down lamp, and went to put out the

light and take what sleep the night would give her, because the appointments would be seated at the fourth hour and there was still tomorrow.

Epilogue

I HAVE COME TO the end of it, which is a thing I did not believe for several of the eleven years that I would live to write. The four shelves of the east vault are catalogued and cross-referenced and bound, and the duplicate set has gone to the second archive on the far side of the complex, because a record that exists in one place exists at the sufferance of whoever holds the key to that place, and I have learned not to trust a single copy of anything that took this long to assemble. The lamp is the same lamp. The cold comes up out of the courtyard stone the way it did the night I began, and my hands have grown no younger in the keeping of these pages, so that the stylus needs more pressure now than it did to leave the same mark.

I said at the outset that I would not give you the end in the beginning, and I have held to it. I will give you the end here, because here is where it belongs, and because a record that closes without stating what it cost would be a record written by someone who was not paying attention.

The corruption was dismantled. The mechanism beneath it, the financial one that fed the faction for seven years through three channels of which the Third Appointments Commission was only the most visible, was unwound entry by entry across the months that followed, slowly enough that the resources did not flee to jurisdictions where the prerogative could not reach them, and that slowness was its own labor, performed by people whose names appear in the depositions and not in the public accounts. Lord Marshal Tewodros Marek was charged before the Throne Court of Inquiry and answered to it. I have read the full transcript of that proceeding more times than I have read any other

document in these vaults, because a man does not reach the Marshalcy of the Bureau by being a fool, and I wanted to understand how a mind of that quality talked itself across the line. The transcript does not tell me. The transcript tells me only that he did.

Three institutional changes outlived the crisis, and a historian owes them to the record more than he owes it any verdict on the people. The appointments process was rebuilt under a standing oversight body seated outside the Bureau of Establishments, so that no single marshalcy could again command both the entry and the confirmation of it. The compact between the Trinitarian Throne and the De Grosvenor house was reaffirmed in formal session, the fourth such reaffirmation across three imperial generations, each prior one having required one party to extend the other a trust that had not yet been earned. And the mandate of the Lionesses was revised, on the recommendation of their own intake officer, to give the apparatus standing authority to investigate the categories of seal it had been unable to touch when this began. I record, because the woman who drafted that revision did not put her own name forward and someone should, that a researcher named Zola Adimu was confirmed to full standing in the same season, on merit assessed against the new criteria she had helped to write.

That is the institutional end of it. I have set it down plainly, in the order an oversight clerk would want, so that whoever comes after me can find it without reading the rest. The rest is harder, and it is what the record cannot hold, and I will say only what I am sure of.

I met Eleanor De Grosvenor three times. I have said elsewhere that the meetings were not warm and that the respect I record is owed and not granted. The official notation in the house ledger, copied into this account under its proper reference, reads that Eleanor De Grosvenor, head of the De Grosvenor apparatus for sixty-one years, was relieved of her duties by reason of death in the third quarter following the close of the proceedings, the succession passing as the compact provides. That is the whole of what the record holds on the matter, and it is the whole of what I will add to it.

There is one further thing in my keeping, and it does not belong to me, and I have decided where it goes.

The letter was found in a locked compartment among Eleanor De Grosvenor's private effects, sealed, bearing no dispatch mark, written in her own hand and never sent. By the terms under which her papers came to inquiry, it should have been read first by an archivist with a ledger and filed by reference. I read enough of the first line to know whose hand it was and whom it was for, and then I sealed it again and I carried it myself to the one person entitled to it before any clerk, which is a small abuse of my office and the only one I will confess to in these pages.

She read it in a room I was not in. I know what I know of that hour the way I have learned to know things, from what was said afterward by people who were near and from the shape of the silence around it, and I will not invent the rest to make it whole for you. The envelope was unsealed when it reached her and unsealed when she set it down. She read it once through without stopping, which is how I am told she reads everything, the page held at the distance the work requires, her face giving the room nothing it could have filed. She came to the line her mother had corrected twice and read past it. She came to the name at the bottom, the signature that never carried a flourish, and she read that too. Then she folded the single sheet along the creases it already held, and she put it down on the table in front of her, and she sat. She did not call for anyone. She did not weep that any witness recorded, and I have not asked, because a record has edges and that is one of them. She sat in the chair with the folded letter under her hand, in the failing light of a room that had been someone else's and was now no one's, and after a while she rose and went back to the work, because the work did not wait, which is the one thing in this account that mother and daughter never once disagreed upon.

I will not tell you what the letter said. It is reproduced in this record under its own reference, in the place where the events of its writing belong, and a reader who has come this far has already read it or will, and either way it is not mine to summarize. I will say that it was meant to arrive and did not, and that the woman it was meant for read it years too late to answer it, and that this is the kind of thing the empire is made of and the histories almost never keep, because it leaves no clause in any minute and moves no money and unmakes no throne. It only happened. I have kept it because it happened.

So I come to the Empress, as I always meant to, because the record closes on her and not on any house or any officer or any letter sealed too long. Amira holds the Trinitarian Throne. She held it through the first crisis she faced with no one above her to absorb the cost, and she governs it still, with the appointments running clean under their new oversight and the compact renewed and the Lionesses watching the seals they could not watch before. She invoked an authority that had lain unused for thirty-one years, and she did it in the open, where it could not be taken back, and she did not waver while the room decided whether to follow her. The room followed. I have wondered, putting this down, whether she knew it would, and I have concluded that she did not know and acted anyway, which is the distinction between a ruler who reigns and one who governs, and the only verdict on her I will permit myself.

The lamp wants trimming again. The hall runs empty toward the stair, as it did, and there is no sound here but the stone settling and the stylus, and when I lift the stylus there will be no sound at all. I have stated what I saw and what I was told and which of the two it was. The account is complete to the limit of what I could learn and honest to the limit of what I could bear, and I leave the rest, as every honest record must, to whoever reads it after me with a colder eye.

Closed and sealed under the hand of the compiler, the account of the first crisis of the reign of the Empress Amira, this twenty-second day of the fourth imperial quarter.

A. Khan, Captain, retired; keeper of the Imperial Record.